

Open Translator's Notes is based on: Open Translator's Notes, [SIL International](#), 2024, which is licensed under a [CC BY-SA 4.0 license](#).

This PDF version is provided under the same license.

Micah

Micah 1:1

Section 1:1: Heading/Introduction

The first verse of the book of Micah serves as an introductory summary for the entire book. It identifies the prophet's name, the subject of his message, and the time period during which he lived and prophesied. Most English versions have a separate book title, such as "Micah," followed directly by 1:1. There are two main ways to show the relationship of 1:1 to the rest of the book:

- Place a section heading before 1:1. Here are some other examples of section headings:

The beginning of the book

The LORD revealed his words to Micah

- Do not place any heading before 1:1. Instead, place the first heading before 1:2. See the examples in the note on Section 1:2-7. The Notes and many English versions follow this approach. You may follow either approach in your translation.

Micah 1:1 is similar to the first verses of books by other prophets. For example see Hosea 1:1, Joel 1:1, Zephaniah 1:1, Haggai 1:1, Zechariah 1:1, and Isaiah 1:1. If you have already translated some of these verses, consider using a similar style here.

1:1

This is the word of the LORD that came to Micah the Moreshite in the days of Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, kings of Judah—what he saw regarding Samaria and Jerusalem: This book contains the words spoken by Micah. Because of that, some translators have translated this verse using the pronouns "I" or "me." For example:

I am Micah from Moresheth. And this is the message about Samaria and Jerusalem that the Lord gave to me when Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah were the kings of Judah. (CEV)

This translation is not recommended, because some scholars believe that an editor added this verse after Micah's messages had been written down. For more details, see "The author, the date, and Micah's audience" in the introduction.

1:1a

This is the word of the LORD that came to Micah the Moreshite

- ¶ This is a word/message from Yahweh. It came/happened to Micah from the town/village of Moresheth
- ¶ These are the words/messages that Yahweh spoke to Micah, who was from Moresheth,
- ¶ In this book is written the message that Yahweh revealed to the prophet Micah from the town of Moresheth.

This is the word of the LORD that came to Micah the Moreshite: This verse part indicates that Micah's

messages were from the LORD. In Hebrew, the phrase the word of the LORD is emphasized by its position at the beginning of the verse. UBS (page 124). Try to keep this emphasis in your translation.

In the Hebrew, this clause is more literally, "the word of the LORD which was to Micah the Moreshite." In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this verse as a complete sentence, as in the BSB. Here are some other ways to translate this:

The Lord spoke his word to Micah, who was from Moresheth... (GW)

This is the prophetic message that the Lord gave to Micah of Moresheth. (NET)

word: In some languages, it may be more natural to use plural forms. Although the book is presented as a single message from the LORD, it is clear from 1:1 that Micah prophesied during the reigns of three different kings of Judah. Scholars agree that he gave a series of different prophecies and that he spoke to more than one group of people. For example:

These are the words of the Eternal One (Voice)

The Lord gave these messages to Micah of Moresheth... (NLT96)

LORD: The word LORD represents the Hebrew word "Yahweh," the personal name of God. In Hebrew, this is a proper name, not a title or general noun. See the discussion of Yahweh, the LORD, in the Introduction.

came: In Hebrew, this word is a form of the verb "to be." It is more literally "became" or "happened." TWOT (#491), NIDOTTE (#2118). It indicates here that Micah experienced messages from the LORD as powerful events that occurred in his life. WBC (page 14) says that

“the Hebrew language is action-oriented. Therefore the force here is that the word ‘happened,’ ‘came in power’ to Micah.” According to NAC (page 43), when the “word-event formula” occurs “in reference...to the coming of the Lord’s word,” it emphasizes the nature of that word as a historical event. In some languages, it may be possible to translate this idea with a word or expression other than came, “gave,” or “spoke.” For example:

happened to Micah

Micah experienced

Micah: This is the name of the prophet who spoke these messages to the people. Micah is a shortened form of Micaiah, which means “Who is like the LORD?” in Hebrew. The prophet Micah is also mentioned in Jeremiah 26:18–19, but there his name is spelled “Micaiah.” Most English versions spell his name as “Micah” in both places. There were several people named Micah in the Old Testament. There was another prophet who was named Micaiah (I Kings 22:8–28; 2 Chronicles 18:4–27). Most English versions spell that other prophet’s name “Micaiah.”

the Moreshite: Micah’s home town is named Moresheth. Most scholars think that it was a small town about 35 kilometers southwest of Jerusalem. Translate this phrase in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Micah, who was from the town of Moresheth (GNT)

Micah the Moresheth person.

1:1a–c (combined/reordered)

- These are the messages about the cities of Samaria and Jerusalem that Yahweh himself showed/revealed to Micah, a prophet from Moresheth. Yahweh gave Micah these messages during the reigns/ruling of Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah in the land/nation of Judah.

1:1b in the days of Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, kings of Judah—

- at different times during the kingship of Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah in Judah.

- during the years that King Jotham, King Ahaz, and King Hezekiah ruled/governed the nation of Judah.
- He delivered these messages when King Jotham ruled in the nation of Judah, then when King Ahaz ruled, and then when King Hezekiah ruled.

in the days of Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, kings of Judah: Micah proclaimed messages from the LORD at various times during the rule of these three kings. Hezekiah was the son of Ahaz, and Ahaz was the son of Jotham. It is difficult to know the exact dates when these three kings ruled, because sometimes before a king died his son began to rule as king together with his father. According to UBS (page 124), Jotham ruled as king from about 740 B.C. until 736 B.C. Ahaz ruled from 734 B.C. until 716 B.C. And Hezekiah ruled from 716 B.C. until 687 B.C. In 1:6–7, Micah predicted that the city of Samaria would be destroyed. Samaria was destroyed in 722 B.C. or 721 B.C., during the time that Ahaz was king in Judah. So we know that the LORD gave this message to Micah before that time. But we do not know the exact time that Micah received and delivered most of the messages in this book. He was probably a prophet for at least 20 years (the end of Jotham’s reign until the beginning of Hezekiah’s reign). But he may have been a prophet for longer than 50 years (from the beginning of Jotham’s reign until the end of Hezekiah’s reign). Waltke 2007 (page 34), whose dates differ slightly from UBS, suggests 53 years as the maximum limit. They ruled one after the other. They did not rule at the same time. If this is not clear in your translation, you may want to make this information explicit. For example:

He told/spoke these messages during the time that King Jotham ruled in Judah, until the time that King Ahaz ruled, and then during the time that King Hezekiah ruled.

in the days of: In this context, the Hebrew phrase in the days of refers to the period of time during which these particular kings ruled. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this information clearer. Here are some possible ways to do this:

- Use a noun other than days. For example:

...during the reigns/governing of Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, kings of Judah.

...during the time of...

...during the years of...

- Use a verb. For example:

...when kings Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah ruled/
reigned in Judah.

Use an expression that is natural in your language.

Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, kings of Judah: If it is more natural in your language, you can use the title “king” with each name, “King Jotham, King Ahaz, and King Hezekiah in Judah.” The story of these kings is written in the book of 2 Kings. For the story of King Jotham, see 2 Kings 15:32–38. For King Ahaz see 2 Kings 16:1–19. For King Hezekiah, see 2 Kings 18:1–20:20. The stories of these kings are also told in 2 Chronicles and in other parts of the Old Testament.

Judah: The name Judah here refers to the southern kingdom of Judah. In some parts of the Bible, the name “Judah” refers to one of Jacob’s twelve sons. In other parts of the Bible, the name “Judah” refers to the Jewish tribe that was descended from Judah. In the books of 1 and 2 Kings, 1 and 2 Chronicles, and in some books written by prophets such as Micah, the name “Judah” refers to the southern kingdom. In some languages, it may be helpful to identify Judah more explicitly. For example:

land of Judah

country of Judah

1:1c

what he saw regarding Samaria and Jerusalem:

- Micah saw this word/message about Samaria and Jerusalem in a vision.
- The words/messages mentioned above that he saw in visions described the cities of Samaria and Jerusalem.
- Yahweh caused Micah to see visions about the cities of Samaria and Jerusalem.

what he saw: There are two ways to interpret the referent of this relative clause:

1. The words what he saw refer to “The word of the LORD that came to Micah.” (1:1a). WBC (page 13). According to A&F (page 118), the strong consensus among translations and commentaries is that “the word of the LORD” is the antecedent of “which he saw.” A&F, however, prefer the view that Micah is the antecedent, which would result in “the word of the LORD” came to Micah “who had a vision (or

visions).” This (referring back) is what Micah saw concerning Samaria and Jerusalem. For example:

he received it in visions about Samaria and Jerusalem (REB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, KJV, NAB, NASB, NET, NIV, NRSV, REB, GNT)

1. The words what he saw refer forward to Micah’s vision about Samaria and Jerusalem. There is no explicit connection with “The word of the LORD...” For example:

The visions he saw concerned both Samaria and Jerusalem. (NLT) (GW, NCV, NJB, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include WBC, Waltke 2007, TOTC, NAC, and Hillers. Commentaries that support interpretation (2) include A&F and perhaps NICOT, whose translation (page 264) has “received by revelation concerning...”

It is important to understand the sense in which Micah saw the word that came to him from the LORD. There are different ways to interpret the meaning of the word in this context:

1. The word saw indicates that Micah saw the messages in the form of visions. The Hebrew word for saw (*hazah*) is related to the Hebrew words for “vision” (*hazon*) and “seer” (*hoze*). All three come from the same root (*hzh*). TOTC (page 165) prefers the auditory (hearing) interpretation, but states that the experience “could be accompanied by visions as well.” EBC (page 501) do not use the term “vision” here, but describe a type of prophecy “in which the prophet describes future events as though they are unfolding before his eyes.”

“...the vision he saw concerning Samaria and Jerusalem.” (NIV)

His visions about Samaria and Jerusalem. (NJB) (GW, NAB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB) In addition to these versions, all of which specify “vision(s),” the BSB, ESV, KJV, NASB, and NRSV all have “saw.” In the context of “seeing” the “word of the LORD,” the verb “saw” probably implies a vision or similar experience. The LXX also has “he saw.”

1. The word saw indicates in a general way that Micah received the messages. In other words, the LORD

revealed them to Micah in some way that is not stated. According to NICOT (page 265), the verb “see” is used as a technical term for prophecy. It refers “not only to visions but to the wider perception of divine revelation.” NAC (page 44) acknowledges that “the verb ‘saw’ by itself can occasionally mean ‘saw in a vision’” but prefers “the more general sense of receiving a divine revelation or a prophecy from the inspiring Spirit of the Lord.”

“The Lord revealed to Micah all these things about Samaria and Jerusalem.” (GNT)

These words/messages were made known to Micah about Samaria and Jerusalem. (GNT)

1. The word saw indicates that Micah “prophesied.” This third interpretation is supported by the Targum, which translates Micah 1:1c as “...who prophesied concerning....” A&F (page 118) think that the translation “who prophesied” (NJPS) is correct.

“...who prophesied concerning Samaria and Jerusalem.” (NJPS) (NET, NJPS)

1. The word saw indicates that Micah “heard” the messages. No versions follow this interpretation, but it is supported by several commentaries. CBC quotes NICOT (page 265), who comments that “see” is “a technical term of prophecy which developed to refer not only to visions but to the wider perception of divine revelation. In Micah’s case it was evidently of an auditory nature.” Waltke 1993 (pages 614–615) also interprets Micah’s experience as “auricular” (having to do with hearing). His reason is that “the Hebrew associates diverse sorts of vivid sensations with the eyes.”

The Display will follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. You may follow either interpretation (1) or (2). There is little difference in meaning between them.

regarding Samaria and Jerusalem:

- Micah talked about those two cities. He said that Samaria would be destroyed (1:6–7). He said that Jerusalem would be destroyed (3:12).
- Micah also talked to the people who lived in those two cities. He accused them of sinning. He warned them that the LORD would punish them. He also told them that the LORD would bless them again in the future.

- Samaria was the capital of Israel (the northern kingdom). Jerusalem was the capital of Judah (the southern kingdom). So Micah’s message was for all the people in those two countries.

You will probably want to translate the names Samaria and Jerusalem literally. For example:

about Samaria and Jerusalem

the cities of Samaria and Jerusalem

General Comment on 1:1a–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse. Here are two ways to do this:

- Put the time phrase (1:1b) at the beginning of the sentence. For example:

^{1b}During the time when kings Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah ruled over the nation of Judah, ^{1a}the LORD gave the following message to Micah from the village of Moresheth. ^{1c}This is the message that the LORD showed him in a vision about the cities of Samaria and Jerusalem.

- Put the time phrase (1:1b) at the end of the sentence. For example:

^{1a}These are messages from the LORD that Micah from Moresheth experienced. ^{1c}He saw them in a vision and he spoke/prophesied concerning Samaria and Jerusalem ^{1b}during the reigns of Kings Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah of Judah.

See “Overall structure of the book” in the Introduction for more details about the three divisions.

Micah 1:2

Section 1:2–7: The LORD will punish the people in Samaria

In the first paragraph of this section (1:2–5), Micah is the speaker. He began by telling the entire earth, with all its inhabitants, (1:2) to listen because the LORD would soon come down from heaven to accuse them. In 1:3–4, he continued to use vivid, figurative language to describe the LORD’s coming. In 1:5, he warned the whole nation of Israel, naming both Samaria and Jerusalem, that the LORD would judge them because of their idolatry and other sins. In the second paragraph (1:6–7), the speaker is the LORD. The LORD

warned Samaria that he would completely destroy the city.

The Notes have separate section headings for 1:2-7 and 1:8-16. Here are some other examples of section headings for 1:2-7:

Judgment on Samaria (CEV)

Judgment pronounced against Samaria (NRSV)

Several other English versions use a section heading for 1:2-16. You may follow either pattern. Here are some other examples of section headings for 1:2-16:

The Coming Destruction (ESV)

Grief over Samaria and Jerusalem (NLT)

The capital cities of Israel and Judah destroyed (GW)

1:2

Verses 1:2a and 1:2b are parallel commands. Verse 1:2c gives the reason for the commands in 1:2a-b.

1:2a-b (combined/reordered)

- All of you^(plur) people in all the nations of the world, listen carefully to the words that Lord Yahweh will speak.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^a Hear, **O peoples, all of you;**

^b listen, **O earth, and everyone in it!**

Hear...listen: These parallel commands both mean “listen carefully” or “pay attention.” Micah used the same Hebrew word for Hear in 3:1, 3:9, 6:1, and 6:2.

all of you...and everyone in it! These phrases emphasize and/or clarify the commands to “Hear” and “listen.”

1:2a

Hear, O peoples, all of you;

- ¶ Listen now, all of you^(plur) different groups of people in the various nations/countries.
- ¶ You people in all parts of the world whose languages are mutually different, it will be good if you listen.

Hear, O peoples, all of you: In Hebrew, the first phrase is literally “Hear, peoples.” The second phrase, all of you, adds emphasis. The second phrase is literally “all of them.” Hillers (page 16) and Waltke 2007 (pages 45-46) both point out that normal Hebrew syntax uses third-person pronouns in modifying clauses following a vocative. Waltke notes that lack of the definite article in both parallel vocatives can be attributed to the “terse prophetic style.” It refers here to all the people groups or nations of the world. In some cases, these “people groups” may be described in terms of different languages. For example:

groups of people who speak mutually different languages

Many English versions supply a word such as “you” (NIV) or O to indicate that Micah is addressing the peoples directly and wants them to start listening to his words.

In some languages, it may not be natural to address people groups in this way. Here are some ways to address the people directly as well as to emphasize all of them:

All of you people must listen!

Listen, everybody!

In some languages, it may be necessary for a verb like “hear” to have an object. If that is true in your language, here are some ways to make an object explicit:

Hear this message...

Listen to what God says...

1:2b

listen, O earth, and everyone in it!

- Listen carefully, all of you^(plur) who live on earth.
- All of you who inhabit the earth, pay attention to these words.

listen, O earth, and everyone in it: The phrase and everyone in it is literally “and its fullness” or “and what fills it.” WBC (page 15) glosses the literal Hebrew text as “all her fullness.” JFB (page 688) has “whatever fills it.” BART glosses the construct noun as “what fills it.” There are two main ways to interpret this verse part:

1. Micah is using a poetic way to address all the people on the earth. For example:

...listen, earth and all who live in it. (NIV11)

...earth and everyone on it (NJB) (BSB, GW, NCV, NET, NIV11, NJB, NLT96, REB, GNT) Most versions listed under this interpretation use words such as “everyone” and “all who.” In the opinion of the TN editor, the NET “all inhabitants of earth” refers primarily to human inhabitants, but technically, according to Webster’s, an inhabitant is “a person or animal that inhabits some specified region, dwelling, etc.” So the NET rendering may include animals as well as people.

1. Micah is addressing the earth and all created things on it, including people, animals, mountains, trees, rivers, etc. For example:

listen, O earth, and all it contains (NASB)

Earth and everything on it, pay close attention. (CEV) (CEV, ESV, NAB, NLT, KJV, NASB, NJPS, NRSV) Most versions listed under this interpretation use words such as “everything” and “all that.”

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Many commentaries do not speak to this issue. Others make statements that could support either interpretation. NAC (page 48) clearly favors interpretation (1). It says: “The addressees are ‘all peoples,’ a reference to all nations, as shown by the parallel (more literally ‘those who fill the earth’).” KD (page 289–290) agrees with NAC, WBC, and Waltke 2007 that the phrase “those who fill with earth” supports the view that “all peoples” refer to all nations, not to all tribes of Israel, but he thinks that “the whole earth, and all creatures upon it, are to hear, because the judgment which the prophet has to announce to Israel affects the whole earth.” With this view, the command to pay careful attention must be understood as highly personified, since mountains and non-human creatures cannot literally “listen” to what the Sovereign LORD says in the more literal sense that peoples/nations can listen. There are at least two reasons:

General Comment on 1:2a–b

1. The parallel line (1:2a) clearly refers to the people groups or nations of the world rather than to the earth or other created things. With interpretation

(1), the parallel parts in 1:2b have the same reference.

2. The context that follows these parallel commands deals primarily with Israel and Judah and with other nations. It assumes that Micah’s audience will be able to pay attention and respond to this first message. The second message begins at 3:1. It is addressed to the leaders of Jacob/Israel. The third message begins at 6:1. Like the other messages, it presents a legal case, this time the LORD’s case against Israel. It corresponds somewhat to interpretation (2) in 1:2b, because it urges the mountains and foundations of the earth to listen to the LORD as he presents his case.

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these two parallel lines. For example:

All you people on earth, you from all the nations,
listen carefully.

1:2c

May the Lord GOD bear witness against you, the Lord from His holy temple.

- The Lord Yahweh, who is in his holy temple, will testify/witness against you^(plur).
- Hear what Lord/King Yahweh says as he accuses/judges you from the holy place where he lives.
- Yahweh the all-powerful King will tell about the evil things you have done. He will speak from the special place that is set apart as his own home.

May the Lord GOD bear witness against you: In this verse part, Micah implied that the people should listen to the testimony that the Lord was about to give. Some of these words are found in 1:6–7.

There are textualThe MT, two different Hebrew manuscripts, and the LXX all differ in the way they understand the initial word (wih) in this verse part. TN has focused on the main textual and interpretation issues rather than complicating the discussion. See Waltke 2007 (page 45) for more details. In addition to these textual issues, the LXX has “among you for a testimony” rather than “a witness against you.” The REB has “so that the Lord GOD...may bear witness among you.” The rendering “among you” is not supported by other English versions used in TN or by most scholars. and interpretation issues that affect the function of this verse part and its relationship to Micah’s commands in 1:2a–b to listen carefully. The Notes will discuss these issues together. Here are the main interpretations:

1. This verse part is a statement that the Lord GOD will testify against the people. For example:

The Lord GOD will be a witness against you (NCV) (CEV, GW, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB, GNT)

1. This verse part is an indirect, third-person request. It expresses Micah's prayer or desire that the Lord GOD will testify against the people. For example:

and let the Lord GOD be a witness against you (ESV) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NABRE, NASB, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. In this context, this kind of jussive constructive ("and let...") normally functions like an imperfect (non-past) verb. NICOT (page 266), WBC (page 15), and A&F (page 132) translate this clause as a jussive but give no justification. Waltke 2007 (page 45) and NET footnote (c) give reasons that support the majority of English versions. With both interpretations, it is implied from 2:1a-b that the people should listen carefully to the Lord's testimony against them.

There is more than one way to interpret the relationship between Micah's commands in 1:2a-b that the people listen and the statement in 1:2c that the Lord GOD would testify against them:

1. The connection is not explicit. It should be left implied. For example:

Yahweh intends to give evidence against you (NJB)

The Sovereign Lord will testify against you. (GNT) (BSB, CEV, GW, NCV, NET, NJB, NLT, GNT)

1. The statement in 1:2c gives the reason why Micah told the people to listen in 1:2a-b. For example:

for I AM will become a witness against you Waltke 2007 (page 44).

1. The statement in 1:2c gives the purpose why the people should heed the commands in 1:2a-b. For example:

that the Sovereign Lord may witness against you (NIV) (NIV, REB)

The Display will follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. It will leave the relationship unspecified. You may follow either interpretation (1) or (2). In many languages, a reason will be implied whether or not 1:2c is introduced with a word such as "for" or "because."

One reason not to follow interpretation (3) is that a purpose word or phrase like "that" or "so that" may wrongly imply that if the people did not listen, the LORD would not testify.

Lord GOD: In Hebrew, this double name, 'adonay yhwh, is used over 280 times in the Old Testament to refer to God. The word 'adonay means "lord/master." The word yhwh is God's personal name.

Most English versions follow the tradition of using "LORD" instead of "Yahweh" (yhwh). Since it is awkward to have an expression such as Lord LORD, most English versions use one expression to indicate God's authority and another one to translate his own name. For example:

Sovereign Lord (NLT)

Lord GOD (NCV)

Almighty Lord (GW)

See the note on "Yahweh, the LORD" in the Introduction.

bear witness against you: This phrase is usually used in a courtroom. It figuratively describes God as a lawyer who is presenting a case in a trial. Micah told all people to listen to the evidence that God will present. This evidence will prove that all people were guilty of doing evil.

In some languages, this courtroom language may be confusing, because God is the judge as well as the lawyer. If this is true in your language, you may want to use a more general expression. For example:

The Almighty LORD accuses/judges you

The Lord Yahweh will declare that what you have done wrong

the Lord from His holy temple: The word Lord here is 'adonay, the same as in the first part of 1:2c. The Lord was in His holy temple when he spoke as a witness against the people. He would speak from that location.

This phrase contains implied information from the first part of 1:2c. In some languages, it may be more natural to make this information explicit. For example:

The Lord will be a witness from his holy temple.
(GW)

Listen! He speaks from his holy temple. (adapted from GNT)

His holy temple: This phrase refers here to heaven, the LORD's dwelling place, not to the temple in Jerusalem. In 1:3, Micah described God leaving "his place" ("his home" in the NJB) and coming down to the earth. So it is logical that the phrase His holy temple in 1:2c also refers to heaven, the place where God lives. If possible, do not specify in your translation that the temple is in heaven or in Jerusalem.

holy: God's temple is called holy because it is special, set apart to be his dwelling place. In most languages, you will be able to use the same term for holy that you used for "holy temple" or "holy place" elsewhere in Scripture.

temple: The Hebrew word that is translated here as temple refers to a large magnificent building. In some OT passages, it refers to a palace, the home of a king. In this verse, where it refers to the home of the great king, God, there is little practical difference between "palace" and temple. NIDOTTE (#2121). According to TWOT (#493), the Hebrew word *hekal* is a loan from Sumerian/Akkadian that occurs 80 times. It "essentially represents a king's dwelling quarters, i.e. a palace." NIDOTTE clarifies that it refers to "palace" in only 15 OT passages. TWOT agrees that "God's true temple and throne are in heaven" and lists Micah 1:2 specifically in support of that statement. Almost all English versions translate it as temple. Exceptions are the NET "his majestic palace" and NJPS "his holy abode." Here are some other ways to translate "his holy temple":

his holy house/home

the holy place where he lives

the special place that is set apart as his own home

General Comment on 1:2c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine the first and last phrases of this verse part. For example:

The Lord Yahweh accuses you from his holy temple. (adapted from the CEV).

Micah 1:3

Section 1:2-7: The LORD will punish the people in Samaria

In the first paragraph of this section (1:2-5), Micah is the speaker. He began by telling the entire earth, with all its inhabitants, (1:2) to listen because the LORD would soon come down from heaven to accuse them. In 1:3-4, he continued to use vivid, figurative language to describe the LORD's coming. In 1:5, he warned the whole nation of Israel, naming both Samaria and Jerusalem, that the LORD would judge them because of their idolatry and other sins. In the second paragraph (1:6-7), the speaker is the LORD. The LORD warned Samaria that he would completely destroy the city.

The Notes have separate section headings for 1:2-7 and 1:8-16. Here are some other examples of section headings for 1:2-7:

Judgment on Samaria (CEV)

Judgment pronounced against Samaria (NRSV)

Several other English versions use a section heading for 1:2-16. You may follow either pattern. Here are some other examples of section headings for 1:2-16:

The Coming Destruction (ESV)

Grief over Samaria and Jerusalem (NLT)

The capital cities of Israel and Judah destroyed (GW)

1:3a-b

For behold, the LORD comes forth from His dwelling place; He will come down and tread on the high places of the earth: The previous verse described a courtroom where the Lord GOD will act simultaneously as a prosecuting attorney, witness, and judge. Here in 1:3a-b, Micah figuratively described the LORD as a warrior who would come from heaven to defeat

and establish control over the whole earth. ZIBBC, JFB, IVPB, A&F, and NAC are among the commentaries that draw attention to the LORD's metaphorical role in this verse as a military commander that subdues the earth.

1:3a

For behold, the LORD comes forth from His dwelling place;

- Look! Yahweh is already beginning to come out of the place where he lives in heaven.
- Pay attention, because Yahweh will soon leave that place,

For behold: Verse 1:2c already implies a reason why the people should listen. The word For introduces a further reason why they should begin to listen.

The word behold here has the basic meaning "Look!" It indicates that Micah's words were urgent. It was as if all people could look up in the sky at that moment and see the LORD coming down out of heaven.

Here are some ways to translate the function of these words:

- Make both words explicit. For example:

For see, the Lord comes forth... (NAB)

- Make only one word explicit. For example:

Look! The Lord is coming... (NIV)

- Leave both words implied. For example:

The Lord is coming... (GNT)

With any of these options, be sure that your translation clearly expresses the urgent reason for the people to pay close attention to what will happen.

the LORD comes forth from: This phrase indicates an action that could take place at any time in the near future. NAC (page 50). Waltke 2007 (page 47) concurs that this participial phrase "denotes imminent action." Here are some other ways to translate it:

the LORD is about to come

the LORD is starting to come

the LORD will come very soon

His dwelling place: This phrase refers to the place where God lives in heaven. It refers to the same thing as the phrase "His holy temple" in 1:2c.

1:3b

He will come down and tread on the high places of the earth.

- He will come down to the earth to walk on the high places.
- and he will come down to the earth. His feet will step on the tops of the hills and mountains.

He will come down and tread on the high places

of the earth: This phrase indicates that the LORD will come down from heaven and tread on (stride across and step/walk on) the high places of the earth. Deuteronomy 33:29 and Amos 4:13 also talk about God treading on the high places. According to most scholars, this action symbolizes the LORD's conquest and control of the earth. These scholars include JFB, IVPB, KD, NICOT, NAC, and Waltke 2007.

high places: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as high places can refer to either the tops of hills and mountains or to pagan shrines/altars, where people worshiped other gods. These shrines were called high places because people usually built them on the upper slopes or tops of hills or mountains. Sometimes such shrines were called "high places" even if the shrine was in a valley (see Jeremiah 7:31). The Canaanite and Philistine people who lived near the Jews in Palestine worshiped their gods at high places (for example, see Numbers 33:52; Jeremiah 48:35). Later the Jews also began to worship at such high places. Sometimes they worshiped the LORD at high places, especially before the temple was built in Jerusalem (for example, see 1 Samuel 9:12; 1 Kings 3:3-4). Many Jews also began to worship the false gods that the Canaanites worshiped (for example, see 1 Kings 11:7; 22:43). This is one of the sins that Micah accused the Jews of in this book.

In the context of the phrase "of the earth" and "the mountains" in v.4, the phrase high places probably refers primarily to the tops of hills and mountains. However, the mention in v.5 of the centers of idol worship in Samaria and Jerusalem probably also implies the LORD's defeat of idol worship. WBC (page 17) and ZIBBC (pages 123-124) think that Micah also intended "high places" to refer to pagan places of worship. See EBC (pages 503-504) for succinct and coherent arguments in favor of both implications. It is recommended that you translate this phrase in a general way. For example:

the high places of the earth (ESV)

the tops of the mountains (GNT)

on the hills and mountains

Do not use a phrase such as “the worship places of the earth” (GW) or “every pagan altar” (CEV) that can refer only to idol worship. It is recommended that you add a footnote that clarifies the two implied meanings. For example:

The Hebrew word used here means “high places.” Most scholars think that it refers here to hills or mountains. Some scholars think that it also refers to the pagan altars that were located there.

Micah 1:4

Section 1:2–7: The LORD will punish the people in Samaria

In the first paragraph of this section (1:2–5), Micah is the speaker. He began by telling the entire earth, with all its inhabitants, (1:2) to listen because the LORD would soon come down from heaven to accuse them. In 1:3–4, he continued to use vivid, figurative language to describe the LORD’s coming. In 1:5, he warned the whole nation of Israel, naming both Samaria and Jerusalem, that the LORD would judge them because of their idolatry and other sins. In the second paragraph (1:6–7), the speaker is the LORD. The LORD warned Samaria that he would completely destroy the city.

The Notes have separate section headings for 1:2–7 and 1:8–16. Here are some other examples of section headings for 1:2–7:

Judgment on Samaria (CEV)

Judgment pronounced against Samaria (NRSV)

Several other English versions use a section heading for 1:2–16. You may follow either pattern. Here are some other examples of section headings for 1:2–16:

The Coming Destruction (ESV)

Grief over Samaria and Jerusalem (NLT)

The capital cities of Israel and Judah destroyed (GW)

1:4

This verse describes what will happen when the LORD figuratively appears as the conqueror and judge of the earth and walks on the mountains. This poetic language is called a theophany. Several places in the Old Testament describe the LORD’s coming like an earthquake or like a violent storm. One of the most well-known passages is Psalm 18:7–16. The results are described as a combination of earthquakes, thunderstorms, and/or volcanic eruptions. JFB (page 688), A&F (page 166), UBS (page 131). A&F (page 159–160) describe this verse as a “composite of images” that are not necessarily consistent. He thinks that they derive from the three major comparisons that identify the presence of God in 1 Kings 19:11–12: “earthquake, wind (that is, hurricane with torrential rain) and fire (lightning).” The mountains will melt (1:4a), and the valleys will split apart (1:4b).

This verse has four poetic lines:

^{4a} The mountains will melt beneath Him,

^{4b} and the valleys will split apart,

^{4c} like wax before the fire,

^{4d} like water rushing down a slope.

The first two lines (1:4a–b) mention events that will happen. The last two lines (1:4c–d) are two similes that refer to these events. There are two main interpretations of these similes:

1. The simile in 1:4c describes the event in 1:4a (“the mountains will melt”). The simile in 1:4d describes the event in 1:4b (“the valleys will split apart”). For example:

^{4a}Mountains will melt under him ^{4c}like wax near a fire. ^{4b}Valleys will split apart ^{4d}like water pouring down a steep hill. (GW) (CEV, GW, REB)

1. The two similes in 1:4c–d both describe the event in 1:4a (the mountains will melt). For example:

^{4a}The mountains will disintegrate beneath him, ^{4b}and the valleys will be split in two. ^{4c}The mountains will melt like wax in a fire, ^{4d}the rocks will slide down like water flows down a steep slope. (NET) (NET, NLT, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most commentaries. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include UBS, NAC, JFB, ZIBBC, KD, and Waltke 2007. A&F support interpretation (2). They comment on page 159 that the simile of “water cascading down a sluice does not make sense” in reference to valleys that are split apart. Footnote (d) in the NET also supports interpretation (2). Waltke 2007 (page 49) and Waltke 1993 (pages 618–619) describe the effect of heavy rainfall in Palestine as the water flows down a steep slope. He and other commentaries that support interpretation (1) apparently think that the simile does make sense. UBS (page 131) says that “water pouring down a hill is probably intended to bring to mind a heavy thunderstorm.” In addition to these main interpretations, WBC (pages 17–18), whose description of rainfall matches that of Waltke, advocates the view that both similes apply to the valleys. With this interpretation, the poetic lines are balanced. Each event has a simile that corresponds to it. UBS (page 130).

Most English versions are ambiguous. They do not clearly express that 4a is connected with 4c, and 4b with 4d. These versions include: BSB, KJV, NAB, NASB, NIV, NJB, NJPS, and NRSV.

1:4a,c; 1:4b,d

The mountains will melt beneath Him,

- Then the mountains will melt under his feet,
- The mountains that he steps on will become soft/liquid,
- In the place where he walks, the rocks of the mountains will become like mud,

The Notes will discuss lines 1:4a and 1:4c together here to make it easier to see the connection between the event (1:4a) and the simile (1:4c). The Notes will follow the same pattern for 1:4b and 1:4d.

This verse starts with the Hebrew waw, which introduces what will happen after the LORD walks on the high places of the earth (1:3b). Some languages may express this relationship without a conjunction. For example:

Beneath him, the mountains melt (NJB)

Introduce what will happen in a natural way in your language.

The mountains will melt beneath Him: The figurative heat or intensity of the LORD’s anger will cause the mountains to melt. They will become soft and liquid. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Mountains will melt beneath his feet... (CEV)

The mountains will become soft where he walks.

The places where his feet touch the mountains will become like liquid/mud

1:4a–d (combined/reordered)

- When that happens, the mountains will become soft beneath him like a candle that is placed close to a fire. Wide/Deep cracks/gullies will also appear in the flat land between the mountains. It will look like a place where water has flowed down the side of a mountain/cliff.

1:4b and the valleys will split apart,

- and the lowlands/plains will split apart.
- and wide/deep chasms/ravines will suddenly appear in the flat lands.

and the valleys will split apart: This is the second thing that will happen after the LORD walks on the high places (1:3b). The valleys will “split open” (ESV), “crack open” (NCV), or “are torn open” (NJB).

This description of the valleys probably refers to the results of an earthquake and/or soft or watery material that flows down from the mountains to the land below, eroding the ground into deep gullies. See the preceding note on 1:4 regarding the combination of events.

Try to translate in a way that can refer to one or more of these events. For example:

Valleys will split apart (GW)

valleys are torn open (REB)

there will be cracks and deep gullies in the lowlands/plains

valleys: In Hebrew, this word refers to land that is between mountains or to land where there are no mountains. English versions translate it here as valleys. You may use any word or phrase in your language that normally contrasts with mountains. For example:

valleys

open lands

prairies/plains

lowlands

1:4c

like wax before the fire,

- The mountains will become like wax/ice that is heated by a fire,
- The way that the mountains will soften/melt can be compared to beeswax/resin that a person places near a fire.

like wax before the fire: When wax is put close to a fire, it quickly becomes soft and liquid.

wax: Bees use the substance called wax to make honeycomb. Beeswax or a similar wax are used to make candles. If there is no word for wax in your language, here are some other ways to translate it:

- Borrow the word from another language, such as the national language.
- Replace this simile with a different one. Use the name of something that melts easily when heated near a fire, such as ice, butter, or resin.
- Translate without a simile. For example:

The mountains will quickly become soft and melt

If possible, use a simile to help the readers picture the event more vividly.

1:4d

like water rushing down a slope.

- and the lowlands/plains will be like land/places where water has gushed/rushed down a steep hill.
- The result is that these flat lands will resemble areas/places where water has flowed rapidly downward and severely eroded the ground.

like water rushing down a slope: This simile describes how the melted or crumbled rocks of the mountains flow rapidly down a steep hill.

water: In Hebrew, this word is the ordinary word for water. In this context, it refers to the water, mud, or lava that flows down from the mountains.

rushing down a slope: In Hebrew, the phrase rushing down is a single word. It means “to flow downhill.” Here are some other ways to translate this simile:

like water cascading down a slope (NET)

as when torrents pour down a hillside (REB)

The point of this simile is the destructive result of the rapid downhill flow. You may use any word or phrase in your language that can refer to rushing water, mud in a landslide, or lava. Use an expression that will help your readers understand the violence of this event.

General Comment on 1:4a–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder of the parts of this verse so that each simile directly follows the event that it describes. For example:

^{4a}Then the mountains will melt under his feet

^{4c}like wax that is held close to a fire.

^{4b}The valleys will split apart

^{4d}like when rushing water flows downhill.

See 1:4a–d (combined/reordered) in the Display for another example.

Micah 1:5

Section 1:2–7: The LORD will punish the people in Samaria

In the first paragraph of this section (1:2–5), Micah is the speaker. He began by telling the entire earth, with all its inhabitants, (1:2) to listen because the LORD would soon come down from heaven to accuse them. In 1:3–4, he continued to use vivid, figurative language to describe the LORD’s coming. In 1:5, he warned the whole nation of Israel, naming both Samaria and Jerusalem, that the LORD would judge them because of their idolatry and other sins. In the second paragraph (1:6–7), the speaker is the LORD. The LORD warned Samaria that he would completely destroy the city.

The Notes have separate section headings for 1:2–7 and 1:8–16. Here are some other examples of section headings for 1:2–7:

Judgment on Samaria (CEV)

Judgment pronounced against Samaria (NRSV)

Several other English versions use a section heading for 1:2-16. You may follow either pattern. Here are some other examples of section headings for 1:2-16:

The Coming Destruction (ESV)

Grief over Samaria and Jerusalem (NLT)

The capital cities of Israel and Judah destroyed (GW)

1:5a-f

This verse has six poetic lines. The first two lines give the reason for the coming judgment of the LORD that is described in 1:4a-d. In 1:5a-b, 1:5b restates the meaning of 1:5a. In 1:5c-d, the question in 1:5c repeats the person named in 1:5a, and the answer in 1:5d corresponds to the capital of the nation that bears his name. The question in 1:5e unexpectedly includes Judah as the southern part of the nation of Israel as a whole, and the answer in 1:5f corresponds to the capital of that southern part:

^{5a}All this is for the transgression of **Jacob**

^{5b}and the sins of **the house of Israel**.

^{5c}What is the transgression of **Jacob**?

^{5d}Is it not Samaria?

^{5e}And what is the high place of **Judah**?

^{5f}Is it not Jerusalem?

1:5a-b (combined/reordered)

- All these things will happen because of the wicked disobedience of the descendants of Jacob, the people of Israel.
- All this will happen because the people of Israel have sinned and rebelled against Yahweh. (GNT, slight adaptation)

There are two main ways to interpret the underlined parts, transgression and sins, and the parts in bold print, **Jacob** and **the house of Israel**:

1. The parallel parts in these two lines refer to the same thing. The words “transgression” and “sins” refer to the same crime or offense. The names

“Jacob” and “the house of Israel” refer to the same people. For example:

All this will happen because the people of Israel have sinned and rebelled against God. (GNT) (CEV, NCV, NIV, NJB, NLT, GNT) Versions such as the NCV, NIV, and NJB have been listed here, because they do not connect the parallel parts or lines with the word “and” in a way that normally indicates two separate things.

1. The parallel parts in these two lines refer to different things. The words “transgression” and “sins” seem to refer to different crimes or offenses. The name “Jacob” refers to the people of the northern kingdom, and “the house of Israel” refers to the people of the southern kingdom. For example:

All this is because of Jacob’s rebellion and the sins of the nation of Israel. (NET) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NET, NJPS, NRSV, REB) With the possible exception of the NLT96, which may be ambiguous, the other versions listed here do connect the parallel parts or lines with the word “and” in a way that normally indicates two separate things.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is true that Micah referred to the capitals of the northern and southern kingdoms in 1:5c-d, but the names “Jacob” and “house of Israel” in 1:5a-b do not clearly refer to those two kingdoms. It is more likely that both names refer to all of Israel, that is, all the Jews, both north and south. Micah used the name “Jacob” in ten other places in his book. In several verses, he used the names “Jacob” and “Israel” as parallel terms (besides 1:5, see also 2:12; 3:1; 3:8; 3:9). In these other verses “Jacob” and “Israel” do not refer to the northern and southern kingdoms, but rather both refer to all of the Jews. Many commentaries follow this interpretation. Commentaries agree that the name Israel is another name for Jacob. UBS, JFB, NICOT, and A&F support the view that Israel and Judah are used together to represent the entire nation of Israel. Waltke 2007 and NAC prefer the view that the first mention of Israel refers specifically to the northern kingdom, whereas the mention of Judah links the southern kingdom to the nation as a whole. Here are some other ways to translate 1:5a-b:

^{5a}All this is because of the crime of Jacob, ^{5b}the sin of the House of Israel. (NJB)

^{5a}And why is this happening? Because of the rebellion of Israel—^{5b}yes, the sins of the whole nation. (NLT)

1:5a

All this is for the transgression of Jacob

- All this will happen because the descendants of Jacob have disobeyed God's laws.
- Yahweh will do all this because the people of Israel have rebelled against him.

transgression: In Hebrew, this word means “disobedience of a law” or “rebellion against a king or other leader.” In this verse, it refers to the fact that the Jews had transgressed (disobeyed) God's laws. They had rebelled against the LORD. In some languages, it may be better to translate this with a verb. For example:

All this has happened because Jacob's descendants have rebelled against the LORD.

Jacob: Jacob is the name of Abraham's grandson whom God later renamed Israel (see Genesis 35:10). The name Jacob here represents all of Jacob's descendants, the people of Israel. Micah used the name Jacob to mean the people of Israel ten other times in his book. Besides here in 1:5a, see 1:5c; 2:7; 2:12; 3:1; 3:8; 3:9; 4:2; 5:7; 5:8; 7:20. It does not refer to the man Jacob himself.

Here are some ways to translate the name Jacob:

Jacob's descendants

Israel (GNT)

the people/nation of Israel

1:5b

and the sins of the house of Israel.

- It is because the nation of Israel has sinned.
- Yes, the Israelites have done wicked things.

and the sins of the house of Israel: See the note above on 1:5a–b. The word sins is a general word. It restates the more specific meaning of “rebellion” in 1:5a. In some languages, it may be better to translate 1:5b as a separate sentence. For example:

Yes, the people of Israel have sinned.

the house of Israel: The word house here means “nation” or “people.” Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Israelites

the people of Israel

the nation of Israel (NCV)

General Comment on 1:5a–b

The GNT (quoted above) gives an example where “Jacob” and “Israel” have been combined into one term. Here is an example where “transgressions” and “sins” have been combined into one term:

This will happen because of the terrible sins of Israel, the descendants of Jacob. (CEV)

1:5c–f

These four lines are rhetorical questions that made the audience think about the nature and cause of the rebellion of the Israelites. For Micah's original hearers and readers, these rhetorical questions were vivid and emphatic. The four questions occur in two pairs. In each pair of questions, the second question answers the first question by asking another question that expects the answer “Yes.”

1:5c–d

What is the transgression of Jacob? Is it not Samaria?: There are at least three ways to interpret the meaning of the first question:

1. It means “What (or who) is the cause of Jacob's transgression?” or “Who is to blame for his crime?” For example:

Who is to blame for Israel's rebellion? Samaria, the capital city itself! (GNT) (CEV, NLT, GNT)

1. It means “What transgression did Jacob commit?” or “What did Jacob do to transgress God's laws?” For example:

What is Jacob's crime? Isn't it Samaria? (GW) (BSB, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, REB)

1. It means “What (or where) is the place of Jacob's transgression?” For example:

What is the place of Jacob's sin? Isn't it Samaria?
(NCV) (NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is the best way to understand the Hebrew text. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as "who" is usually translated as "who." JFB (page 586) says that the Hebrew is literally "Who is the transgression of Jacob?" and means "Who is its cause?" KD (page 427) says that this question means "Who is the author of Jacob's transgression?" and it is supported by a majority of commentaries. Commentaries that support the first interpretation (the cause of the crime) include KD, UBS, JFB, WBC, NAC, and Waltke 2007. EBC supports the second interpretation (the nature of the crime). Commentaries that support the third interpretation (the place of the crime) include NICOT, A&F, and perhaps Hillers.

Here are some other ways to translate interpretation (1):

Who is to blame for Israel's rebellion? Samaria, its capital city! (NLT)

Samaria has led Israel to sin (CEV)

If you decide to follow interpretation (2), here are two possible ways to translate it:

How have Jacob's descendants rebelled? Look at the people in Samaria!

In what way have Jacob's descendants rebelled?
The people in Samaria are an example!

1:5c

What is the transgression of Jacob?

- What caused the descendants of Jacob to disobey God's laws?
- Who led the people of Israel to rebel?

What is the transgression of Jacob?: The phrase transgression of Jacob is the same phrase that Micah used in 1:5a. If possible, translate this phrase in a similar way.

1:5d

Is it not Samaria?

- Is it not the people in Samaria the capital? Of course it is!
- It is the people/rulers in Samaria, the capital city.

Is it not Samaria?: There are at least two ways to answer this question. These ways may not follow the unrelated interpretation choices followed for 1:5c.

- Use another rhetorical question that expects a "yes" answer. For example:

It is the people in Samaria, isn't it?

- Use a statement. For example:

Samaria epitomizes their rebellion! (NET)

It is the people who live in the city of Samaria!

Samaria: Micah used the name of this city here to refer to the people (or rulers) who lived there. Samaria was the capital city of the northern kingdom. The northern kingdom was usually called Israel. Some English versions make this information explicit. For example:

Samaria, the capital city itself! (GNT)

1:5e-f

And what is the high place of Judah? Is it not Jerusalem?: Before we consider the textual issue, note that the Hebrew text here uses the plural "high places." Most English versions use the singular high place, because the second question specifies Jerusalem.

There is a textual issue with the first question:

1. The Masoretic Text (MT) uses the Hebrew word translated as "high places." For example:

What is Judah's high place? (NIV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, GNT)

1. The LXX (Septuagint) uses the Greek word "sin." For example:

And what is the sin of the house of Judah? (RSV) (NAB, NJB, REB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow the first option along with most versions and commentaries.

1:5e

And what is the high place of Judah?

- And who are the ones who worship idols on the high places in Judah?
- Who are the people of Judah who sacrifice to other gods?

And what is the high place of Judah?: There are at least two ways to interpret this rhetorical question. They correspond to the first and third choices in 1:5c–d.

1. It means “Who is responsible for the high places in Judah?” This question can be sub-divided into two related questions: “Who worships idols at the high places?” and “Who/What causes the people to worship idols at the high places?” See the UBS Handbook for more details. For example:

Who is guilty of idolatry in Judah? (GNT)

...pagan altars at Jerusalem have made Judah sin (CEV) (CEV, GNT)

1. It means “Where...” or “In what place are the high places of Judah?”

What is Judah’s place of idol worship? (NCV) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation. It is the best way to understand the Hebrew text. It also corresponds better with the recommended interpretation for 1:5c. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as what is almost always translated as “who.” in the Old Testament.

If you decide to follow interpretation (2), here are two possible ways to translate it:

And what are the shrines of Judah but Jerusalem? (NJPS)

What is Judah’s worship place? Isn’t it Jerusalem? (GW)

high place: In 1:3b, Micah used the phrase “high places of the earth” to refer to the tops of hills and mountains. But here in 1:5e, Micah used high place to refer to a place where people worshiped idols. Here are some other ways to translate the Hebrew word for high place:

center of idolatry (NLT)

pagan worship centers (NET)

Judah: The name Judah refers to the southern kingdom. Micah used the name “Jacob” in 1:5a. He used the name “Israel” in 1:5b. He used “Jacob” in 1:5c. So the people who heard or read his prophecy probably expected him to use the name “Israel” again in 1:5e. But instead, he used the name “Judah.” The people in Judah considered the people in the northern kingdom (Israel) to be rebels against God. They were not surprised that God would punish the northern kingdom. But they thought that God loved the people in Judah and that he would never punish them. Here are some other ways to translate this name here:

the nation/people of Judah

1:5f Is it not Jerusalem?

- Is it not the people in Jerusalem, the capital city? Yes, it is!
- It is the people/rulers who live in the capital city of Jerusalem.

Is it not Jerusalem?: Jerusalem is the capital city of Judah. Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question:

General Comment on 1:5c–f

- Use a rhetorical question, as in the BSB. Supply other details, including the expected answer. For example:

Is it not the people of Jerusalem? Yes, it is!

- Use an exclamation. For example:

Jerusalem itself! (GNT)

- Use a complete statement, with or without an exclamation mark. For example:

It is the people of Jerusalem, the capital city!

In 1:5c–f, Micah used four rhetorical questions to convey his message vividly and forcefully. Here are some ways to translate these questions in your language:

- Translate all four questions as questions. Most literal English versions do this.
- Translate the first and third questions as questions, and the second and fourth questions as statements. For example:

^{5c}Who is to blame for Israel's rebellion? ^{5d}Samaria, its capital city! ^{5e}Where is the center of idolatry in Judah? ^{5f}In Jerusalem, its capital! (NLT)

^{5c}How have the people of Jacob rebelled against God, you ask? ^{5d}Those in the city of Samaria are the worst rebels! ^{5e}Where are Judah's pagan worship centers, you ask? ^{5f}Right in Jerusalem! (based on NET)

- Translate all four questions as statements. For example:

^{5c-d}Samaria has led Israel to sin, ^{5e-f}and pagan altars at Jerusalem have made Judah sin. (CEV)

^{5c-d}The people in the city of Samaria led the people of Israel to rebel ^{5e}against God. ^{5e-f}And the people of Judah worship idols/gods at altars in Jerusalem itself.

Micah 1:6

Section 1:2-7: The LORD will punish the people in Samaria

In the first paragraph of this section (1:2-5), Micah is the speaker. He began by telling the entire earth, with all its inhabitants, (1:2) to listen because the LORD would soon come down from heaven to accuse them. In 1:3-4, he continued to use vivid, figurative language to describe the LORD's coming. In 1:5, he warned the whole nation of Israel, naming both Samaria and Jerusalem, that the LORD would judge them because of their idolatry and other sins. In the second paragraph (1:6-7), the speaker is the LORD. The LORD warned Samaria that he would completely destroy the city.

The Notes have separate section headings for 1:2-7 and 1:8-16. Here are some other examples of section headings for 1:2-7:

Judgment on Samaria (CEV)

Judgment pronounced against Samaria (NRSV)

Several other English versions use a section heading for 1:2-16. You may follow either pattern. Here are some other examples of section headings for 1:2-16:

The Coming Destruction (ESV)

Grief over Samaria and Jerusalem (NLT)

The capital cities of Israel and Judah destroyed (GW)

Paragraph 1:6-7

The main point of this paragraph is that the LORD will destroy the city of Samaria as a result of the sins of the people of Israel (1:5).

In the previous paragraph (1:2-5), Micah was the speaker. But in this paragraph (1:6-7), the LORD is the one who speaks. You may want to make this explicit in your translation. For example:

So the Lord says, "I will make Samaria a pile of ruins... (GNT)

So I, the Lord, will make the city of Samaria a heap of ruins... (NLT)

Many modern English versions begin a new paragraph here at 1:6. Most English versions put quotation marks around 1:6-7 to show that someone is speaking. The CEV translates 1:6 as an indirect quote: "So the Lord will leave Samaria in ruins...He will scatter its stones..."

1:6a

Therefore I will make Samaria a heap of rubble in the open field,

- ¶ Therefore Yahweh says: "I will cause Samaria to become a pile of rocks/ruins in an empty/open field.
- ¶ So this is what Yahweh says, "Because of all these sins, I will destroy the city of Samaria. It will become an area/land that is empty and ruined,

Therefore: This word introduces the result of the people's sin. In English, another way to introduce this result is to use the word "So" (NJB). Some versions leave it implied that 1:6a is a result. For example:

I will make Samaria a stone heap in the field. (NAB)

Use a natural way in your language to clearly show that this paragraph is the result of the previous verse.

I will make Samaria a heap of rubble in the open field: This line means that the LORD will destroy the city so that nothing is left except a pile of ruins in a rural area. According to historical records, the Assyrian army attacked and destroyed Samaria in 722 B.C.

a heap of rubble in the open field: This phrase refers to rocks and other debris that remain after the buildings and walls of a city are destroyed. The city and the surrounding area will become like open field that can be used for farming, specifically a place where people can plant vineyards (see 1:6b). A&F (page 177) say that it will “revert to agriculture.” Waltke 2007 (pages 51–53) says that it will return to “its formerly unsettled condition” and will “again become a place for planting vineyards.” Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a ruin in the open country (REB)

a pile of ruins in the open country (GNT)

a heap of ruins in an open field (NET)

in ruins—merely an empty field (CEV)

1:6b

a planting area for a vineyard.

- It will be a place/area to plant vineyards.
- where people can plant and tend grape plants/vines,

a planting area for a vineyard: Vineyards are fields where people plant and tend grape vines. Grapes are a kind of fruit from which wine and raisins are made. In languages that do not use a word such as vineyards, translators may use a phrase. For example:

a place where people can plant grape plants/vines

If you have translated terms for grapes or vineyards in other parts of the Bible, you should use the same terms here.

1:6c

I will pour her stones into the valley

- I will cause the stones of its walls and buildings to tumble down into the valley,
- and I will roll/tumble the crumbled stones down to the bottom of the mountain/hill.

I will pour her stones into the valley: The main part of the city of Samaria was built on the upper part of a hill. The walls around the city and many of the buildings in the city were made of stones. The LORD will cause those stones to fall down to the valley that was downhill from the city.

pour: In Hebrew, this verb is the same word that Micah used in 1:4b. There he used in the phrase “like waters

rushing down a steep place.” Here in 1:6c, it is used of stones, not water. God will cause the stones to roll or tumble downhill. Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

I will tumble the rubble of her stone walls down into the valley... (NET)

I will roll the stones of her walls into the valley below... (NLT)

her stones: In Hebrew, the word for “city” is feminine, so some versions use the word her to refer to the stones that fell. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

its stones (GW)

the rubble of the city (GNT)

valley: In Hebrew, this is a different word than the one used in 1:4b. The word used here in 1:6c refers in this context to the open area downhill from the city. Here is another way to translate this word:

I will make the city’s stones roll down to the bottom of the hill/mountain.

1:6d

and expose her foundations.

- and I will make the city’s foundations bare.
- I will destroy Samaria’s walls so that her/its foundations have nothing left on top of them.

and: This word introduces the next thing that the LORD will do. It is also the result of 1:6c. The LORD will cause the city’s stones to tumble down into the valley. As a result, he will uncover the city’s foundations. For example:

I will roll the stones of her walls into the valley below, exposing her foundations. (1:6c–d, NLT)

expose her foundations: In Hebrew, the word expose means “to strip something so that it is exposed and bare.” When the LORD destroys Samaria and its rocks roll down into the valley, the foundations of the city walls and buildings will be bare. They will have nothing on top of them. The Hebrew word that is translated as expose here is also used to describe stripping off a person’s clothes. Some scholars say that Micah’s

words here picture Samaria as an immoral woman: God will strip her naked in public to punish and shame her.

foundations: The foundations are the lowest parts of the city walls and buildings. The walls and buildings are built on top of the foundations. If there is no term for foundations in your language, here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

until the bottom layer of stones has nothing on top of it

Then people will be able to see even the lowest layer of building stones.

Micah 1:7

Section 1:2-7: The LORD will punish the people in Samaria

In the first paragraph of this section (1:2-5), Micah is the speaker. He began by telling the entire earth, with all its inhabitants, (1:2) to listen because the LORD would soon come down from heaven to accuse them. In 1:3-4, he continued to use vivid, figurative language to describe the LORD's coming. In 1:5, he warned the whole nation of Israel, naming both Samaria and Jerusalem, that the LORD would judge them because of their idolatry and other sins. In the second paragraph (1:6-7), the speaker is the LORD. The LORD warned Samaria that he would completely destroy the city.

The Notes have separate section headings for 1:2-7 and 1:8-16. Here are some other examples of section headings for 1:2-7:

Judgment on Samaria (CEV)

Judgment pronounced against Samaria (NRSV)

Several other English versions use a section heading for 1:2-16. You may follow either pattern. Here are some other examples of section headings for 1:2-16:

The Coming Destruction (ESV)

Grief over Samaria and Jerusalem (NLT)

The capital cities of Israel and Judah destroyed (GW)

Paragraph 1:6-7

The main point of this paragraph is that the LORD will destroy the city of Samaria as a result of the sins of the people of Israel (1:5).

In the previous paragraph (1:2-5), Micah was the speaker. But in this paragraph (1:6-7), the LORD is the one who speaks. You may want to make this explicit in your translation. For example:

So the Lord says, "I will make Samaria a pile of ruins... (GNT)

So I, the Lord, will make the city of Samaria a heap of ruins... (NLT)

Many modern English versions begin a new paragraph here at 1:6. Most English versions put quotation marks around 1:6-7 to show that someone is speaking. The CEV translates 1:6 as an indirect quote: "So the Lord will leave Samaria in ruins...He will scatter its stones...."

1:7

Here is some background information that may be useful in translating this verse. The Jews were the LORD's special people. In many Old Testament passages, when the Jews worshiped idols or other gods, the LORD compared them to prostitutes. A prostitute sleeps with other men, so she is unfaithful to her husband. In the same way, if the LORD's people worshiped other gods, they were unfaithful to God.

During the time of Micah, the people who lived in some of the nations near Israel worshiped idols. In some of these nations, there were prostitutes who worked at the idol temples. People who came to worship the idols had sex with the prostitutes as part of their worship. The worshipers gave money and gifts to these prostitutes.

In the city of Samaria, the Jews also had built temples to worship idols. Temple prostitutes were probably part of their idol worship. Commentaries that support this view include UBS, ABC, NAC, and Waltke 2007.

1:7a-c (combined/reordered)

- Samaria's idols will be smashed, and her wealth gained by prostitution will be destroyed by fire,
- I will cause to be smashed/destroyed all the idols/images in Samaria, and I will cause to be completely burned all valuable things that the city and its people gained from their idolatry.

^{7a}All her carved images will be smashed to pieces;

^{7b}all her wages will be burned in the fire,

^{7c}and I will destroy all her idols.

The three parallel lines in 1:7a–c have similar meanings. Each statement begins with the word “all” to give extra emphasis. The LORD would destroy all the idols that the people in Samaria worshiped.

All her carved images...all her wages...all her idols:

The pronoun her used in these three phrases refers to the city of Samaria. Actually, these idols and images belonged to the people who lived in Samaria, not to the city itself. Refer to the city here in a natural way in your language. For example:

all its idols,

all the idols in the city

all of the idols that the people in Samaria worship

carved images...idols: In Hebrew, the words carved images in 1:7a and idols 1:7c both refer to objects that people made to worship. These idols could be carved out of rock or wood, or they could be made of metal. Some of them were overlaid with gold or silver. A&F (page 179) mention “wood carving, gilded or otherwise adorned with precious metal.” CBC (page 306) describes “statues of gods (or goddesses) carved from wood or stone (and sometimes overlaid with silver or gold).” English versions translate these two words in various ways. For example:

idols...images (NIV)

precious idols...images (GNT)

carved figures...idols (REB)

idols...statues (GW)

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder and/or combine the sentences about carved images (1:7a) and idols (1:7c) into one or two sentences. See the General Comment on 1:7a–c at the end of 1:7c.

will be smashed to pieces...will be burned...I will destroy: In Hebrew, the passive verbs in the first two

lines do not specify the one who beats and burns. Historically, it was the invading Assyrian army that did this. The third line specifies I as the one who lays waste. The LORD is the one who causes all three things to be done. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate all three verbs with the LORD (I) as the subject. For example:

I will smash into pieces...I will burn...I will destroy...

I will cause to be smashed into pieces...I will cause to be burned...I will cause to be destroyed...

1:7a

All her carved images will be smashed to pieces;

- All her/its images will be smashed.
- I will cause all the idols to be broken into pieces.

smashed to pieces: The Hebrew word for smashed to pieces means “to smash something,” “to hit it so that it breaks into pieces.” This word probably implies using a tool like a club.

1:7b

all her wages will be burned in the fire,

- All of Samaria’s earnings from prostitution will be completely burned up,
- I will cause all the valuable things at their idol-worship places to be put in a fire and burned.

wages: In this context, the word wages may have both literal and figurative meanings. It may refer literally to the wages and expensive gifts that were paid to prostitutes. These earnings enriched the city of Samaria and its inhabitants. At the same time, it may refer figuratively to the city’s idols and the wealth that came from idolatry. Commentaries that support a literal referent of temple prostitutes include ABC, UBS, CBC, NAC, and Waltke 2007. Hillers (page 20) suggests that the images used in worship in Samaria and the wealth assembled in the sanctuaries were contemptuously referred to as “whore’s fees.” “This is in part figurative (Yahweh as the husband of the faithless wife Israel). At the same time there is a literal component, in that sacred prostitution was practiced at the shrines.” IVPB (electronic edition, Micah 1:7) also mentions both figurative and literal options, though not necessarily occurring simultaneously.

If possible, translate 1:7b, d, and e in a way that allows the word wages to be understood either literally or figuratively.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Samaria earned her money by being unfaithful to me

all the gifts to her idols (NCV)

burned in the fire: In Hebrew, this phrase means “completely burned up.” In some languages, it may be redundant to specify in the fire. In other languages, it may not be necessary to specify “completely.” Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

will be burned (NLT)

destroyed by fire (NET)

burned until it is gone

Use an expression that is natural in your language.

1:7c

and I will destroy all her idols.

- and all the idols/statues that the people worship will be completely destroyed,
- I will also cause all the statues/carvings that the people worship to be destroyed.

I will destroy all her idols: In Hebrew, the phrase I will destroy means that the LORD will totally destroy all the idols in Samaria. Here are some other ways to translate this line:

I will destroy all her images. (NIV)

All its statues will be turned into a pile of rubble. (GW)

General Comment on 1:7a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these three poetic lines. For example, in the CEV, lines a and c have been combined, and line b is given last:

Samaria’s idols will be smashed, and the wages of temple prostitutes will be destroyed by fire. (CEV)

1:7d–e

The two parallel lines in 1:7d–e have similar meanings:

^{7d}Since she collected the wages of a prostitute,

^{7e}they will be used again on a prostitute.

The first line refers to the source of Samaria’s earnings. These earnings may be compared to the literal wages paid to prostitutes who worked in idol temples. At the same time, these earnings were figuratively gained by unfaithfulness to the LORD.

The second line refers to the future use of these earnings in idol worship elsewhere. The invading army will take the loot to their own country and use it for the similar purpose of idol worship involving prostitutes. UBS (page 135–137), JFB (page 688), NICOT (page 274), EBC (page 505), NAC (pages 52–53), Waltke 2007 (page 54).

1:7d

Since she collected the wages of a prostitute,

- because they collected all those things by being unfaithful to me.
- I will do that because the inhabitants of Samaria got those valuable things from being unfaithful to me, just like a prostitute gets money from sleeping with men who are not her husband.

Verse 1:7d begins with a Hebrew conjunction that is often translated as “for.” It indicates that 1:7d–e gives the reason for 1:7a–c. The Lord will destroy the idols and valuable things in Samaria because the people had gathered them as a result of their worship of idols involving temple prostitutes. Some versions make a conjunction such as “for” explicit. For example:

for she collected them from a harlot’s earnings... (NASB)

Other versions, such as the BSB, do not translate the conjunction. They leave the connection implicit. For example:

They were amassed out of prostitutes’ earnings (NJB)

Samaria acquired these things for its fertility rites (GNT)

Translate this in a natural way in your language to make the connection clear.

Since: In the Hebrew, the conjunction that the BSB translates as Since is at the beginning of 7e. This conjunction gives the result of 1:7d. The people gathered valuable things in their worship of idols, and so the LORD will cause those things to be taken away. Other people will use them to worship idols.

The BSB and some other English versions show the relationship between 1:7d and 1:7e by using a conjunction at the beginning of 1:7d. For example:

^{7d} Since she gathered her gifts from the wages of prostitutes, ^{7e} as the wages of prostitutes they will again be used. (NIV)

The emphasized word in the above translation is the conjunction that makes 1:7d the reason and 1:7e the result.

In some languages, it may be better to use a conjunction at the beginning of 1:7e. For example:

^{7d} Samaria acquired these things for its fertility rites, ^{7e} and now her enemies will carry them off for temple prostitutes elsewhere. (GNT)

she collected: The pronoun she refers to the city of Samaria. And Samaria represents the people who live in it. People brought money and other gifts to the idol temples in Samaria. The people in Samaria collected all these valuable things.

the wages of a prostitute: See the earlier note on 1:7d–e (first line) regarding the literal and figurative meanings of wages.

1:7e

they will be used again on a prostitute.

- Similarly, in the future other people will use those things to worship their own idols.”
- And so their enemies will take away those things and also use them to worship idols.”
- So that is why I will cause those things to be carried away by their enemies, who will use them to worship other idols.”

they will be used again on a prostitute: By these words, Micah implied that an enemy army would carry away the expensive things in the city that were used for idol worship and use them again for the same purpose.

Verses 1:7a–c have just described the smashing and burning of all idols and other expensive things, so it may be hard to understand how these things can be used again. One explanation is that the enemy soldiers stripped off the gold and silver coating before they smashed or burned the stone or wooden items. NICOT (page 274), JFB (page 688), Waltke 2007 (page 54). Another explanation is that 1:7a–c and 1:7d–e are both poetic ways to refer to “the ending of the false worship, together with the destruction of the

city where it was carried out. There is no real contradiction” (UBS, pages 135–137). In some languages, it may be helpful to supply a footnote that gives this explanation.

Micah 1:8

Section 1:8–16: Micah mourned because an enemy army will invade Judah and take many people into exile

In 1:5, Micah mentioned the sins of the people in Samaria and Jerusalem. In 1:6–7, he predicted that the LORD would destroy Samaria. Here in 1:8–16, he predicted that the LORD would also punish the people in Judah, including Jerusalem. He would punish them by causing an enemy army to invade Judah.

This section has two paragraphs: 1:8–9 and 1:10–16. In the first paragraph, Micah said that he would “lament and wail” (BSB). He described the way that he would mourn and then gave the reason. In the second paragraph, he mentioned several cities in Judah that an enemy army would soon attack on its way to Jerusalem. Some versions have separate section headings for each paragraph. The Notes will include both paragraphs as part of the same section. Here are some other examples of section headings for the entire section (1:8–16):

Lament for Jerusalem and the lowland towns (NJB)

Judah Is Doomed (CEV)

The Doom of the Cities of Judah (NRSV)

Micah mourned the disaster that will happen to various cities in Judah

If you choose to use separate section headings for 1:8–9 and 1:10–16, here are some examples for 1:8–9:

Weeping and Mourning (NIV, BSB)

Micah’s Great Sadness (NCV)

Either the CEV or NRSV headings above will be appropriate for 1:10–16. Here is another example:

Disaster will happen to various cities in Judah

Paragraph 1:8–9

In this paragraph, Micah described the sadness that he felt because of the disaster that would happen to Samaria (1:8a–c, 9a). Then he described the disaster that would also happen to Judah and Jerusalem (1:9b–c).

In 1:6–7, the LORD was the speaker. But here in 1:8–9, Micah is the speaker. In some languages, it may be helpful to make this explicit. For example:

Then Micah said, “Because of this I will mourn and lament. (GNT)

1:8a

Because of this I will lament and wail;

- ¶ Micah said: Because of those things that will happen, I will mourn with loud cries and wail.
- ¶ Then I said: I am sorrowful because of those terrible things that will happen to Samaria, so I will weep loudly and wail/howl.

Because of this: This phrase refers back to the LORD’s statement in 1:6–7 that he will punish the people of Samaria severely. For this reason, Micah will lament and wail. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

For this... (NRSV)

And so,...

That is the reason why...

I will lament and wail: Most versions translate these verbs as future tense (will). Here are some other ways to express the meaning of the Hebrew verb tense here:

I lament and wail (NAB)

I must lament and wail (NASB)

I have decided to lament and wail

lament and wail: These verbs have almost the same meaning. They both refer to the Jewish custom of weeping in a loud voice and wailing loudly to show their sorrow. Micah used both verbs here to emphasize his sorrow. Here are some other examples of versions that use two similar verbs to express loud mourning:

I will weep and wail (NIV)

I shall howl and wail (NJB)

In some languages, it may be more natural to express this emphasis in a different way. For example:

I will mourn greatly

I will mourn and mourn

1:8b

I will walk barefoot and naked.

- I will walk around barefoot, and I will wear no outer garment.
- As a sign that I am mourning, I will wear no sandals/shoes and no outer clothes while I am walking around.
- I will walk with bare feet and I will wear only a loincloth, so people will know that I am greatly distressed.

I will walk barefoot and naked: This is a symbolic action. Micah said he will walk around barefoot and naked to show that he was very sad. In some languages, it may be helpful to make the meaning of Micah’s actions explicit. For example:

To show my sorrow, I will walk around barefoot and naked. (GNT)

In other languages, it may be appropriate to supply a footnote that clarifies the meaning of the symbolic action. Here is an example:

Micah did this to show how sad he was that the LORD planned to punish his people.

barefoot: In Hebrew, there are two ways to interpret the word barefoot:

1. It means that Micah would not wear any shoes or sandals on his feet. For example:

I will walk around barefoot (GNT) (BSB, CEV, GW, NAB, NET, NASB, NCV, NLT, NIV, NJB, NRSV, GNT)

1. It means that Micah would not wear any jewelry or good clothing. For example:

I will go stripped (RSV) (ESV, KJV, NJPS, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. The REB (“despoiled”) is unique among English versions. It is hard to know what this translation means in the context. Here are some other ways to translate barefoot:

I will not wear/use any shoes/sandals

I will wear nothing on my feet

naked: In Hebrew, there are two ways to interpret the word naked:

1. It means “to not wear an outer garment” but “to wear only a loincloth.” For example:

I will walk around barefoot and without my outer garments. (NET)

1. It means “completely naked,” without any clothes. Almost all English versions translate this as “naked.”

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with almost all commentaries. According to UBS (page 137), the usual meaning of the Hebrew word for naked (“having no outer garments and wearing only a loincloth”) probably applies here. KD (page 292) explains that Micah was “not wearing an upper garment,” and JFB (page 688) adds that a “prophet’s upper garment was usually rough and coarse-haired.” Other commentaries that agree with interpretation (1) include NAC, NICOT, and WBC. A&F prefer interpretation (2). On pages 193–194, they explain that “Nakedness suits a captive better than a mourner. So the balance is even. In v 16 a mother mourns her captured children; in v 8 the prophet mimes both captives and their mourners in one acted prophecy.”

Here are some other ways to translate interpretation (1):

I will walk around barefoot and wearing only a loincloth.

I will walk around with no shoes and no shirt or sarong.

1:8c

I will howl like a jackal and mourn like an ostrich.

- I will howl like a jackal and will raise my voice to moan like an ostrich.

- I will wail. Because of my sorrow, I will howl like wolves/coyotes. I will make loud, harsh noises like ostriches.
- I will wail and make loud, sad noises like some animals and birds.

In 1:8a, Micah said that he would “lament and wail.” Here in 1:8c, he used two similes to compare his lamenting and wailing to the noises made by two kinds of animals: jackals and ostriches. The following note on “howl” applies to both similes.

I will howl: In Hebrew, the word the BSB translates as howl is a noun that is related to the verb “lament” in 1:8a. In some languages, it may be more natural to use a verb here in 1:8c too, as the BSB does. For example:

I will cry loudly... (NCV)

like a jackal: In Hebrew, the word jackal is plural. Some versions translate it as plural, others as singular. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

A jackal is a wild animal that resembles a wild dog. Jackals often howl at night. If there is no word for jackal in your language, you may be able to use the word for a similar kind of animal that makes a sad/lonely howling noise. The KJV has “dragons.” No modern scholars follow this interpretation. A&F (page 194) give the following explanation: “The reading in LXX of ‘dragons’ (cf. Vulgate) has confused the plural of tan, ‘jackal,’ with tannîm a variant of tannin.” Hillers (page 22) says: “The LXX drakontōn and the V draconum arise from confusion with tannin.” For example:

like a wolf (REB)

like the wild dogs (NCV)

like a pack of coyotes/hyenas

and mourn like an ostrich: There are two main ways to interpret the meaning of the Hebrew word for ostrich:

1. It refers to an ostrich. This very large bird used to be found in Israel but is now found mainly in Africa. For example:

I will...wail like an ostrich. (GNT) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NJPS, NRSV, GNT)

1. It refers to a kind of owl. For example:

I shall shriek like the owls (NJB) (KJV, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB)

TN will follow interpretation (1). You may follow either interpretation. Choose an interpretation that fits the terminology of your language and also has cultural associations with a loud, shrill, or harsh noise. Both interpretations are almost equally supported by translations and commentaries. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include Hillers, KD, WBC, ZIBBC, and JFB. Hillers (page 23) says that the ostrich gives a “loud, strident call.” KD (page 292) describes it as a “strong, mourning cry.” JFB (page 688) says that ostriches give a shrill and long-drawn, sigh-like cry, especially at night.” Commentaries that support interpretation (2) include NAC, Waltke 2007, EBC, CBC, ABC, and IVPB. NAC (pages 54–45) comments that the word is an “Arabic etymological cognate with the root idea of “desert.” So the entire Hebrew phrase (*bnôṭ ya ʿānā*) would mean literally “daughters of the desert,” hence “desert owls” or “eagle owls” or simply “owls” (REB “desert-owl”).” Waltke 2007 (pages 66–67) explains: The literal meaning of *baṭ ya ʿānā*...is either ‘daughter of greed’ (Gesenius) or ‘the daughter of the wilderness’ (Wetzstein), and it has consequently been always explained as the ostrich (LXX, Vulg., Targ., Pesh.); for this bird is noted for its voracious appetite and is found only in the wilderness. Not all, however, that is said of this bird in the O.T. is applicable to the ostrich. This indeed inhabits the open wilderness..., but it does not haunt deserted or ruined cities; it certainly does not wail (Mic. 1:8) but booms; nor is it raptorial. These are all habits of owls, so that the *baṭ ya ʿānā* may well be the eagle owl (Aharoni), a large owl which is found in semi-desert areas covered with scrub, where it rests on bushes during the day and hunts...by night...The Syr. *ba(r)t yarora* (Pesh.) “daughter of the vomiter” (Mic. 1:8) agrees with the explanation of the word; for all owls bring up the indigestible parts of their food in the form of pellets...”

Here are some questions to ask in deciding on an interpretation to follow:

- How do the major translations in your area or country translate the name of this bird?
- What birds in your area are known for making loud, shrill, or harsh cries?

Be sure to test your translation carefully for unexpected meanings. For example, in some parts of the world, people believe that owls are a sign (omen) of bad luck or disaster. In such areas, it may be better to refer to a different bird.

Here are some other options for translating jackal or ostrich (or “owls”):

- Borrow words from a language of wider communication. Then supply a footnote that explains the meaning. Here is an example footnote that explains jackals and owls:

In the thinking of the Jews, jackals and owls made loud, sad noises.

- Translate the meaning without using similes. Then supply the similes in a footnote. Here is an example:

I will wail and make sad noises. (Footnote: In Hebrew, it says: I will howl like the jackals and moan loudly like the ostriches.)

If possible, use similes to keep the vividness that these figures of speech conveyed to the original audience.

Micah 1:9

Section 1:8–16: Micah mourned because an enemy army will invade Judah and take many people into exile

In 1:5, Micah mentioned the sins of the people in Samaria and Jerusalem. In 1:6–7, he predicted that the LORD would destroy Samaria. Here in 1:8–16, he predicted that the LORD would also punish the people in Judah, including Jerusalem. He would punish them by causing an enemy army to invade Judah.

This section has two paragraphs: 1:8–9 and 1:10–16. In the first paragraph, Micah said that he would “lament and wail” (BSB). He described the way that he would mourn and then gave the reason. In the second paragraph, he mentioned several cities in Judah that an enemy army would soon attack on its way to Jerusalem. Some versions have separate section headings for each paragraph. The Notes will include both paragraphs as part of the same section. Here are some other examples of section headings for the entire section (1:8–16):

Lament for Jerusalem and the lowland towns (NJB)

Judah Is Doomed (CEV)

The Doom of the Cities of Judah (NRSV)

Micah mourned the disaster that will happen to various cities in Judah

If you choose to use separate section headings for 1:8–9 and 1:10–16, here are some examples for 1:8–9:

Weeping and Mourning (NIV, BSB)

Micah's Great Sadness (NCV)

Either the CEV or NRSV headings above will be appropriate for 1:10–16. Here is another example:

Disaster will happen to various cities in Judah

Paragraph 1:8–9

In this paragraph, Micah described the sadness that he felt because of the disaster that would happen to Samaria (1:8a–c, 9a). Then he described the disaster that would also happen to Judah and Jerusalem (1:9b–c).

In 1:6–7, the LORD was the speaker. But here in 1:8–9, Micah is the speaker. In some languages, it may be helpful to make this explicit. For example:

Then Micah said, "Because of this I will mourn and lament. (GNT)

1:9a

For her wound is incurable;

- For Samaria's wounds/injuries cannot be healed.
- For the disaster that will certainly happen to Samaria is like a wound from which the people will never recover.
- The reason for my sorrow is that the people of Samaria will not survive the disaster that Yahweh causes them to experience.

For her wound is incurable: Micah used the word *wound* to introduce the reason for his loud weeping in 1:8a–c. He mourned because the wound that the LORD would soon cause the city of Samaria to suffer is incurable. Here are some other ways to translate this line:

because Samaria's wound cannot be healed (NCV)

for Samaria's disease is incurable (NET)

For my people's wound is too deep to heal. (NLT)

The nation is fatally wounded. (CEV)

wound: In Hebrew, this word is plural. It refers to injuries caused by beating someone, either with fists or with a weapon like a club.

Micah used the word *wound* as a metaphor. It refers figuratively to punishment from the LORD. This punishment is compared to wounds that cannot be healed.

is incurable: When Micah said that Samaria's wound was incurable, he meant that the city's disaster would be certain and severe. The punishment would be so terrible that the people would not recover.

Here are some ways to translate this verse part without using a metaphor:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

For the terrible things that will happen to Samaria will definitely take place. The people will not escape. It will be like a severe wound that cannot be healed.

- Translate without using a figure of speech. For example:

For the LORD will punish the inhabitants of Samaria, and they will not survive.

1:9b–c

In 1:9b–c, Micah gave an additional reason for his sorrow in 1:9a. The reason was that the LORD would not only punish the northern kingdom of Israel with its capital Samaria. He would also punish the land of Judah, including the city of Jerusalem.

The two parallel lines in 1:9b–c are similar in meaning:

^{9b}it has reached even Judah;

^{9c}it has approached the gate of my people, as far as Jerusalem itself.

Both lines refer to the southern kingdom of Judah. The second line refers specifically to the capital city, Jerusalem, the center of worship and government.

1:9b

it has reached even Judah;

- For this disaster will also reach the land of Judah.
- The same terrible thing will certainly happen in the land of Judah as well.

- And Yahweh will certainly cause the people in Judah to be punished too.

In Hebrew, this portion of the verse begins with the same word (“For”) that was used in 1:9a. Since it is an additional part of the same reason, many English versions, including the BSB, do not translate this word. The connection is clear without an explicit conjunction. For example:

it has come to Judah (NIV)

In some languages, the connection will be clearer with a specific word such as “for” or “and.” For example:

for it has come to Judah (NASB)

and Judah is about to suffer in the same way (GNT)

it has reached even Judah: This means that Samaria’s incurable wound will also come to the land of Judah. The LORD will certainly punish the people who live there. In some languages, it is not natural to say that punishment or disaster reaches a place. It may be more natural to say that it happens in a place or arrives at a place.

Micah spoke as if this disaster had already happened to Judah. He spoke like this to emphasize that the terrible things that will happen to Samaria will also certainly happen in the land of Judah. The Hebrew verb is a qal perfect. In Hebrew, perfect verbs usually refer to past events. But prophets often used perfect verbs to talk about something that was certain to happen in the future.

In many languages, it may be clearer to use a future expression here. For example:

Judah is about to suffer in the same way (GNT)

It will spread to Judah (NCV)

1:9c

it has approached the gate of my people, as far as Jerusalem itself.

- It will happen to the main city of my own people, Jerusalem itself.
- He will even punish Jerusalem, the capital city of my countrymen!

it has approached the gate of my people, as far as Jerusalem itself: This line means that even the capital city of Judah, Jerusalem, will experience disaster along with other towns in Judah that will be mentioned in 1:10–16.

The verb tense used here is the same as in 1:9b. See the note and footnote there. Micah used it to emphasize that something would happen in the future. Here are some ways to indicate this future meaning:

It will reach the gates of my people in Jerusalem. (GW)

Jerusalem will fall. (CEV)

the gate of my people, as far as Jerusalem itself:

There are two main ways to interpret the connection between the phrase the gate of my people and the phrase as far as Jerusalem:

1. Micah used the word gate as a metaphor. It represents the city of Jerusalem itself. For example:

It falls on the gateway of my people, on Jerusalem itself. (NJB) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NAB, NASB, NIV, NJB, NRSV, REB)

1. Micah used the word gate literally. The disaster will reach the gate of Jerusalem itself. According to interpretation (2), Micah’s words refer to what happened in 701 B.C. In 721 B.C. the Assyrian army destroyed Samaria. Then in 201 B.C., the Assyrian army invaded Judah. They captured many towns in Judah. They surrounded Jerusalem and came right up to the city gate. But they did not conquer or destroy Jerusalem. For example:

destruction has reached the gates of Jerusalem itself, where my people live (GNT) (GW, NCV, NLT, GNT) It is possible that NET refers here to the literal gate, although it gives “gate” a figurative meaning. It has “to the leadership of my people,” and adds a footnote that the word “gate” is used “by metonymy to refer to the leadership who would be present at the gate.”

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include UBS, NICOT, KD, A&F, and Hillers. UBS (page 139) says that the phrase “the gate of my people” “is a picture of the capital city as the center and

focus of national life.” A&F (page 198) comments in greater detail: “Targum has the more familiar ‘gates,’ but the other ancient versions support the singular of MT. If the intention was to report the investiture of Jerusalem in siege one might have expected ‘city gate’ (2 Kgs 23:8); compare Isa 14:31, where the construct phrase ‘the gate of...the city’ is broken and distributed over two colons of poetry. It is more likely, in the larger context of the chapter (especially if we read vv 2-9 as a unit) that the goal of the theophany announced in v 3 is ‘Yahweh’s triumphal entry into the temple precincts of the holy city Jerusalem’ (Hanson 1975: 375).” Commentaries that support interpretation (2) include ABC and JFB. JFB (page 688) says: “The foe came to the gate of Jerusalem but did not enter.” ZIBBC (page 126) supports aspects of both interpretations. It says: “In one sense, the gate can stand for the whole city. Assyrian kings often set up memorial stones or impaled kings in front of the gate in order to reach the whole population in the most public terms possible, and they summarized times of siege by noting control over the ability to enter or exit the gate.” The TN editor could not determine which interpretation was followed by Waltke 2007 or NAC.

gate: This word refers to the large gate or doorway in the fortified wall of a city. The city gate was an important place in a city. The city leaders met there to listen to disputes and to make decisions, and people did their buying and selling there also.

In some languages, it may be clearer to translate this metaphor without using a figure of speech. For example:

This terrible thing will happen in the most important place among my people, in Jerusalem itself.

my people: This phrase refers to the people who were part of the same country as Micah. Micah was from Moresheth, a small town in Judah, about 35 kilometers from Jerusalem. (see 1:1a). Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

my fellow citizens

my fellow people from Judah

people of my tribe/country

Use a word or phrase in your language that refers to someone who is from the same country, ethnic group

or language group as you, but not necessarily the same village or town.

Jerusalem itself: The name Jerusalem is emphatic in this verse. The BSB marks this with itself. Express this emphasis in a natural way in your language.

Micah 1:10

Section 1:8-16: Micah mourned because an enemy army will invade Judah and take many people into exile

In 1:5, Micah mentioned the sins of the people in Samaria and Jerusalem. In 1:6-7, he predicted that the LORD would destroy Samaria. Here in 1:8-16, he predicted that the LORD would also punish the people in Judah, including Jerusalem. He would punish them by causing an enemy army to invade Judah.

This section has two paragraphs: 1:8-9 and 1:10-16. In the first paragraph, Micah said that he would “lament and wail” (BSB). He described the way that he would mourn and then gave the reason. In the second paragraph, he mentioned several cities in Judah that an enemy army would soon attack on its way to Jerusalem. Some versions have separate section headings for each paragraph. The Notes will include both paragraphs as part of the same section. Here are some other examples of section headings for the entire section (1:8-16):

Lament for Jerusalem and the lowland towns (NJB)

Judah Is Doomed (CEV)

The Doom of the Cities of Judah (NRSV)

Micah mourned the disaster that will happen to various cities in Judah

If you choose to use separate section headings for 1:8-9 and 1:10-16, here are some examples for 1:8-9:

Weeping and Mourning (NIV, BSB)

Micah’s Great Sadness (NCV)

Either the CEV or NRSV headings above will be appropriate for 1:10-16. Here is another example:

Disaster will happen to various cities in Judah

Paragraph 1:10–16

In this paragraph, Micah mentioned the names of eleven towns in Judah in addition to the city of Jerusalem (v.12). These towns were located in the foothills between the low coastal area and the mountains of Judah. EBC (page 508). According to A&F (page 212), some of the cities mentioned have not been identified, and it is not possible to guess the route of the attack or the identity of the invaders. It could have been any of several different kings.

In many English versions as well as TN, 1:10–16 forms one paragraph. Some versions divide it into two or three paragraphs. For example, the GNT has two paragraphs (10–14 and 15–16). The NLT has three paragraphs (10–12, 13–15, and 16). Use whatever paragraph structure is appropriate for your language.

Here are some of the poetic variations of Micah's lament in 1:10–16:

1. In some verses, he spoke to the people in a particular town. In other verses, he spoke about them.
2. Sometimes he used plural nouns or pronouns to refer to the people in a particular town. At other times, he used singular nouns or pronouns.

English versions consistently use either plural or singular forms throughout these verses. For example, in 1:11b, the NJB uses singular pronouns:

She has not left her city, she who lives in Zanaan.
(NJB)

The NIV uses a plural pronoun:

Those who live in Zaanani will not come out. (NIV)

You may use either singular or plural forms or a combination of the two, depending on what is natural and appropriate in your language.

In 1:10–16, Micah used past tense verbs to describe what was still in the future. See the notes on 1:9b and 1:9c for more details.

Micah also made puns with the names of several of the towns or cities. A pun is a figure of speech in which a person uses a word that has two meanings or a word that sounds like another word.

1. In some verses, he used a word that sounded like the name of that town.
2. In other verses, he said something about a town that was related to the meaning of its name.

Here is a brief summary of the puns in each verse. This summary is condensed and adapted from EBC (pages 407–8.) and some general advice on how to translate puns. Complete notes on each verse will start with 1:10a.

- Beth-leaphrah (1:10b): The name of this city sounds like the Hebrew words that mean “house of dust.” Micah commanded those who live in that town to roll in the dust.
- Shaphir (1:11a): This name means “beautiful” or “pleasant” in Hebrew. Micah said that the lives of the people in that town will not be pleasant.
- Zaanani (1:11b): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “come out.” Micah said that the people there will not come out of their city.
- Beth-ezel (1:11c): This name probably means “nearby house” in Hebrew. Micah said that Beth-ezel would no longer be nearby to serve as a “standing place” (protection, refuge) for Jerusalem.
- Maroth (1:12a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “bitter.” Micah said that the people in that town will suffer bitterly.
- Lachish (1:13): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “team of horses.” Micah told the people in that town to flee like running horses.
- Moresheth (-gath) (1:14a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “betrothed” (engaged to be married). Just like a young woman departs from her family when she gets married, so the people in that town would soon depart from Judah.
- Achzib (1:14b): This name means “deception” in Hebrew. That town will be a deception to the kings of Israel. These kings had hoped in vain that the people of Achzib would help them fight the enemy.
- Mareshah (1:15a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “conqueror.” The LORD will bring an enemy to that town who will conquer them.

In addition to the above puns, Micah also included the names of two places (Gath 1:10a) and Adullam (1:15b) that are famous in Jewish history. Their significance will be discussed in the notes on those verses.

The people to whom Micah spoke over 2,700 years ago understood the puns. They also understood the historical significance of Gath and Adullam. But most people today do not understand these things. That is the reason it is difficult to translate these verses clearly. Here are some general options to consider in translating the puns:

- Ignore the puns. Most English versions do this in the actual translation. Just translate the name in the Hebrew text. Those who read your translation will

understand the basic meaning of each verse, but they will not know that there was a pun in Hebrew.

- Use footnotes to explain the puns. Many English versions with footnotes do this. For example, the NIV uses footnotes at 1:10a, 11b, 12a, 13a, and 15a to explain that a name sounds like another Hebrew word. It uses other footnotes at 1:10b, 11a, and 14b to explain the meaning of the name of a town.
- Explain in your translation the meaning or the sound of the names for the cities. If you use this option, you will need to clearly indicate in some way that this information is not part of your translation.

Choose an option that is appropriate for the readers in your language area.

1:10a

Do not tell it in Gath; do not weep at all.

- ¶ Don't talk^(plur) about this bad news in the city of Gath. Don't weep at all, even though you are sad.
- ¶ People of Judah! Don't let our^(incl) enemies in Gath hear you talking about this disaster. Do not weep about it.

Do not tell it in Gath: Micah quoted the words “Tell it not in Gath” from 2 Samuel 1:20a, but he changed the order of the words. The Hebrew word order in 2 Samuel 1:20a is literally “Do not tell it in Gath.” In Micah 1:10a, the Hebrew word order is “In Gath do not tell it.” The result in Hebrew is that those words sound similar to the words of the next line “Weep not at all.” The NIV footnote says: “**Gath** sounds like the Hebrew for **tell**.” (The Hebrew word is *nagad*). Here is the Hebrew for 1:10a: *bāgat ʾal-taggidu*—In Gath do not tell [it]. *bakoh ʾal-tibku*—Do not weep at all. Notice that the three words of each line begin with b, ʾ and t, and that the vowels of each line are similar also. Micah spoke the words in 1:10a to the people in Judah. In some languages, it may be helpful to make this information explicit. For example:

You people of Judah! Don't tell our enemies in Gath how we have been defeated.

it: This word refers to the news that God would punish his people. Some versions make this explicit. For example:

Don't tell our enemies in Gath about our defeat (GNT)

Gath: Instead of Gath, the NCV has Acco. It has a footnote that says: “[Acco] This name sounds like the Hebrew word for ‘cry.’” The NIV has the following

footnote: “Septuagint may suggest ‘not in Acco.’” All other versions have Gath. JFB (pages 688–689) thinks that “Acco” is a good possibility because of the resemblance to the Hebrew word *bakoh* “weeping.” Waltke 2007 and NAC (page 57) give persuasive evidence, textual and otherwise, that the correct rendering is Gath. Gath was one of the five main cities of the Philistines. The Philistines were enemies of the Jews. Some versions make this explicit. For example:

Don't tell our enemies in Gath about our defeat (GNT)

In 2 Samuel 1:20–27, David sang a song to mourn the death of King Saul and Jonathan. David's song began: “Tell it not in Gath.” David did not want anybody to tell the Philistine people in Gath about Saul's death, because he did not want the Philistines to be happy about it. Micah deliberately quoted the first verse of David's song here with a similar meaning.

If you use cross references in your translation, you may want to cross-reference that verse here. You may also want to include a footnote to explain some of the background information. For example:

Gath was a Philistine city (CEV)

The people in Gath were Philistines, enemies of the Jews. Micah did not want them to hear about the terrible things that would happen to the cities in Judah. He did not want them to be glad about it. This part of the verse is a quote from David's words in 2 Samuel 1:20.

do not weep at all: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “weeping do not weep.” This repetition gives additional emphasis. Here are some other ways to emphasize this command:

Don't even cry. (CEV)

Don't shed even a single tear! (NET)

1:10b

Roll in the dust in Beth-leaphrah.

- You^(plur) in Beth-leaphrah, roll in the dust to show your despair.
- As for you inhabitants of Beth-leaphrah, mourn because of what will happen.

- You people in Beth-leaphrah, the name of your town means “house of dust,” so you will roll in the dust because you are so sad.

Roll in the dust in Beth-leaphrah: Micah spoke these words to the people who lived in the city of Beth-leaphrah. The last part of the name Beth-leaphrah sounds like the Hebrew word for dust (‘apar). Some scholars think that this name means “House of Dust.” Many English versions supply a footnote to explain this pun. For example:

Beth Ophrah means **house of dust.** (NIV)

Beth-Leaphrah is unknown, but in Hebrew it sounds like “House of Dust.” (CEV)

If you do not use footnotes, you may want to include this information in your translation. For example:

You people in Beth-leaphrah! The name of your town means “house of dust,” so you will roll in the dust.

Roll in the dust: This is a symbolic action that shows extreme sadness. When the Jews mourned, they sometimes scattered dust or ashes on their heads and bodies. Sometimes they lay down in the dust or ashes and rolled around to cover themselves with the substance.

If people who read your translation do not understand this symbolic action as a sign of mourning, you may want to make the purpose of the action explicit in your translation. For example:

People of Beth Leaphrah, show your despair by rolling in the dust! (GNT)

Another option is to use a footnote instead. For example:

To sit in the dust was an outward sign of mourning. The name Beth Leaphra means “house of dust.” (NET footnote)

Beth-leaphrah: The name of this town is spelled in several ways in English versions. For example:

Bethleaphrah (RSV)

Beth Leaphrah (GNT)

Beth Leaphra (NET)

Beth-Leaphrah (NJB)

Beth-le-aphrah (ESV)

Beth Ophrah (NIV)

Beth-aphrah (REB)

You may want to use a spelling that fits the phonetic rules of your language or a spelling that is used in a language of wider communication in your country.

Micah 1:11

Section 1:8–16: Micah mourned because an enemy army will invade Judah and take many people into exile

In 1:5, Micah mentioned the sins of the people in Samaria and Jerusalem. In 1:6–7, he predicted that the LORD would destroy Samaria. Here in 1:8–16, he predicted that the LORD would also punish the people in Judah, including Jerusalem. He would punish them by causing an enemy army to invade Judah.

This section has two paragraphs: 1:8–9 and 1:10–16. In the first paragraph, Micah said that he would “lament and wail” (BSB). He described the way that he would mourn and then gave the reason. In the second paragraph, he mentioned several cities in Judah that an enemy army would soon attack on its way to Jerusalem. Some versions have separate section headings for each paragraph. The Notes will include both paragraphs as part of the same section. Here are some other examples of section headings for the entire section (1:8–16):

Lament for Jerusalem and the lowland towns (NJB)

Judah Is Doomed (CEV)

The Doom of the Cities of Judah (NRSV)

Micah mourned the disaster that will happen to various cities in Judah

If you choose to use separate section headings for 1:8–9 and 1:10–16, here are some examples for 1:8–9:

Weeping and Mourning (NIV, BSB)

Micah's Great Sadness (NCV)

Either the CEV or NRSV headings above will be appropriate for 1:10–16. Here is another example:

Disaster will happen to various cities in Judah

Paragraph 1:10–16

In this paragraph, Micah mentioned the names of eleven towns in Judah in addition to the city of Jerusalem (v.12). These towns were located in the foothills between the low coastal area and the mountains of Judah. EBC (page 508). According to A&F (page 212), some of the cities mentioned have not been identified, and it is not possible to guess the route of the attack or the identity of the invaders. It could have been any of several different kings.

In many English versions as well as TN, 1:10–16 forms one paragraph. Some versions divide it into two or three paragraphs. For example, the GNT has two paragraphs (10–14 and 15–16). The NLT has three paragraphs (10–12, 13–15, and 16). Use whatever paragraph structure is appropriate for your language.

Here are some of the poetic variations of Micah's lament in 1:10–16:

1. In some verses, he spoke to the people in a particular town. In other verses, he spoke about them.
2. Sometimes he used plural nouns or pronouns to refer to the people in a particular town. At other times, he used singular nouns or pronouns.

English versions consistently use either plural or singular forms throughout these verses. For example, in 1:11b, the NJB uses singular pronouns:

She has not left her city, she who lives in Zanaan.
(NJB)

The NIV uses a plural pronoun:

Those who live in Zaanana will not come out. (NIV)

You may use either singular or plural forms or a combination of the two, depending on what is natural and appropriate in your language.

In 1:10–16, Micah used past tense verbs to describe what was still in the future. See the notes on 1:9b and 1:9c for more details.

Micah also made puns with the names of several of the towns or cities. A pun is a figure of speech in which a person uses a word that has two meanings or a word that sounds like another word.

1. In some verses, he used a word that sounded like the name of that town.
2. In other verses, he said something about a town that was related to the meaning of its name.

Here is a brief summary of the puns in each verse. This summary is condensed and adapted from EBC (pages 407–8.) and some general advice on how to translate puns. Complete notes on each verse will start with 1:10a.

- Beth-leaphrah (1:10b): The name of this city sounds like the Hebrew words that mean “house of dust.” Micah commanded those who live in that town to roll in the dust.
- Shaphir (1:11a): This name means “beautiful” or “pleasant” in Hebrew. Micah said that the lives of the people in that town will not be pleasant.
- Zaanana (1:11b): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “come out.” Micah said that the people there will not come out of their city.
- Beth-ezel (1:11c): This name probably means “nearby house” in Hebrew. Micah said that Beth-ezel would no longer be nearby to serve as a “standing place” (protection, refuge) for Jerusalem.
- Maroth (1:12a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “bitter.” Micah said that the people in that town will suffer bitterly.
- Lachish (1:13): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “team of horses.” Micah told the people in that town to flee like running horses.
- Moresheth (-gath) (1:14a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “betrothed” (engaged to be married). Just like a young woman departs from her family when she gets married, so the people in that town would soon depart from Judah.
- Achzib (1:14b): This name means “deception” in Hebrew. That town will be a deception to the kings of Israel. These kings had hoped in vain that the people of Achzib would help them fight the enemy.
- Mareshah (1:15a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “conqueror.” The LORD will bring an enemy to that town who will conquer them.

In addition to the above puns, Micah also included the names of two places (Gath 1:10a) and Adullam (1:15b) that are famous in Jewish history. Their significance will be discussed in the notes on those verses.

The people to whom Micah spoke over 2,700 years ago understood the puns. They also understood the

historical significance of Gath and Adullam. But most people today do not understand these things. That is the reason it is difficult to translate these verses clearly. Here are some general options to consider in translating the puns:

- Ignore the puns. Most English versions do this in the actual translation. Just translate the name in the Hebrew text. Those who read your translation will understand the basic meaning of each verse, but they will not know that there was a pun in Hebrew.
- Use footnotes to explain the puns. Many English versions with footnotes do this. For example, the NIV uses footnotes at 1:10a, 11b, 12a, 13a, and 15a to explain that a name sounds like another Hebrew word. It uses other footnotes at 1:10b, 11a, and 14b to explain the meaning of the name of a town.
- Explain in your translation the meaning or the sound of the names for the cities. If you use this option, you will need to clearly indicate in some way that this information is not part of your translation.

Choose an option that is appropriate for the readers in your language area.

1:11a

Depart in shameful nakedness, O dwellers of Shaphir.

- You^(plur) who live in Shaphir, you will leave your town as prisoners, naked and ashamed.
- O people of Shaphir, your enemies will capture you and force you to leave your town. You will be naked and ashamed at the time you leave.
- To the Shaphir people I say: the name of your town means “pleasant place,” but you will leave that town as captives. Your enemies will take off your clothes and shame you.

Depart in shameful nakedness, O dwellers of Shaphir: Grammatically, Micah’s words Depart in shameful nakedness... are a command. However, his intention is not to command them to do something, but to predict what will happen to them. The people of Shaphir will be forced to leave their city in shame. In some languages, it may be clearer to express this as a future event. For example:

You inhabitants of Shaphir! You will depart naked and ashamed.

There is implied information in this verse. An enemy army will capture the people in Shaphir and take them away as slaves or as prisoners of war.

Here are some ways to make this implied information explicit:

You people of Shaphir, go into exile, naked and ashamed. (GNT)

You people of Shaphir, go as captives into exile—naked and ashamed. (NLT)

Depart: NJB understands that there is a pun between Shaphir and the Hebrew word *shoḥar* (“horn”). It has “Sound the horn, inhabitant of Shapir!” But this rendering would require changing the Hebrew text. It is not followed by other versions or supported by commentaries used in these notes. In Hebrew, the verb phrase used here means that the people in Shaphir will leave their city. Here are some other ways to translate it:

Pass on your way (ESV)

Take to the road (REB)

in shameful nakedness: In Hebrew, both these words are nouns (“nakedness and shame” (NRSV)). In many languages, it may be clearer to translate these nouns as adjectives or verbs. The BSB took a mixed approach. For example:

naked and ashamed (CEV)

Your captors will strip off your clothes and humiliate you.

When the enemy army captures the people in Shaphir, they will strip off the people’s clothes and lead the people away as captives. That is why the people will be naked and ashamed.

Shaphir: This name means “beautiful” or “pleasant” in Hebrew. But what will happen there will not be pleasant. It will be horrible. You may want to use a footnote to explain the implied information in 1:11a. For example:

1:11a **Shaphir** means “pleasant.” (NLT footnote)

The place name Shaphir means “pleasant” in Hebrew. (NET footnote)

See the third meaning line in the Display for a way to explain the meaning of the pun in the translation itself.

1:11b**The dwellers of Zaanan will not come out.**

- Those who reside in Zaanan will not leave their town.
- As for the people in Zaanan, the name of their town sounds like “come out,” but they will be afraid to come out, because their enemies are outside.

The dwellers of Zaanan will not come out: In 1:11a, Micah talked to the people in Shaphir. But here in 1:11b, he talked about the people in Zaanan.

Zaanan: The name Zaanan sounds like the Hebrew word that means “come out” or “come forth.” The name Zaanan in Hebrew is זָאָנָן, and “come out” is יָצָא. Both words have the consonants ז and נ. But even though the name of their town sounds like “come out,” the people there will not come out. They will remain inside their town. All English versions except the REB follow the interpretation that the residents of Zaanan will not or cannot come out. The REB has: “Have not the people of Zaanan gone out in shame from their city?”

You may want to use a footnote to make explicit the pun in 1:11b. For example:

[Zanaan] This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “come out.” (NCV footnote)

In some languages, it may be better to make this meaning explicit in the translation itself. For example:

As for the people in Zaanan, the name of their town sounds like “come out,” but they will not go out of their town.

will not come out: Zaanan probably had a wall around the town. The phrase will not come out means that the people will not go outside the wall. Hebrew and most English versions do not supply a reason for their staying inside. The implied reason is that an enemy army will be outside, so the people will be unable or unwilling to face them. In some languages, it may be helpful to make a reason explicit. For example:

Those who live in Zaanan do not dare to come out of their city. (GNT)

The residents of Zaanan can't leave their city. (NET)

1:11c**Beth-ezel is in mourning; its support is taken from you.**

- The people of Beth-ezel will wail. They will no longer be able to protect you^(plur).
- The people who live in Beth-ezel will wail because they are sad. They will no longer be able to help you fight the enemy.
- The people in Beth-ezel will wail. The name of their city means “nearby house,” but they will no longer be nearby to protect/help you.

Beth-ezel is in mourning; its support is taken from you: There are at least three ways to interpret this sentence:

1. Beth-ezel will no longer help protect the people of Judah. It will withdraw its support, because it is in mourning. For example:

Beth Ezel is in mourning; it no longer protects you. (NIV11)

When you hear the people of Beth-ezel mourn, you will know that there is no refuge there. (GNT) (BSB, GW, NCV, NIV11, NJPS, NRSV, REB, GNT)

1. Beth-ezel's foundations will be destroyed. For example:

Beth-Ezel is torn from its foundations, from its strong supports. (NJB) (NJB, NLT)

1. Verse 1:11c is a direct quote. It is what the people in Beth-ezel will say:

The lamentation of Beth-ezel: “He will take from you its support.” (NASB) (NASB, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries.

Beth-ezel: The name of this town is spelled in several ways in different versions. For example:

Beth-ezel (NJPS)

Beth Ezel (NIV)

Beth-Ezel (NJB)

Bethezel (GNT)

You may want to use a spelling that fits the phonetic rules of your language or a spelling that is used in a language of wider communication in your country.

The literal meaning of Beth-ezel in Hebrew is probably “house of nearness,” meaning “nearby house” or “house next door.” We do not know for sure whether Micah used a pun here. If he did, the probable meaning is that people in nearby towns hoped that the inhabitants of Beth-ezel would help them if an enemy attacked.

It may be helpful to use a footnote to help your readers understand the meaning of the possible pun. For example:

[Beth Ezel] This name means “house by the side of another,” suggesting help or support. (NCV footnote)

The place name Beth Ezel means “house of nearness” or “house of proximity” in Hebrew. (NET footnote)

If you do not use footnotes, you may decide to include the meaning of the place and possible pun in your translation. For example:

The people in Beth-ezel will wail. The name of their city means “nearby house,” but they will no longer be nearby to protect/help you.

its support is taken from you: In Hebrew, the word that most versions translations as “support,” “protection,” or “refuge” is literally “standing place” (RSV, ESV). It is difficult to know what “standing place” would mean in this context. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

its protection is taken from you (NIV)

they will not give you any support (NCV)

you will know that there is no refuge there (GNT)

Notice that the BSB and the NIV use a present tense verb. Remember that Micah spoke about a disaster that would happen to these cities in the future. When Micah spoke these words, this disaster had not yet

happened. You should translate all the verses in 1:10–16 in a way that makes this meaning clear.

from you: The pronoun you is plural in Hebrew. It probably refers to the people of Judah in general.

Micah 1:12

Section 1:8–16: Micah mourned because an enemy army will invade Judah and take many people into exile

In 1:5, Micah mentioned the sins of the people in Samaria and Jerusalem. In 1:6–7, he predicted that the LORD would destroy Samaria. Here in 1:8–16, he predicted that the LORD would also punish the people in Judah, including Jerusalem. He would punish them by causing an enemy army to invade Judah.

This section has two paragraphs: 1:8–9 and 1:10–16. In the first paragraph, Micah said that he would “lament and wail” (BSB). He described the way that he would mourn and then gave the reason. In the second paragraph, he mentioned several cities in Judah that an enemy army would soon attack on its way to Jerusalem. Some versions have separate section headings for each paragraph. The Notes will include both paragraphs as part of the same section. Here are some other examples of section headings for the entire section (1:8–16):

Lament for Jerusalem and the lowland towns (NJB)

Judah Is Doomed (CEV)

The Doom of the Cities of Judah (NRSV)

Micah mourned the disaster that will happen to various cities in Judah

If you choose to use separate section headings for 1:8–9 and 1:10–16, here are some examples for 1:8–9:

Weeping and Mourning (NIV, BSB)

Micah’s Great Sadness (NCV)

Either the CEV or NRSV headings above will be appropriate for 1:10–16. Here is another example:

Disaster will happen to various cities in Judah

Paragraph 1:10–16

In this paragraph, Micah mentioned the names of eleven towns in Judah in addition to the city of Jerusalem (v.12). These towns were located in the foothills between the low coastal area and the mountains of Judah. EBC (page 508). According to A&F (page 212), some of the cities mentioned have not been identified, and it is not possible to guess the route of the attack or the identity of the invaders. It could have been any of several different kings.

In many English versions as well as TN, 1:10–16 forms one paragraph. Some versions divide it into two or three paragraphs. For example, the GNT has two paragraphs (10–14 and 15–16). The NLT has three paragraphs (10–12, 13–15, and 16). Use whatever paragraph structure is appropriate for your language.

Here are some of the poetic variations of Micah's lament in 1:10–16:

1. In some verses, he spoke to the people in a particular town. In other verses, he spoke about them.
2. Sometimes he used plural nouns or pronouns to refer to the people in a particular town. At other times, he used singular nouns or pronouns.

English versions consistently use either plural or singular forms throughout these verses. For example, in 1:11b, the NJB uses singular pronouns:

She has not left her city, she who lives in Zanaan.
(NJB)

The NIV uses a plural pronoun:

Those who live in Zaanani will not come out. (NIV)

You may use either singular or plural forms or a combination of the two, depending on what is natural and appropriate in your language.

In 1:10–16, Micah used past tense verbs to describe what was still in the future. See the notes on 1:9b and 1:9c for more details.

Micah also made puns with the names of several of the towns or cities. A pun is a figure of speech in which a person uses a word that has two meanings or a word that sounds like another word.

1. In some verses, he used a word that sounded like the name of that town.
2. In other verses, he said something about a town that was related to the meaning of its name.

Here is a brief summary of the puns in each verse. This summary is condensed and adapted from EBC (pages 407–8.) and some general advice on how to translate puns. Complete notes on each verse will start with 1:10a.

- Beth-leaphrah (1:10b): The name of this city sounds like the Hebrew words that mean “house of dust.” Micah commanded those who live in that town to roll in the dust.
- Shaphir (1:11a): This name means “beautiful” or “pleasant” in Hebrew. Micah said that the lives of the people in that town will not be pleasant.
- Zaanani (1:11b): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “come out.” Micah said that the people there will not come out of their city.
- Beth-ezel (1:11c): This name probably means “nearby house” in Hebrew. Micah said that Beth-ezel would no longer be nearby to serve as a “standing place” (protection, refuge) for Jerusalem.
- Maroth (1:12a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “bitter.” Micah said that the people in that town will suffer bitterly.
- Lachish (1:13): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “team of horses.” Micah told the people in that town to flee like running horses.
- Moresheth (-gath) (1:14a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “betrothed” (engaged to be married). Just like a young woman departs from her family when she gets married, so the people in that town would soon depart from Judah.
- Achzib (1:14b): This name means “deception” in Hebrew. That town will be a deception to the kings of Israel. These kings had hoped in vain that the people of Achzib would help them fight the enemy.
- Mareshah (1:15a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “conqueror.” The LORD will bring an enemy to that town who will conquer them.

In addition to the above puns, Micah also included the names of two places (Gath 1:10a) and Adullam (1:15b) that are famous in Jewish history. Their significance will be discussed in the notes on those verses.

The people to whom Micah spoke over 2,700 years ago understood the puns. They also understood the historical significance of Gath and Adullam. But most people today do not understand these things. That is the reason it is difficult to translate these verses clearly. Here are some general options to consider in translating the puns:

- Ignore the puns. Most English versions do this in the actual translation. Just translate the name in the Hebrew text. Those who read your translation will

understand the basic meaning of each verse, but they will not know that there was a pun in Hebrew.

- Use footnotes to explain the puns. Many English versions with footnotes do this. For example, the NIV uses footnotes at 1:10a, 11b, 12a, 13a, and 15a to explain that a name sounds like another Hebrew word. It uses other footnotes at 1:10b, 11a, and 14b to explain the meaning of the name of a town.
- Explain in your translation the meaning or the sound of the names for the cities. If you use this option, you will need to clearly indicate in some way that this information is not part of your translation.

Choose an option that is appropriate for the readers in your language area.

1:12a

For the dwellers of Maroth pined for good,

- The Maroth people will be anxious, waiting for good news.
- Yes indeed, the people who reside in Maroth will wait and wait for something good to happen, but nothing good will happen.
- The people of Maroth town will be worried. They will wait for someone to help them. But nobody will help them.

For the dwellers of Maroth pined for good: Micah spoke here about the inhabitants of Maroth, another town in Judah.

For: In Hebrew, this word probably emphasizes here the certainty of the terrible disaster that would happen. According to Waltke 2007 (page 77), the interpretation “wait anxiously” “favors the asseverative force.” It does not introduce a reason. One way to express this certainty is to begin the verse with a word such as “Indeed.” For example:

Indeed, the residents of Maroth hope for something good to happen. (NET)

Many English versions begin this verse with no connecting word. For some examples, see the NIV, GNT, and CEV quoted below.

Maroth: The name Maroth means “bitterness.” In Hebrew, bitterness was a symbol of sadness or unpleasant experiences. We do not know for sure whether Micah used a pun here. If he did, the probable meaning is that the people in Maroth “pined for good,” but what would happen to them would be bitter, that is, unpleasant. According to Mays 1976 (pp. 57–58), Micah made a word play on “Maroth” (bitter) and “good,”... and also on “evil” and “Jerusalem” (the city of shalom —“peace”): “How can the community of bitterness

hope for the good of help when the evil of calamity has come from YHWH to the very gates of the city of salvation!”

The situation with the possible pun and its probable meaning is similar to the one with Beth-ezel in 1:11c. Consider using a similar approach here.

It may be helpful to use a footnote to help your readers understand the meaning of the possible pun. For example:

Maroth sounds like the Hebrew term for “bitter.” (NLT footnote)

The name Maroth means “bitter.” Eating bitter things is unpleasant. Similarly, unpleasant things will happen to the people in Maroth.

If you do not use footnotes, you may decide to include the meaning of the place and possible pun in your translation. For example:

The inhabitants of Maroth The name of their town means “bitter.” will wait anxiously for someone to help them. Nothing good will happen to them.

pined: In Hebrew, this verb phrase can be interpreted in at least three ways:

1. It means “wait anxiously.” The people of Maroth were worried. They were afraid that no one would help them. For example:

The people of Maroth anxiously wait for relief (GNT) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NCV, NET, NLT, NRSV, REB, The REB indicates extreme anxiety. It has “in the depths of despair.” Conceivably, it could be listed with the NIV “writhe,” but being in deep despair does not necessarily imply bodily contortions. GNT)

1. It means “writhe while waiting.” They twisted or contorted their bodies as they waited in extreme fear. For example:

Those who live in Maroth writhe in pain, waiting for relief... (NIV) (NIV)

1. It means “hope.” The people hoped that someone would help them and that good would result. For example:

the residents of Maroth hope for something good to happen (NET) (CEV, NET, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. Interpretation (2) also implies that the people are extremely anxious, but the translation “writhe” requires an unusual form of the original word. See A&F (page 226) for a discussion of the confusing details. The meaning “writhe” is not supported by any commentaries or other versions.

To “pine” means to wait for something to happen and to be anxious (worried and afraid) that it will not happen. In some languages, the expression pined may need to be translated as two clauses or as a direct quote. For example:

The inhabitants of Maroth wait for something good to happen, but they are worried/afraid that nothing good will happen.

The inhabitants of Maroth wait and wait. They say, “Will anything good ever happen?”

for good: The implied information here is that an enemy army will attack Judah. The people in “Maroth” wait anxiously for good news to come or for something good to happen. Here are some other ways to translate “wait anxiously for good”:

will be anxious for good news to come (NCV)

wait for something good to happen (NET)

See also the GNT (quoted above).

1:12a-b (combined/reordered)

- Yahweh will cause disaster to come to the gate of Jerusalem. That is why the people in the town of Maroth will wait anxiously for help but no help will come.

1:12b

but calamity came down from the LORD, even to the gate of Jerusalem.

- They will need to wait, because Yahweh will send enemies, and those enemies will arrive outside the gate of Jerusalem.
- The reason is that/because Yahweh will cause an enemy army to come right up to the main entrance of Jerusalem itself.

- There will be no help, because even the capital city of Jerusalem will be threatened by disaster/defeat from enemy soldiers that Yahweh causes to reach the entrance of the city.

but calamity came down from the LORD, even to the gate of Jerusalem: This verse part also begins with the Hebrew word *ki*. In 1:12a, this word indicated certainty. Here in 1:12b, there are at least two ways to interpret its function:

1. It indicates either the reason that the people of Maroth wait anxiously or else the reason that nothing good will happen. For example:

because trouble will come from the Lord, all the way to the gate of Jerusalem (NCV) (ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, NIV, RSV, GNT)

1. It indicates contrast or concession. The people of Maroth wait anxiously, but/yet although that is the case, nothing good will happen. The reason is that even Jerusalem, the capital city, faced disaster and would need help. For example:

though the Lord has sent disaster against the city of Jerusalem (NET) (BSB, CEV, KJV, NET, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. More commentaries follow interpretation (2), but this use of *ki* is extremely rare. The meaning “because” is much more common. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include ABC and UBS. ABC (page 1077) speaks of “a rescuing army from Jerusalem that will never come because the Assyrian army will march right up to the gate of Jerusalem.” UBS (page 146) comments: “it is even worse to have the enemies at Jerusalem than to have them in their own town, since it means there is no one left to send help and no place to which they can escape.” Commentaries that support interpretation (2) include WBC, JFB, NAC, and Waltke 2007. NAC (pages 58–59) explains: The suffering inhabitants of Maroth wait for ‘good’; instead, the Lord will send ‘disaster.’ Waltke 2007 (page 78) says that good represents “military aid, probably from Jerusalem; instead the Assyrian army marched right up to the gates of Jerusalem.”

In some languages, the meaning of *ki* (“because”) may be clear without giving an explicit conjunction. For example:

From the Lord disaster will come on the gates of Jerusalem. (GW)

Use a natural way in your language to make the correct relationship clear.

came down from the LORD: The verb came down is the same verb in Hebrew that Micah used in 1:3b (“the LORD...will come down and tread upon the high places of the earth”). Here in 1:12b, it means that the LORD will cause the disaster and that this disaster will soon happen.

In some languages, it may not be natural to say that a disaster came down. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Lord has sent disaster against the gate of Jerusalem (NET)

The LORD will cause a disaster to happen in front of the gate of Jerusalem.

trouble will come from the Lord, all the way to the gate of Jerusalem (NCV)

to the gate of Jerusalem: In 1:9c, Micah said that the disaster would come “to the gate of my people, to Jerusalem.” Here in 1:12b, he used a shorter phrase, to the gate of Jerusalem. This phrase refers to the main gate in the wall around the city. An enemy army would normally come to the gate in order to break it down and enter the city. This event probably happened when Hezekiah was king of Judah in 701 B.C. The Assyrian army came to the city gate of Jerusalem and surrounded the city, but they did not conquer it. Several years after Micah said this, an enemy army did come to Jerusalem and attacked the city. For more details, see 2 Chronicles 32:1–22 and Isaiah 36:1–37:38.

General Comment on 1:12a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to reverse the order of 1:12a and 1:12b. For example:

^{12b}The LORD will cause disaster to come to the gate of Jerusalem. ^{12a}That is why the people in the town of Maroth will wait anxiously for help but no help will come.

Micah 1:13

Section 1:8–16: Micah mourned because an enemy army will invade Judah and take many people into exile

In 1:5, Micah mentioned the sins of the people in Samaria and Jerusalem. In 1:6–7, he predicted that the LORD would destroy Samaria. Here in 1:8–16, he predicted that the LORD would also punish the people in Judah, including Jerusalem. He would punish them by causing an enemy army to invade Judah.

This section has two paragraphs: 1:8–9 and 1:10–16. In the first paragraph, Micah said that he would “lament and wail” (BSB). He described the way that he would mourn and then gave the reason. In the second paragraph, he mentioned several cities in Judah that an enemy army would soon attack on its way to Jerusalem. Some versions have separate section headings for each paragraph. The Notes will include both paragraphs as part of the same section. Here are some other examples of section headings for the entire section (1:8–16):

Lament for Jerusalem and the lowland towns (NJB)

Judah Is Doomed (CEV)

The Doom of the Cities of Judah (NRSV)

Micah mourned the disaster that will happen to various cities in Judah

If you choose to use separate section headings for 1:8–9 and 1:10–16, here are some examples for 1:8–9:

Weeping and Mourning (NIV, BSB)

Micah’s Great Sadness (NCV)

Either the CEV or NRSV headings above will be appropriate for 1:10–16. Here is another example:

Disaster will happen to various cities in Judah

Paragraph 1:10–16

In this paragraph, Micah mentioned the names of eleven towns in Judah in addition to the city of Jerusalem (v.12). These towns were located in the foothills between the low coastal area and the mountains of Judah. EBC (page 508). According to A&F (page

212), some of the cities mentioned have not been identified, and it is not possible to guess the route of the attack or the identity of the invaders. It could have been any of several different kings.

In many English versions as well as TN, 1:10–16 forms one paragraph. Some versions divide it into two or three paragraphs. For example, the GNT has two paragraphs (10–14 and 15–16). The NLT has three paragraphs (10–12, 13–15, and 16). Use whatever paragraph structure is appropriate for your language.

Here are some of the poetic variations of Micah's lament in 1:10–16:

1. In some verses, he spoke to the people in a particular town. In other verses, he spoke about them.
2. Sometimes he used plural nouns or pronouns to refer to the people in a particular town. At other times, he used singular nouns or pronouns.

English versions consistently use either plural or singular forms throughout these verses. For example, in 1:11b, the NJB uses singular pronouns:

She has not left her city, she who lives in Zanaan.
(NJB)

The NIV uses a plural pronoun:

Those who live in Zaanana will not come out. (NIV)

You may use either singular or plural forms or a combination of the two, depending on what is natural and appropriate in your language.

In 1:10–16, Micah used past tense verbs to describe what was still in the future. See the notes on 1:9b and 1:9c for more details.

Micah also made puns with the names of several of the towns or cities. A pun is a figure of speech in which a person uses a word that has two meanings or a word that sounds like another word.

1. In some verses, he used a word that sounded like the name of that town.
2. In other verses, he said something about a town that was related to the meaning of its name.

Here is a brief summary of the puns in each verse. This summary is condensed and adapted from EBC (pages 407–8.) and some general advice on how to translate puns. Complete notes on each verse will start with 1:10a.

- Beth-leaphrah (1:10b): The name of this city sounds like the Hebrew words that mean “house of dust.”

Micah commanded those who live in that town to roll in the dust.

- Shaphir (1:11a): This name means “beautiful” or “pleasant” in Hebrew. Micah said that the lives of the people in that town will not be pleasant.
- Zaanana (1:11b): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “come out.” Micah said that the people there will not come out of their city.
- Beth-ezel (1:11c): This name probably means “nearby house” in Hebrew. Micah said that Beth-ezel would no longer be nearby to serve as a “standing place” (protection, refuge) for Jerusalem.
- Maroth (1:12a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “bitter.” Micah said that the people in that town will suffer bitterly.
- Lachish (1:13): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “team of horses.” Micah told the people in that town to flee like running horses.
- Moresheth (-gath) (1:14a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “betrothed” (engaged to be married). Just like a young woman departs from her family when she gets married, so the people in that town would soon depart from Judah.
- Achzib (1:14b): This name means “deception” in Hebrew. That town will be a deception to the kings of Israel. These kings had hoped in vain that the people of Achzib would help them fight the enemy.
- Mareshah (1:15a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “conqueror.” The LORD will bring an enemy to that town who will conquer them.

In addition to the above puns, Micah also included the names of two places (Gath 1:10a) and Adullam (1:15b) that are famous in Jewish history. Their significance will be discussed in the notes on those verses.

The people to whom Micah spoke over 2,700 years ago understood the puns. They also understood the historical significance of Gath and Adullam. But most people today do not understand these things. That is the reason it is difficult to translate these verses clearly. Here are some general options to consider in translating the puns:

- Ignore the puns. Most English versions do this in the actual translation. Just translate the name in the Hebrew text. Those who read your translation will understand the basic meaning of each verse, but they will not know that there was a pun in Hebrew.
- Use footnotes to explain the puns. Many English versions with footnotes do this. For example, the NIV uses footnotes at 1:10a, 11b, 12a, 13a, and 15a to explain that a name sounds like another Hebrew word. It uses other footnotes at 1:10b, 11a, and 14b to explain the meaning of the name of a town.

- Explain in your translation the meaning or the sound of the names for the cities. If you use this option, you will need to clearly indicate in some way that this information is not part of your translation.

Choose an option that is appropriate for the readers in your language area.

1:13a

Harness your chariot horses, O dweller of Lachish.

- Tie^(plur) horses to the chariots, you people of Lachish!
- You people of Lachish! Hitch/Harness horses to your chariots.
- You who live in Lachish, prepare horses/animals and carts so you can escape/flee from your enemies.

Harness your chariot horses, O dweller of Lachish:

In this sentence, Micah spoke to the people who lived in the town of Lachish. According to NAC (page 59), Lachish was located “almost thirty miles southwest of Jerusalem and only six miles southwest of Moresheth Gath.” It was south and slightly east from Gath (maps in the NLT and NIV study Bibles). It was an important town that King Rehoboam of Judah had fortified (see 2 Chronicles 11:5–12). That means that there were soldiers, horses, chariots, and other fighting equipment in the town.

There are two ways to interpret Micah’s words in this verse part:

1. The inhabitants should prepare to flee from the enemy. They should ride in chariots to get away. For example:

Harness your chariot horses and flee, you people of Lachish. (NLT) (NLT)

1. The inhabitants should prepare to fight the enemy. For example:

Get the war chariots ready, you people of Lachish. (CEV) (CEV)

Almost all commentaries clearly support interpretation (1). It is possible that WBC supports interpretation (2). His translation is ambiguous, but in the comment section (pages 20–21), he says “the horses in Lachish were to be harnessed to the chariots because the day of battle has come.” Most English versions are ambiguous. They say only that the people should harness the horses to the chariots. It is recommended that you leave the purpose for harnessing the horses implicit if possible. If that is not possible in your language, you should follow interpretation (1). The first two meaning

lines in the Display will leave the purpose implied. The third meaning line will make it explicit.

Harness your chariot horses: In Hebrew, this clause is literally “Harness the chariot to the steed.” Most English versions reverse this order (“Harness the steeds to the chariots” (NRSV)). Use whatever order is natural in your language.

Micah used the definite article “the” two times in this sentence: “Harness the steeds to the chariots.” He was referring to the horses and chariots that were in Lachish. In some languages, it may be better to use the pronoun your or to not use a definite article. For example:

People in Lachish! Tie horses to your^(plur) chariots.

Another example is the NLT (quoted above).

In Hebrew, “steed” and “chariot” are singular. Perhaps Micah used these singular words to refer to each horse or team of horses that pulled a chariot. For example:

harness the team to the chariot (NIV)

Harness the chariot to the team of horses (NASB)

Most versions uses plural forms. Use whatever is natural in your language.

Harness: This word means “to tie or fasten horses to the chariots.” People tied special ropes or straps on the horses and tied these ropes to the chariot. The horses pulled the chariot. Here is another way to translate this word:

hitch the horses to the chariots (NET)

chariot horses: This phrase refers to a team of two or more horses that worked together to pull a chariot. See the NIV, NASB, and GNT (quoted above) for some ways to translate this phrase.

chariot: The word chariot refers to two-wheeled carts pulled by one or more horses. One or more people rode in a chariot. In languages that do not use a specific word such as chariot, it may be possible to use a general term such as “carts” or “war carts.”

In some areas, people do not know about horses and chariots. If that is true in your area, you may want to translate the implied purpose in interpretation (1) without mentioning either of these words. For example:

You people in Lachish! Prepare to flee from your enemies.

horses...Lachish: Micah made a pun in this sentence. In Hebrew, the word translated as horses sounds like the name of the city Lachish. In Hebrew, the name Lachish is lakiš, and the word “steed(s)” is larekeš.

You may want to use a footnote to help your readers understand this pun. For example:

Lachish sounds like the Hebrew term for “team of horses.” (NLT footnote)

If you do not use footnotes, you may decide to include the meanings of the place and the pun in your translation. For example:

And you who live in Lachish, the name of your town sounds like “horses,” so fasten your horses to your chariots.

O dweller of Lachish: In Hebrew, these words are at the end of the sentence. In some languages, this may be the natural place to put these words. In other languages, it may be more natural to put this phrase at the beginning of the sentence. For example:

You who live in Lachish, harness the team to the chariot. (NIV)

Put this phrase in a place that is natural in your language.

1:13b

You were the beginning of sin to the Daughter of Zion,

- You^(plur) were the first people in Judah to encourage the people in Zion to sin.
- You were the ones who first influenced the people in Jerusalem to sin.

You were the beginning of sin to the Daughter of Zion: In this sentence, Micah said that the people of Lachish were the beginning of sin to the people of Jerusalem.

You: In Hebrew, this pronoun is either “she” or “it.” The pronoun refers to Lachish in 1:13a. The pronoun “she” or “it” refers to the city of Lachish. Most scholars think it means the people in Lachish. Most English versions change the pronoun to “you” to make it agree with the rest of the verse.

the beginning of sin: Lachish was the beginning of sin to Jerusalem in the sense that the people of Lachish were the first ones to lead (encourage, influence) the people of Jerusalem to do a certain sin. Here are some other ways to translate 1:13b:

You were the first to lead the people of Zion into sin. (GW)

Jerusalem’s sins started in you (NCV)

You influenced Daughter Zion to sin (NET)

sin: Micah did not specify a particular sin. Almost all English versions leave the kind of sin implied. The NLT96 is an exception. It has “You were the first city in Judah to follow Israel in the sin of idol worship, and so you led Jerusalem into sin.” Commentaries interpret the nature of the sin in two main ways:

1. The sin was idolatry, including the worship of Baal. The northern kingdom’s first king, Jeroboam, began idol worship in Israel (cf. 1 Kings 16:26, 22:52–53), and idol worship in that nation became common. Although Israel had its own centers of worship, many people still traveled to the temple in Jerusalem and influenced them to worship idols in the temple there.
2. The sin was relying on military power instead of God.

It is likely that some of the people were guilty of one or both of these sins. Commentaries slightly favor interpretation (1), but it is recommended that you use a general word for sin and leave the specific sin implied. Commentaries that favor interpretation (2) include Waltke 2007, NAC, and ZIBBC. NAC (page 59) says: “The NIV seems to capture the intended sense: ‘You trust in military power. / That was the beginning of sin / for the people of Zion...’ It is instructive that ‘military power’ (horses and war chariots) would be demolished by the Lord (5:10).” Commentaries that favor interpretation (1) include A&F, WBC, JFB, and TOTC. JFB (page 689) says: “As lying near the border of the north kingdom, Lachish was first to be infected by its [Israel’s] idolatry, which thence spread to Jerusalem.” According to A&F (page 230), “ ‘She’ is the goddess whose image and cult were exported from Samaria to various other places and that the capital sin of the north (idolatry) reached Jerusalem via Lachish. The sin was setting up idols (and precisely idols of that goddess) in the high places of Judah (v 5)...The best sense we can make out of Micah 1:13 is that it documents the spread of a serious sin from Samaria to Jerusalem.”

If your translation uses footnotes, you may want supply a footnote that summarizes the specific sins that were probably implied. For example:

The sin that Micah was talking about was probably the sin of worshiping idols, specifically Baal (see 1 Kings 16:26–32). But the sin may also have been that Lachish led the nation to trust the power of war chariots instead of the LORD.

the Daughter of Zion: This phrase is a poetic way to refer to the people who live in Jerusalem. One of the hills on which Jerusalem was built was called Zion, and the temple was on that hill, so the Jews used the name Zion as another name for Jerusalem. In Hebrew, the word for “city” is feminine, so Hebrew prophets and poets sometimes personified the city as a woman and the people who lived there as her daughter. The phrase Daughter of Zion occurs four times in the book of Micah: 1:13; 4:8; 4:10; and 4:13. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Jerusalem (GNT)

the people of Jerusalem

the people of Zion (GW)

If you use a translation like one of these, you may want to use a footnote to give the literal translation. For example:

Hebrew: the daughter of Zion (NLT footnote)

1:13b “the people of Jerusalem.” What it says in Hebrew is: the daughter of Zion.

1:13c

for the transgressions of Israel were found in you.

- For you^(plur) are guilty of the same crime as the Israel people.
- You broke God’s law in the same way that the people in Israel did.
- I say this is because you rebelled against God, just like the people of Israel rebelled.

for: This word (ki in Hebrew) is a conjunction that marks a reason. Micah used it here to give evidence for what he said in 1:13b. The NCV translates this conjunction as “yes”: “Jerusalem’s sins started in you; yes, Israel’s sins were found in you.” According to this

interpretation, 1:13b and c are parallel lines of poetry that have similar meaning. This is a possible interpretation, and the NJB, for example, ends this line with an exclamation mark. But most English versions clearly interpret 1:13c as the evidence for 1:13b. For example:

Because (NASB)

Some versions leave the reason implied. For example:

the crimes of Israel can be traced to you (NJB)

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses so that the reason precedes the result. For example:

You imitated the sins of Israel and so caused Jerusalem to sin. (GNT)

the transgressions of Israel were found in you: This clause means that the people in Lachish rebelled against the LORD and broke his laws in the same way that the people of Israel did.

the transgressions of Israel: See the note on the word “transgression” at 1:5a for more information about the meaning of that word.

Israel: The name Israel refers here to the people in the northern kingdom. Lachish was a city in Judah, the southern kingdom. But the people in Lachish did the same kind of evil things.

were found: This is probably a figurative way of saying that the transgressions of Israel also occurred in Lachish. Here are some ways to translate this clause:

You imitated the sins of Israel... (GNT)

you broke the same laws of God that the people of Israel broke

you imitated the people of Israel and broke God’s laws in the same way that they did

General Comment on 1:13b–c

In some languages, it may be clearer to reverse the order of 1:13b and c. For example:

“You people of Lachish are guilty of breaking God’s laws, just like the people of Israel did.”^bAnd so you

were the first to cause the people of Jerusalem to sin.

Translate 1:13b–c in the order that is natural and clear in your language.

Micah 1:14

Section 1:8–16: Micah mourned because an enemy army will invade Judah and take many people into exile

In 1:5, Micah mentioned the sins of the people in Samaria and Jerusalem. In 1:6–7, he predicted that the LORD would destroy Samaria. Here in 1:8–16, he predicted that the LORD would also punish the people in Judah, including Jerusalem. He would punish them by causing an enemy army to invade Judah.

This section has two paragraphs: 1:8–9 and 1:10–16. In the first paragraph, Micah said that he would “lament and wail” (BSB). He described the way that he would mourn and then gave the reason. In the second paragraph, he mentioned several cities in Judah that an enemy army would soon attack on its way to Jerusalem. Some versions have separate section headings for each paragraph. The Notes will include both paragraphs as part of the same section. Here are some other examples of section headings for the entire section (1:8–16):

Lament for Jerusalem and the lowland towns (NJB)

Judah Is Doomed (CEV)

The Doom of the Cities of Judah (NRSV)

Micah mourned the disaster that will happen to various cities in Judah

If you choose to use separate section headings for 1:8–9 and 1:10–16, here are some examples for 1:8–9:

Weeping and Mourning (NIV, BSB)

Micah’s Great Sadness (NCV)

Either the CEV or NRSV headings above will be appropriate for 1:10–16. Here is another example:

Disaster will happen to various cities in Judah

Paragraph 1:10–16

In this paragraph, Micah mentioned the names of eleven towns in Judah in addition to the city of Jerusalem (v.12). These towns were located in the foothills between the low coastal area and the mountains of Judah. EBC (page 508). According to A&F (page 212), some of the cities mentioned have not been identified, and it is not possible to guess the route of the attack or the identity of the invaders. It could have been any of several different kings.

In many English versions as well as TN, 1:10–16 forms one paragraph. Some versions divide it into two or three paragraphs. For example, the GNT has two paragraphs (10–14 and 15–16). The NLT has three paragraphs (10–12, 13–15, and 16). Use whatever paragraph structure is appropriate for your language.

Here are some of the poetic variations of Micah’s lament in 1:10–16:

1. In some verses, he spoke to the people in a particular town. In other verses, he spoke about them.
2. Sometimes he used plural nouns or pronouns to refer to the people in a particular town. At other times, he used singular nouns or pronouns.

English versions consistently use either plural or singular forms throughout these verses. For example, in 1:11b, the NJB uses singular pronouns:

She has not left her city, she who lives in Zanaan. (NJB)

The NIV uses a plural pronoun:

Those who live in Zanaan will not come out. (NIV)

You may use either singular or plural forms or a combination of the two, depending on what is natural and appropriate in your language.

In 1:10–16, Micah used past tense verbs to describe what was still in the future. See the notes on 1:9b and 1:9c for more details.

Micah also made puns with the names of several of the towns or cities. A pun is a figure of speech in which a person uses a word that has two meanings or a word that sounds like another word.

1. In some verses, he used a word that sounded like the name of that town.
2. In other verses, he said something about a town that was related to the meaning of its name.

Here is a brief summary of the puns in each verse. This summary is condensed and adapted from EBC (pages 407–8.) and some general advice on how to translate puns. Complete notes on each verse will start with 1:10a.

- Beth-leaphrah (1:10b): The name of this city sounds like the Hebrew words that mean “house of dust.” Micah commanded those who live in that town to roll in the dust.
- Shaphir (1:11a): This name means “beautiful” or “pleasant” in Hebrew. Micah said that the lives of the people in that town will not be pleasant.
- Zaanen (1:11b): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “come out.” Micah said that the people there will not come out of their city.
- Beth-ezel (1:11c): This name probably means “nearby house” in Hebrew. Micah said that Beth-ezel would no longer be nearby to serve as a “standing place” (protection, refuge) for Jerusalem.
- Maroth (1:12a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “bitter.” Micah said that the people in that town will suffer bitterly.
- Lachish (1:13): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “team of horses.” Micah told the people in that town to flee like running horses.
- Moresheth (-gath) (1:14a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “betrothed” (engaged to be married). Just like a young woman departs from her family when she gets married, so the people in that town would soon depart from Judah.
- Achzib (1:14b): This name means “deception” in Hebrew. That town will be a deception to the kings of Israel. These kings had hoped in vain that the people of Achzib would help them fight the enemy.
- Mareshah (1:15a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “conqueror.” The LORD will bring an enemy to that town who will conquer them.

In addition to the above puns, Micah also included the names of two places (Gath 1:10a) and Adullam (1:15b) that are famous in Jewish history. Their significance will be discussed in the notes on those verses.

The people to whom Micah spoke over 2,700 years ago understood the puns. They also understood the historical significance of Gath and Adullam. But most people today do not understand these things. That is the reason it is difficult to translate these verses clearly. Here are some general options to consider in translating the puns:

- Ignore the puns. Most English versions do this in the actual translation. Just translate the name in the Hebrew text. Those who read your translation will

understand the basic meaning of each verse, but they will not know that there was a pun in Hebrew.

- Use footnotes to explain the puns. Many English versions with footnotes do this. For example, the NIV uses footnotes at 1:10a, 11b, 12a, 13a, and 15a to explain that a name sounds like another Hebrew word. It uses other footnotes at 1:10b, 11a, and 14b to explain the meaning of the name of a town.
- Explain in your translation the meaning or the sound of the names for the cities. If you use this option, you will need to clearly indicate in some way that this information is not part of your translation.

Choose an option that is appropriate for the readers in your language area.

1:14a

Therefore, send farewell gifts to Moresheth-gath;

- Therefore you^(plur) will give a farewell gift to Moresheth-gath.
- So you must give good-bye gifts to the people of Moresheth-gath.
- And so, you people of Judah, you will say good-bye to those who live in Moresheth-gath, for they will be taken away by their enemies.

Therefore, send farewell gifts to Moresheth-gath:

In this verse part, Micah talked about Moresheth-gath, another small town in Judah.

Therefore: There are two ways to interpret the connection of the word Therefore:

1. What Micah said about Moresheth-gath is the result of what he said in the previous verse. For example:

And so (NJB) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NRSV, REB)

1. What Micah said about Moresheth-gath is the next thing he said in his list of comments to cities in Judah.

And now (GNT) (CEV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most English versions. The people in Jerusalem and Judah had begun to sin just like the northern kingdom. Therefore they must say good-bye to the people in Moresheth-gath. Here is another way to translate this connection:

That is why (GW)

Translate this connection in a natural way in your language.

send farewell gifts to Moresheth-gath: Micah made a pun here. The name “Moresheth” sounds like the Hebrew word for fiancée. In the Jewish culture, parents gave their engaged daughter a special gift at the time she left their home to go live with her husband.

Micah’s pun means that an enemy army will capture the city of Moresheth-gath and take the people away as captives. The people are like a daughter that will soon leave home. The other people in Judah will soon no longer see them. It is not recommended that you make this pun explicit in the translation itself.

If you use footnotes in your translation, here are some sample footnotes:

1.14a Moresheth sounds like the Hebrew term for “gift” or “dowry.” (NLT footnote)

1.14 farewell gift: The gift (dowry) that a bride’s father gave her when she left the home of her parents to live with the family of her husband. In Hebrew the word for “bride” or “fiancée” sounds like “Moresheth.” (CEV footnote)

Here are some ways to translate 1:14a without a figure of speech:

And so, people of Judah, you will say good-bye to the town of Moresheth Gath. (based on GNT)

So wave good-bye to the people of Moresheth-gath, for they must soon go away.

If you prefer not to refer to the pun in a footnote, you may translate without a figure of speech (as in the two preceding examples), but supply a footnote that explains the reason the people will have to leave. For example:

Micah told the people of Judah to say good-bye to the people of Moresheth-gath, because an enemy army would capture that city and take the people away as captives.

send: It is not clear to whom this command is given. Here are the main interpretations:

1. It is given to the people in Judah.

people of Judah, say good-bye to the town of Moresheth Gath (GNT) (GNT)

1. It is given to the people in Lachish (see 1:13a–c).
2. It is given to the people in Jerusalem (“daughter of Zion,” see 1:13b).

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most commentaries. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include NAC, JFB, and TOTC. According to JFB (page 689), “‘Israel’ in this verse is used for the kingdom of Judah, which was the chief representative of the whole nation of Israel.” Interpretation (2) is supported by a footnote in the NET: “The subject of the feminine singular verb is probably Lachish.” Interpretation (3) is supported by A&F (page 232), who say only: “In the absence of a clear candidate to be subject of the verb, Jerusalem is the probable giver.” A fourth interpretation is suggested by Waltke 2007. On pages 81–82, he says: “the parallel in v 14b shows that the rulers of Israel are the subjects.” The GNT explicitly follows this interpretation. Other versions leave the reference implicit (ambiguous). For many readers, an ambiguous command will incorrectly refer back to Israel or Lachish. So it is recommended that you translate in a way that refers clearly to Judah.

In Hebrew, this command is singular. Micah used Hebrew poetry here, so he spoke to the nation as if it were one person. You may use either singular or plural, depending on whether you refer here to the nation or the people of the nation.

Moresheth-gath: In 1:1a, Micah called the name of his home town Moresheth, but here he called it Moresheth-gath. There was probably more than one town named Moresheth, so by adding the extra name “Gath” Micah made it clear which town he meant. Some scholars think that this town was called Moresheth-gath because it was near the Philistine city of Gath.

Some English versions spell the name of this town differently. For example:

Moresheth Gath (NIV)

Moreshethgath (KJV)

Moresheth in Gath (NCV)

You may want to use a spelling that fits the phonetic rules of your language or a spelling that is used in a language of wider communication in your country.

1:14b**the houses of Achzib will prove deceptive to the kings of Israel.**

- The kings of Israel will get no help from the people in Achzib.
- The kings of Israel will be disappointed. The town of Achzib will not help them.
- The kings of Israel hope that the people of Achzib will be their ally, but they will be disappointed.

the houses of Achzib will prove deceptive to the kings of Israel:

Micah used a pun in this sentence. The name Achzib sounds like the Hebrew word for deceptive (achzab). In Hebrew, the name Achzib is (ʾakzib). The word for “deceptive” is (ʾakzab). Instead of “deceptive,” two versions follow another possible meaning. The NET has: “as disappointing as a dried up well.” The NJPS has “like a spring that fails.” NAC (pages 59–60) has the following comment: “In Jer 15:18 ‘deceptive’ is used of a brook that has dried up. Achzib will be as undependable and disappointing as a dried-up brook because its people won’t be able to give any help to the kings of Israel.” A footnote in the NET has: The term אַכְזִיב (ʾakzab) is often translated “deception,” as derived from the verb אָכַזַב (“to deceive, lie”; HALOT 467–68 s.v. אָכַזַב). However, it probably means “what is dried up,” since (1) the noun elsewhere refers to an empty well or dried river in summer (Jer 15:18; cf. Job 6:15–20) (HALOT 45 s.v. אָכַזַב); (2) the place-name “Achzib” (אַכְזִיב) literally means “place on the אָכַזַב [dried up river]” (HALOT 45 s.v. אָכַזַב); and (3) it is derived from the verb אָכַזַב (“to dry up [brook]”; Isa 58:11), which also appears in Mishnaic Hebrew and Arabic. The point of the metaphor is that Achzib will be as disappointing to the kings of Israel as a dried up spring in the summer is to a thirsty traveler in the Jordanian desert.

The kings of Israel hoped that the town of Achzib would be their ally. They hoped that the people in Achzib would send soldiers to help them fight the enemy. But the kings of Israel would soon feel deceived or disappointed, because Achzib would not send any help. Here are some other ways to translate this idea:

The kings of Israel will get no help from the town of Achzib. (GNT)

Israel’s kings will discover that they cannot trust the town of Achzib. (CEV)

The town of Achzib has deceived the kings of Israel, for it promised help it could not give. (NLT96)

The kings in Israel trusted the Achzib people to help them. But they will send no help.

the houses of Achzib: This phrase is a poetic way to refer to the town of Achzib or to the people who live there. The Hebrew text has plural “houses of” (Hebrew: botteh). The plural form is reflected in the BSB, ESV, KJV, NASB, NCV, NJPS, and NRSV. Singular “house of” would be bet in Hebrew. Versions that reflect the singular form include the CEV, GW, NAB, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB and GNT. The singular form may also assume that “house of” is part of the name of the town, such as the Bethlehem (meaning “house of bread”). The Notes have not treated this as a textual or interpretation issue, because the singular-plural distinction does not affect the number of towns and has only a slight effect on the meaning of the pun. Waltke 2007 (page 83) advances the idea that “houses” should be translated as “workshops” and that these workshops (factories) would no longer produce goods that could be sold. No versions translate this word as “workshops.” NAC (pages 59–60) gives persuasive reasons for rejecting Waltke’s idea. It says: “Elsewhere when bayit, ‘house,’ is used in the sense of “workshop,” the nature of the work is specified. In 1 Chr 4:21 it is linen work; in Jer 18:2 it is the work of a potter. Here in Mic 1:14 no such work is specified. Furthermore, as Hillers points out, this passage speaks not of ‘loss’ but of ‘something that deceives or disappoints.’ So while ‘workshops’ is semantically possible, ‘town’ seems more likely.” Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the town of Achzib (GNT)

the residents of Achzib (NET)

Beth-Achzib (NJB)

kings of Israel: This phrase may refer to kings of the northern kingdom in contrast to kings of the southern kingdom of Judah. It may also refer to kings of Judah with the assumption that Judah is considered to be part of the kingdom of Israel as a whole. All English versions identify the country as Israel. It is recommended that you do the same thing. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

rulers/leaders of Israel

the person who sits on the throne in Israel

If you feel it will be helpful for your readers, it is suggested that you supply a footnote that gives some of this background material. For example:

The phrase “kings of Israel” might refer to a king or kings who ruled in Judah (Jerusalem). Sometimes Judah was considered to be part of the nation of Israel as a whole.

Micah 1:15

Section 1:8–16: Micah mourned because an enemy army will invade Judah and take many people into exile

In 1:5, Micah mentioned the sins of the people in Samaria and Jerusalem. In 1:6–7, he predicted that the LORD would destroy Samaria. Here in 1:8–16, he predicted that the LORD would also punish the people in Judah, including Jerusalem. He would punish them by causing an enemy army to invade Judah.

This section has two paragraphs: 1:8–9 and 1:10–16. In the first paragraph, Micah said that he would “lament and wail” (BSB). He described the way that he would mourn and then gave the reason. In the second paragraph, he mentioned several cities in Judah that an enemy army would soon attack on its way to Jerusalem. Some versions have separate section headings for each paragraph. The Notes will include both paragraphs as part of the same section. Here are some other examples of section headings for the entire section (1:8–16):

Lament for Jerusalem and the lowland towns
(NJB)

Judah Is Doomed (CEV)

The Doom of the Cities of Judah (NRSV)

Micah mourned the disaster that will happen to various cities in Judah

If you choose to use separate section headings for 1:8–9 and 1:10–16, here are some examples for 1:8–9:

Weeping and Mourning (NIV, BSB)

Micah’s Great Sadness (NCV)

Either the CEV or NRSV headings above will be appropriate for 1:10–16. Here is another example:

Disaster will happen to various cities in Judah

Paragraph 1:10–16

In this paragraph, Micah mentioned the names of eleven towns in Judah in addition to the city of Jerusalem (v.12). These towns were located in the foothills between the low coastal area and the mountains of Judah. EBC (page 508). According to A&F (page 212), some of the cities mentioned have not been identified, and it is not possible to guess the route of the attack or the identity of the invaders. It could have been any of several different kings.

In many English versions as well as TN, 1:10–16 forms one paragraph. Some versions divide it into two or three paragraphs. For example, the GNT has two paragraphs (10–14 and 15–16). The NLT has three paragraphs (10–12, 13–15, and 16). Use whatever paragraph structure is appropriate for your language.

Here are some of the poetic variations of Micah’s lament in 1:10–16:

1. In some verses, he spoke to the people in a particular town. In other verses, he spoke about them.
2. Sometimes he used plural nouns or pronouns to refer to the people in a particular town. At other times, he used singular nouns or pronouns.

English versions consistently use either plural or singular forms throughout these verses. For example, in 1:11b, the NJB uses singular pronouns:

She has not left her city, she who lives in Zanaan.
(NJB)

The NIV uses a plural pronoun:

Those who live in Zanaan will not come out. (NIV)

You may use either singular or plural forms or a combination of the two, depending on what is natural and appropriate in your language.

In 1:10–16, Micah used past tense verbs to describe what was still in the future. See the notes on 1:9b and 1:9c for more details.

Micah also made puns with the names of several of the towns or cities. A pun is a figure of speech in which a person uses a word that has two meanings or a word that sounds like another word.

1. In some verses, he used a word that sounded like the name of that town.
2. In other verses, he said something about a town that was related to the meaning of its name.

Here is a brief summary of the puns in each verse. This summary is condensed and adapted from EBC (pages 407–8.) and some general advice on how to translate puns. Complete notes on each verse will start with 1:10a.

- Beth-leaphrah (1:10b): The name of this city sounds like the Hebrew words that mean “house of dust.” Micah commanded those who live in that town to roll in the dust.
- Shaphir (1:11a): This name means “beautiful” or “pleasant” in Hebrew. Micah said that the lives of the people in that town will not be pleasant.
- Zaanan (1:11b): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “come out.” Micah said that the people there will not come out of their city.
- Beth-ezel (1:11c): This name probably means “nearby house” in Hebrew. Micah said that Beth-ezel would no longer be nearby to serve as a “standing place” (protection, refuge) for Jerusalem.
- Maroth (1:12a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “bitter.” Micah said that the people in that town will suffer bitterly.
- Lachish (1:13): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “team of horses.” Micah told the people in that town to flee like running horses.
- Moresheth (-gath) (1:14a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “betrothed” (engaged to be married). Just like a young woman departs from her family when she gets married, so the people in that town would soon depart from Judah.
- Achzib (1:14b): This name means “deception” in Hebrew. That town will be a deception to the kings of Israel. These kings had hoped in vain that the people of Achzib would help them fight the enemy.
- Mareshah (1:15a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “conqueror.” The LORD will bring an enemy to that town who will conquer them.

In addition to the above puns, Micah also included the names of two places (Gath 1:10a) and Adullam (1:15b) that are famous in Jewish history. Their significance will be discussed in the notes on those verses.

The people to whom Micah spoke over 2,700 years ago understood the puns. They also understood the historical significance of Gath and Adullam. But most people today do not understand these things. That is the reason it is difficult to translate these verses clearly. Here are some general options to consider in translating the puns:

- Ignore the puns. Most English versions do this in the actual translation. Just translate the name in the Hebrew text. Those who read your translation will

understand the basic meaning of each verse, but they will not know that there was a pun in Hebrew.

- Use footnotes to explain the puns. Many English versions with footnotes do this. For example, the NIV uses footnotes at 1:10a, 11b, 12a, 13a, and 15a to explain that a name sounds like another Hebrew word. It uses other footnotes at 1:10b, 11a, and 14b to explain the meaning of the name of a town.
- Explain in your translation the meaning or the sound of the names for the cities. If you use this option, you will need to clearly indicate in some way that this information is not part of your translation.

Choose an option that is appropriate for the readers in your language area.

1:15a

I will again bring a conqueror against you, O dweller of Mareshah.

- I will send someone to conquer you^(plur) also, people who live in Mareshah.
- And Yahweh says, “As for you people who live in Mareshah, I will send someone who will conquer you as well.”
- Yahweh said that he will cause/send enemies to fight against your town to defeat you.

In this verse part, Micah talked about Mareshah, another town in Judah. The LORD will send an enemy to conquer that city also.

I will again bring a conqueror against you: In Hebrew, there are three ways to interpret the word again:

1. It means “furthermore” or “also.” In 1:10–14, Micah said that an enemy army would attack several Jewish cities. Here in 1:15a, the LORD said that in addition to those other cities, he would also send an enemy army to conquer Mareshah. For example:

People of Mareshah: I will send someone to conquer you also.

And you too, people of Mareshah, I shall send others to take your place... (REB)

And besides that, I will send an army to conquer you too, people of Mareshah! (NASB, REB)

1. Some scholars think this word means “again,” or “one more time.” God will send a conqueror to Mareshah again. This implies that this is not the first time that God had sent a conqueror to Mareshah.

I will again bring a conqueror to you, inhabitants of Mareshah. (ESV) (BSB, ESV, GW, NJB, NRSV)

1. Some scholars think that this word mean “yet” or “still.” God had not yet sent an army to conquer them, but he would still do it. For example:

Yet must I bring to you the conqueror (NAB) (KJV, NAB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most commentaries. Most scholars do not mention this issue. No commentary supports the translation “again.” UBS (pages 149–150) says that if “again,” is correct, it would have to refer to a previous incident in which an enemy conquered Mareshah. “If ‘again’ does not mean ‘a second time’ in this verse, it may well be omitted in other languages, since the other alternatives are simply connecting words which do not add anything new to the sense.” Waltke 2007 (83–84) comments: “*ōḏ* (Also) can mean “beside,” or “again” (NRSV). The latter, however, diffuses the threat by raising the question, “When previously did God bring a conqueror against Mareshah?” “Besides” fits the context well.”

Many English versions (the NIV and GNT are two examples) leave this word untranslated. If the recommended interpretation is clear in your language, you may do the same thing.

I: This pronoun refers to the LORD. Micah spoke the LORD’s words here, like he did in 1:6.

In all of the rest of 1:10–16 Micah is the speaker. Only here at 1:15a is the LORD the speaker. A literal translation of 1:15a may confuse your readers. They may think that I refers to Micah. There are several ways you can translate this:

- Translate the pronoun I literally. Your readers may need to study and think about the verse to understand that the LORD is the speaker, not Micah. Many English versions do this.
- Translate the pronoun as I and also add a footnote to indicate who the speaker is. For example:

1:15a: The Lord is the one who is speaking here.

- Translate the pronoun as I and also include a phrase such as “The LORD says,” or “This is what the LORD says” at the beginning or end of the sentence, wherever it is natural in your language. For example,

The LORD says, “You people of Mareshah, I will send enemies to conquer your town also...”

- Translate 1:15a as an indirect quote. For example:

The LORD says that he will send a conqueror against you people in Mareshah.

- Translate 1:15a as Micah’s words. For example:

People of Mareshah, the Lord will hand you over to an enemy, who is going to capture your town. (GNT)

People of Mareshah, the Lord will send someone to capture your town. (CEV)

Choose an option that is clear, natural, and appropriate in your language.

bring a conqueror against you: There are two ways to interpret the word conqueror here:

1. It refers to an enemy army that will fight against Mareshah and conquer it. For example:

an enemy, who is going to capture your town (GNT) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NAB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, GNT)

1. It refers to an enemy army that will take possession of Mareshah like an heir takes possession of an inheritance. In addition to the NASB, the NJPS has “a dispossessor” and the REB has “others to take your place.” The KJV has “an heir.” For example:

the one who takes possession (NASB) (KJV, NASB, NJPS, REB)

Most commentaries prefer interpretation (2). UBS prefers interpretation (1), but comments (pages 149–150) that a translation such as “others to take your place” (NEB) “can be related to the idea of a conqueror if it means that the conquering people will take the people of Mareshah away into exile and brings others to live in their town.” Commentaries that support interpretation (2) include NICOT, WBC, A&F, EBC, JFB, TOTC, and NAC. WBC (page 19–20) says that the word can mean “possessor,” “heir,” or “conqueror.” Waltke 2007 and TOTC both translate “conqueror,” but TOTC (pages 170–171) comments: “Possibly by popular etymologizing, Mareshah was associated with the verb ‘dispossess’. A new heir will dispossess the old her-

itage of Judah.” NICOT (page 282) relates the name to yōrēš, “possessor, heir.” He comments: “Mareshah is to be taken over by a new heir. It is not insignificant that the word is often used of gains in war: the right of inheritance is to be won by conquest.” But it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. It is not known whether enemy soldiers or people from other countries dispossessed the people of the town. A more general translation such as conqueror allows for both interpretations.

conqueror: This word is singular. It probably refers to an enemy army. It is possible that the singular conqueror refers to the king of the Assyrian enemies. The king sent his soldiers to attack the cities in Judah. If it is clearer in your language, you can translate this word as plural. For example:

I will bring against you people who will take your land, you who live in Mareshah. (NCV)

you: In Hebrew, this pronoun is singular. It refers by personification to the town of Mareshah. In some languages, it may be clearer to use a plural pronoun here. Translate this pronoun in a natural way in your language.

O dweller of Mareshah: If it is more natural in your language, you can translate it as plural, as in the NRSV (“inhabitants of Mareshah”).

In Hebrew, the phrase dweller of Mareshah is at the end of 1:15b. In some languages, it may be better to have this phrase at the beginning of the sentence. For example:

O people of Mareshah, I will bring a conqueror to capture your town. (NLT)

Do whatever is natural in your language.

Mareshah: Mareshah was a town in Judah. It was about seven kilometers southwest of Achzib and five kilometers south of Moresheth.

Micah used a pun here. The Hebrew word for “conqueror” (yoresh) has a similar sound to the name Mareshah. If you use footnotes in your translation, here are some suggested footnotes:

The place name Mareshah sounds like the Hebrew word for “conqueror.” (NET footnote)

[Mareshah] This name sounds like the Hebrew word for a person who captures other cities and lands. (NCV footnote)

If you do not use footnotes and you feel it is important for your readers to understand that this is a pun, here is a way to translate this verse part so that the pun is explicit:

You people in Mareshah! The name of your town sounds like the word “conqueror.” So to you the LORD says, “I will send enemies to conquer your town also!”

1:15b

The glory of Israel will come to Adullam.

- The leaders of Israel will flee to the town of Adullam.
- The important people of Israel will run away and hide at Adullam.
- The leaders of Israel will hide from their enemies, like David did long ago in the cave at Adullam.

The glory of Israel will come to Adullam: During the time of Micah, Adullam was an important fortified town. It was part of Rehoboam’s defense system along with Lachish (2 Chr. 11:6–10) and was located not far from Achzib between Lachish and Moresheth-gath. UBS, NAC, NICOT.

Micah is probably the speaker here. Even if the speaker is the LORD instead of Micah, it does not affect the meaning. There are two ways to interpret the meaning of the phrase The glory of Israel:

1. It refers to the leaders of the nation. For example:

The leaders of Israel (GNT) (NET, NLT, GNT)

1. It refers to a single king. For example:

Israel’s glorious king (CEV) (CEV, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a majority of versions and commentaries. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include UBS, JFB, NAC, ABC, and Waltke 2007. NAC (pages 60–61) uses the phrase “Israel’s glorious leaders,” and Waltke 2007 (page 85) refers to “Israel’s military leaders and officials.” WBC (page 22) refers to a combination of things and people. He has “wealth and nobles.” EBC (page 509) has simply “the people.” The NIV translation “He who is the glory of Israel” could refer to the king of Judah, or it could even refer

to the Messiah. The Hebrew word for glory is also used to mean leaders in Isaiah 5:13; 17:3–4.

glory: Micah called these leaders Israel’s glory because they were important people. The other people in the nation were proud of them. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Israel’s respected/famous leaders

will come to Adullam: The historical context of this phrase is that over 200 years earlier, when King Saul and his army were searching for David to kill him, David and his men hid in a cave near the town of Adullam (1 Samuel 22:1).

Here in Micah 1:15b, Adullam is a symbol for running away and hiding from danger. Micah’s words mean that Israel’s leaders will be in danger. They will run away and hide, just like David had done long ago.

Here are some ways that you can translate the phrase will come to Adullam:

- Translate the verb will come literally. For example:

the leaders of Israel shall flee to Adullam (NET)

If you do this, you may want to add a footnote to explain the meaning. For example:

Adullam is the place where David hid in a cave when he was in danger. See 1 Samuel 22:1. Micah’s words in 1:15b indicate that Israel’s leaders will hide from danger just like David did.

...This probably means that the nation’s leadership will run for their lives and, like David of old, hide from their enemy in the caves of Adullam... (NET footnote)

- Translate the verb will come in a way that will help your readers understand the symbolic meaning. For example:

The leaders of Israel will go and hide in the cave at Adullam. (GNT)

Here are some other ways to translate the name Adullam:

the town of Adullam

the cave at Adullam (GNT)

Adullam Cave (CEV)

Micah 1:16

Section 1:8–16: Micah mourned because an enemy army will invade Judah and take many people into exile

In 1:5, Micah mentioned the sins of the people in Samaria and Jerusalem. In 1:6–7, he predicted that the LORD would destroy Samaria. Here in 1:8–16, he predicted that the LORD would also punish the people in Judah, including Jerusalem. He would punish them by causing an enemy army to invade Judah.

This section has two paragraphs: 1:8–9 and 1:10–16. In the first paragraph, Micah said that he would “lament and wail” (BSB). He described the way that he would mourn and then gave the reason. In the second paragraph, he mentioned several cities in Judah that an enemy army would soon attack on its way to Jerusalem. Some versions have separate section headings for each paragraph. The Notes will include both paragraphs as part of the same section. Here are some other examples of section headings for the entire section (1:8–16):

Lament for Jerusalem and the lowland towns (NJB)

Judah Is Doomed (CEV)

The Doom of the Cities of Judah (NRSV)

Micah mourned the disaster that will happen to various cities in Judah

If you choose to use separate section headings for 1:8–9 and 1:10–16, here are some examples for 1:8–9:

Weeping and Mourning (NIV, BSB)

Micah’s Great Sadness (NCV)

Either the CEV or NRSV headings above will be appropriate for 1:10–16. Here is another example:

Disaster will happen to various cities in Judah

Paragraph 1:10–16

In this paragraph, Micah mentioned the names of eleven towns in Judah in addition to the city of Jerusalem (v.12). These towns were located in the foothills between the low coastal area and the mountains of Judah. EBC (page 508). According to A&F (page 212), some of the cities mentioned have not been identified, and it is not possible to guess the route of the attack or the identity of the invaders. It could have been any of several different kings.

In many English versions as well as TN, 1:10–16 forms one paragraph. Some versions divide it into two or three paragraphs. For example, the GNT has two paragraphs (10–14 and 15–16). The NLT has three paragraphs (10–12, 13–15, and 16). Use whatever paragraph structure is appropriate for your language.

Here are some of the poetic variations of Micah's lament in 1:10–16:

1. In some verses, he spoke to the people in a particular town. In other verses, he spoke about them.
2. Sometimes he used plural nouns or pronouns to refer to the people in a particular town. At other times, he used singular nouns or pronouns.

English versions consistently use either plural or singular forms throughout these verses. For example, in 1:11b, the NJB uses singular pronouns:

She has not left her city, she who lives in Zanaan.
(NJB)

The NIV uses a plural pronoun:

Those who live in Zaanani will not come out. (NIV)

You may use either singular or plural forms or a combination of the two, depending on what is natural and appropriate in your language.

In 1:10–16, Micah used past tense verbs to describe what was still in the future. See the notes on 1:9b and 1:9c for more details.

Micah also made puns with the names of several of the towns or cities. A pun is a figure of speech in which a person uses a word that has two meanings or a word that sounds like another word.

1. In some verses, he used a word that sounded like the name of that town.
2. In other verses, he said something about a town that was related to the meaning of its name.

Here is a brief summary of the puns in each verse. This summary is condensed and adapted from EBC (pages 407–8.) and some general advice on how to translate puns. Complete notes on each verse will start with 1:10a.

- Beth-leaphrah (1:10b): The name of this city sounds like the Hebrew words that mean “house of dust.” Micah commanded those who live in that town to roll in the dust.
- Shaphir (1:11a): This name means “beautiful” or “pleasant” in Hebrew. Micah said that the lives of the people in that town will not be pleasant.
- Zaanani (1:11b): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “come out.” Micah said that the people there will not come out of their city.
- Beth-ezel (1:11c): This name probably means “nearby house” in Hebrew. Micah said that Beth-ezel would no longer be nearby to serve as a “standing place” (protection, refuge) for Jerusalem.
- Maroth (1:12a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “bitter.” Micah said that the people in that town will suffer bitterly.
- Lachish (1:13): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “team of horses.” Micah told the people in that town to flee like running horses.
- Moresheth (-gath) (1:14a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “betrothed” (engaged to be married). Just like a young woman departs from her family when she gets married, so the people in that town would soon depart from Judah.
- Achzib (1:14b): This name means “deception” in Hebrew. That town will be a deception to the kings of Israel. These kings had hoped in vain that the people of Achzib would help them fight the enemy.
- Mareshah (1:15a): This name sounds like the Hebrew word for “conqueror.” The LORD will bring an enemy to that town who will conquer them.

In addition to the above puns, Micah also included the names of two places (Gath 1:10a) and Adullam (1:15b) that are famous in Jewish history. Their significance will be discussed in the notes on those verses.

The people to whom Micah spoke over 2,700 years ago understood the puns. They also understood the historical significance of Gath and Adullam. But most people today do not understand these things. That is the reason it is difficult to translate these verses clearly. Here are some general options to consider in translating the puns:

- Ignore the puns. Most English versions do this in the actual translation. Just translate the name in the Hebrew text. Those who read your translation will

understand the basic meaning of each verse, but they will not know that there was a pun in Hebrew.

- Use footnotes to explain the puns. Many English versions with footnotes do this. For example, the NIV uses footnotes at 1:10a, 11b, 12a, 13a, and 15a to explain that a name sounds like another Hebrew word. It uses other footnotes at 1:10b, 11a, and 14b to explain the meaning of the name of a town.
- Explain in your translation the meaning or the sound of the names for the cities. If you use this option, you will need to clearly indicate in some way that this information is not part of your translation.

Choose an option that is appropriate for the readers in your language area.

1:16

In this verse, Micah addressed the people of Judah. The GNT makes this explicit by starting the verse with the words “People of Judah...”

This verse has two pairs of parallel lines that are similar in meaning. The first line is parallel to the third line. The **second** line is parallel to the **fourth** line:

^{16a} Shave yourselves bald and cut off your hair

^{16b} **in mourning for your precious children,**

^{16c} make yourselves as bald as an eagle,

^{16d} **for they will go from you into exile.**

In some languages, this kind of parallelism may cause confusion. If that is true in your language, it may be possible to combine the similar verse parts. For example:

^{16a,c} People of Judah, shave your head as bald as a buzzard and start mourning. ^{16b,d} Your children whom you love will be dragged off to a foreign country. (similar to CEV)

1:16a-c

Shave yourselves bald and cut off your hair in mourning...make yourselves as bald as an eagle: Here Micah talked about a symbolic action. One way that the Jews mourned when they were very sad was to cut off some of the hair on their heads. Other verses that talk about this symbolic action are Job 1:20; Isaiah 15:2; 22:12; Jeremiah 7:29; 16:6; and Amos 8:10.

The BSB and many other English versions make explicit the meaning of the action by using the words

“in mourning” or “in sorrow” or something similar, usually in 1:16a. For example:

“Shave your heads in mourning” (NIV)

shave your heads in sorrow (NLT)

cut off your hair to show you are sad (NCV)

1:16a-b

(combined/reordered)

- You people of Judah! Mourn for all the people in your cities whom you love. Cut off your hair to show how sad you are.

Shave yourselves bald and cut off your hair in mourning for your precious children: Micah ordered the people to mourn for their beloved children by cutting off the hair on their own heads and making themselves bald. These two actions are not in chronological order. The first phrase, Shave yourselves bald, is the result of cutting off the hair.

If it is clearer in your language, you may reverse the order. For example:

Cut off your hair to make yourselves bald!

You may also translate Shave yourselves bald and cut off your hair as one action. For example:

People of Judah, cut off your hair in mourning for the children you love. (GNT)

Shave your heads bald as you mourn for the children you love (NET)

Use a natural option for your language.

for: In Hebrew, the word for in 1:16b indicates purpose. The purpose for mourning is to show their sorrow because of what will happen to their children. For example:

in order to mourn for the children whom you love

to show your sorrow about the children whom you love

your precious children: This phrase is a figure of speech. It refers to the people in the cities that Micah

mentioned in 1:10–15. In 1:16, Micah talked to the people Judah as if the entire nation were a mother. In Hebrew the commands in 1:16a–b are feminine singular, as if Micah was talking to a woman. Most scholars agree that Micah was talking to the nation of Judah, or perhaps to the rulers of Judah in Jerusalem, and its cities were like the mother’s children.

Here are some ways to translate this figure of speech (personification) in your language:

- Translate this figure of speech literally. The GNT and NET (quoted above under 1:16a) are two examples.
- Translate this figure of speech literally. Add a footnote to explain the meaning. For example:

your precious children (CEV)

The CEV also has the following footnote:

1:16 precious children: The towns mentioned in verses 10–15.

General Comment on 1:16a–b

- Translate this figure of speech as a simile. For example:

You people of Judah! Cut off your hair until you are bald! Do this to mourn for your fellow-citizens, whom you love like a mother loves her own children.

- Translate the meaning directly without using a figure of speech. For example:

People of Judah, cut off your hair to mourn for all the people in those cities of yours.

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the information in 1:16a–b. See 1:16a–b (combined/reordered) in the Display for an example.

1:16a

Shave yourselves bald and cut off your hair

- Cut off^(plur) your hair and thus make yourselves bald! Show how sad you are
- You people of Judah! Shave off all of your hair!

1:16b

in mourning for your precious children;

- because of what will happen to your^(plur) children whom you loved so much.
- Do this in order to mourn for all the people in those cities that gave you such joy.

1:16a–d

(combined/reordered)

- People of Judah, your^(plur) enemies will capture the people in your cities who are like children that you love and will force them to live in other countries. So show how sad you are by cutting off your hair till you are bald. Yes, make yourselves bald like a vulture.

1:16c

make yourselves as bald as an eagle,

- Cut off^(plur) all of your hair until you are as bald as a vulture,
- That’s right! Cut off your hair until you are totally bald to show how sad you are.

make yourselves as bald as an eagle: In 1:16a, Micah told the people to make themselves bald. Here in 1:16c, he added emphasis by using a simile that compares their baldness to a bird that has few or no feathers on its head. In Hebrew, there are two main ways to interpret the word that the BSB translates as eagle: According to a footnote in the NET, “The Hebrew term נֶשֶׁר (nešer) refers to the griffon vulture or eagle.” A&F also say that the Hebrew word is a general term for eagles or vultures.

1. It refers to a vulture or buzzard. For example:

make yourselves as bald as the vulture (NIV)

...as bald as a buzzard (CEV) (CEV, GW, NABRE, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB, GNT)

1. It refers to an eagle. For example:

Let your baldness be as the eagle’s (NAB) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Commentaries that favor interpretation (1) include: UBS, KD, ZIBBC, NICOT, NAC, and Waltke. JFB, however, comments that all eagles are comparatively bald in molting season. Pusey (page 27) comments that in terms of actual baldness, the vulture is a better choice, but in favor of the eagle, he quotes Bochart as saying, “The moulting of the eagle involves some degree of weakness, with which he compares Judah’s mournful and weak condition amid the loss of their children, gone into captivity.” unless “eagle” better conveys Micah’s emphasis in your language area. Vultures are known in most parts of the world as bald-headed birds that eat dead animals.

as bald as an eagle: This simile means “very bald” or “completely bald.” Here are some ways to translate this figure of speech (following interpretation (1)):

- Use a simile that is similar to one used in the NIV or CEV (quoted above).
- Substitute the name of a bird in your country that is well-known for its bare head. For example:

as bald as a wanaa-bird’s head

- Translate the meaning without a figure of speech. For example:

Make yourselves completely bald.

Use a natural option for your language that is acceptable and clear.

1:16d

for they will go from you into exile.

- because all those people will go away from you^(plur) and live as slaves in a foreign land.
- You will be sad because your enemies will take away all those people from your land and make them live as slaves in another land.

for: In Hebrew, the word for in 1:16d introduces the reason for 1:16c.UBS (pages 150–152). The reason is that the people will go into exile.

they: The pronoun they refers to “your precious children” in 1:16a. That phrase is a figure of speech for the people in the cities Micah had talked about in 1:10–15. (See the Note on 1:16b above.)

will go from you into exile: Some English versions translate this verb phrase as if the action has already occurred. For example:

they have gone away from you into exile (REB)

Most scholars think that Micah used the past tense here to emphasize that this event will certainly happen. See the note and endnote at 1:9b.UBS (pages 150–152) and NAC (pages 61–62) both document in detail the historical events that indicate that Micah was using the prophetic perfect tense to refer to future events. WBC (pages 22–23) agrees, but he makes the following comment: “Those who read it as complete in the past regard this verse as a post-exilic addition to the work of Micah.” A&F give other reasons to support a historical exile in the past: “All references to “exile” do not have to be attached to the Babylonian Exile of the sixth century, just because it has been given

so much space in the Hebrew Bible. If 2 Chronicles 28 provides the background for Micah 1 we are at a moment where captives have been taken, but not yet returned.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verb phrase:

because your children will be taken away to a foreign land (NCV)

for they are taken from you into exile (NET)

from you: Many of the people in Judah will be taken away from their cities, neighbors, and relatives, but most of them will remain. The pronoun you here refers to those who remain.

into exile: This means that the enemy army will capture their cities, take some of the people as prisoners, and force them to move to a different country.

General Comment on 1:16a–d

Micah’s main point in this verse is that an enemy army will force many people in Judah to go live in another country (1:16b, d). In some languages, it may be clearer to reorder the verse parts so that the main point occurs first. See 1:16a–b (combined/reordered in the Display for an example).

Micah 2:1

Section 2:1–11: The LORD will punish those who oppress poor people

This section is divided into two parts: 2:1–5 and 2:6–11.

- In verses 1–5, the LORD accused people in Israel of doing evil: they were dishonestly taking property away from other people. He said that he would punish them.
- In verses 6–11, Micah said that people had rebuked him for prophesying these things. And the LORD again said that he would punish the people of Israel.

If you use section headings in your translation, here are some options:

- Use one heading for all of 2:1–11, using the above wording. Here are some other section headings for 2:1–11:

Land Robbers Will Lose their Land (NET)

Punishment for Those Who Abuse Their Power (CEV)

Israel's Sins Are Condemned (GW)

- Use one heading for 2:1–5 and another heading for 2:6–11. For example:

^{1–5}Judgment against Wealthy Oppressors

^{6–11}True and False Prophets (NLT)

^{1–5}The Evil Plans of People

^{6–11}Micah Is Asked Not to Prophecy (NCV)

- Use one heading for all of chapter 2 (2:1–13). For example:

The Fate of Those Who Oppress the Poor (GNT)

Woe to Oppressors (NASB)

TN will use one heading for 2:1–11 and another heading for 2:12–13. Use a heading or headings that will be appropriate and acceptable for your language situation.

Paragraph 2:1–5

In this paragraph, Micah is the speaker in verses 1–2. He spoke about evil people who oppressed poor people. The LORD is the speaker in verses 3–5. He spoke to those evil people. He said that he would punish them.

2:1

Notice the parallel parts in bold print that are similar in meaning:

^{1a}Woe to those who devise **iniquity** and plot **evil** on their beds!

^{1b}At morning's light they accomplish it because the power is in their hands.

2:1a**Woe to those who devise iniquity and plot evil on their beds!**

- ¶ How terrible it will be for those people who lie on their beds at night thinking about doing wicked things and planning evil deeds!
- ¶ Yahweh will punish the people who lie awake at night planning to do bad things.

Woe: In Hebrew, this word has several meanings. Here it is an exclamation to show sadness. The Jews used this word when they mourned someone who had just

died (for example, 1 Kings 13:30; Jeremiah 22:18). Here are some other ways to translate this word:

How terrible it will be... (GNT)

How horrible it will be... (GW)

What sorrow awaits you... (NLT)

Those people are as good as dead... (see NET)

You may also use a word or expression in your language that people say when they are very sad because someone has died or has been in a terrible accident.

Micah said Woe to these people because he knew that God would punish them. Here is a translation that emphasizes this aspect of meaning:

God will certainly punish those people who...

to those who devise iniquity and plot evil: The meaning of this phrase is that the people plan to do evil things. The BSB uses two nouns iniquity and evil as objects of the verbs devise and plot. Some versions use two nouns as objects of one verb. For example:

for those who devise wickedness and evil deeds (NRSV)

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate these two phrases as one phrase. For example:

...those who...plan evil (GNT)

who lie in bed, making evil plans (CEV)

on their beds: The phrase on their beds describes the location of those people when they “devise iniquity and plot evil.” It implies that this occurs at night. They lie awake on their beds at night, planning to do evil things. Some versions make the time (“at night”) and location (“on their beds”) explicit. For example:

At night you lie in bed (CEV)

Other versions make the time (“at night”) explicit and leave the location (“on their beds”) implied. For example:

you who lie awake at night, thinking up evil plans (NLT)

Other versions leave the time implied (REB) or leave both time and place implied (GNT). For example:

...those who lie in bed (REB)

...those who lie awake (GNT)

Translate in a clear and natural way so that your readers will understand the time and location, whether you make it implied or explicit.

2:1b

At morning's light they accomplish it because the power is in their hands.

- When morning comes/arrives, they do those evil things, because they have the ability/power to do them.
- At dawn/sunrise, they get up and start doing the bad things they thought about during the night. They are able to do those things, so they do them.

At morning's light they accomplish it: At night these people plan to do evil. At morning's light, they do what they have planned.

At morning's light: This means "early morning, when the sun first appears." Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

at dawn (NLT)

when the sun appears

when night ends

they accomplish it: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they carry out their plans (GW)

they do what they planned (NCV)

they do the evil they planned (GNT)

because the power is in their hands: In Hebrew, this phrase is an idiom (literally "...in the power of their hand"). It means that they have the power/ability to do it, probably because they are wealthy or have

influence. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because it is in their power to do it (NIV)

because they are able to (GW)

knowing that they have the power to do evil (REB)

Micah 2:2

Section 2:1-11: The LORD will punish those who oppress poor people

This section is divided into two parts: 2:1-5 and 2:6-11.

- In verses 1-5, the LORD accused people in Israel of doing evil: they were dishonestly taking property away from other people. He said that he would punish them.
- In verses 6-11, Micah said that people had rebuked him for prophesying these things. And the LORD again said that he would punish the people of Israel.

If you use section headings in your translation, here are some options:

- Use one heading for all of 2:1-11, using the above wording. Here are some other section headings for 2:1-11:

Land Robbers Will Lose their Land (NET)

Punishment for Those Who Abuse Their Power (CEV)

Israel's Sins Are Condemned (GW)

- Use one heading for 2:1-5 and another heading for 2:6-11. For example:

¹⁻⁵Judgment against Wealthy Oppressors

⁶⁻¹¹True and False Prophets (NLT)

¹⁻⁵The Evil Plans of People

⁶⁻¹¹Micah Is Asked Not to Prophesy (NCV)

- Use one heading for all of chapter 2 (2:1-13). For example:

The Fate of Those Who Oppress the Poor (GNT)

Woe to Oppressors (NASB)

TN will use one heading for 2:1–11 and another heading for 2:12–13. Use a heading or headings that will be appropriate and acceptable for your language situation.

Paragraph 2:1–5

In this paragraph, Micah is the speaker in verses 1–2. He spoke about evil people who oppressed poor people. The LORD is the speaker in verses 3–5. He spoke to those evil people. He said that he would punish them.

2:2a–b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{2a}They covet fields and **seize them**;

^{2b} **they take away** houses.

Some English versions translate 2:2b so that it contains an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase). For example:

houses, and take them away (NRSV)

If you follow this interpretation, it may be necessary to supply the missing verb from 2:2a. For example:

^{2b} they covet houses and take them away

2:2a**They covet fields and seize them;**

- They desire to own fields that belong to other people. So they take those fields away from them.
- Those people want to have land for farming. So they dishonestly/wrongfully take possession of that land.

In 2:1, Micah spoke about people who planned to do evil and then did it. Here in 2:2, he gave specific examples of the wicked things they did.

The people Micah talked about here coveted fields or houses that belonged to other people. They deceived, cheated, or even harmed those people in order to get their fields or houses. A good example of this is found in 1 Kings 21:1–16. King Ahab strongly desired a field that belonged to another man. The king's wife gave orders to have that man killed.

In some languages, emotions like coveting are naturally expressed with direct quotes. For example:

They see fields or houses and they say in their hearts, "I want that!" Those things belong to other people. But they do evil to those people to get those things for themselves.

They covet fields and seize them: This is the first example that Micah gave of the evil deeds of these people.

covet: The word covet means "to strongly desire to own something." It is the same word that is used in the last of the Ten Commandments: "You shall not covet your neighbor's house..." (Exodus 20:17). Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

desire (GW)

want (NLT)

fields: The word fields refers to farmland, areas of land on which farmers plant crops. (The same Hebrew word is translated as "the open field" in 1:6a.)

It is implied that these fields belong to other people. In some languages, it may be good to make this explicit. For example:

They desire other people's fields... (GW)

and: This conjunction is used here to mean "and then" or "and so." Some versions translate this as a time relationship. For example:

They covet fields, and then seize them... (NASB)

When they want fields, they seize them... (GNT)

Some versions translate this as a result relationship. For example:

They desire other people's fields, so they seize them. (GW)

In this context, a time and result relationship are very close in meaning. First these people desire to get a field, and then, as a result, they take the field. Translate this relationship in a natural way in your language.

seize: The verb seize often means "to grab something with one's hands." But here it means "to forcibly become the owner of something." These people did evil

to other people in order to become the owners of their fields. Here are some other ways to translate seize:

They covet fields and take them by force... (REB)

They confiscate the fields they desire... (NET)

2:2b

they take away houses.

- They desire houses that belong to others. So they take those houses from them.
- Or, they want to own houses, so they do wicked things to the house owners so that the houses become theirs.

they take away houses: Another thing these people desired and took was houses.

Some English versions make the verb “covet” from 2:2a explicit in this verse part as well. For example:

^{2a}When they want fields, they seize them; ^{2b}when they want houses, they take them. (GNT)

^{2a}They desire other people’s fields, so they seize them. ^{2b}They desire people’s houses, so they take them. (GW)

Translate this verb in a way that fits the grammatical patterns of your language.

take away: This phrase means the same thing as “seize” in 2:2a. It means “become the owner of the houses.” It does not mean to remove the houses. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they take over houses as well (NJB)

houses...take them (NIV)

Some versions make explicit the means by which these people take possession of someone’s house. For example:

When you want someone’s house, you take it by fraud and violence. (NLT)

they oppress a man and his house (ESV)

they cheat people to get their houses (NCV)

You may want to make this explicit in your language if it will be helpful.

General Comment on 2:2a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the parallel parts in these two lines. For example:

You grab any field or house that you want... (CEV)

2:2c–d

(combined/reordered)

- They cause other people extreme hardship in order to take away their inherited houses and land.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{2c}They deprive a man **of his home**,

^{2d} a fellow man **of his inheritance**.

These verse parts are very similar in meaning to 2:2a–b. There is also an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted word) in 2:2d of the verb “deprive” in 2:2c. This is similar to the ellipsis of the verb “covet” in 2:2b. See the note for 2:2a–b.

2:2c

They deprive a man of his home,

- They treat people cruelly in order to take away their houses
- Those people do bad things to others. They take away their houses

They deprive a man of his home: There is a textual issue with this verse part:

1. The Masoretic Text has “and they oppress a man and his house.” This verse part leaves implicit whether the reference is to people who take the householder’s property only, or to people who take his life along with his property. Forced enslavement or murder of a homeowner would be two possible ways a life might be “taken” along with property. However, we don’t know that these atrocities would always have accompanied such land seizures. For example:

They oppress a man and his house (ESV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. The LXX has “and take as plunder a man and his house.” This verse part makes explicit that the ref-

erence is to people who take the householder as plunder along with his property. For example:

owner and house they seize alike (NJB) (NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and commentaries. By leaving some aspects implicit, it best reflects the lack of scholarly consensus on the exact nature and details of these land seizures. ZIBBC (page 132) points out that “Several attempts have been made to determine the exact nature of the offending land seizure, from an economic reorganization that disenfranchised smaller landholders to some sort of military conquest. The text, however, is not specific on this point...”

deprive: To deprive a person involves causing that person extreme hardship, often by illegal means such as cheating.

Some versions make the means of oppression more explicit. For example:

They cheat people to get their houses (NCV)

They defraud people of their homes (NET)

They rob a man and his house (NASB)

a man: In Jewish culture, it was usually men who owned houses, not women. Here are some other ways to translate a man:

They defraud men of their homes (NJPS)

They cheat an owner of his house (NAB)

Notice that the NJPS uses a gender-specific form: “men.” The NAB uses a generic word: “owner.” Use whatever is natural in your language.

his home: In Hebrew, the phrase his home can mean either a building or a household/family. For that reason there are two main ways to interpret this word in this context:

1. It refers to a literal house as in 2:2b. For example:

They defraud men of their homes (NJPS) (NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT)

1. It refers to “family.” Waltke 2007 (page 96) says: “the singular, *bayit* (house), in v 2B, in accord with

its linkage with *geber*, refers to family.” This interpretation accords with standard Hebrew grammar, in which the object of the verb “oppress” is always a person. See also A&F (pages 269–270) and UBS (pages 154–155). For example:

They cheat a man and his family (GW) (GW, GNT) The GNT has “No one’s family or property is safe.” UBS states that the word “family” is a translation of “house.”

Versions that translate the word in 2:2c as home or “house” are ambiguous. Some examples are the BSB, the ESV, the KJV, the NASB, and the NRSV.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with the majority of versions. The parallel of home to “inheritance” in 2:2d makes it likely that both words refer to property. A difficulty is the grammatical mismatch noted in an earlier footnote, that the verb “oppress” requires a person as the object. A&F (pages 269–270) offers the explanation that in Hebrew the language is elliptical here.

2:2d

a fellow man of his inheritance.

- and other property that they inherited.
- and/or other property.

a fellow man of his inheritance: There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 2:2d that is similar to the one in 2:2b. Here in 2:2d, the subject and verb are both implied from the previous verse part. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing subject and verb from 2:2c. For example:

They oppress a man in order to get his inheritance.

a fellow man: In Hebrew, this word (lit. “man”) is a synonym of the word “householder” (lit. man) used in 2:2c. It can refer to any person, including a “man” (in contrast to a woman) or a “husband.”

In Jewish culture, men (not women) were usually the ones who owned houses and property. But the main point here in 2:2c–d is that these people owned houses or other property. The main point is not that they were males. Here are some other ways to translate man in 2c and 2d:

men

others

Use whatever is natural in your language.

inheritance: An inheritance is anything that a person has received from his parents when they die, including land, houses, or money. Here is another way to translate 2:2c–d:

They defraud people of their homes, and deprive people of the land they have inherited. (NET)

General Comment on 2:1–2

In 2:1–2, Micah spoke about evil people. Many translations use third-person pronouns in these verses. For example:

Woe to those who devise wickedness and work evil...they perform it...the power of their hand... they covet fields...they oppress a man... (ESV)

But in 2:3–5, the LORD spoke to these people. All English versions in 2:3–5 use the second-person pronouns “you” and “your.” In some languages, it may be confusing to use third-person pronouns in 2:1–2, and second-person pronouns in 2:3–5 to refer to the same people. If this is true in your language, you may want to translate 2:1–2 using second-person pronouns. For example:

^{1a}What sorrow awaits you who lie awake at night,... ^{1b}You rise at dawn.... ^{2a}When you want a piece of land, you find a way to seize it. ^{2b}When you want someone’s house, you take it by fraud and violence...You cheat a man of his property... (NLT)

Use pronouns that are natural in your language to make the meaning clear.

General Comment on 2:2c–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the parallel parts in these two lines. For example:

you cheat families out of homes and land (CEV)

Micah 2:3

Section 2:1–11: The LORD will punish those who oppress poor people

This section is divided into two parts: 2:1–5 and 2:6–11.

- In verses 1–5, the LORD accused people in Israel of doing evil: they were dishonestly taking property

away from other people. He said that he would punish them.

- In verses 6–11, Micah said that people had rebuked him for prophesying these things. And the LORD again said that he would punish the people of Israel.

If you use section headings in your translation, here are some options:

- Use one heading for all of 2:1–11, using the above wording. Here are some other section headings for 2:1–11:

Land Robbers Will Lose their Land (NET)

Punishment for Those Who Abuse Their Power (CEV)

Israel’s Sins Are Condemned (GW)

- Use one heading for 2:1–5 and another heading for 2:6–11. For example:

^{1–5}Judgment against Wealthy Oppressors

^{6–11}True and False Prophets (NLT)

^{1–5}The Evil Plans of People

^{6–11}Micah Is Asked Not to Prophesy (NCV)

- Use one heading for all of chapter 2 (2:1–13). For example:

The Fate of Those Who Oppress the Poor (GNT)

Woe to Oppressors (NASB)

TN will use one heading for 2:1–11 and another heading for 2:12–13. Use a heading or headings that will be appropriate and acceptable for your language situation.

Paragraph 2:1–5

In this paragraph, Micah is the speaker in verses 1–2. He spoke about evil people who oppressed poor people. The LORD is the speaker in verses 3–5. He spoke to those evil people. He said that he would punish them.

2:3

In 2:1–2, Micah spoke about evil people. In 2:3–5, following Micah’s introductory phrase in 2:3a, the LORD spoke to these evil people. The BSB and some other

versions begin a new paragraph here at 2:3. The Notes will follow versions that have one paragraph for 2:1–5. You may do whatever best fits the paragraph structure of your language.

2:3a

Therefore this is what the LORD says:

- And so, this is what Yahweh says:
- Therefore, because those people are so wicked, Yahweh speaks these words to them:

Therefore this is what the LORD says: The word **Therefore** connects the reason (2:1–2) with the result (2:3–4). The LORD said these words to the people because they oppressed others. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Therefore these are the words of the Lord: (REB)

So Yahweh says this: (NJB)

That is why the Lord says: (NCV)

2:3b

“I am planning against this nation a disaster

- “Listen, I have decided to bring a disaster on your^(plur) nation.
- “I am indeed planning to punish your wicked nation.

This verse part begins with a Hebrew word that the BSB translated as “behold” in 1:3a. See the notes there. Its purpose is to get the people’s attention, or to emphasize the need to pay close attention to what the LORD says. Here are some other ways to translate this word here:

lo (NRSV)

Look (NET)

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this word with an expression that means “Listen!” or “Indeed.”

Many English versions leave this word untranslated. If you leave it implied in your translation, be sure that the importance of the LORD’s words is clearly emphasized in some other way.

I am planning: The BSB translates this verb using present tense. The LORD was already planning what he would do. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

I am devising (NRSV)

against this nation a disaster: In Hebrew, the word **nation** is more literally “clan” or “extended kinship group.” Here it has the broader meaning “people” or nation. TWOT (#2442b). There are two ways to interpret the phrase **this nation** in this context:

1. It refers to the evil people that Micah talked about in 2:1–2. For example:

“Look, I am planning trouble against such people” (NCV) (CEV, NCV, NJB, NLT, GNT) The NJB has “this breed.” The Notes have listed it with interpretation (1), because “this breed” is a critical and scornful phrase. Such a phrase is appropriate for an evil nation.

1. It refers to the nation of Israel, that is, to all of the Jewish people. For example:

“Look, I am devising disaster for this nation!” (NET) (BSB, NAB, NET, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include UBS, ABC, JFB, CBC, and WBC. Commentaries that support interpretation (2) include EBC and TOTC. Waltke 2007 has apparently contradictory comments. On page 97, he says: “In biblical theology the whole “family,” bound together by blood and history, suffers for the sins of individuals within it, especially its leaders.” But on page 98, he says: “his oracle of doom was addressed directly to the venal land barons, whose identity will be unmasked in the next oracle.” Although the versions listed under (1) do not explicitly use the word “evil,” it is strongly implied by the entire context, preceding (2:1–2) as well as following (2:6–11), that the nation as a whole was evil. In addition, the versions listed under (2) do not explicitly mention the wickedness of the nation, but that wickedness is implied by the entire context.

Most English versions are ambiguous. They do not clearly follow either interpretation (1) or (2). For example:

this family (NASB)

this people (NIV)

this clan (NJPS)

It is recommended that you translate this phrase in a way that clearly indicates in the context that the people or nation as a whole are evil. For example:

“Listen, I have decided to bring a disaster on this wicked nation. And none of you will be able to avoid it.

“Indeed, I am planning to punish people like you. You will not be able to escape.

a disaster: The Hebrew word translated disaster here also appears in 2:1a. There, it refers to iniquity.” Here in 2:3b, it refers to a disaster that the LORD will cause to happen. Here are other ways to translate a disaster in 2:3b:

disaster (NIV)

trouble (NCV)

calamity (NASB)

2:3c

from which you cannot free your necks.

- It will be like a yoke that is fastened to your^(plur) necks, and none of you wicked people will be able to remove it.
- You will not be able to escape.

from which you cannot free your necks: This is a metaphor in which most of the body parts have been left implied. It compares the “disaster” that the nation of Israel will experience to a yoke that cannot be removed from the necks of cows or oxen. It means that they will not be able to escape or avoid the disaster.

When the Jews plowed their fields, they used cows or oxen to pull the plow. They fastened the yoke that was connected to the plow onto the necks of the cows. The cows were unable to get their necks out of the yokes. In the same way, these wicked people will not avoid the disaster that God will send.

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

I am planning disaster for this nation, a yoke which you cannot remove from your necks (REB)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

“Look, I am devising disaster for this nation. It will be like a yoke from which you can’t free your neck. (NET)

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

“I am planning disaster against this people, from which you cannot save yourselves. (NIV)

Translate this metaphor in a clear and natural way in your language.

The metaphor means that the people will not be able avoid this disaster. You can also translate the metaphor using a positive expression. For example:

...you will certainly be included

...you will certainly suffer in this disaster

2:3d

Then you will not walk so proudly,

- And then you^(plur) will no longer walk around proudly,
- When it happens, you will no longer walk with your head held high,

Then you will not walk so proudly: To walk so proudly means “to walk around in a manner that shows that one is proud and arrogant.” In Jewish culture, people who were haughty walked with their necks stretched out and heads held up straight. (For example, see Isaiah 3:16.)

Think how arrogant people in your language group act as they walk around. Consider using an expression in your language that describes people who walk around looking proud.

not walk: Previously, these people walked around haughtily, but later, when God punishes them, they will no longer walk that way. Some versions make a phrase like this explicit. For example:

You will no longer walk proudly (NIV)

and then you will not walk so proudly any more (GNT)

2:3d-e

(combined/reordered)

- Yes, I will cause a terrible disaster to happen to you, and as a result you will stop acting so proud.

2:3e**for it will be a time of calamity.**

- because the disaster I will send will be very bad.
- because at that time you will suffer greatly.

for it will be a time of calamity: The word for introduces the reason why those people will no longer "walk so proudly." They will no longer be haughty, because the disaster that the LORD sends will be so terrible. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because it will be a terrible time (NCV)

for it will be an evil time (NRSV)

it will be such a time of disaster (NJPS)

General Comment on 2:3d–e

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the two clauses in 2:3d–e. For example:

You are going to find yourselves in trouble, and then you will not walk so proudly any more. (GNT)

Micah 2:4**Section 2:1–11: The LORD will punish those who oppress poor people**

This section is divided into two parts: 2:1–5 and 2:6–11.

- In verses 1–5, the LORD accused people in Israel of doing evil: they were dishonestly taking property away from other people. He said that he would punish them.
- In verses 6–11, Micah said that people had rebuked him for prophesying these things. And the LORD again said that he would punish the people of Israel.

If you use section headings in your translation, here are some options:

- Use one heading for all of 2:1–11, using the above wording. Here are some other section headings for 2:1–11:

Land Robbers Will Lose their Land (NET)

Punishment for Those Who Abuse Their Power (CEV)

Israel's Sins Are Condemned (GW)

- Use one heading for 2:1–5 and another heading for 2:6–11. For example:

^{1–5}Judgment against Wealthy Oppressors

^{6–11}True and False Prophets (NLT)

^{1–5}The Evil Plans of People

^{6–11}Micah Is Asked Not to Prophecy (NCV)

- Use one heading for all of chapter 2 (2:1–13). For example:

The Fate of Those Who Oppress the Poor (GNT)

Woe to Oppressors (NASB)

TN will use one heading for 2:1–11 and another heading for 2:12–13. Use a heading or headings that will be appropriate and acceptable for your language situation.

Paragraph 2:1–5

In this paragraph, Micah is the speaker in verses 1–2. He spoke about evil people who oppressed poor people. The LORD is the speaker in verses 3–5. He spoke to those evil people. He said that he would punish them.

2:4a–b

In 2:3b–c, the LORD is the speaker. Based on the quotation marks in some versions, there are two ways to interpret the identity of the speaker in 2:4a–b:

1. The LORD is still the speaker. There are no closed quotes at the end of v. 3. (BSB, NCV, NET, NIV, GNT)
2. Micah is now the speaker. The closing quotation mark (") at the end of verse 4 shows that the LORD stopped speaking there. (CEV, NLT)

Most other English versions are ambiguous. They do not use quotation marks to show who is speaking.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). With either interpretation, the wording of the quote is the same.

2:4a**In that day they will take up a proverb against you**

- When that time arrives, people will make fun of you^(plur) by singing a song.
- When that disaster happens to you, others will mock you: they will chant

In that day: Micah used this or a similar phrase in 4:6 and 5:10 (see also 7:11–12). The word day here means "a

period of time,” not a literal 24-hour day. It refers to the time when the LORD will punish the nation. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

When that time comes (GNT)

When that happens (CEV)

At that time (NCV)

they: The pronoun they refers to people in general. See UBS (pages 156–158) for a summary of other views of who the pronoun they refers to. The NLT is the only English version that specifies who sings the taunt song. It has “your enemies.” Here are some other ways to translate this general reference:

- Use the word “people.” For example:

At that time people will make fun of you (NCV)

- Use a passive verb. For example:

On that day there will be heard this verse about you (REB)

Use what is natural in your language to refer to people in general.

will take up a proverb against you: In Hebrew, the word that the BSB translates proverb can refer to a proverb, a parable, a well-known saying, or a short poem or song. There are two ways to interpret this word:

1. It refers to a taunt song, a song that contains sarcasm and mocks the listener. For example:

On that day a satire shall be sung over you (NAB) (ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV)

1. It refers to a song that is a mournful lament and expresses sincere sorrow. For example:

they will sing this song of despair about your experience (GNT) (CEV, KJV, NJPS, REB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include WBC, CBC, ABC, NAC, Hiller, Waltke

2007, and probably A&F. Commentaries that support interpretation (2) include KD, EBC, NICOT, and JFB. Although the words of the song sound mournful, the singers are not sincere. They intend to mock the listeners.

To take up a proverb means “to sing or chant some words.”

against you: The pronoun you refers to the wicked Israelites. (See 2:1–3.) People will sing a taunt song against them. This means they will sing to make fun of them.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

When that day comes, people will make fun of you. (GW)

In that day men will ridicule you (NIV)

2:4b and taunt you with this bitter lamentation:

- They will sing this sad song.
- and pretend to wail sadly and mourn.

and taunt you with this bitter lamentation: In Hebrew, this verse part is literally “and lament with lamenting lamentation.” This means that the people will sing a very sad song. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

singing this song of despair about you: (NLT)

They will sing this sad song about you: (GW)

they will taunt you with this mournful song: (NIV)

The NIV makes it clear that people sang this sad song to mock the Israelites. They were not really sad. They just pretended to be sad.

General Comment on 2:4a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these verse parts. For example:

When that happens, this sorrowful song will be sung about you: (CEV)

When that time comes, people will sing this sad song to ridicule you:

2:4c–f (combined/reordered)

- “There is nothing left! Yahweh has taken away our inherited land and other property and has divided/allotted it among our captors/enemies.”

This part of the verse contains the words that people sing to make fun of their fellow Israelites. In their song, they pretend to express their own sorrow.

2:4c ‘We are utterly ruined!’

- They will say, ‘We^(incl) are completely ruined!
- Here is what they will sing: ‘Our situation is terrible!
- They will ridicule you^(plur) by pretending to be you. They will sing/say: ‘We have nothing left!

We are utterly ruined!: The situation they referred to is that an enemy army had captured their city and taken possession of their houses and lands.

We: The people who sang this song used the pronoun We. They pretended to be the defeated Israelites. If your language has both inclusive and exclusive pronouns, you should use an inclusive pronoun here.

utterly ruined: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “Ruined we are ruined.” This is an emphatic way to say “We are ruined.” Here are some other ways to express this emphasis:

We are finished, completely ruined! (NLT)

Our ruin is complete (NAB)

We have been stripped of everything (NJB)

Ruined! Completely ruined! (CEV)

2:4d He has changed the portion of my people.

- The land that Yahweh caused my/our^(incl) people to inherit, he has given to others.
- Yahweh has given to others the land that belonged to my/our people.
- Yahweh took the property that we inherited away from us^(incl).

He has changed the portion of my people: The subject pronoun of 2:4d refers to the same person as does the subject pronoun of 2:4e–f. There is more than one way to interpret this subject:

1. It refers to the LORD. For example:

^{4d} the Lord has taken away my people’s land (NCV) (BSB, CEV, GW, NASB, The NASB translates “He” with a capital letter in 2:4e, indicating that it refers to God. NCV, NLT, NRSV, GNT)

1. It refers to an unidentified “they,” probably Israel’s enemies. For example:

^{4d} they sell off the property of my people. ^{4e}How they remove it from me! ^{4f}They assign our fields to the conqueror. (NET) (NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include UBS, JFB, WBC, NICOT, EBC, KD, A&F, NAC, and TOTC. No commentaries support interpretation (2). Waltke 2007 (page 102) says that “the subject is impersonal.” On page 103, he says that the land is “allocated to tyrannical Assyrians,” but he does not identify the subject of the impersonal subject “they.” Hillers (page 31) has “our fields are allotted...” Here is another way to indicate the subject in 2:4d and in 2:4e–f:

^{4d}The Lord gives our people’s possessions to others. ^{4e}He takes them from us. ^{4f}He divides our fields among our captors.” (GW)

Some versions translate 2:4d–f with no explicit actor. These versions include the NAB, NJB, NJPS, and REB. For example:

“^{4d}Our fields are portioned out among our captors, ^{4e}The fields of my people are measured out, ^{4f}and no one can get them back!” (NAB)

Some versions simply use the pronoun He in 2d–f, leaving the referent of this pronoun ambiguous. These versions include the ESV, KJV, NIV, and RSV.

has changed: In Hebrew, this word can have several meanings, including “changes,” “exchanges,” and “alters.” Scholars do not agree on the exact meaning of this sentence. But the basic meaning is clear: “The LORD has caused the land that used to belong to ‘my people’ to belong to others.” Here are some other ways to translate 2:4d:

The Lord gives our people’s possessions to others. (GW)

KJV does not identify or hint at any particular group. It has “he hath divided our fields.”

has allotted: In Hebrew, this phrase literally means “to divide or apportion.” It means that God gave or assigned their various fields to other people. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

our fields are portioned out (NAB)

my people’s land has been divided up (NJB)

...has taken our land away And given it... (GNT)

our fields: The word fields refers especially to farmland. It refers to the same kind of inherited property that was referred to by the word “portion” in 2:4d. It included homes and other property as well as land.

traitors: Here is another way in addition to the GNT and NCV (quoted above) to translate this word:

the conqueror (NET)

The quote ends at the end of this verse part. If in your language a direct quote ends with an expression such as “that is what he said,” you may want to use a similar expression at the end of verse 4. For example:

That is what those people will sing to make fun of you. ” That is what the LORD said.

General Comment on 2:4c–f (pronouns)

Different first-person pronouns are used in the four lines of this song: “we” in 2:4c, “my” in 2:4d, “me” in 2:4e, “our” in 2:4f.

The first and last are plural and the middle two are singular. In Hebrew poetry, it is common to change from one kind of pronoun to another, but in some languages, it may be unnatural or confusing. It is also unnatural in English, so some versions change the pronouns “my” and “me” in 2:4d–e to “our” and “us.” All the first-person pronouns are then plural. For example:

^{4c}“We are completely ruined. ^{4d}The Lord gives our people’s possessions to others. ^{4e}He takes them from us. ^{4f}He divides our fields among our captors.” (GW)

Consider doing something similar if it will be preferable in your language.

General Comment on 2:4c–f (combine/reorder)

These three lines are about the LORD taking away the people’s land and giving it to others. In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these lines. For example:

^{4c}We are completely ruined! ^{4d–e}The Lord has taken our land away ^{4f}And given it to those who took us captive.” (GNT)

Micah 2:5

Section 2:1–11: The LORD will punish those who oppress poor people

This section is divided into two parts: 2:1–5 and 2:6–11.

- In verses 1–5, the LORD accused people in Israel of doing evil: they were dishonestly taking property away from other people. He said that he would punish them.
- In verses 6–11, Micah said that people had rebuked him for prophesying these things. And the LORD again said that he would punish the people of Israel.

If you use section headings in your translation, here are some options:

- Use one heading for all of 2:1–11, using the above wording. Here are some other section headings for 2:1–11:

Land Robbers Will Lose their Land (NET)

Punishment for Those Who Abuse Their Power (CEV)

Israel’s Sins Are Condemned (GW)

- Use one heading for 2:1–5 and another heading for 2:6–11. For example:

^{1–5}Judgment against Wealthy Oppressors

^{6–11}True and False Prophets (NLT)

^{1–5}The Evil Plans of People

^{6–11}Micah Is Asked Not to Prophesy (NCV)

- Use one heading for all of chapter 2 (2:1–13). For example:

The Fate of Those Who Oppress the Poor (GNT)

Woe to Oppressors (NASB)

TN will use one heading for 2:1-11 and another heading for 2:12-13. Use a heading or headings that will be appropriate and acceptable for your language situation.

Paragraph 2:1-5

In this paragraph, Micah is the speaker in verses 1-2. He spoke about evil people who oppressed poor people. The LORD is the speaker in verses 3-5. He spoke to those evil people. He said that he would punish them.

2:5

Therefore, you will have no one in the assembly of the LORD to divide the land by lot.

- Therefore, when the land is distributed among Yahweh's people at a future time, you^(plur) will not get any of it.
- And so, when Yahweh's people return from exile and they cast lots to divide the land, no one will give you any land.
- Therefore because of your wicked deeds, when Yahweh's people come back to this country, and divide up the land, no one will give any land to you.
- Therefore I, Micah tell you that none of you wicked people will receive any of the land which Yahweh will give to his people in the future.

In 2:4, the LORD was the speaker. He quoted a "taunt song" that the enemies of the Jews sang. Here in 2:5, Micah is the speaker.

Some versions, such as the BSB and GNT, begin a new paragraph here. The Notes will keep the same paragraph along with the NRSV and some other versions. You may do whatever is more natural in your language.

Therefore: This word introduces another conclusion or result of 2:1-2, which described the deeds of wicked people. Micah here described another thing that would happen to those wicked people.

you will have no one in the assembly of the LORD to divide the land by lot: This clause probably refers to the time after the Jews returned from exile. Apart from NAC, all the scholars who commented on the time issue indicated a preference for a time following the Jews' return from exile or in the more distant eschatological future. These commentaries include Mays, UBS, WBC, KD, ZIBBC, TOTC, and Waltke 2007. At that time, the descendants of the wicked people described in 2:1-2 will not receive any of the land that is distributed. The GNT makes the specific time period explicit. It has:

So then, when the time comes for the land to be given back to the Lord's people, there will be no share for any of you. (GNT)

The NET also has the following footnote:

When judgment passes and the people are restored to the land, those greedy ones who disregarded the ancient land allotments will not be allowed to participate in the future redistribution of the land.

Other versions follow the Hebrew and indicate future time in general. Here are some other ways to do this:

Therefore no one will assign you land in the Lord's community. (NET)

And so you will never again own property among the Lord's people. (CEV)

That is why none of you in the Lord's assembly will draw lots to divide your property. (GW)

will have no one in the assembly of the LORD to divide the land by lot: Long ago, Joshua led the Jews into Canaan. They conquered the land, and then they divided the land to each tribe and to each family. They did this by casting lots to decide who would get each piece of land. (See Joshua 14:1-5; 18:8-10.)

the assembly of the LORD: This phrase refers to the Israelites. They were the people whom God had chosen to be his special people. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Lord's people (GNT)

the Lord's community (NET)

Micah 2:6**Section 2:1-11: The LORD will punish those who oppress poor people**

This section is divided into two parts: 2:1-5 and 2:6-11.

- In verses 1-5, the LORD accused people in Israel of doing evil: they were dishonestly taking property away from other people. He said that he would punish them.
- In verses 6-11, Micah said that people had rebuked him for prophesying these things. And the LORD again said that he would punish the people of Israel.

If you use section headings in your translation, here are some options:

- Use one heading for all of 2:1–11, using the above wording. Here are some other section headings for 2:1–11:

Land Robbers Will Lose their Land (NET)

Punishment for Those Who Abuse Their Power (CEV)

Israel's Sins Are Condemned (GW)

- Use one heading for 2:1–5 and another heading for 2:6–11. For example:

¹⁻⁵Judgment against Wealthy Oppressors

⁶⁻¹¹True and False Prophets (NLT)

¹⁻⁵The Evil Plans of People

⁶⁻¹¹Micah Is Asked Not to Prophecy (NCV)

- Use one heading for all of chapter 2 (2:1–13). For example:

The Fate of Those Who Oppress the Poor (GNT)

Woe to Oppressors (NASB)

TN will use one heading for 2:1–11 and another heading for 2:12–13. Use a heading or headings that will be appropriate and acceptable for your language situation.

Paragraph 2:6–11

In 2:1–2, Micah spoke about wicked people. In 2:3–5, the LORD spoke to those wicked people. Here in 2:6–11, Micah (and the LORD) continued to speak to those wicked people.

TN and most English versions begin a new paragraph at 2:6. A few versions put a section heading before 2:6. For example:

False Prophets (NIV)

Micah Is Asked Not to Prophecy (NCV)

True and False Prophets (NLT)

You can put a section heading here if you wish. But TN will use one section heading for all of 2:1–11.

2:6–7

In addition to interpretation differences that involve the wording of 2:6c, and textual issues in 2:7a and 2:7c, there are at least five differences of interpretation in the English versions that involve the quotation marks. TN will follow American usage (“...”) rather than British (‘...’) for all quotes. To minimize clutter and confusion, it will also use the BSB as the source line whenever possible, even when the quotations differ in their starting and ending points. Both the TN Notes and Display will follow the textual and interpretation recommendations in the use of quotation marks in quoted versions, regardless of the actual quotation marks found in those versions.

2:6

In 2:6, Micah quoted the words of people who did not like his message.

^{6a}“Do not preach,” they preach.

^{6b}“Do not preach these things;

^{6c}disgrace will not overtake us.”

There are two main ways to interpret the identity of these people:

1. They were people who did not like the message of Micah or other true prophets. These were probably wicked people. For example:

^{6a}The people preach at me and say, “Don’t preach at us. (GNT) (NLT, GNT)

1. They were prophets who did not like the message of Micah or other true prophets. They were probably false prophets. For example:

^{6a}“Do not prophesy,” their prophets say. (NIV) (GW, NCV, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a minority of commentaries. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include UBS, WBC, JFB, and Hillers. Commentaries that support interpretation (2) include KD, ABC, NICOT, EBC, A&F, NAC, TOTC and Waltke 2007. A reference to people in general would also include false prophets. Versions that are not

listed under the above two interpretations use general words such as “you,” “one,” or “they.” In your translation, it is recommended that you use a general word like one of these. If that is not suitable for your language, then use a phrase such as “people” or “some people.”

2:6a

“Do not preach,” they preach.

- ¶ “Stop preaching!” That is what they/people preach to me.
- ¶ Here is the message that some people preach/announce to me: “Do not preach/announce that message to us^(excl).”

“Do not preach,” they preach: Micah here quoted words that were spoken by people who did not like his message. When these people said this, they themselves were preaching. In Hebrew, the command “Do not preach” is plural. When the people said this to Micah, they included other prophets and their disciples as well. For example, Isaiah and Hosea lived at the same time as Micah. They also said that God would punish the Jewish people (TOTC).

preach: In Hebrew, this word for preach occurs three times in this verse. It literally means “drip.” Here it means “to prophesy, preach, proclaim a message.” The NJB translates this command as “Do not drivel.” No other versions have similar renderings. A footnote in the NET says: Heb “Do not foam at the mouth, ‘...’ The verb (nataf) means “to drip.” When used of speech it probably has the nuance “to drivel, to foam at the mouth” (HALOT 694). The sinful people tell the LORD’s prophets not to “foam at the mouth.” This “probably refers in a derogatory way to their impassioned style of delivery.” Waltke 2007 and Hillers both say that the word may have the connotation of contempt, but other commentaries disagree. According to EBC (page 512), the primary meaning of the verb is “to drip.” It is a “figure used for words issuing from the lips. It predominantly describes prophetic speech. A&F (pages 302–303) give the most complete defense of the often neutral and even positive connotation of words that “drip from the lips.” According to them, “the connotation in Micah is undetermined, and the nuance of ‘rant’ or ‘dribble’ in frenzy is not called for.”

There are at least two ways you can translate this command:

- Use a specific term in your language for “prophesy,” “preach,” or “proclaim a message.” For example:

“Stop preaching!” they preach. “That’s no way to preach...” (NJPS)

“Don’t prophesy to us! Don’t prophesy about these things!... (NCV)

“Do not proclaim/announce a message like that...

- Use a general term, such as “speak about.” For example:

“Don’t say such things,” the people respond.
“Don’t prophesy like that... (NLT)

“Don’t talk about those things to us^(excl)...

Notice that the NLT uses a general term for the first command and a specific term for the second. If your language uses a phrase like “speak God’s words” or “proclaim God’s message” to translate “preach” or “prophesy,” consider using a different phrase here. Micah’s opponents did not believe that Micah’s message was truly from the LORD.

they preach: If it is more natural in your language, you may want to put this phrase first in the sentence. For example:

The people preach at me and say, “Don’t preach at us... (GNT)

2:6b

“Do not preach these things;

- “No one should preach about those things.
- It is not good to preach/announce that Yahweh will do those bad things to our^(incl) people.

Do not preach these things: In Hebrew, this statement is third-person plural, “They...” It is probably a general statement, meaning “People should not preach about such things.” There are two ways you can translate this statement:

- Use a general statement. Here are some other examples:

“people should not preach of such things...

“it is not fitting to talk about these things...

- Use a command. For example:

“Do not prophesy about these things... (NIV)

Don't preach about all that... (GNT)

Use what is natural in your language.

these things: This phrase refers to the things Micah had talked about since the beginning of the book. He had prophesied that the LORD would destroy the city of Samaria (1:6–7) and that an enemy army would attack cities in Judah and send many people into exile (1:10–16). He had rebuked the people for their wicked ways and prophesied that the LORD would punish them by taking away their land (2:1–5). But many people did not like to hear Micah speak about these things.

2:6c

disgrace will not overtake us.”

- Those terrible/shameful things will never happen to us^(incl)!”
- Yahweh will never shame us like that.”

disgrace will not overtake us: In Hebrew, the word disgrace is plural. The situation is actually more complicated. The NAB has “The shame will not withdraw.” Other versions, such as the NIV, NJB, and NRSV, also use a singular noun (“disgrace”), but have “...will not overtake us.” In Hebrew, the noun is feminine plural (“disgraces”). The NLT follows this approach with “Such disasters...” The NASB, KJV and REB follow other minor interpretations. To avoid unnecessary complexity, the Notes will not discuss them. It probably refers to the bad things that happen that cause people to feel shame. Here are some other ways to translate 2:6c:

Nothing to make us feel bad will happen!” (NCV)

Such disasters will never come our way!” (NLT)

God is not going to disgrace us.” (GNT)

us: The pronoun us probably refers to the people as a whole. Micah's opponents believed that the LORD would never disgrace the Jewish people by punishing them. If your language distinguishes inclusive and exclusive pronouns, you should probably use inclusive forms here.

Micah 2:7

Section 2:1–11: The LORD will punish those who oppress poor people

This section is divided into two parts: 2:1–5 and 2:6–11.

- In verses 1–5, the LORD accused people in Israel of doing evil: they were dishonestly taking property away from other people. He said that he would punish them.
- In verses 6–11, Micah said that people had rebuked him for prophesying these things. And the LORD again said that he would punish the people of Israel.

If you use section headings in your translation, here are some options:

- Use one heading for all of 2:1–11, using the above wording. Here are some other section headings for 2:1–11:

Land Robbers Will Lose their Land (NET)

Punishment for Those Who Abuse Their Power (CEV)

Israel's Sins Are Condemned (GW)

- Use one heading for 2:1–5 and another heading for 2:6–11. For example:

^{1–5}Judgment against Wealthy Oppressors

^{6–11}True and False Prophets (NLT)

^{1–5}The Evil Plans of People

^{6–11}Micah Is Asked Not to Prophesy (NCV)

- Use one heading for all of chapter 2 (2:1–13). For example:

The Fate of Those Who Oppress the Poor (GNT)

Woe to Oppressors (NASB)

TN will use one heading for 2:1–11 and another heading for 2:12–13. Use a heading or headings that will be appropriate and acceptable for your language situation.

Paragraph 2:6–11

In 2:1–2, Micah spoke about wicked people. In 2:3–5, the LORD spoke to those wicked people. Here in 2:6–11, Micah (and the LORD) continued to speak to those wicked people.

TN and most English versions begin a new paragraph at 2:6. A few versions put a section heading before 2:6. For example:

False Prophets (NIV)

Micah Is Asked Not to Prophecy (NCV)

True and False Prophets (NLT)

You can put a section heading here if you wish. But TN will use one section heading for all of 2:1-11.

2:7

In verse 2:7, there are four questions. The TN recommendation regarding the speaker and his audience are in parentheses following the quoted question in each verse part.

^{7a}Should it be said, O house of Jacob, (Micah speaks to the people of Israel who were opposed to his message)

^{7b}“Is the Spirit of the LORD impatient? (start of the quoted words of the people identified in 7a)

^{7c}Are these the things He does?” (end of the quoted words in 7b-c)

^{7d}Do not My words bring good to him who walks uprightly? (start of the LORD’s words spoken through his prophet Micah to the same people who were opposed to his message)

2:7a

Should it be said, O house of Jacob,

- “Descendants of Jacob! Do you^(plur) say things like this:
- “You people who are descended from Jacob! Why do you say things like this:
- “People of Israel! You should not say things like this:

Should it be said, O house of Jacob: There is a textual issue here regarding the way the Hebrew verb phrase “it be said” is spelled:

1. The Masoretic Text (MT) has the original spelling. This results in a question. For example:

Is it being said, O house of Jacob: (NASB) (BSB, CEV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NET, NIV, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. Some scholars think that the original Hebrew verb phrase was a question with a different meaning. For example:

Do you think the people of Israel are under a curse? (GNT) (NJB, NJPS, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. The proposed spelling change is from he`amur “is it said?” to he`arur “is it cursed?” This spelling is not found in any Hebrew manuscripts, nor is there any evidence for it in the LXX or other ancient versions.

This is a rhetorical question. It expects the answer “No.” When Micah asked, “Should this be said...,” his meaning was “You should not say this.” Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Should the descendants of Jacob be asked: (GW)

People of Israel, why do you say things like this?

- As a statement. For example:

O family of Israel, you should not say things like this.

Translate this rhetorical question in a natural way in your language.

O house of Jacob: In this phrase, the word house means “nation” or “people.” It refers to the nation of Israel, not to a literal house. In Genesis 32:28 God gave Jacob the name Israel. Because of this, phrases like “house of Israel” and “house of Jacob,” or “children of Israel” and “children of Jacob,” have the same meaning in many verses. Here are some other ways to translate it:

descendants of Jacob (GW)

people of Israel (GNT)

2:7b-c

“Is the Spirit of the LORD impatient? Are these the things He does?”: There are two main ways to interpret these two sentences:

1. These sentences are a quote. Micah continued to quote the people he quoted in 2:6a.

^{7a}Should it be said, O house of Jacob: ^{7b}“Is the Spirit of the Lord angry? ^{7c}Does he do such things?” (NIV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, REB, NET, NJPS)

1. These sentences are Micah’s words. Micah spoke to the people he quoted in 2:6a.

^{7a}Should the descendants of Jacob be asked: ^{7b}Has the Spirit of the Lord become impatient with you?
^{7c}Has he done these things? (GW) (GW, KJV, NCV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

2:7b

“Is the Spirit of the LORD impatient?”

- ‘Has Yahweh become impatient?
- ‘Yahweh has not become impatient with us^(incl), has he?
- ‘Surely Yahweh will never become angry with us!

Is the Spirit of the LORD impatient?: Micah had told the people that the LORD would punish them. But some people thought that the LORD would never become impatient with them. So they responded with this question. In Hebrew, it is literally “Has the LORD’s spirit become short?” There are two ways to interpret this question:

1. The word “spirit” refers to the LORD’s inner feelings. In other words, it refers to the LORD himself. For example:

Is the Lord’s patience truly at an end? (REB)

Has the Lord lost his patience? (GNT) (ESV, NAB, NJB, NJPS, KJV, NCV, NET, NIV11, NLT96, NRSV, REB, GNT)

1. The word “spirit” refers to “the LORD’s Spirit.” Some versions spell the word “spirit” with a capital letter. This usually refers to the Holy Spirit. For example:

Is the Spirit of the Lord impatient? (NASB)

Is the Spirit of the Lord angry? (NIV) (BSB, GW, NASB, NIV, NLT, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and all commentaries. A few commentaries quote a version that uses “Spirit of the

LORD” with a capital “S,” but none define this phrase as referring to the Holy Spirit.

This is a rhetorical question. It expects the answer “No.” Two versions (NCV and NLT) have a different interpretation. They understand that the rhetorical question means that the LORD will not be patient. TN has not treated this as a separate interpretation issue. Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Has Yahweh grown short-tempered? (NJB)

The LORD is not impatient, is he?

- As a statement. For example:

Certainly the LORD has not become impatient.

2:7c

Are these the things He does?”

- He would never do such things, would he?”
- Surely he will not cause those terrible things you^(sing) speak of to happen to us^(incl).”

Are these the things He does?: This is the second question that the people asked in response to Micah’s prophecy that the LORD would punish them. It is also a rhetorical question that expects the answer “No.” Like the previous rhetorical question, you should translate it in a natural way.

- You can translate it as a rhetorical question. For example:

Are these his deeds? (REB)

Would he really do such things? (GNT)

- You can translate it as a statement. For example:

He would never do such things!

2:7d

Do not My words bring good to him who walks uprightly?

- “The words that I speak bless/prosper the people who behave in a way that is upright.
- But Yahweh says, “My words cause good things to happen to those people whose actions are upright.

- To those people Yahweh says, “Indeed, I promise to prosper those who do what is right.”

The Notes will first discuss the rhetorical question in the entire verse part. They will then discuss the textual issue in the phrase “My words.”

Do not My words bring good to him who walks uprightly?: This is a rhetorical question. It expects the answer “Yes.” Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Do not my words do good to him whose ways are upright? (NIV)

My words do good to people who live righteously, don’t they?

- As a statement. For example:

My words are welcome to the person who does what is right. (NCV)

My commands bring a reward for those who obey them (NET)

My words: There is a textual issue here:

1. The Masoretic Text uses the Hebrew pronoun “my” in the phrase “my words.” For example:

Do not My words do good to the one walking uprightly? (NASB) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. The LXX (Septuagint) uses the Greek pronoun “his” in the phrase “his words.” For example:

Doesn’t he speak kindly to those who do right?” (GNT) (CEV, GW, NJB, REB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and commentaries. With either option, the phrase refers to the words of the LORD that were prophesied through his prophet Micah. And with either option, the rhetorical question in 2:7d expects the answer “yes.”

The phrase My words refers to the words of the LORD spoken through his prophet Micah. The LORD is the speaker starting in 2:7d and continuing until the end of chapter 2.

bring good: The LORD said that his words bring good. This means that when the LORD speaks, his words will prosper or bless those people. Here are some other ways to translate “Do not my words do good...”:

Does good not come of his words? (REB)

To be sure, my commands bring a reward... (NET)

Doesn’t he always bless... (CEV)

to him who walks uprightly: This phrase is an idiom that means “to behave or conduct oneself in a way that is upright and obeys the LORD’s commands.” Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

those who do right (CEV)

to the person who does what is right (NCV)

to people whose behavior is upright

Micah 2:8

Section 2:1–11: The LORD will punish those who oppress poor people

This section is divided into two parts: 2:1–5 and 2:6–11.

- In verses 1–5, the LORD accused people in Israel of doing evil: they were dishonestly taking property away from other people. He said that he would punish them.
- In verses 6–11, Micah said that people had rebuked him for prophesying these things. And the LORD again said that he would punish the people of Israel.

If you use section headings in your translation, here are some options:

- Use one heading for all of 2:1–11, using the above wording. Here are some other section headings for 2:1–11:

Land Robbers Will Lose their Land (NET)

Punishment for Those Who Abuse Their Power (CEV)

Israel’s Sins Are Condemned (GW)

- Use one heading for 2:1–5 and another heading for 2:6–11. For example:

¹⁻⁵Judgment against Wealthy Oppressors

⁶⁻¹¹True and False Prophets (NLT)

¹⁻⁵The Evil Plans of People

⁶⁻¹¹Micah Is Asked Not to Prophesy (NCV)

- Use one heading for all of chapter 2 (2:1-13). For example:

The Fate of Those Who Oppress the Poor (GNT)

Woe to Oppressors (NASB)

TN will use one heading for 2:1-11 and another heading for 2:12-13. Use a heading or headings that will be appropriate and acceptable for your language situation.

Paragraph 2:6-11

In 2:1-2, Micah spoke about wicked people. In 2:3-5, the LORD spoke to those wicked people. Here in 2:6-11, Micah (and the LORD) continued to speak to those wicked people.

TN and most English versions begin a new paragraph at 2:6. A few versions put a section heading before 2:6. For example:

False Prophets (NIV)

Micah Is Asked Not to Prophesy (NCV)

True and False Prophets (NLT)

You can put a section heading here if you wish. But TN will use one section heading for all of 2:1-11.

2:8-11

In verses 8-11, the LORD continued to speak to the wicked Jews through Micah his prophet. In contrast to the upright people mentioned in 2:7d, the people in 2:8-11 did not walk uprightly.

2:8a

But of late My people have risen up like an enemy:

- But you^(plur) attack my people, as if you were their enemy.
- But as for you, you do cruel things to my people, like you were their enemy.
- But this does not apply to you! You act like enemies who attack my people.

(NRSV) But you rise up against my people as an enemy: The NRSV has been used as the source line for 2:8a because it follows the recommended option. There is a textual issue in the Hebrew text that affects the presence or absence of a time phrase in this verse part:

1. Some scholars think the original text said “And/But you^(plur) rise against my people as an enemy.” The interpretation presented here is the most common of the many ways that scholars have suggested to change the Hebrew text. According to this interpretation, they change the words “and/but recently my-people” to “and/but-you^(plur) against my-people.” They also change the verb from 3rd singular “he rose” to another form, such as the participle “rising.” See NET note, EBC (page 514), A&F (pages 315-316), Hillers (page 35) and Waltke 2007 (page 117) for more details. Hillers, NICOT, Mays, and UBS are among those who support the changes. Waltke 2007, WBC, and KD are among those who support no changes. For example:

...but you rise up as an enemy against my people
(NET)

but an enemy arises against my people (NJPS)
(CEV, NCV, NET, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, REB, GNT)

1. The Masoretic Text has “And/But yesterday/earlier...” The initial w conjunction can be translated as either “and” or “but.” BART uses the word “yesterday.” Most versions that follow this interpretation use “recently” or “earlier.” For example:

Recently My people have arisen as an enemy—
(NASB)

Lately my people have risen up like an enemy.
(NIV) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NIV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with a slight majority of versions and commentaries.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

You attack my people like enemies. (GNT)

But you are fighting against my people like an enemy. (NCV)

(NRSV) rise up...as an enemy: This phrase means that the people mentioned here acted like an enemy acts. They did cruel things to the LORD's people, treating them like an enemy would treat them. This is a general statement. In 2:1–2, Micah had already described some of the cruel things that they did. They took land and houses away from other people.

2:8b–9b

In 2:8b–9b, the LORD, speaking through Micah, specifically described three of the cruel things that these people did: they took robes away from men (2:8b–c), they took houses away from women (2:9a), and they took God's blessing away from children (2:9b).

2:8b

You strip off the splendid robe

- You^(plur) take away the outer garments
- You forcibly take people's coats away from them.

You strip off the splendid robe: There is a textual issue here with the phrase off the splendid robe:

1. The Masoretic Text has “from in front of a garment.” It means that the outer robe would be stripped from the garment underneath. For example:

You strip off the rich robe... (NIV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, NIV, KJV, NJPS, NLT, GNT)

1. Some scholars think that the original text said “from the peaceful.” It means that the robe would be stripped from those who are peaceful. For example:

you strip the robe from the peaceful (NRSV) (NJB, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow the first option along with almost all English versions and all the commentaries used in the preparation of these notes.

strip off the splendid robe: This phrase means “to forcibly pull or yank the robe off a person's body.” In Micah 2:8b, these words probably refer to violent people literally pulling a robe off another person's body. However, it is also possible that the people addressed here were money-lenders and that the words should be understood figuratively. If a person borrowed money from a money-lender and could not pay it back in time, the money-lender would take the person's coat away. In the case of a poor, homeless person, he would be left without anything to keep him warm at night. God forbade this in Exodus 22:26–27. In Hebrew, the verb tense indicates that these people did this regularly, whenever they had the opportunity. In

Hebrew, the verb tense is imperfect. It indicates that this is something they have done and are still doing. They did it to more than one person. The same verb tense also occurs in 2:9a and 2:9b.

splendid robe: This word refers to the long outer garment or mantle that Jewish men often wore on top of their other clothes. This splendid robe was like a coat that helped keep them warm.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

you have stripped off the mantle covering the tunic... (NAB)

you take the cloaks from people... (NCV)

you habitually take the coats away from people...

2:8c

from unsuspecting passersby

- from people who walk by on their way home. They do not suspect danger,
- They do not think that anyone will harm/attack them,

from unsuspecting passersby: The wicked people strip the robe from any travelers who are walking past the places where the wicked people live. These travelers pass by unsuspecting. They do not suspect that anyone will harm them. They think that there is no danger and that they are safe. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

from those who pass by trustingly (NRSV)

from those who pass by without a care (GW)

from those who think no one will harm them

2:8c–d

(combined/reordered)

- from people who walk by as they return home from battle, thinking they are safe.
- You^(plur) take them from people who are going home after a battle. They think that they are now safe, but you take/snatch their coats away from them as they walk by.

2:8d

like men returning from battle.

- because the battle is over. That is not what they are thinking about.
- and there is no thought of battle in their mind, because the fighting/battle is finished.

like men returning from battle: This phrase further describes the meaning of 2:8c. There are at least three ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It refers literally to people who are returning from battle. They are not thinking about the battle or the war, because the fighting is over and they are on their way home. For example:

from those returned from war (NASB) (CEV, GW, NASB, NRSV, GNT)

1. It is a simile. It means that these travelers were like people returning from battle. For example:

like men returning from battle (NIV) (BSB, NAB, NET, NIV, NLT)

1. It refers either literally or with a simile to people who are opposed to war and do not expect to go to war. For example:

as men averse from war (KJV) (KJV, NJPS)

TN will follow interpretation (1). You may follow either (1) or (2) in your translation. There is commentary support for all three interpretations. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include Waltke 2007, A&F, UBS, and the NET note. Commentaries that support interpretation (2) include TOTC and NAC. Commentaries that support interpretation (3) include KD, WBC, EBC, and JFB. According to A&F (page 313), “The abuses described in v 9 resemble those described in vv 1–5; the abuses described in v 9 have a background in war, perhaps the same war as was the occasion for the lament in 1:10–16.” Waltke 2007 (pages 118–119) says: they are returned from battle (cf. Isa 59:20, where šûb with the genitive also means “return from”). The qal passive participle šûbê is a hapax legomenon. BDB thinks it means “averse,” but this is an overly extended meaning of “return.” The passive, “returned,” indicates that the subject has been acted upon, though, as often, the agent is unnamed and impersonal. Our poet uses military imagery throughout the verse. Many scholars want to add “like,” but he began the metaphor when he called the powerful “enemies.” In support of interpretation (2), NAC (pages 67–68) says: “he charges them with attacking innocent passers-by as if they were enemies...The latter thought they were as safe

as soldiers returning from a battle they had won.” Few versions follow interpretation (3).

General Comment on 2:8c–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these two lines. For example:

Men return from battle, thinking they are safe at home, but there you are, waiting to steal the coats off their backs. (GNT)

Micah 2:9

Section 2:1–11: The LORD will punish those who oppress poor people

This section is divided into two parts: 2:1–5 and 2:6–11.

- In verses 1–5, the LORD accused people in Israel of doing evil: they were dishonestly taking property away from other people. He said that he would punish them.
- In verses 6–11, Micah said that people had rebuked him for prophesying these things. And the LORD again said that he would punish the people of Israel.

If you use section headings in your translation, here are some options:

- Use one heading for all of 2:1–11, using the above wording. Here are some other section headings for 2:1–11:

Land Robbers Will Lose their Land (NET)

Punishment for Those Who Abuse Their Power (CEV)

Israel’s Sins Are Condemned (GW)

- Use one heading for 2:1–5 and another heading for 2:6–11. For example:

^{1–5}Judgment against Wealthy Oppressors

^{6–11}True and False Prophets (NLT)

^{1–5}The Evil Plans of People

^{6–11}Micah Is Asked Not to Prophesy (NCV)

- Use one heading for all of chapter 2 (2:1–13). For example:

The Fate of Those Who Oppress the Poor (GNT)

Woe to Oppressors (NASB)

TN will use one heading for 2:1–11 and another heading for 2:12–13. Use a heading or headings that will be appropriate and acceptable for your language situation.

Paragraph 2:6–11

In 2:1–2, Micah spoke about wicked people. In 2:3–5, the LORD spoke to those wicked people. Here in 2:6–11, Micah (and the LORD) continued to speak to those wicked people.

TN and most English versions begin a new paragraph at 2:6. A few versions put a section heading before 2:6. For example:

False Prophets (NIV)

Micah Is Asked Not to Prophecy (NCV)

True and False Prophets (NLT)

You can put a section heading here if you wish. But TN will use one section heading for all of 2:1–11.

2:9a

You drive the women of My people from their pleasant homes.

- You^(plur) force some women who are my people to leave the houses that they love/value.
- You take good/nice houses away from women who are my people.
- Also, some of the women in my nation own houses that are valuable to them. But you take possession of those houses and force those women to move out.

You drive the women of My people from their pleasant homes: This is the second evil thing that the LORD accused the people of doing regularly.

You drive: The women probably owed money to these wicked people. The women were not able to pay back the money, so the wicked people forced the women to give them their houses to pay their debt. Then they evicted them from the houses.

the women of My people: The pronoun My refers to the LORD, just as in 2:8a. These women were the LORD's people. In the Jewish culture, men were the ones who usually owned houses, so these women were probably widows. It is possible that some of these women had husbands who had been sold into

slavery (UBS, page 163), but almost all commentaries agree that these women were probably widows. A&F (page 321) points out that it is Micah's style to use general terms such as "women" and "children" when he is actually referring to "widows" and "orphans." Their children (see 2:9b) had no fathers to provide the finances necessary to maintain a home.

pleasant homes: This means that the houses were good homes. They were houses that the women appreciated and valued. It is possible that some of the houses were beautiful and expensive, but in Hebrew, the word pleasant focuses here on the value of the house to the widow and her fatherless children. A&F (page 321) says: "The question of whether the houses as such are 'modest' (Mays) or luxurious does not arise. The word brings out the value of the house for the occupant. 'Pleasant' is an attribute of 'children' in 1:16."

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

My people's women you evict from the homes they love (NJB)

You've forced the women of my people from their nice houses (NCV)

You take over lovely homes that belong to the women of my nation. (CEV)

You evict widows who are my people from the homes that are precious/valuable to them.

2:9b

You take away My blessing from their children forever.

- From the little children of these women you^(plur) permanently take away the blessings I wanted them to have.
- And as for their children, you take away the good things I blessed them with. They will never enjoy these things.
- I wanted to give blessings to the little children in those families. But you have prevented them from ever having those blessings.

You take away My blessing from their children forever: This is the third evil thing that the LORD accused the people of doing regularly.

My blessing: The word translated My blessing is used in an unusual way here. It probably refers here to the blessings that the LORD wanted to give to those young

children. It may refer specifically to the ancestral land that the LORD had given to each Israelite family or to material wealth. Because of the many possibilities, it is best to translate this phrase in a general way. For example:

my blessings (GNT)

the good things I want to give them

forever: This means that the children will never get those good things. The evil people have permanently deprived them of the blessings that the LORD wanted them to have.

Micah 2:10

Section 2:1–11: The LORD will punish those who oppress poor people

This section is divided into two parts: 2:1–5 and 2:6–11.

- In verses 1–5, the LORD accused people in Israel of doing evil: they were dishonestly taking property away from other people. He said that he would punish them.
- In verses 6–11, Micah said that people had rebuked him for prophesying these things. And the LORD again said that he would punish the people of Israel.

If you use section headings in your translation, here are some options:

- Use one heading for all of 2:1–11, using the above wording. Here are some other section headings for 2:1–11:

Land Robbers Will Lose their Land (NET)

Punishment for Those Who Abuse Their Power (CEV)

Israel's Sins Are Condemned (GW)

- Use one heading for 2:1–5 and another heading for 2:6–11. For example:

¹⁻⁵Judgment against Wealthy Oppressors

⁶⁻¹¹True and False Prophets (NLT)

¹⁻⁵The Evil Plans of People

⁶⁻¹¹Micah Is Asked Not to Prophesy (NCV)

- Use one heading for all of chapter 2 (2:1–13). For example:

The Fate of Those Who Oppress the Poor (GNT)

Woe to Oppressors (NASB)

TN will use one heading for 2:1–11 and another heading for 2:12–13. Use a heading or headings that will be appropriate and acceptable for your language situation.

Paragraph 2:6–11

In 2:1–2, Micah spoke about wicked people. In 2:3–5, the LORD spoke to those wicked people. Here in 2:6–11, Micah (and the LORD) continued to speak to those wicked people.

TN and most English versions begin a new paragraph at 2:6. A few versions put a section heading before 2:6. For example:

False Prophets (NIV)

Micah Is Asked Not to Prophesy (NCV)

True and False Prophets (NLT)

You can put a section heading here if you wish. But TN will use one section heading for all of 2:1–11.

2:10a

Arise and depart, for this is not your place of rest,

- Leave! Go away! For this land will no longer be a place where you^(plur) can rest.
- Leave this land! You can no longer live here in safety.
- You must leave this country! I will no longer allow you to live peacefully here.

Arise and depart, for this is not your place of rest:

There are two ways to interpret this sentence:

1. This is what the LORD said to the evil people. For example:

Get up, go away! For this is not your resting place (NIV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB, GNT)

1. This is what the evil people said to the women and children of 2:9. For example:

^{9a}My people's women you evict from the homes they love, ^{9b}and deprive the children of my glory for ever, ¹⁰saying, 'Up and off with you! You can't stay here!' (NJB) (NAB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. The LORD had promised the Jews that he would give them that land. But because of their evil deeds, they would need to leave. An enemy army would capture them and take them away as prisoners.

Arise and depart: In Hebrew, the two verbs in this command emphasize the command to leave. In a similar way, Micah used the command “arise” along with another verb in 4:13 and 6:1. If it is more natural in your language to use just one verb, you may do so. For example:

Get out of here,...! (CEV)

If you need to make explicit the place from which they must leave, you can say: “Leave this land!” or “Leave this country!”

Arise: In Hebrew, this verb literally means “stand up” (from a lying down or sitting position). Here this verb means basically the same thing as “Go!” In idiomatic English, we can say, “Go on! Leave!”

for: The conjunction *for* introduces the reason why the people must leave their land. Some versions leave this conjunction implicit. For example:

Get up and go; there is no safety here any more. (GNT)

Get out of here, you crooks! You'll find no rest here. (CEV)

this: The word *this* refers to the land or country in which the Jews lived.

is not your place of rest: Hundreds of years earlier, the LORD had promised the Jews that this land would be a place for them to rest. (See Deuteronomy 12:9-10; 25:19.) But now he told them that this land would no longer be a place like this. A place of rest means “a place where people can live in safety and peace.”

Here are some other ways to translate 2:10a (in addition to the versions quoted above):

Get up and leave. This is not your place of rest anymore. (NCV)

Up! Begone! This is no longer your land and home. (NLT)

2:10b

because its defilement brings destruction—a grievous destruction!

- The reason is that I will soon destroy this place completely. I will do this because your^(plur) sins have made the land unclean/filthy in my sight.
- Your wicked behavior has made your country unclean/defiled, so its destruction will be extreme/severe.
- You cannot stay here because your sins have made this land unclean, so I will destroy it, and there will be no way to remedy the terrible ruin.

Because there are at least six ways to understand this verse part, the Notes will present only the best-supported interpretation. Versions that support this interpretation include BSB, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT, NRSV, and GNT. TN understands the GW's rendering “it offends me” to refer to the uncleanness of the land. Commentaries that support this interpretation include UBS, NAC, CBC, Waltke 2007, and EBC. Details of other interpretations can be found in the next footnote. The NJB and NAB are similar to each other. The NJB has “For a worthless thing you exact an extortionate pledge.” The NAB has “for any trifle you exact a crippling pledge.” The REB follows another interpretation: “To defile yourselves you would commit any mischief however cruel.” The NJPS has “because of [your] defilement” referring to the people. The CEV has “you will be destroyed,” referring to the people, but does not give a reason. The KJV has “it shall destroy [you],” referring to the land destroying the people. TOTC and A&F support the interpretation that it is primarily the people who are unclean, not the land.

because its defilement brings destruction—a grievous destruction!: In Hebrew, this verse part is literally

“uncleanness will destroy, and destruction will be severe.” This verse part gives the reason why the land is no longer a place of rest (2:10a). The reason is that the people had sinned through their worship of idols (ch. 1), and through the way they had oppressed their fellow Jews (2:1-9). Their sins had caused the land to become “unclean,” “defiled,” or “impure.” EBC (page 514) mentions the dual sins of the people. CBC (page 313) also mentions the sin of idolatry and refers to the similar situation in Hosea in which the Israelites were “expelled from their land and exiled to Assyria (Hos 5:3; 6:10; 9:3-4).” CBC and NAC both reference Leviticus 18:24-28, which describes the land's defilement because of the sins of the people. As a result,

the LORD said that the land was doomed to “severe” or extreme destruction.

because its defilement: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

You have made this place unclean (NCV)

for you have filled it with sin (NLT)

a grievous destruction: The NCV correctly expresses the reason for the destruction. The GNT is similar. It has “your sins have doomed this place to destruction.” But these renderings fail to emphasize the extreme nature of the destruction that is indicated by the word “severe” in Hebrew. Here are some other ways to express this emphasis:

because it is defiled, it is ruined, beyond all remedy (NIV)

because of the uncleanness that brings on destruction, a painful destruction (NASB)

Sin will thoroughly destroy it! (NET)

Express this emphasis in a natural way in your language.

Micah 2:11

Section 2:1–11: The LORD will punish those who oppress poor people

This section is divided into two parts: 2:1–5 and 2:6–11.

- In verses 1–5, the LORD accused people in Israel of doing evil: they were dishonestly taking property away from other people. He said that he would punish them.
- In verses 6–11, Micah said that people had rebuked him for prophesying these things. And the LORD again said that he would punish the people of Israel.

If you use section headings in your translation, here are some options:

- Use one heading for all of 2:1–11, using the above wording. Here are some other section headings for 2:1–11:

Land Robbers Will Lose their Land (NET)

Punishment for Those Who Abuse Their Power (CEV)

Israel’s Sins Are Condemned (GW)

- Use one heading for 2:1–5 and another heading for 2:6–11. For example:

^{1–5}Judgment against Wealthy Oppressors

^{6–11}True and False Prophets (NLT)

^{1–5}The Evil Plans of People

^{6–11}Micah Is Asked Not to Prophesy (NCV)

- Use one heading for all of chapter 2 (2:1–13). For example:

The Fate of Those Who Oppress the Poor (GNT)

Woe to Oppressors (NASB)

TN will use one heading for 2:1–11 and another heading for 2:12–13. Use a heading or headings that will be appropriate and acceptable for your language situation.

Paragraph 2:6–11

In 2:1–2, Micah spoke about wicked people. In 2:3–5, the LORD spoke to those wicked people. Here in 2:6–11, Micah (and the LORD) continued to speak to those wicked people.

TN and most English versions begin a new paragraph at 2:6. A few versions put a section heading before 2:6. For example:

False Prophets (NIV)

Micah Is Asked Not to Prophesy (NCV)

True and False Prophets (NLT)

You can put a section heading here if you wish. But TN will use one section heading for all of 2:1–11.

2:11

In this verse, the LORD, speaking through Micah, described the evil people of the nation. The GNT and a few other versions begin a new paragraph at verse 11. The Notes do not begin a new paragraph until verse

12. You may do whatever is more appropriate in your language.

2:11a

If a man of wind were to come and say falsely,

- If a person goes from place to place and tells many lies, and he says,
- Suppose that a person repeatedly tells lies wherever he goes.

If a man of wind were to come and say falsely:

In Hebrew, this verse part is more literally “If a man walking wind and falsehood lies.” This literal version of the Hebrew is based on BART and the first NET footnote for v.11. Some of the words have more than one meaning. They are also connected to each other in different ways. The Notes will give the most likely meaning rather than try to lay out multiple interpretation issues. These words describe any man who said/claimed he was a prophet, but his message was not from the LORD.

a man of wind: In some languages, it may be clearer to translate this phrase as a plural. For example:

Liars and frauds may go around and say (GW)

If people come telling many lies

of wind...say falsely: In Hebrew, this phrase (“wind and falsehood lies”) has two aspects of meaning:

1. The false prophet said things that were worthless. His words were empty. They were just like wind.
2. His words were falsehoods. They were not true.

The Hebrew phrase may imply that the people who listened were deceived (NIV: “liar and deceiver”), because they enjoyed listening to his preaching.

were to come: This verb probably has two aspects of meaning: Versions that focus on a person who is a liar and tells many lies include CEV, NCV, NET, NIV, and NLT. Versions that focus on the aspect of going from place to place include BSB, ESV, GW, NRSV, and REB. The GNT includes both aspects.

1. The false prophet continually spoke lies.
2. He traveled from place to place.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

These people want the kind of prophet who goes around full of lies and deceit... (GNT)

If a person goes from place to place and repeatedly tells lies

2:11a-c

(combined/reordered)

- These people want the kind of prophet who goes around and repeatedly tells lies. He says, ‘I prophesy/predict that you will have plenty of wine and intoxicating/alcoholic beverages to drink.’

2:11b

“I will preach to you of wine and strong drink,”

- ‘I proclaim/predict to you^(plur) that you will have plenty of wine and beer,’
- He claims to be a prophet and says, ‘You will be prosperous and have lots of intoxicating/alcoholic beverages/things to drink.’

“I will preach to you of wine and strong drink,”:

The false prophet preached to the people of wine and strong drink. This probably means that he predicted that the people would have lots of wine and strong drink. The implication is that they would have good crops and a prosperous life.

preach: The word preach is the same word that is found three times in Micah 2:6. It means “to preach, to proclaim a message.” See the note at 2:6a.

to you: In Hebrew, the pronoun you is singular. But it clearly refers to the Jewish people. So in most languages, it will probably be more natural to use a plural pronoun.

wine and strong drink: In Hebrew, the phrase wine and strong drink refers to wine and beer. Waltke 2007 (pages 123–124) points out that although *šēkār* almost always occurs together with *yayin* and “denotes not just barley beer but any alcoholic beverage, the article with ‘wine and beer’ marks them out as belonging to a class unique and determined in themselves. Both are light intoxicants, about 7–10 percent alcoholic content, by comparison with modern liquors and strong drinks.” Both wine and beer are alcoholic drinks that contain a small percentage of alcohol. If your language does not have specific words for wine and beer, you may use a general phrase such as “intoxicating drinks” or “drinks that can make a person drunk.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

I will prophesy for you plenty of wine and beer (NIV)

I’ll promise you blessings of wine and beer (NET)

2:11c**he would be just the preacher for this people!**

- that is the kind of preacher/prophet that these people want to listen to.”
- These evil people like to listen to people who preach/prophesy that kind of message.”

he would be just the preacher for this people!: This verse part shows sarcasm. The LORD said this to show that he was angry with these evil people. If a true prophet preached to them a message from the LORD, they said “Do not preach” (2:6). But if a false prophet preached a worthless message about wine and beer, that is the kind of preacher these people liked to hear. Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

That would be the kind of preacher these people would like.

You people would enjoy a preacher who said things like that.

this people: This phrase refers to the people that the LORD has been speaking to in 2:8–10. Notice that in 2:8–10, the LORD spoke to these people, but here in 2:11, he spoke about them. If this will confuse your readers, you can translate this people as “you” or “people like you.” For example:

But you people want a false prophet who will tell you nothing but lies. (NCV)

General Comment on 2:11a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

“These people want the kind of prophet who goes around full of lies and deceit and says, ‘I prophesy that wine and liquor will flow for you.’ (GNT)

Micah 2:12**Section 2:12–13: The LORD promised to gather his people again and bless them**

In the previous sections of the book, the LORD, speaking through Micah, said that he would punish the Jewish nation. Samaria would be destroyed (1:6–7), and many people in Judah would go away as prisoners (1:16). He told the people that they could no longer stay in their land (2:10). Other people would capture them and take away their land (2:4–5).

This section (2:12–13) is about the more distant future. The LORD is the speaker in 2:12. Verse 2:13 describes what the LORD promises he will do. He will gather his people together again from the places where they will be scattered in exile. He will be their leader and will make them safe again.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Promises of Restoration (NJB)

A Promise for the Remnant of Israel (NRSV)

The Lord Will Restore His People (NET)

Israel Will Be Gathered Again by the Lord (GW)

2:12a**I will surely gather all of you, O Jacob;**

- **י** “Descendants of Jacob, I will certainly bring all of you^(plur) together in one place.
- **י** Yahweh says, “Listen, you who are descendants/people of Jacob! The time will come that I will gather all of you back together. This will certainly happen!”

I: The LORD is the speaker in verse 12. If this is not clear in your translation, here are some other ways you can begin this verse:

The LORD said, “I

“I, the LORD

will surely gather: In Hebrew, this is literally “gathering I will gather.” This Hebrew phrase emphasizes that the LORD will gather. Here are some other ways to emphasize this phrase:

I will certainly gather

Truly, I will gather

Believe me, I will gather

all of you, O Jacob: There is a textual issue here:

1. The Hebrew text has “all of you, Jacob.” For example:

“I will surely assemble all of you, Jacob... (NASB) (BSB, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB, GNT)

1. The LXX does not have the word “you.” Instead it refers to “all of Jacob.” The LXX for Micah 2:12a says “Jacob will be assembled with all.” For example:

I shall assemble the whole of Israel. (NJB) (CEV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and commentaries. According to interpretation (1), in 2:12a the LORD spoke to the people, not about them.

O Jacob: See the note about O at 1:2b. The name Jacob here means “descendants of Jacob.” It is parallel with “Israel” in 2:12b and refers to the whole Jewish nation. See the note on the name Jacob at 1:5a.

2:12b–d

In 2:12a, the LORD spoke to the people, but in 2:12b–d, he spoke about the people.

2:12b

I will collect the remnant of Israel.

- I will certainly gather together the people of Israel who still remain alive.
- Yes, I will indeed bring together the Jewish/Israelite people who have been scattered but who still survive.

I will collect the remnant of Israel: In Hebrew, 2:12b is literally “gathering I will gather the remnant of Israel.” This verse part is parallel to 2:12a. It has a similar meaning and similar emphasis.

the remnant of Israel: The name “Jacob” (2:12a) and the phrase the remnant of Israel both refer to the Israelites who will survive the war and exile that Micah has predicted. In the future, the LORD will gather this remnant together again in their own land.

General Comment on 2:12a–b

There are at least two ways to translate these parallel lines:

- Translate 12a and 12b separately, as two sentences. In 12a, the LORD spoke to the descendants of Jacob. In 12b, he spoke about the survivors of Israel. For example:

I will surely gather all of you, O Jacob; I will surely bring together the remnant of Israel. (NIV)

- Translate 12a and 12b as one unit. Translate “Jacob” and “survivors of Israel” as one phrase. Translate the sentence so that the LORD speaks to the people. For example:

But I will gather you together, all you people of Israel that are left. (GNT)

Choose an option that is clear and natural in your language.

2:12c–d

These two verse parts are parallel to each other. They are also parallel to 2:12a–b. In 2:12c–d, there are two similes:

- In 2:12c, the LORD compared the people to sheep in a pen. The main point of this simile is safety. The people will be safe like sheep in a fold/pen.
- In 2:12d, the LORD compared the people to a flock of sheep in a pasture. The main point of this simile is a noisy throng. There will be many people and they will make lots of noise.

2:12c

I will bring them together like sheep in a pen,

- I will set them together like sheep in a fold. (NRSV)
- I will bring them together in one place. They will be safe, like sheep in a pen.
- I will bring them all together in a safe place, like a shepherd puts his sheep inside a/an fence/enclosure.

I will bring them together like sheep in a pen: The verb bring...together is another synonym for “gather” in 2:12a–b. The pronoun them refers to the “remnant of Israel” mentioned in 2:12b.

like sheep in a pen: A shepherd puts sheep inside a pen so they will be safe. In the same way the LORD will gather the remnant of Israel so that they will be safe.

pen: A pen is a fence or wall around a small piece of land. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

enclosure (NJB)

fold (NRSV)

corral

2:12d

like a flock in the midst of its pasture—a noisy throng.

- Like a flock of sheep in its pasture, they will be a noisy crowd of people.”
- They will also be like many sheep in a field. There will be many of them and they will be noisy and happy.”
- There will be a big crowd of them, making happy noise, like a flock of sheep in a pasture.”

like a flock in the midst of its pasture—a noisy throng: There are two main ways to interpret these phrases: In addition to the two interpretations given in the Notes, there are at least two other interpretations: The REB has “like a flock in the pasture, moved away by men.” The NAB has “like a herd in the midst of its corral, they shall not be thrown into panic by men.”

1. The Jewish survivors will be like a flock of sheep in a pasture. They will be a noisy crowd of people. For example:

like a flock in its pasture, a noisy multitude of men (ESV) (BSB, GW, KJV, NASB, NET, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. The Jewish survivors will be like a flock of sheep in a fold. They will make noise far away from any people. For example:

like a flock within their fold, they will bleat far away from anyone (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with almost all English versions.

a noisy throng: This phrase means that the people will make lots of noise. They will probably be noisy because they will be happy and talking together. Be careful not to translate this in a way that will make your readers think that the people are angry or fighting.

Here are some other ways to translate 2:12d:

...like a flock in the middle of a pasture; they will be so numerous that they will make a lot of noise. (NET)

...like a flock in its pasture. They will make a lot of noise because there will be so many people. (GW)

Some versions give attention only to the large number of people and leave implicit the accompanying noise. For example:

your land will once again be filled with many people (GNT) The NCV, the NIV and the GNT speak of the crowd, but leave implicit the noise of the crowd.

Micah 2:13

Section 2:12–13: The LORD promised to gather his people again and bless them

In the previous sections of the book, the LORD, speaking through Micah, said that he would punish the Jewish nation. Samaria would be destroyed (1:6–7), and many people in Judah would go away as prisoners (1:16). He told the people that they could no longer stay in their land (2:10). Other people would capture them and take away their land (2:4–5).

This section (2:12–13) is about the more distant future. The LORD is the speaker in 2:12. Verse 2:13 describes what the LORD promises he will do. He will gather his people together again from the places where they will be scattered in exile. He will be their leader and will make them safe again.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Promises of Restoration (NJB)

A Promise for the Remnant of Israel (NRSV)

The Lord Will Restore His People (NET)

Israel Will Be Gathered Again by the Lord (GW)

2:13

In verses 12 and 13, the meaning is the same whether the LORD or Micah is the speaker. But in some languages, it may be necessary to make clear who the speaker is. The LORD was clearly the speaker in verse 12. There are three ways to interpret the identity of the speaker here in verse 13:

1. Micah is the speaker. The GNT has a closing quotation mark (”) at the end of 2:12 to show that the LORD stopped speaking there. (GNT)
2. The LORD is still the speaker in 2:13. The CEV indicates this by using the pronoun “I.” For example:

I will break down the gate and lead them out—then I will be their king. (CEV) The NIV and some other versions have an open quotation mark (“) at the beginning of verse 12 and a closing quotation mark (”) at the end of verse 13 to show that the LORD is the speaker in both verses. (CEV, NASB,

NCV, NIV, NLT) Although the CEV does not use quotation marks, v.13 is clearly a continuation of v.12 which identifies “I the Lord” as the speaker.

1. The speaker is not identified. No quotation marks are used in 2:12–13 to help the reader know who the speaker is. (BSB, GW, KJV, NAB, NET, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, REB)

The Notes will follow interpretation (1) along with most of the commentaries that discuss the issue. Most commentaries do not comment on who the speaker is in v.13. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include UBS, NAC, Waltke 2007, and probably A&F. No commentaries used in the Notes clearly supported interpretation (2). In verse 13, the name “the LORD” appears. Also, the phrases “the one who breaks out” and “their king” probably refer to the LORD. Because of this, it is simplest to understand verse 13 as the words of Micah speaking about the LORD. You may follow any of the three interpretations in your translation.

2:13a

One who breaks open the way will go up before them;

- The one who breaks down the wall will go in front of them.
- Someone will break open the wall for them. He will lead them out of the city.
- Their leader will knock down the wall so they can leave and will go ahead of them.

One who breaks open the way will go up before them: This phrase refers to the leader of the people. He will make a gap in the wall around the city where his people have been in captivity or exile and will lead them as they escape. There are two main ways to identify this leader:

1. Leave the identity of the leader unspecified in 2:13a, though his actions are specified. For example:

Someone will open the way and lead the people out. (NCV)

Their leader breaks out before them (REB) (BSB, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. Specify that the leader is the LORD (God). For example:

God will open the way for them and lead them out of exile. (GNT)

The Lord will open the way and lead them. (GW)
(CEV, GW, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow choice (1). Do not specify the identity of the leader in 2:13a. Wait until 2:13c before you further identify this leader. The one who breaks open is someone who will lead the Jewish people back home. It could refer to their king, or to the Messiah. No version specifies that the “one who breaks out” is “the Messiah,” but Pusey, NAC, KD, EBC, ABC, and CBC all mention the role of the Messiah in various ways. EBC (page 517) understand the “breaker” to be Israel’s King, but they also say: “The remnant will receive its final glory and vindication only through the Messiah. He will arise from his people and lead them into the security of God’s kingdom.” CBC (page 315) makes a connection between the “breaker” and Yahweh, but he comments: “Kaiser (1992:45) understands ‘the Breaker’ as a title for God and sees the role of ‘Breaker’ fulfilled ultimately in the ministry of Jesus the Messiah.” Pusey (page 37) quotes Isaiah 42:6–7 and comments: “From this passage, the ‘breaker-through’ was one of the titles of the Christ, known to the Jews...” KD (page 304) says: “the breaker through, who goes before them, is not Jehovah, but...in the highest sense Christ, who opens the prison-doors, and redeems the captives of Zion (vid., Isa. 42:7).” or to the LORD himself.

breaks open the way: It is implied that the people are inside a walled city. Their leader will lead the people out of the city. The city was a figure of speech for captivity or exile. Some English versions make this explicit. For example:

Someone will open the way and lead the people out. The people will break through the gate and leave the city where they were held captive. (2:13a–b, NCV)

Your leader will break out and lead you out of exile, out through the gates of the enemy cities, back to your own land. (2:13a–b, NLT)

will go up before them: These words mean that the leader will walk in front of the people to lead them out of the city. It does not mean that they will go uphill. See the NCV and NLT (quoted above).

2:13b

they will break through the gate, and go out by it.

- Then the people will break open the city gate and go out through it.

- The people will follow him out. They will break open the gate of the city where they had been captives/exiled and leave.

they will break through the gate, and go out by it:

The pronoun they refers to the people and their leader. They will leave the city through the broken gate or doorway in the wall around the city. Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

They will break out, go through the gate, and leave. (GW)

they will break through the gate and go out (NIV)

They will break out of the city gates and go free. (GNT)

2:13c

Their King will pass through before them, the LORD as their leader.

- Their king will lead the way, and Yahweh will go in front of them.
- Their king will walk in front of them. Yahweh himself will lead them out.

Their King will pass through before them, the LORD as their leader:

In 2:13a, the leader of the people is identified as the “one who breaks out.” The two phrases of 2:13c identify the one who leads the whole group as Their King and the LORD. As was mentioned in the note on 2:13a, the “one who breaks out” could be their king, the Messiah, or the LORD. Here in 2:13c, versions translate the two phrases in two ways:

1. In some versions, each phrase is a separate function or name/title. For example:

So their king goes on before them, and the Lord at their head. (NASB)

with their king leading the way and with Yahweh at their head (NJB) (BSB, GW, KJV, NABRE, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. In some versions, the phrase Their King refers to the LORD.

Their king, the Lord himself, will lead them out. (GNT) (CEV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow choice (1). This choice allows your readers to interpret the specific relationships or roles of the leader(s) mentioned in 2:13a and 2:13c according to their own understanding of Scripture as a whole.

will pass through before them...as their leader:

These two phrases, as well as the phrase “will go up before them” in 2:13a, all refer to someone who precedes others. In 2:13a–b, the phrases clearly refer to going outside the city through the broken wall and gate. The two phrases in 2:13c may refer to leading the people as they continue on their journey home. According to NAC (pages 70–71), “The ultimate, complete fulfillment of vv. 12–13 extends to the future coming of the Messiah and even to his second advent and millennial reign for the final stage in the progressive fulfillment of the whole.” Waltke 2007 (page 136) says: “Whether or not this is a salvation oracle, the accidental perfective vividly and dramatically represents the future as a single independent situation.”

See Overall structure of the book in the Introduction for more details about the three divisions.

Micah 3:1

Section 3:1–12: Micah rebuked the leaders of Israel

In this section, Micah is the speaker. He spoke to the leaders of the Jews and to the prophets. He rebuked (scolded) them for their wicked deeds. He also told them that God would punish the nation because of them.

The Notes will divide this section into three paragraphs:

- In 3:1–4, Micah rebuked the judicial leaders.
- In 3:5–8, Micah rebuked the wicked prophets.
- In 3:9–12, Micah rebuked all the leaders: judges, prophets, and priests.

In each paragraph, Micah used the word “justice” (3:1, 8, 9). In each paragraph, he first rebuked the leaders for their evil deeds. Then he described what would happen as a result of their wickedness. Some versions begin a new paragraph at verse 4 or verse 8. It is recommended that you follow the paragraphs used in the Notes.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Micah Denounces Israel’s Leaders (GNT)

Leaders and Prophets Rebuked (NIV)

Israel's Sinful Leaders—Rulers, Prophets, and Priests (GW)

Wicked Rulers and Prophets (NRSV)

Paragraph 3:1–4

In this paragraph, Micah first spoke to the judicial leaders of Israel. He accused them of doing evil and cruel things (verses 1–3). Then he spoke about them. He said that the LORD would punish them (verse 4).

3:1a

Then I said: “Hear now, O leaders of Jacob, you rulers of the house of Israel.”

- ¶ Then/And I said: Listen, you^(plur) leaders of the descendants of Jacob! Listen, you rulers of the people of Israel!
- ¶ Pay attention to what I say, you rulers of Jacob's descendants, who serve as judges for the nation of Israel.
- (combined/reordered)
- ¶ You who rule/lead and judge the Jewish people, listen to my message!
- ¶ Now I speak to you leaders of Israel. Listen to what I say.

Then I said: “Hear now, O leaders of Jacob, you rulers of the house of Israel: It is unusual for a prophet to begin his message with the words Then I said. Perhaps Micah used these words because he began a new message here. Here is another way to introduce this message:

I said (REB)

Some versions make the words Then I said implicit and begin this verse with the command to listen. For example:

Listen, you rulers of Israel! (GNT)

Introduce this message in a natural way in your language.

Hear now: In Hebrew, this is the same word as the word “hear” that Micah used in 1:2a. It means “Listen carefully!” or “Pay attention!”

O leaders...you rulers: These two words are synonyms that mean “chiefs” or “leaders.” They both refer to local leaders who did the work of judges. They listened to disputes, investigated crimes, and punished criminals. Commentaries agree that the parallel terms “heads” and “rulers” refer to officials whose duties

were primarily or totally judicial in nature. A&F (page 339–340) say that they were “some kind of civil magistrates” that were ultimately responsible to the king. 2 Chronicles 19:4–11 describes how Jehoshaphat appointed judges in all the fortified towns of Judah, and according to A&F (page 351), there is no evidence “that the traditional village courts had been abolished or curtailed by Micah's time.”

of Jacob...of the house of Israel: The name Jacob means the “descendants of Jacob.” The phrase house of Israel means the “people/nation of Israel.” Together, these parallel phrases refer to all the Jews. Micah used these same two phrases in 1:5a–b. See the Notes there.

Here are some other ways to translate the part of 3:1a that begins with the command to listen:

Listen, leaders of the people of Jacob; listen, you rulers of the nation of Israel. (NCV)

Listen, you who rule the descendants of Jacob, you who judge the country of the Jews.

General Comment on 3:1a

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder some of the parallel parts in this line. For example:

Listen to me, you rulers of Israel! (CEV)

3:1b

Should you not know justice?

- Are you^(plur) not supposed to be skilled at ruling justly?
- You know that you ought to govern fairly, do you not?
- You should be fair in the way you judge legal cases/disputes.

Should you not know justice?: This is a rhetorical question that expects the answer “Yes.” Micah used this question to rebuke the leaders. His question implies that they did not rule with justice. Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Translate it as a rhetorical question. For example:

Is it not your duty to know what is right (NAB)

You should know how to rule justly, should you not?

- Change the question so that it is clearly a rebuke in your language. For example:

Why do you not rule the people with fairness?

- Translate this question as a statement. For example:

You should know how to decide cases fairly (NCV)

You are supposed to be concerned about justice (GNT)

Translate this question in a way that makes clear to your readers Micah's purpose in rebuking these leaders.

know justice: In this verse, know justice does not only mean “know about justice.” It means “know how to rule in a just and fair way.” Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

know how to rule justly

know how to be fair when you decide court cases

be skilled in leading/ruling the people fairly

Micah 3:2

Section 3:1–12: Micah rebuked the leaders of Israel

In this section, Micah is the speaker. He spoke to the leaders of the Jews and to the prophets. He rebuked (scolded) them for their wicked deeds. He also told them that God would punish the nation because of them.

The Notes will divide this section into three paragraphs:

- In 3:1–4, Micah rebuked the judicial leaders.
- In 3:5–8, Micah rebuked the wicked prophets.
- In 3:9–12, Micah rebuked all the leaders: judges, prophets, and priests.

In each paragraph, Micah used the word “justice” (3:1, 8, 9). In each paragraph, he first rebuked the leaders for their evil deeds. Then he described what would happen as a result of their wickedness. Some versions begin a new paragraph at verse 4 or verse 8. It is recommended that you follow the paragraphs used in the Notes.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Micah Denounces Israel's Leaders (GNT)

Leaders and Prophets Rebuked (NIV)

Israel's Sinful Leaders—Rulers, Prophets, and Priests (GW)

Wicked Rulers and Prophets (NRSV)

Paragraph 3:1–4

In this paragraph, Micah first spoke to the judicial leaders of Israel. He accused them of doing evil and cruel things (verses 1–3). Then he spoke about them. He said that the LORD would punish them (verse 4).

3:2a

You hate good and love evil.

- You^(plur) hate to do what is right. You love to do what is evil.
- But/Instead you like to do what is evil, and you do not like to do what is right.
- So why do you prefer to do what is wicked rather than what is good/right?

You hate good and love evil: This verse part contrasts with 3:1b. The leaders ought to rule with justice. But instead they hate good and love evil. Some versions make this contrast explicit. For example:

yet you hate what is good and you love what is evil (GNT)

yet you hate what is right, and love what is wrong (NET)

but you are the very ones who hate good and love evil (NLT)

hate good...love evil: The first phrase means “to not want to do what is good or right.” The second phrase means “to enjoy doing what is evil.”

In some languages, it is not natural to speak about hating good or loving evil. Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

but you prefer to do evil instead of what is right (CEV)

But you enjoy doing what is wicked, you do not like to do what is good.

This verse part continues Micah's rebuke from 3:1b. In some languages, it may be natural to translate this rebuke as a rhetorical question. For example:

So why do you hate doing what is right and love doing what is evil?

3:2b–3e

In verses 2b–c and 3a–e, Micah used a horrifying extended metaphor to describe the extreme cruelty of the evil rulers toward the people. Most scholars think that Micah was comparing the evil rulers to people who ate human flesh or to butchers who chopped up meat. Parts of the metaphor may also refer to ritual human sacrifices or to the cruelty of the Assyrians, who sometimes flayed the skin off their captives. TOTC, Waltke 1993, and Waltke 2007 say that the metaphor refers to cannibalism, as do ABC and IVPB. UBS (pages 170–171) suggests either one comparison (cannibals) or two comparisons (a butcher and wild animals). NICOT, EBC, and NAC prefer the analogy of a butcher, as does KD (page 306), who summarizes the details as “treat them like cattle.” ZIBBC (page 133) speaks of the “horrors of human sacrifice.” A&F (page 353) mention the practice of sacrificing children in the fire and references 2 Kings 16:3 and 17:16–17, but they also say that the wording here does not support the idea of ritual sacrifice and that there is “no information as to whether human flesh was actually consumed.” They make the point that “cannibalism under duress” is a very different thing from eating “a human out of sheer malevolence” and say it is unlikely that “the entire leadership of Israel engaged in such practices together.”

The parts of this metaphor are in the form of a seven-line chiasm. The main point occurs in the third line (3a). Verses 2b and 3b form a pair, as do 2c and 3c. Verses 3d–e are connected to 3c as part of the overall cooking process. According to Waltke 1993 (page 658), the similes in the last lines of verse 3 add further details to the incomplete metaphors in the first part of the verse. Waltke 2007 (page 149) comments that the first three clauses of v.3 probably represent “three aspects of one situation” and that “the repetition of their skin and bones...emphasizes and confirms the cannibalism of the culprits.” Chronologically, 2b–c and 3b–e precede the main point in 3a.

^{2b}You tear the skin from my people

^{2c}and strip the flesh from their bones.

^{3a}You eat the flesh of my people

^{3b}after stripping off their skin

^{3c}and breaking their bones.

^{3d}You chop them up like flesh for the cooking pot,

^{3e}like meat in a caldron.

See the General Comment at the end of the note on 3:3d–e for ways to translate this metaphor and to make the lines chronological.

3:2b

You tear the skin from my people

- You^(plur) pull off the skin of my countrymen,
- You oppress my fellow Jews. Your cruelty can be compared to someone who skins another person while they are still alive,

You tear the skin from my people: To tear the skin from means “to pull or peel the skin off a person’s body.”

my people: This phrase does not occur here in Hebrew. It is supplied from 3:3a. It means “my fellow Jews” or “my countrymen.” (See the Note on this same phrase at 1:9c.)

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

You skin my people alive (NCV)

You flay my people’s skin (NET)

3:2c

and strip the flesh from their bones.

- and you^(plur) tear/separate the meat from their bones.
- and then he tears/strips the meat from their bones.

and strip the flesh from their bones: After they tore off the skin of the people, they tore the flesh from their bones.

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted word or phrase) in 3:2c in Hebrew. For example, here is 3:2b–c in the NRSV:

who tear the skin off my people, and the flesh off their bones

In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing phrase from 3:2b, as the BSB does. For example:

and rip the flesh from their bones (NET)

flesh: The word flesh refers to the soft part of a human or animal's body. It is the part of an animal that people eat as meat.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

and rip the flesh from their bones (NET)

pulling the flesh off their bones (NJB)

Micah 3:3

Section 3:1–12: Micah rebuked the leaders of Israel

In this section, Micah is the speaker. He spoke to the leaders of the Jews and to the prophets. He rebuked (scolded) them for their wicked deeds. He also told them that God would punish the nation because of them.

The Notes will divide this section into three paragraphs:

- In 3:1–4, Micah rebuked the judicial leaders.
- In 3:5–8, Micah rebuked the wicked prophets.
- In 3:9–12, Micah rebuked all the leaders: judges, prophets, and priests.

In each paragraph, Micah used the word “justice” (3:1, 8, 9). In each paragraph, he first rebuked the leaders for their evil deeds. Then he described what would happen as a result of their wickedness. Some versions begin a new paragraph at verse 4 or verse 8. It is recommended that you follow the paragraphs used in the Notes.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Micah Denounces Israel's Leaders (GNT)

Leaders and Prophets Rebuked (NIV)

Israel's Sinful Leaders—Rulers, Prophets, and Priests (GW)

Wicked Rulers and Prophets (NRSV)

Paragraph 3:1–4

In this paragraph, Micah first spoke to the judicial leaders of Israel. He accused them of doing evil and cruel things (verses 1–3). Then he spoke about them. He said that the LORD would punish them (verse 4).

3:3a

You eat the flesh of my people

- You^(plur) eat my countrymen.
- You oppress my fellow Jews so harshly/cruelly, it is as if you eat them up.

You eat the flesh of my people: This line is the main point of the metaphor. The point is that the wicked leaders treated the common people with extreme cruelty. They wrongfully deprived them of their land and property and everything that they needed to stay alive. Here are some of the cruel things these leaders did: They took land and houses away from poor people (Micah 2:2; Micah 2:8–9), they took bribes (Micah 3:11a), and they did not help widows and orphans (see Psalm 82:1–4; Isaiah 1:17, 23; Jeremiah 22:3). Here are some other verses in which cruel people are compared to those who eat human flesh: Psalms 14:4; Proverbs 30:14; Zephaniah 3:3.

Micah compared their cruelty to people who would enjoy eating the flesh of their fellow countrymen. He was probably not referring to ritual cannibalism or to mothers who ate dead children to avoid starvation during the siege of Samaria (2 Kings 6:29). (See the two footnotes in the earlier note on 3:2b–3e).

3:3b

after stripping off their skin

- Listen again to what I just said: You^(plur) pull off their skin.
- Yes indeed! It is like you peel/tear the skin off their bodies,

after stripping off their skin: See the notes on the parallel clause in 3:2b.

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine these parallel clauses into one line. For example:

You skin my people alive. (CEV)

See also the CEV reordering of 3:2b–3e in the General Comment at the end of the note on 3:3d–e.

3:2b–3e

(combined/reordered)

- You^(plur) oppress my people/countrymen with extreme cruelty. Because of this, your unbelievable wickedness is like a person who rips the skin and

flesh from the bones of his countrymen, chops up all the pieces, throws them into a large pot, and then cooks them and eats them.

3:3c and breaking their bones.

- Then/And you^(plur) chop/cut their bones into pieces,
- and then you chop up their bones and flesh.

and breaking their bones: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and break their bones (NLT)

breaking up their bones (NJB)

breaking their bones to bits (NJPS)

3:3d-e You chop them up like flesh for the cooking pot, like meat in a cauldron.”

- and you^(plur) put all the pieces of meat and bone in a big cooking pot.
- You can be compared to a person who treats his fellow Jews like they are just pieces of meat to be cooked in a pot/cauldron.

You chop them up like flesh for the cooking pot, like meat in a cauldron: To chop them up refers here to cutting the flesh/meat into pieces with a big knife. Notice the parallel phrases:

^{3d}like flesh for the **cooking pot**,

^{3e}like meat in a **cauldron**.

In these parallel similes, the words meat and flesh mean the same thing, and the words cooking pot and cauldron both refer to a large cooking pot.

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine these two verse parts. For example:

You chop them up like meat for the cooking pot.
(NLT)

...and chop them up like meat for the pot (GNT)

General Comment on 3:2b-3e

Here are some other ways to translate the metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. Keep the original (chiastic) order of the lines, but indicate in some way that

the lines preceding and following the main point emphasize that point. For example:

You skin my people alive and tear the flesh from their bones. Yes, you eat my people's flesh, strip off their skin, and break their bones. You chop them up like meat for the cooking pot. (NLT)

- Keep the metaphor. Reorder and/or combine the lines so that they occur in chronological order with the main point at the end. For example:

You skin my people alive. You strip off their flesh, break their bones, cook it all in a pot, and gulp it down. (CEV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. Keep the original (chiastic) order with the main point in the middle. For example:

You treat my people cruelly. You are like someone who strips off their skin and rips their flesh from their bones. Then he eats the meat. I will repeat: Your comparison/likeness is a person who eats my people, first chopping them up and cooking them in a big pot.

- Change the metaphor to a simile. Reorder and/or combine the lines so that they occur in chronological order with the main point at the end. For example:

It is as if you tear the skin from my people, rip the flesh from their bones, break their bones in pieces, chop them up, cook them in a large pot, and eat them. That is what you are like, because you oppress my people so harshly.

Micah 3:4

Section 3:1-12: Micah rebuked the leaders of Israel

In this section, Micah is the speaker. He spoke to the leaders of the Jews and to the prophets. He rebuked (scolded) them for their wicked deeds. He also told them that God would punish the nation because of them.

The Notes will divide this section into three paragraphs:

- In 3:1-4, Micah rebuked the judicial leaders.
- In 3:5-8, Micah rebuked the wicked prophets.
- In 3:9-12, Micah rebuked all the leaders: judges, prophets, and priests.

In each paragraph, Micah used the word “justice” (3:1, 8, 9). In each paragraph, he first rebuked the leaders for their evil deeds. Then he described what would happen as a result of their wickedness. Some versions begin a new paragraph at verse 4 or verse 8. It is recommended that you follow the paragraphs used in the Notes.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Micah Denounces Israel’s Leaders (GNT)

Leaders and Prophets Rebuked (NIV)

Israel’s Sinful Leaders—Rulers, Prophets, and Priests (GW)

Wicked Rulers and Prophets (NRSV)

Paragraph 3:1–4

In this paragraph, Micah first spoke to the judicial leaders of Israel. He accused them of doing evil and cruel things (verses 1–3). Then he spoke about them. He said that the LORD would punish them (verse 4).

3:4

Here Micah began to speak about the leaders instead of to them, so he used the pronoun “they” instead of “you.” He described the way that the LORD would punish them in the future.

^{4a}Then they will cry out to the LORD,

^{4b}but he will not answer them.

^{4c}At that time He will hide His face from them

^{4d}because of the evil they have done.

3:4a

Then they will cry out to the LORD,

- The time will come when those wicked leaders will call out to Yahweh for help.
- Sometime in the future, when trouble comes, those wicked leaders will pray earnestly to Yahweh. They will say loudly, “Help us^(excl) please!”

Then they will cry out to the LORD: The word Then refers to a time in the future when disaster will come upon the nation. (See 2:3–4.) Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Someday.... (NET)

The time is coming when.... (GNT)

they: The pronoun they refers to the evil leaders that Micah spoke to in 3:1–3. It does not refer to the poor people whom the leaders mistreated. If this pronoun reference is not clear to your readers, you may want to use a more explicit phrase. For example:

Someday these sinners will cry to the Lord for help (NET)

will cry out to the LORD: This phrase means that they will call out loudly to the LORD. They will plead with him to help them, because they are in distress. Waltke 2007 (page 151) says that the phrase used here indicates earnest prayer to God for help in which a person expresses strong emotion. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

In a coming day, they will pray earnestly for the LORD’s help

In some languages, it may be more natural to use a direct quote here. For example:

In the future, those wicked leaders will cry out to the LORD, saying, “Please help us^(excl)!”

3:4a–d

(combined/reordered)

- You^(plur) leaders have done very wicked deeds, so in the future, you will plead loudly with Yahweh to rescue/help you, but he will turn his back on you and ignore you.

3:4b

but He will not answer them.

- But he will not respond.
- But he will not help them.

but He will not answer them: This line implies that the LORD will not respond to their prayers. In other words, he will not help them. Here are some other ways to translate this line:

but he will just ignore them

but he will do nothing

but he will turn a deaf ear to them

The last suggestion is a figurative expression. In some languages, there are similar figures of speech that will effectively communicate the meaning.

Notice that there is a different figure of speech with a similar meaning in the parallel line in 3:4c.

3:4c

At that time He will hide His face from them

- When that time comes, he will hide/turn his face from them,
- He will absolutely ignore them,

At that time He will hide His face from them: The figurative expression hide His face and the parallel phrase in 3:4b both mean that the LORD will refuse to help them.

Here is a similar figure of speech that also occurs in some other languages:

he will turn his back on them

At that time: This phrase refers to the same time as the word “Then” in 3:4a. Some versions use only one time phrase. See the GNT and CEV in the General Comment on 3:4a–d.

3:4d

because of the evil they have done.

- because of the evil deeds they have done.
- because of their wicked behavior/actions.

because of the evil they have done: The reason that the LORD will refuse to help the wicked leaders is that they have done evil deeds.

General Comment on 3:4a–d

Some versions translate 3:4a–d using the pronoun “you” instead of “they.” They do this so that the pronoun “you” will be used consistently in 3:1–4. For example:

Then you will cry to the Lord, ^bbut he will not answer you. ‘He will hide his face from you at that time because you have done evil things. (GW)

The time is coming when you will cry out to the Lord, but he will not answer you. He will not listen to your prayers, for you have done evil. (GNT)

Someday you will beg the Lord to help you, ^{b-d}but he will turn away because of your sins. (CEV)

Notice that the GW uses separate time phrases for 4a and 4c. The CEV combines 4b–d into one line.

If it is clearer or more natural in your language to use “you” pronouns in 3:4 as well as 3:1–3, you may do so.

Micah 3:5

Section 3:1–12: Micah rebuked the leaders of Israel

In this section, Micah is the speaker. He spoke to the leaders of the Jews and to the prophets. He rebuked (scolded) them for their wicked deeds. He also told them that God would punish the nation because of them.

The Notes will divide this section into three paragraphs:

- In 3:1–4, Micah rebuked the judicial leaders.
- In 3:5–8, Micah rebuked the wicked prophets.
- In 3:9–12, Micah rebuked all the leaders: judges, prophets, and priests.

In each paragraph, Micah used the word “justice” (3:1, 8, 9). In each paragraph, he first rebuked the leaders for their evil deeds. Then he described what would happen as a result of their wickedness. Some versions begin a new paragraph at verse 4 or verse 8. It is recommended that you follow the paragraphs used in the Notes.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Micah Denounces Israel’s Leaders (GNT)

Leaders and Prophets Rebuked (NIV)

Israel’s Sinful Leaders—Rulers, Prophets, and Priests (GW)

Wicked Rulers and Prophets (NRSV)

Paragraph 3:5–8

In this paragraph, Micah rebuked the wicked prophets. He first described the way in which they misled the people (3:5). He then described their future punishment by God (3:6–7). He concluded by contrasting his own status as a true prophet (3:8).

Micah began this paragraph with the phrase “Thus says the LORD.” This phrase indicates that his message came from the LORD. But it is not clear which verses are a direct quote of the LORD’s words. In the examples below, the verse parts may differ, depending on the version. Here are the main interpretations:

1. All of verses 5–8 are Micah’s words. These verses are the message that he received from the LORD. The lack of quotation marks indicates that he did not quote the LORD’s words directly. Interpretation (1) is supported by WBC 1984 (pages 32–33). For example:

^{5a}Thus says the Lord concerning the prophets who lead my people astray;...^{6a}Therefore it will be night for you...^{7a}The seers will be ashamed...^{8a}On the other hand I am filled with power... (NASB) (ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NJB, NRSV, REB) The NJPS does not use any quote marks in 3:5–8. It has not been listed under interpretation (1), because it spells the phrase “My people” with a capital letter, referring to the LORD.

1. Verses 5b–7 are a direct quote of the LORD’s words. The quote is marked with quotation marks. Verse 8 is Micah’s words. Interpretation (2) is supported by Hillers (page 44). For example:

^{5a}This is what the Lord says: ^{5b}“As for the prophets who lead my people astray,... ^{7b}They will all cover their faces because there is no answer from God.” ^{8a}But as for me... (NIV) (BSB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT) The NET includes 3:8 in the same paragraph as 3:5–7. In the NCV, NIV, and NLT, 3:8 starts a new paragraph.

1. Verse 3:6 is a direct quote of the LORD’s words. Verses 5, 7, and 8 are Micah’s words. Interpretation (3) is supported by TOTC, Waltke 1993, and Waltke 2007. For example:

⁵My people are deceived by prophets...To these prophets the Lord says, ⁶“Prophets, your day is almost over;...you will not be able to predict anything.” ⁷Those who predict...⁸But as for me,... (GNT) (GNT)

1. Verses 6–7 are a direct quote of the LORD’s words. Verses 5 and 8 are Micah’s words. For example:

⁵You lying prophets...Here is what the Lord says to you prophets: ⁶“You will live in the dark...⁷You prophets...no message from me.” ⁸But the Lord has filled me... (CEV) (CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is the simplest. Micah is the speaker in each of the three paragraphs in this section (3:1–12).

The meaning of these verses is almost the same with all four interpretations. Regardless of the quote marks, Micah’s message came to him from the LORD. His audience understood that he claimed to be the LORD’s spokesman.

If you decide not to follow interpretation (1), here are two things that you should consider:

- If you follow interpretation (1), (3), or (4), the phrase “my people” in 3:5a means “Micah’s people.” But if you follow interpretation (2), it means “the LORD’s people.”
- If you follow interpretation (2) or (4), the phrase “there is no answer from God” (3:7d) may need to be translated “there is no answer from me.”

3:5

Verse 3:5a gives a general reason for Micah’s rebuke of the prophets. Verses 3:5b–c give more details. A&F (page 364), Waltke 1993 (page 662).

^{5a}This is what the LORD says: “As for the prophets who lead My people astray,

^{5b}who proclaim peace while they chew with their teeth,

^{5c}but declare war against one who puts nothing in their mouths:

3:5a

This is what the LORD says: “As for the prophets who lead My people astray,

- ¶ This is what Yahweh says about the prophets who deceive/mislead my people/countrymen.
- ¶ Here is a message from Yahweh. It is a message about the prophets who encourage/teach my fellow Jews to follow a sinful way of life.

This is what the LORD says: Micah used this phrase to introduce a message from the LORD. See how you translated the same phrase in 2:3a.

As for the prophets: This phrase indicates that Micah’s message was about the prophets. Here is another way to translate these two phrases:

This is what the Lord says about the prophets... (GW)

who lead My people astray: Some translations interpret the Hebrew phrase “my people” as referring to Micah’s people, since Micah is the one quoting God.

The BSB chose to translate the phrase My people to refer to God's people. The phrase My people refers to Micah's people. See the Note about this phrase at 1:9c.

The phrase lead...astray (present tense) means that the wicked prophets habitually or frequently pretended that their messages were from the LORD. But actually, their words were lies that deceived or misled the people. They did not warn the people that the LORD would punish them if they did not turn from their sins.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

who regularly deceive my people

who mislead my people (GW)

who teach my people the wrong way to live (based on NCV)

3:5b

who proclaim peace while they chew with their teeth,

- If people give those prophets food, they loudly say, "All will go well for you^(plural)!"
- If people feed those prophets as payment for their message, they proclaim this message: "You will prosper!"
- Those prophets speak a good message to people who give them food. They promise them, "You will have a good life!"

who proclaim peace while they chew with their teeth: In Hebrew, the verb proclaim means "to speak loudly," "to proclaim a message."

peace: These prophets proclaim that there will be peace (šalom in Hebrew). This word means more than just no fighting or no noise. It means "wholeness," "prosperity," or "well-being." It refers to the happy life of a person whom God blesses. UBS (page 174).

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate peace as a sentence. For example:

"You will prosper."

"Your life will be happy and safe."

while they chew with their teeth: Here, this clause means "to bite food," in other words, to eat.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

who promise prosperity in return for food (REB)

If these prophets are given food to eat, they shout, "Peace!" (NCV, quote marks adjusted)

If people give those prophets food to eat, they loudly proclaim this message, "You will be safe and happy."

It was the custom in Israel to give food or money to prophets to help them. But the prophets that Micah talked about here were not honest. If people paid them or gave them food, they preached messages of peace and prosperity instead of warning the people to repent.

3:5c

but declare war against one who puts nothing in their mouths:

- But if people do not feed them, they fight a war against them.
- But they oppose any people who do not give them food.
- But if people don't give them anything as payment, they threaten them, saying, "The Lord will destroy you!"

but declare war against one who puts nothing in their mouths: If a person did not give food to these prophets, they did not preach messages of peace and prosperity. Instead they declare war against those people.

declare war: Other versions translate this phrase in these ways:

prepare to wage war (NIV)

threaten war (GNT)

declare a holy war (GW)

This is a figure of speech called a hyperbole. These prophets did not literally declare war against people who did not give them food. Perhaps the prophets spoke angrily to them. Perhaps they preached messages against them. Perhaps they cursed them, saying, "God will destroy you!"

If a literal translation of this figure of speech is not clear or natural, you may want to translate it another way. For example:

But if people do not give them food to eat, they threaten disaster on them.

But they speak angrily against anyone who does not give them food.

Micah 3:6

Section 3:1–12: Micah rebuked the leaders of Israel

In this section, Micah is the speaker. He spoke to the leaders of the Jews and to the prophets. He rebuked (scolded) them for their wicked deeds. He also told them that God would punish the nation because of them.

The Notes will divide this section into three paragraphs:

- In 3:1–4, Micah rebuked the judicial leaders.
- In 3:5–8, Micah rebuked the wicked prophets.
- In 3:9–12, Micah rebuked all the leaders: judges, prophets, and priests.

In each paragraph, Micah used the word “justice” (3:1, 8, 9). In each paragraph, he first rebuked the leaders for their evil deeds. Then he described what would happen as a result of their wickedness. Some versions begin a new paragraph at verse 4 or verse 8. It is recommended that you follow the paragraphs used in the Notes.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Micah Denounces Israel’s Leaders (GNT)

Leaders and Prophets Rebuked (NIV)

Israel’s Sinful Leaders—Rulers, Prophets, and Priests (GW)

Wicked Rulers and Prophets (NRSV)

Paragraph 3:5–8

In this paragraph, Micah rebuked the wicked prophets. He first described the way in which they misled the people (3:5). He then described their future punishment by God (3:6–7). He concluded by contrasting his own status as a true prophet (3:8).

Micah began this paragraph with the phrase “Thus says the LORD.” This phrase indicates that his message came from the LORD. But it is not clear which verses are a direct quote of the LORD’s words. In the examples below, the verse parts may differ, depending on the version. Here are the main interpretations:

1. All of verses 5–8 are Micah’s words. These verses are the message that he received from the LORD. The lack of quotation marks indicates that he did not quote the LORD’s words directly. Interpretation (1) is supported by WBC 1984 (pages 32–33). For example:

^{5a}Thus says the Lord concerning the prophets who lead my people astray;...^{6a}Therefore it will be night for you...^{7a}The seers will be ashamed...^{8a}On the other hand I am filled with power... (NASB) (ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NJB, NRSV, REB) The NJPS does not use any quote marks in 3:5–8. It has not been listed under interpretation (1), because it spells the phrase “My people” with a capital letter, referring to the LORD.

1. Verses 5b–7 are a direct quote of the LORD’s words. The quote is marked with quotation marks. Verse 8 is Micah’s words. Interpretation (2) is supported by Hillers (page 44). For example:

^{5a}This is what the Lord says: ^{5b}“As for the prophets who lead my people astray;... ^{7b}They will all cover their faces because there is no answer from God.” ^{8a}But as for me... (NIV) (BSB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT) The NET includes 3:8 in the same paragraph as 3:5–7. In the NCV, NIV, and NLT, 3:8 starts a new paragraph.

1. Verse 3:6 is a direct quote of the LORD’s words. Verses 5, 7, and 8 are Micah’s words. Interpretation (3) is supported by TOTC, Waltke 1993, and Waltke 2007. For example:

⁵My people are deceived by prophets...To these prophets the Lord says, ⁶“Prophets, your day is almost over;...you will not be able to predict anything.” ⁷Those who predict...⁸But as for me,... (GNT) (GNT)

1. Verses 6–7 are a direct quote of the LORD’s words. Verses 5 and 8 are Micah’s words. For example:

⁵You lying prophets...Here is what the Lord says to you prophets: ⁶“You will live in the dark...” ⁷You prophets...no message from me.” ⁸But the Lord has filled me... (CEV) (CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is the simplest. Micah is the speaker in each of the three paragraphs in this section (3:1–12).

The meaning of these verses is almost the same with all four interpretations. Regardless of the quote marks, Micah's message came to him from the LORD. His audience understood that he claimed to be the LORD's spokesman.

If you decide not to follow interpretation (1), here are two things that you should consider:

- If you follow interpretation (1), (3), or (4), the phrase "my people" in 3:5a means "Micah's people." But if you follow interpretation (2), it means "the LORD's people."
- If you follow interpretation (2) or (4), the phrase "there is no answer from God" (3:7d) may need to be translated "there is no answer from me."

3:6

In 3:5, Micah spoke about the wicked prophets and the way they deceived the people. Here in 3:6, he used the metaphor of night and darkness to describe their future punishment by God. In 3:6a–b, he spoke to these prophets. In 3:6c–d and 3:7 he spoke about them again.

For other ways to translate the change from "about" to "to" and then back to "about" again, see the General Comment on 3:5–7 at the end of the note on 3:7d.

The Notes will first discuss the details of the metaphor and the parallelism before suggesting ways to translate the verse as a whole.

The "you" pronouns in these parallel lines refer to the wicked prophets. Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{6a}Therefore night will come over you without **visions**,

^{6b}and darkness without **divination**.

night will come over you...and darkness: The metaphor of night and darkness figuratively describes the punishment of the wicked prophets. Their future inability to see visions is compared to people who are unable to see things at night in the darkness.

without visions...without divination: These parallel phrases explain the meaning of the metaphor. The metaphor means that God will not give visions or messages to those prophets in the future. He will punish them by taking away their ability to be prophets and to receive revelation.

3:6a

Therefore night will come over you without visions,

- Therefore, it will become night for you^(plur) prophets. You will receive no visions from God.
- Therefore, soon it will become like night for you prophets. God will not show you things that are like dreams.
- And so, you prophets, the time will soon come when God will stop giving you visions.

Therefore: This word connects verse 6 to verse 5. It introduces the result of the behavior of the wicked prophets. Here are some other ways to express this connection:

And so (NJB)

That is why (GW)

visions: A "vision" is like a dream, but the person having a vision is not asleep. Visions are one way that God spoke to prophets. In some languages, the word visions may need to be translated as a phrase. For example:

You will not see anything that is like a dream.

3:6a–d (combined/reordered)

- Therefore, the time of success for you^(plur) prophets is almost finished. You will soon be in darkness. You will have no visions from God, and you will not be able to predict what will happen in the future.

3:6b

and darkness without divination.

- It will become dark for you^(plur). Things that will happen in the future will not be revealed/shown to you.
- It will be like dark night for you. You will no longer be able to predict the future.
- Yes, you will be in the dark. God will no longer tell you what will happen in the future.

divination: divination is predicting what will happen in the future. Micah told these prophets that they will not be able to practice divination, because God will not tell them anything. Non-Jewish people who worshiped idols practiced divination. Here are some ways they did this: They threw arrows and looked at how they landed on the ground. They asked idols to help them. They looked at the liver of an animal they had killed. (See Ezekiel 21:21–22.) They asked a spirit or ghost to help them. (See Leviticus 19:31; 1 Samuel 28:7–8.) Micah's words in Micah 3:6b imply that some

of the wicked prophets also did some things that were like divination. God commanded his people not to use divination (Deuteronomy 18:10) except for the use of the Urim and Thummim by the High Priest. (See Exodus 28:30.) The term “divination” is “never used in the Bible for the activities of true prophets.” (UBS, page 176) Here are some other ways to translate this word:

without any way to tell the future (NCV)

you will not be able to predict anything (GNT)

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Therefore you shall have night, not vision, darkness, not divination (NAB)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

Therefore, it will be like night and darkness for you prophets. You will have no visions from God. You will not be able to predict the future.

Therefore God will not give you visions. He will no longer tell you what will happen in the future. Instead it will be as though dark night surrounds you.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

And so, in the future, those prophets will no longer see any visions. They will no longer be able to use their power to predict what will happen.

3:6c

The sun will set on these prophets,

- The day/time of those prophets will be finished,
- It will be like the sun no longer shines on those prophets.
- The career/work of those prophets will stop.

3:6d

and the daylight will turn black over them.

- and night will come/arrive.
- It will be like they are surrounded by blackness/night.
- They will no longer be able to prophesy.

3:6c-d

In 3:6a-b, Micah used the pronoun “you.” He spoke to these wicked prophets. Here in 3:6c-d, Micah spoke about them. Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{6c}The sun will set **on these prophets,**

^{6d}and the daylight will turn black **over them.**

The sun will set...the daylight will turn black: Here again, Micah used darkness as a metaphor. He said that The sun will set. In other words, it will become night. He said that the daylight will turn black. This is a poetic way to say that it will become dark or night.

The meaning of the metaphor is that the time of these prophets will soon be finished. Their ability to prophesy will soon be gone. It will be a “dark” (sad, humiliating) time for them.

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

General Comment on 3:6a-d

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

The sun will set for the prophets, and the day will go dark for them. (NIV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

It will be like the sun has set and it has become dark. Their time of being prophets will be finished.

It will be like the sun is no longer shining and it has become dark. They will no longer be able to prophesy.

Yes, the time is coming when it will be as though the day has ended for those prophets, and it will be as though they are in darkness, without the ability to prophesy.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

They will no longer be able to prophesy. They will be humiliated, because their career as prophets will be ended.

It will be a time of sadness for them, because they will no longer have the ability to be prophets.

Verse 6a and 6b are parallel. Verse 6c and 6d are also parallel. Most English versions translate each of these four lines separately.

In some languages, this repetition may be confusing or unnatural. Here are some ways to combine and/or reorder these four lines to reduce the amount of repetition.

Prophets, your day is almost over; the sun is going down on you. Because you mislead my people, you will have no more prophetic visions, and you will not be able to predict anything. (GNT)

And so, you prophets, your time of success is almost over. You will soon be in darkness. You will have no visions from God and you will not be able to predict the future.

Notice that these translations use the pronoun “you” for all of verse 6. In Hebrew, 6a–b use the pronoun “you” but 6c–d use “they/them.”

Micah 3:7

Section 3:1–12: Micah rebuked the leaders of Israel

In this section, Micah is the speaker. He spoke to the leaders of the Jews and to the prophets. He rebuked (scolded) them for their wicked deeds. He also told them that God would punish the nation because of them.

The Notes will divide this section into three paragraphs:

- In 3:1–4, Micah rebuked the judicial leaders.
- In 3:5–8, Micah rebuked the wicked prophets.
- In 3:9–12, Micah rebuked all the leaders: judges, prophets, and priests.

In each paragraph, Micah used the word “justice” (3:1, 8, 9). In each paragraph, he first rebuked the leaders for their evil deeds. Then he described what would happen as a result of their wickedness. Some versions begin a new paragraph at verse 4 or verse 8. It is recommended that you follow the paragraphs used in the Notes.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Micah Denounces Israel’s Leaders (GNT)

Leaders and Prophets Rebuked (NIV)

Israel’s Sinful Leaders—Rulers, Prophets, and Priests (GW)

Wicked Rulers and Prophets (NRSV)

Paragraph 3:5–8

In this paragraph, Micah rebuked the wicked prophets. He first described the way in which they misled the people (3:5). He then described their future punishment by God (3:6–7). He concluded by contrasting his own status as a true prophet (3:8).

Micah began this paragraph with the phrase “Thus says the LORD.” This phrase indicates that his message came from the LORD. But it is not clear which verses are a direct quote of the LORD’s words. In the examples below, the verse parts may differ, depending on the version. Here are the main interpretations:

1. All of verses 5–8 are Micah’s words. These verses are the message that he received from the LORD. The lack of quotation marks indicates that he did not quote the LORD’s words directly. Interpretation (1) is supported by WBC 1984 (pages 32–33). For example:

^{5a}Thus says the Lord concerning the prophets who lead my people astray;...^{6a}Therefore it will be night for you...^{7a}The seers will be ashamed...^{8a}On the other hand I am filled with power... (NASB) (ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NJB, NRSV, REB) The NJPS does not use any quote marks in 3:5–8. It has not been listed under interpretation (1), because it spells the phrase “My people” with a capital letter, referring to the LORD.

1. Verses 5b–7 are a direct quote of the LORD’s words. The quote is marked with quotation marks. Verse 8 is Micah’s words. Interpretation (2) is supported by Hillers (page 44). For example:

^{5a}This is what the Lord says: ^{5b}“As for the prophets who lead my people astray....” ^{7b}They will all cover their faces because there is no answer from God.” ^{8a}But as for me... (NIV) (BSB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT) The NET includes 3:8 in the same paragraph as 3:5–7. In the NCV, NIV, and NLT, 3:8 starts a new paragraph.

1. Verse 3:6 is a direct quote of the LORD’s words. Verses 5, 7, and 8 are Micah’s words. Interpretation (3) is supported by TOTC, Waltke 1993, and Waltke 2007. For example:

⁵My people are deceived by prophets...To these prophets the Lord says, ⁶“Prophets, your day is almost over;...you will not be able to predict anything.” ⁷Those who predict...⁸But as for me,... (GNT) (GNT)

1. Verses 6–7 are a direct quote of the LORD’s words. Verses 5 and 8 are Micah’s words. For example:

⁵You lying prophets...Here is what the Lord says to you prophets: ⁶“You will live in the dark...”⁷You prophets...no message from me.” ⁸But the Lord has filled me... (CEV) (CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is the simplest. Micah is the speaker in each of the three paragraphs in this section (3:1–12).

The meaning of these verses is almost the same with all four interpretations. Regardless of the quote marks, Micah’s message came to him from the LORD. His audience understood that he claimed to be the LORD’s spokesman.

If you decide not to follow interpretation (1), here are two things that you should consider:

- If you follow interpretation (1), (3), or (4), the phrase “my people” in 3:5a means “Micah’s people.” But if you follow interpretation (2), it means “the LORD’s people.”
- If you follow interpretation (2) or (4), the phrase “there is no answer from God” (3:7d) may need to be translated “there is no answer from me.”

3:7a–b (combined/reordered)

- Those prophets who used to see visions and predict the future will be ashamed.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{7a}Then the seers **will be ashamed**,

^{7b}and the diviners **will be disgraced**.

3:7a Then the seers will be ashamed

- Those who now can see visions will be ashamed,
- At that time, those prophets will be humiliated because they will no longer be able to do those things.

the seers: This word means “people who see visions.” It was often used to refer to prophets. (See 1 Samuel 9:9.)

will be ashamed: This word means “disgraced” or “humiliated.”

3:7b and the diviners will be disgraced.

- and those who now predict the future will be embarrassed.
- The fortunetellers will feel/experience shame/disgrace.

and the diviners: In Hebrew, this word means “people who practice divination.” It is related to the word translated “divination” in 3:6b. Other ways to translate it are:

fortunetellers (CEV)

people who see the future (NCV)

omen readers (NET)

The words diviners and “seers” both refer to the wicked prophets that Micah talked about in verses 5 and 6.

will be disgraced: In Hebrew, this phrase is a word that means “ashamed” or “embarrassed.” It is a synonym of “ashamed” in 3:7a.

Here are some ways to translate 3:7a–b:

- Translate each line without combining the parallel parts. For example:

The seers will be ashamed and the diviners will be embarrassed. (NASB)

The prophets will be ashamed; the omen readers will be humiliated. (NET)

- Combine the parallel parts into one line. For example:

Seers and diviners alike will be overcome with shame (REB)

Those prophets who used to be able to predict the future will be ashamed.

Those who predict the future will be disgraced by their failure. (GNT)

The words “by their failure” (GNT) is the implied reason that the seers and diviners will be humiliated. In contrast to their success in the past, they will fail to see visions or predict the future.

3:7c

They will all cover their mouths

- All of them will cover their lower faces,
- They will all put their hands over their mouths in shame,

They will all cover their mouths: The pronoun They refers to the seers and diviners in verse 7a-b. Notice the word all. All of them will do this.

cover their mouths: In Hebrew, the word mouths refers to the lower half of the face. It can refer to the mouth, mustache, or beard. The phrase cover their mouths means “they put the palm of their hand over their mouth and lower face to hide it.”

This is a symbolic gesture. Jewish people covered their mouths like this to show that they were very sad or ashamed. (See Ezekiel 24:17; Leviticus 13:45.)

Here are some ways to translate this symbolic gesture:

- Keep the gesture. For example:

They will all cover their faces (NIV)

they will all put their hands over their mouths (NJB)

- Keep the gesture and supply the meaning. For example:

They will cover their faces in shame

- Translate the meaning without the gesture. For example:

They will all be humiliated (GNT)

- Substitute a different symbolic gesture that has the same meaning in your language. For example:

All of them will put their hands on their chests

If you choose the last option, consider adding a footnote that gives the Hebrew gesture along with the meaning.

3:7c-d

(combined/reordered)

- God will no longer give them any messages, so all of them will place their hands over their mouths to show that they are humiliated.

3:7d

because there is no answer from God.”

- because God will not answer them.
- for God no longer pays attention to what they say.

because there is no answer from God: This line gives the reason that the wicked prophets cover their faces. It is because God does not answer them. When they ask him to show them a vision or give them a message, God does not do it. As a result, they are ashamed.

General Comment on 3:5-7

In verse 5, Micah spoke about the evil prophets. In 6a-b, he spoke to the evil prophets. In 6c-d and verse 7, Micah again spoke about these prophets. In Hebrew poetry, it is common to switch from “they” to “you,” or switch from “you” to “they” like this. But in some languages, this may be confusing.

Here are some ways that you can translate the pronouns in this passage:

- Translate all the pronouns as they are in Hebrew. The BSB is one of the versions that does this.
- Change the “you” pronouns in 3:6a-b to “them.” For example:

So it will become like night for them, without visions. It will become dark for them, without any way to tell the future. (NCV)

- Translate all of verses 5-7 using the pronoun you. For example:

⁵This is what the Lord says about you false prophets who are leading his people astray! You promise peace for those who give you food, but you declare war on those who refuse to feed you.

⁶Now the night will close around you, cutting off all your visions. Darkness will cover you, putting an end to your predictions. The sun will set for you prophets, and your day will come to an end. ⁷Then you seers will be put to shame, and you fortune-tellers will be disgraced. And you will cover your faces because there is no answer from God.” (adapted from the NLT) The NLT has: “This is what the Lord says: “You false prophets are leading my people astray!...” The Notes have adapted it to fit interpretation (1) in the paragraph note on 3:5-8.

Translate the pronouns in a way that is clear and natural in your language.

Micah 3:8

Section 3:1-12: Micah rebuked the leaders of Israel

In this section, Micah is the speaker. He spoke to the leaders of the Jews and to the prophets. He rebuked (scolded) them for their wicked deeds. He also told them that God would punish the nation because of them.

The Notes will divide this section into three paragraphs:

- In 3:1-4, Micah rebuked the judicial leaders.
- In 3:5-8, Micah rebuked the wicked prophets.
- In 3:9-12, Micah rebuked all the leaders: judges, prophets, and priests.

In each paragraph, Micah used the word “justice” (3:1, 8, 9). In each paragraph, he first rebuked the leaders for their evil deeds. Then he described what would happen as a result of their wickedness. Some versions begin a new paragraph at verse 4 or verse 8. It is recommended that you follow the paragraphs used in the Notes.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Micah Denounces Israel’s Leaders (GNT)

Leaders and Prophets Rebuked (NIV)

Israel’s Sinful Leaders—Rulers, Prophets, and Priests (GW)

Wicked Rulers and Prophets (NRSV)

Paragraph 3:5-8

In this paragraph, Micah rebuked the wicked prophets. He first described the way in which they misled the people (3:5). He then described their future punishment by God (3:6-7). He concluded by contrasting his own status as a true prophet (3:8).

Micah began this paragraph with the phrase “Thus says the LORD.” This phrase indicates that his message came from the LORD. But it is not clear which verses are a direct quote of the LORD’s words. In the examples below, the verse parts may differ, depending on the version. Here are the main interpretations:

1. All of verses 5-8 are Micah’s words. These verses are the message that he received from the LORD. The lack of quotation marks indicates that he did not

quote the LORD’s words directly. Interpretation (1) is supported by WBC 1984 (pages 32-33). For example:

^{5a}Thus says the Lord concerning the prophets who lead my people astray;...^{6a}Therefore it will be night for you...^{7a}The seers will be ashamed...^{8a}On the other hand I am filled with power... (NASB) (ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NJB, NRSV, REB) The NJPS does not use any quote marks in 3:5-8. It has not been listed under interpretation (1), because it spells the phrase “My people” with a capital letter, referring to the LORD.

1. Verses 5b-7 are a direct quote of the LORD’s words. The quote is marked with quotation marks. Verse 8 is Micah’s words. Interpretation (2) is supported by Hillers (page 44). For example:

^{5a}This is what the Lord says: ^{5b}“As for the prophets who lead my people astray....” ^{7b}They will all cover their faces because there is no answer from God.” ^{8a}But as for me... (NIV) (BSB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT) The NET includes 3:8 in the same paragraph as 3:5-7. In the NCV, NIV, and NLT, 3:8 starts a new paragraph.

1. Verse 3:6 is a direct quote of the LORD’s words. Verses 5, 7, and 8 are Micah’s words. Interpretation (3) is supported by TOTC, Waltke 1993, and Waltke 2007. For example:

⁵My people are deceived by prophets...To these prophets the Lord says, ⁶“Prophets, your day is almost over;...you will not be able to predict anything.” ⁷Those who predict...⁸But as for me,... (GNT) (GNT)

1. Verses 6-7 are a direct quote of the LORD’s words. Verses 5 and 8 are Micah’s words. For example:

⁵You lying prophets...Here is what the Lord says to you prophets: ⁶“You will live in the dark...” ⁷You prophets...no message from me.” ⁸But the Lord has filled me... (CEV) (CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is the simplest. Micah is the speaker in each of the three paragraphs in this section (3:1-12).

The meaning of these verses is almost the same with all four interpretations. Regardless of the quote marks, Micah’s message came to him from the LORD.

His audience understood that he claimed to be the LORD's spokesman.

If you decide not to follow interpretation (1), here are two things that you should consider:

- If you follow interpretation (1), (3), or (4), the phrase "my people" in 3:5a means "Micah's people." But if you follow interpretation (2), it means "the LORD's people."
- If you follow interpretation (2) or (4), the phrase "there is no answer from God" (3:7d) may need to be translated "there is no answer from me."

3:8a-b (combined/reordered)

- But as for me, Yahweh has given me his Spirit. So/Therefore I have the strength and courage to announce his words, and I thoroughly understand the meaning of justice/fairness.

In the BSB and many other versions, the phrases in 3:8a-b are divided into three lines. The Notes have divided them into two lines to make it easier to understand the relationship between the phrases, especially in the Display.

In these lines, Micah listed four qualifications (superscripts ¹⁻⁴) that contrasted him with the wicked prophets:

^{8a}As for me, however, I am ¹filled with power ²by the Spirit of the LORD,

^{8b}³With justice ⁴and courage,

3:8a

As for me, however, I am filled with power by the Spirit of the LORD,

- But as for me, I have great/much power that the Spirit of Yahweh has given me.
- But my situation/status is different. Yahweh has given me the power/strength that comes from his Spirit.
- But I am definitely not like those prophets, because through his Spirit, Yahweh has given me the ability to prophesy.

As for me, however: Micah used this phrase to emphatically contrast his status as a true prophet with the wicked prophets. Here are some other ways to express this strong contrast:

On the other hand (NASB)

Not so with me (NJB)

I am filled with power: Micah used the word filled in a figurative sense. To be filled with power means to have special power, to be very powerful. This verb phrase is also passive.

In some languages, it may be necessary to use an active verb and to make explicit the agent (the one who does the action). Here the implied agent is the LORD. Waltke 2007 (page 167). A&F (page 376) say specifically that "the understood agent is Yahweh. The spirit should not be identified as the agent of the filling (so NICOT)." Some versions make the agent explicit. For example:

But the Lord has filled me with power and with his Spirit. (CEV)

filled with power: This is the first qualification that Micah listed. Here the word power refers primarily to his ability as a prophet to proclaim the message that the LORD gave him. This ability requires inner, moral strength. It can also refer to physical strength and energy, but physical power is not the primary meaning. NAC (pages 78-79) identifies the focus of Micah's empowerment as his prophet ministry. UBS (pages 177-178) says that "power" "implies not only physical strength but moral strength as well." Mays (page 85) says that it's "the power to persevere in the face of opposition and discouragement." Waltke 2007 (page 157) says "it could be translated by 'energy, vigor.'"

by the Spirit of the LORD: This is the second qualification that Micah listed. Versions and commentaries differ as to whether the word Spirit should be spelled with a capital letter. They also differ as to the connection of Spirit or "spirit" with the other qualifications. The Notes will first discuss the spelling of Spirit:

1. The word Spirit should be spelled with a capital letter. When it is spelled this way, it refers to the Holy Spirit, even though the word "Holy" is not explicit. For example:

But as for me, I am filled with power, with the Spirit of the Lord (NIV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NABRE, NASB NCV, NET, NIV, NLT, RSV)

1. The word "spirit" should be spelled with a small letter. When it is spelled this way, it may refer to the power of the LORD or to a special kind of energy. UBS (pages 177-178) says that to be filled with the spirit means to be able to see things from the LORD's

point of view of the way he expects people to live. NICOT (page 314) describes “spirit” as the “extension of Yahweh’s personality...by which his will was communicated to the prophets.” Waltke 2007 (page 166) identifies it as the energy of I AM. For example:

Not so with me, I am full of strength (full of Yahweh’s spirit) (NJB) (KJV, NAB, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include EBC, KD, CBC, ABC, JFB, Barnes, TOTC, and Waltke 1993. Commentaries that support interpretation (2) include A&F, NICOT, WBC, UBS, and Waltke 2007.

The Notes will now discuss the connection of Spirit or “spirit” with the other qualifications:

1. The phrase “with the Spirit/spirit of the LORD” is in a separate category. It is the Spirit/spirit of the LORD that enabled Micah to be filled with the other three qualifications. For example:

But I, I am filled with strength by the spirit of the Lord, and with judgment and courage, (NJPS) (BSB, KJV, NET, NJPS)

1. The phrase “with the Spirit/spirit of the LORD” is one of four equal qualifications. Micah has been filled with or given each of them. For example:

But as for me, I am filled with power, with the Spirit of the Lord, and with justice and might, (NIV) (CEV, ESV, NAB, NCV, NIV, NRSV, GNT)

1. The phrase “with the Spirit/spirit of the LORD” further identifies the word “power.” Micah has also been filled with the other two qualifications. For example:

But as for me, I am filled with power—with the Spirit of the Lord. I am filled with justice and strength (NLT) (GW, NASB, NJB, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) or (2) and that you capitalize the word that you use for Spirit. The Notes will follow interpretation (1). More versions follow interpretation (2), but the Notes will follow interpretation (1). It is more logical to think that Micah’s qualifications as a prophet were all dependent

in some way on his being filled with the Spirit of the LORD. Commentaries that support the idea of the LORD’s Spirit/spirit being on a different level from the other qualifications or gifts include NAC, Barnes, Mays, A&F, TOTC, and Waltke 1993. Waltke 1993 (page 667) says: “Power, justice, and valor are the signs of the Spirit’s presence in Micah.” A&F (page 377) says: “The attributes of power, judgment and might come from (or with) the spirit of Yahweh.”

3:8b with justice and courage,

- Because of him, I know what deeds are just/fair. I have great courage
- He has caused me to know the true meaning of justice, and he has made me very brave.
- He has told me what is right/fair, and I am not afraid to speak his message.

with justice: This is the third qualification that Micah listed. The word justice is the same word that Micah used in 3:1b. (See the note there on “know justice.”) When Micah said that he was “filled...with justice,” he meant that the Spirit of the LORD caused him to thoroughly understand what actions were just, right, and fair. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I am full...of the sense of right (NJB)

He gave me great ability to know what deeds are just and fair.

and courage: This is the fourth qualification that Micah listed. When Micah said that he was “filled...with courage,” he meant that the Spirit of the LORD caused him to have great courage and bravery to announce his message. Even if people opposed Micah, he was not afraid to proclaim the message that the Spirit of the LORD had made known to him. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and might (NRSV)

I have also been given real boldness

3:8c-d (combined/reordered)

- This is the kind of person that Yahweh has caused me to become in order that I will be able to make known to the entire nation of Israel that they have sinned and rebelled against Yahweh.

These two lines are parallel. Notice the parts that are similar in meaning:

^{8c}to declare to Jacob **his transgression**

^{8d}and to Israel **his sin**.

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 3:8d. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing verb from 3:8c. For example:

^{8d}and to declare to Israel **his sin**.

The names “Jacob” and “Israel” refer here to the same people. The words “transgression” and “sin” are similar in meaning. In 1:5a–b, Micah used these same four words. See the notes there.

In 3:8c–d, Micah told the purpose for the qualifications that the LORD had given him. The purpose was so that he would be able to announce his message. Here is another way to translate these lines:

This enables me to confront Jacob with its rebellion, and Israel with its sin. (NET)

to declare: In Hebrew, this verb means “to announce, to report, to tell publicly.”

Jacob...Israel: Micah used the names Jacob and Israel together in 1:5a–b; 2:12a–b, and 3:1a. The name Jacob here represents all the people who are descendants of Jacob. The name Israel represents the people/nation of Israel. Together, these parallel names refer to all the Jews.

transgression...sin: The word transgression refers to disobedience of the law or rebellion against the LORD. The word sin is a general word.

In some languages, it may be clearer to translate the words transgression and sin as verbs. For example:

...to tell the descendants of Jacob that they have transgressed his laws, in other words, to tell the people of Israel that they have sinned.

General Comment on 3:8c–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the parallel parts in these lines. For example:

He gave me these things so that I can tell the entire nation of Israel that they have sinned and rebelled against him.

3:8c to declare to Jacob his transgression

- to announce to the descendants of Jacob that they have broken/disobeyed Yahweh’s laws,
- He gave me these qualities so that I can tell the descendants of Jacob that they have disobeyed Yahweh and rebelled against him.

3:8d and to Israel his sin.

- and to tell the nation/people of Israel that they have sinned.
- Yes, I will be able to announce to the people of Israel that they have done wrong.

Micah 3:9

Section 3:1–12: Micah rebuked the leaders of Israel

In this section, Micah is the speaker. He spoke to the leaders of the Jews and to the prophets. He rebuked (scolded) them for their wicked deeds. He also told them that God would punish the nation because of them.

The Notes will divide this section into three paragraphs:

- In 3:1–4, Micah rebuked the judicial leaders.
- In 3:5–8, Micah rebuked the wicked prophets.
- In 3:9–12, Micah rebuked all the leaders: judges, prophets, and priests.

In each paragraph, Micah used the word “justice” (3:1, 8, 9). In each paragraph, he first rebuked the leaders for their evil deeds. Then he described what would happen as a result of their wickedness. Some versions begin a new paragraph at verse 4 or verse 8. It is recommended that you follow the paragraphs used in the Notes.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Micah Denounces Israel’s Leaders (GNT)

Leaders and Prophets Rebuked (NIV)

Israel’s Sinful Leaders—Rulers, Prophets, and Priests (GW)

Wicked Rulers and Prophets (NRSV)

Paragraph 3:9–12

This paragraph is similar to 3:1–4. Micah again spoke to the leaders of Israel. He specifically included the judicial leaders (verse 9a–b, 11a), priests (verse 11b), and prophets (verse 11c). He told them to listen (verse 9a). He then accused them of behaving wickedly and described the sins of each group (verses 9b–11). Finally, he told them that God would destroy Jerusalem, including the area where the temple was located (verse 12).

3:9a

Now hear this, O leaders of the house of Jacob and rulers of the house of Israel,

- ¶ Listen to this, you^(plur) leaders of the descendants of Jacob! Listen, you rulers of the people of Israel!
- ¶ Pay attention to what I will say, you rulers of Jacob's descendants who serve as judges for the nation of Israel.
- (combined/reordered)
- ¶ Listen to this that I will say/announce, you who rule/lead the Jewish people!
- ¶ You who are leaders/rulers over the people/nation of Israel, listen to what I am going to tell you!

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{9a}Now hear this, O leaders of **the house of Jacob** and rulers of **the house of Israel**,

Now hear this: Micah told the leaders to listen to what he said. The word this probably refers forward to what Micah said in the rest of this paragraph (3:9b–12).

O leaders of the house of Jacob and rulers of the house of Israel: The parallel words leaders and rulers both refer to the judicial leaders. The phrase house of Jacob means “descendants of Jacob.” The phrase house of Israel means “the nation/people of Israel.” Both phrases refer to the same group of people. See the notes on 3:1a.

Verse 3:9a is similar to 3:1a. See the comparison below:

3:1a Then I said: hear now, O leaders of Jacob, you rulers of the house of Israel.

3:9a Now hear this, O leaders of the house of Jacob and rulers of the house of Israel,

In Hebrew, the phrase “of Jacob” in 3:1a has the same meaning as “the house of Jacob” in 3:9a.

Some versions use different words or phrases in 3:1a and 3:9a. For example:

Listen (1a)...Hear (9a) (NRSV)

heads...rulers (1a), rulers...chiefs (9a) (NRSV)

of Jacob...of the house of Israel (1a), of the house of Jacob...of the house of Israel (9a) (NRSV)

You may follow either approach (the same words/phrases or synonyms). Use what is natural in your language.

General Comment on 3:9a

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder some of the parallel parts in this line. For example:

So listen to my message, you rulers of Israel! (CEV)

3:9b

who despise justice and pervert all that is right,

- You^(plur) hate to rule justly. You change everything that is fair and cause it to be unfair.
- You are the kind of leaders who totally dislike treating people fairly. You make crooked everything that is straight.
- You hate making fair decisions. Instead of doing what is right/straight, you always do what is wrong/crooked.

who despise justice and pervert all that is right:

Micah accused these leaders of two things:

despise justice: To despise something means to hate or strongly dislike it. Micah said that these leaders despise justice. They detested ruling in an honest and fair way. They hated to make fair decisions.

justice: Micah used this same word in 3:1b and 3:8b. See the Notes on 3:1b about justice.

pervert all that is right: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “you who make crooked everything that is straight.” Micah used the words “crooked” and “straight” in a figurative (moral) sense. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

You do not act in straight ways. You always act in crooked ways.

You always behave dishonestly, not honestly.

Micah 3:10

Section 3:1–12: Micah rebuked the leaders of Israel

In this section, Micah is the speaker. He spoke to the leaders of the Jews and to the prophets. He rebuked (scolded) them for their wicked deeds. He also told them that God would punish the nation because of them.

The Notes will divide this section into three paragraphs:

- In 3:1–4, Micah rebuked the judicial leaders.
- In 3:5–8, Micah rebuked the wicked prophets.
- In 3:9–12, Micah rebuked all the leaders: judges, prophets, and priests.

In each paragraph, Micah used the word “justice” (3:1, 8, 9). In each paragraph, he first rebuked the leaders for their evil deeds. Then he described what would happen as a result of their wickedness. Some versions begin a new paragraph at verse 4 or verse 8. It is recommended that you follow the paragraphs used in the Notes.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Micah Denounces Israel’s Leaders (GNT)

Leaders and Prophets Rebuked (NIV)

Israel’s Sinful Leaders—Rulers, Prophets, and Priests (GW)

Wicked Rulers and Prophets (NRSV)

Paragraph 3:9–12

This paragraph is similar to 3:1–4. Micah again spoke to the leaders of Israel. He specifically included the judicial leaders (verse 9a–b, 11a), priests (verse 11b), and prophets (verse 11c). He told them to listen (verse 9a). He then accused them of behaving wickedly and described the sins of each group (verses 9b–11). Finally, he told them that God would destroy Jerusalem, including the area where the temple was located (verse 12).

3:10a–b

who build Zion with bloodshed and Jerusalem with iniquity.

- You^(plur) build things in Zion by murdering/hurting people. You build things in Jerusalem by acting wickedly.

- You build buildings and other things in Zion, whose name is also Jerusalem. But as you do it, you hurt people and do other wicked things.
- You build things in Jerusalem, God’s city, but you treat people violently and wickedly in order to finish the work of building.
- As you work to make new buildings in Jerusalem, you murder/oppress people and you commit other crimes.

This verse has two parallel lines:

^{10a}who build Zion with **bloodshed**

^{10b}and Jerusalem with **iniquity**.

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted word) in 3:10b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing verb from 3:10a. For example:

^{10b}and build Jerusalem with **iniquity**.

build: The word build usually refers to making a house, a building, a wall, etc. Micah said that these leaders built “Zion” and “Jerusalem.” This probably means that they built new buildings or other structures in the city, or they improved old buildings. EBC (page 521) speak of the leaders “discharging their duties...with bloodshed and greed.” Other commentaries understand literal building. Almost all English versions translate the word build literally. One that does not is the CEV: “You make cruelty and murder a way of life in Jerusalem.” It does not mean that they built the entire city.

Zion...Jerusalem: In this verse, the names Zion and Jerusalem are parallel names that refer to the same city. The name Zion originally referred to one area of Jerusalem. There were one or more hills in that area. The temple was built in the area of Jerusalem called Zion. King David also built his palace in Zion. In the Old Testament, the name Zion is often used as a poetic name for Jerusalem (or God’s people). Here are some ways to translate these names:

- Translate both names. For example:

who build Zion with bloodshed, and Jerusalem with violent injustice (NASB)

- Translate both names and supply a footnote that explains the meaning. For example:

You^(plur) build things in Zion by treating people violently. You build things in Jerusalem by acting wickedly. [footnote: **Zion** is another name for **Jerusalem**.]

- Make it clear in your translation that Zion and Jerusalem are the same city. For example:

You build up the city of Zion, that is, Jerusalem. But you do it by hurting people and doing other wicked things.

- Combine the names Zion and Jerusalem into one name. For example:

You are building God's city, Jerusalem, on a foundation of murder and injustice. (GNT)

You build Jerusalem by murdering people; you build it with evil. (NCV)

with bloodshed...with iniquity: These two phrases describe the manner in which the leaders constructed buildings in the city. They built them by treating people violently and by treating people wickedly.

with bloodshed: Here the phrase with bloodshed is a figure of speech. It means "by treating people violently." It refers to actions like oppressing, hurting, and murdering people.

iniquity: In Hebrew, this word means "injustice" or "wickedness." Here are some other ways to translate it:

injustice (GNT)

violent deeds of injustice (NET)

wickedness (NIV)

cruelty (CEV)

General Comment on 3:10a–b

There are at least two ways to translate these parallel lines:

- Translate each line separately. For example:

who build Zion with bloodshed, and Jerusalem with wickedness (NIV)

You^(plur) treat people violently as you construct buildings in Zion. You do wicked deeds as you construct them in Jerusalem.

- Combine the two lines. For example:

You build the city of Jerusalem by treating people violently and wickedly.

You are building Jerusalem on a foundation of murder and corruption. (NLT)

Micah 3:11

Section 3:1–12: Micah rebuked the leaders of Israel

In this section, Micah is the speaker. He spoke to the leaders of the Jews and to the prophets. He rebuked (scolded) them for their wicked deeds. He also told them that God would punish the nation because of them.

The Notes will divide this section into three paragraphs:

- In 3:1–4, Micah rebuked the judicial leaders.
- In 3:5–8, Micah rebuked the wicked prophets.
- In 3:9–12, Micah rebuked all the leaders: judges, prophets, and priests.

In each paragraph, Micah used the word "justice" (3:1, 8, 9). In each paragraph, he first rebuked the leaders for their evil deeds. Then he described what would happen as a result of their wickedness. Some versions begin a new paragraph at verse 4 or verse 8. It is recommended that you follow the paragraphs used in the Notes.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Micah Denounces Israel's Leaders (GNT)

Leaders and Prophets Rebuked (NIV)

Israel's Sinful Leaders—Rulers, Prophets, and Priests (GW)

Wicked Rulers and Prophets (NRSV)

Paragraph 3:9–12

This paragraph is similar to 3:1–4. Micah again spoke to the leaders of Israel. He specifically included the judicial leaders (verse 9a–b, 11a), priests (verse 11b), and prophets (verse 11c). He told them to listen (verse 9a). He then accused them of behaving wickedly and

described the sins of each group (verses 9b-11). Finally, he told them that God would destroy Jerusalem, including the area where the temple was located (verse 12).

3:11

In verses 9 and 10, Micah spoke to the leaders of Israel (“you”). Here in verse 11, he spoke about these leaders (“they”).

3:11a-c

The first three lines of this verse are parallel:

^{11a}Her leaders judge for a **bribe**,

^{11b}her priests teach for a **price**,

^{11c}and her prophets practice divination for **money**.

Micah talked about three kinds of leaders: leaders (government rulers or judges), priests, and prophets.

The words “**bribe**,” “**price**,” and “**money**” all refer to money. All of these leaders acted in evil ways in order to get money.

3:11a

Her leaders judge for a bribe,

- The city’s leaders accept bribes when they decide court cases.
- Those who are chiefs in Jerusalem take bribes when they judge the people.
- The judges in Jerusalem make dishonest decisions if people give them money.
- When the judges in Jerusalem listen to a dispute, they do not make fair decisions. They make decisions that favor the person who gives them money.

Her leaders judge for a bribe: The first type of leaders that Micah spoke about was the leaders of the city.

Her leaders: The word leaders means “rulers” or “judges.” Micah used the same word here in 3:11a as in 3:1a and 3:9a. It is suggested that you translate it the same way in all three verses.

Her: The pronoun Her occurs three times in 3:11a-c. It refers to Jerusalem. Here are some ways you can translate the phrase “her rulers”:

The city’s leaders

The leaders in Jerusalem

Those who lead the people there

judge: This means “decide a legal case.” These leaders worked as judges. For example, perhaps two men both claimed that they owned the same field. The leaders listened to their disagreement and decided who was right and who was wrong.

for a bribe: A bribe is money that a person gives to a judge or other official. The person expects that the judge will decide the case in his favor, even if the decision is dishonest. Here are some other ways to translate “judge for a bribe”:

give verdicts for presents (NJB)

take bribes when they decide legal cases (NET)

take money to decide who wins in court (NCV)

Here is a way to translate 3:11a that makes explicit some of the implied information:

When the judges in Jerusalem listen to a dispute, they do not make fair decisions. Instead, they make decisions that favor the person who gives them a bribe/money.

3:11b

her priests teach for a price,

- The priests in the city teach people who pay them.
- The priests in Jerusalem teach God’s laws only to the people who give them money.

her priests teach for a price: The second type of leaders that Micah spoke about was the priests in Jerusalem.

teach: The duty of the priests was to teach the people about God’s laws. In their teaching, they explained the meaning of the laws and instructed the people about the right way to live. There are two ways to interpret the word teach here:

1. It means “teach or instruct.” For example:

her priests instruct (NASB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NLT, NRSV, GNT)

1. It means “give a ruling, verdict, or decision.” For example:

her priests give rulings (REB) (NAB, NET, NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most English versions, BART, the Syriac, and the Vulgate. NAC (pages 80–81) mentions that the duties of the priests included not only teaching the laws in the Torah but also deciding controversies that were too difficult for local courts to decide (Deuteronomy 17:9, 11). UBS (pages 180–182) and JFB (page 691) are among the commentaries that also mention this secondary duty of the priests. However, you may want to add a footnote such as the following:

Sometimes the priests were also asked to decide legal cases that were too difficult for the local courts to decide. See Deuteronomy 17:8–11.

for a price: This means that the priests fulfilled their duty if the people paid them.

Here are some other ways to translate 3:11b:

her priests instruct for a price (NASB)

the priests interpret the Law for pay (GNT)

3:11c

and her prophets practice divination for money.

- The prophets in the city predict the future to people who pay them.
- The prophets in Jerusalem give advice only to people who give them money.
- The prophets in the city interpret omens and predict fortunes if people pay them.

her prophets practice divination for money: The third type of leaders that Micah spoke about was the prophets in Jerusalem.

practice divination: In Hebrew, this phrase is the verb “divine.” It is related to the word “diviners” in 3:7b. It means “predict the future, tell fortunes, or read omens.”

for money: If a Jewish person had a problem, he or she might go to a prophet for help. Micah accused the prophets in Jerusalem of helping only people who paid them money.

Here are some other ways to translate 3:11c:

its prophets give oracles for money (NRSV)

and her prophets read omens for pay (NET)

the prophets give their revelations for money (GNT)

3:11d

Yet they lean upon the LORD, saying,

- But all these leaders trust in Yahweh, saying,
- But even though they do these wicked things, these leaders all depend on Yahweh to help/protect them. This is what they say, but they are mistaken:

Yet they lean upon the LORD: The word Yet introduces an unexpected contrast. Normally, wicked leaders do not rely on the LORD for his help, but these wicked leaders expected that the LORD would rescue them. Almost all English versions introduce this contrast with “but” or “yet.”

In some languages, it may be helpful to make the implied reasoning explicit. For example:

But even though they do those wicked things, nevertheless they depend on the LORD to rescue them from trouble.

they: The pronoun they refers to all of the three groups mentioned in 3:11a–c: the leaders, priests and prophets. It does not refer only to the prophets. In some languages, it may be necessary to clarify who the pronoun refers to. For example:

and they all claim that the Lord is with them (GNT)

lean upon the LORD: This phrase means to “trust in” or “depend on” the LORD. In languages that do not use a verb such as “trust” or “depend,” it may be possible to express the meaning by using a direct quote. For example:

But all of these leaders say, “The LORD will protect us.”

saying: Some versions use the word “claim” here. For example:

Yet they claim to trust the Lord (NET)

and they all claim that the Lord is with them (GNT)

In this context, the word “claim” means “confidently say” or “assert.”

3:11e

“Is not the LORD among us?”

- “Is it not true that Yahweh is with/among us?^(incl)
- Yahweh is indeed/certainly on our side!

Is not the LORD among us?: In this verse part, Micah quoted what the leaders said. They said this because the temple was in Jerusalem, and they thought that the LORD’s presence was in his temple.

This is a rhetorical question. The function of this rhetorical question was to express their certainty that the LORD was indeed in their midst.

Here are some other ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

“Is not the Lord in the midst of us? (ESV)

The LORD is with us, is that not true?

- As a statement. For example:

“After all, the Lord is with us. (GW)

“The Lord is on our side. (CEV)

3:11e–f (combined/reordered)

- “Nothing bad will happen to us, because Yahweh lives here with us.”
- “Yahweh lives with us here in this city, so we cannot possibly experience any harm/disaster.”

3:11f

No disaster can come upon us.”

- No disaster/harm will happen/come to us^(incl).”
- So of course we will not experience anything bad/harmful!”

No disaster can come upon us: The leaders in Jerusalem did not believe Micah’s prophecy that the LORD would destroy the city (3:12). They thought that nothing bad would happen to them. Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

No disaster is going to overtake us.” (NJB)

No harm will come to us.” (CEV)

Nothing bad will happen to us.” (GW)

General Comment on 3:11e–f

In some languages, it may be clearer or more natural to reorder these verse parts and/or to make explicit the logical connection between them. For example:

“Nothing will harm us^(incl), because the LORD is here among us.”

“The LORD lives with us^(incl) here in this city, so we cannot possibly experience any harm.”

General Comment on 3:11

In 3:9–10 and in 3:12, Micah spoke to the leaders (“you”). But in 3:11, he spoke about the leaders (“they”). In some languages, it may be clearer to use the pronoun “you” in 3:11 as well as in the surrounding verses. For example:

^{3:11}You rulers make decisions based on bribes; you priests teach God’s laws only for a price; you prophets won’t prophesy unless you are paid. Yet all of you claim you are depending on the Lord. “No harm can come to us,” you say, “for the Lord is here among us.” (NLT)

You leaders accept bribes for dishonest decisions. You priests and prophets teach and preach, but only for money. Then you say, “The Lord is on our side. No harm will come to us.” (CEV)

Micah 3:12

Section 3:1–12: Micah rebuked the leaders of Israel

In this section, Micah is the speaker. He spoke to the leaders of the Jews and to the prophets. He rebuked (scolded) them for their wicked deeds. He also told them that God would punish the nation because of them.

The Notes will divide this section into three paragraphs:

- In 3:1–4, Micah rebuked the judicial leaders.
- In 3:5–8, Micah rebuked the wicked prophets.
- In 3:9–12, Micah rebuked all the leaders: judges, prophets, and priests.

In each paragraph, Micah used the word “justice” (3:1, 8, 9). In each paragraph, he first rebuked the leaders for their evil deeds. Then he described what would happen as a result of their wickedness. Some versions begin a new paragraph at verse 4 or verse 8. It is recommended that you follow the paragraphs used in the Notes.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Micah Denounces Israel's Leaders (GNT)

Leaders and Prophets Rebuked (NIV)

Israel's Sinful Leaders—Rulers, Prophets, and Priests (GW)

Wicked Rulers and Prophets (NRSV)

Paragraph 3:9–12

This paragraph is similar to 3:1–4. Micah again spoke to the leaders of Israel. He specifically included the judicial leaders (verse 9a–b, 11a), priests (verse 11b), and prophets (verse 11c). He told them to listen (verse 9a). He then accused them of behaving wickedly and described the sins of each group (verses 9b–11). Finally, he told them that God would destroy Jerusalem, including the area where the temple was located (verse 12).

3:12

In this verse, Micah again spoke to the leaders. He told them that because of their evil deeds, a terrible thing would happen. This verse is similar to 1:6. In that verse, the LORD said that Samaria (the capital of the northern kingdom) would be destroyed. Here in 3:12, Micah said that Jerusalem (the capital of the southern kingdom) would be destroyed, along with the temple.

3:12a–d

This verse is introduced by a phrase in 12a that connects the preceding verses (3:9–11) to three parallel lines that follow:

^{12a}Therefore, because of you,

^{12b} Zion **will be plowed like a field**,

^{12c} Jerusalem **will become a heap of rubble**,

^{12d}and the temple mount **a wooded ridge**.

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 3:12d. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing verb from 3:12c. For example:

^{12d}and the temple mount shall become **a wooded ridge**.

In each of the parallel lines (12b–12d), the parts in bold print describe what will happen to the underlined parts.

3:12a

Therefore, because of you,

- Therefore, because of your^(plur) wicked deeds,
- And so, because you have done those things,

Therefore, because of you: This phrase introduces the result of the sins of the leaders described in 3:9–11. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

That is why, on account of you,...

And so, because of you,... (GNT)

Because of you,... (NCV)

This is what will happen because of your sins:

3:12b

Zion will be plowed like a field,

- Zion will become like a field that people plow.
- in the future the city of Zion will no longer be a city. It will become farmland where people plow the ground and plant crops.

Zion will be plowed like a field: This verse part is a simile. It means that Zion will be plowed in the same way as a field is plowed. In the future, Zion will no longer be a city with buildings and houses. People will plow the ground to plant crops there.

Zion: In 1:13 and 3:10, Micah used the name Zion as another name for Jerusalem. Here in 3:12b, it is probably also another name for Jerusalem. Almost all commentaries say that in this verse, the names Zion and Jerusalem are synonymous, and the phrase “the temple mount” refers to the area in Jerusalem where the temple was located. See Waltke 2007 (pages 182–183) for a summary of “the three aspects of Jerusalem’s complex situation.” KD (page 318) disagrees. He says that “Zion is that portion of the city which contained the royal palace, and Jerusalem the rest of the city.”

plowed: Micah said that people will plow the ground where the city of Zion (Jerusalem) was. In languages that do not have a term for plowing, it may be possible to use a more generic term. For example:

Zion will become like a field that people farm.

...like a field where people plant crops.

In some languages, it may be helpful to make explicit some information about Zion. For example:

in the future Zion will no longer be a city. It will become like a field that people plow.

If a simile here is not natural in your language, you may translate the meaning directly. For example:

Zion will become a ploughed field (REB)

Jerusalem will be plowed under (CEV)

field: In Hebrew, this word refers to open land in contrast to land that has a city or forest on it. Here it refers specifically to farmland, a field for growing crops. The same Hebrew word is used in 1:6a (“open country”) and 2:2a (“fields”).

3:12c

Jerusalem will become a heap of rubble,

- Yes, the city of Jerusalem will become piles of broken rocks, bricks, and other rubble/debris.
- People will destroy the city of Jerusalem so that no walls or buildings remain,

Jerusalem will become a heap of rubble: Micah said that the city of Jerusalem will become a heap of rubble. It is implied that an enemy army will destroy the buildings and walls. Only a heap of rubble will be left.

a heap of rubble: In Hebrew, the phrase a heap of rubble is a single word. It refers to a pile of broken rocks, bricks, wood, and other debris/residue that is left after the buildings and walls of a city are destroyed. Micah used the same word in 1:6a (“heap”). Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

reduced to ruins (NLT)

a pile of ruins (GNT)

left in ruins (CEV)

3:12d

and the temple mount a wooded ridge.

- The hill on which the temple now stands will be overgrown/covered with bushes and small trees.

- and thickets/brush will grow on the hill where the temple is now located.

and the temple mount: In Hebrew, this is literally “the mountain/hill of the house.” The word “house” here refers to the temple, the house of the LORD. The temple was on top of a hill in Jerusalem. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the mountain of the house (NRSV)

the mountain where the temple now stands (CEV)

the hill on which the Temple stands (NCV)

a wooded ridge: Micah said that the hill on which the temple stood will become a wooded ridge. This implies that the temple will first be destroyed. It will no longer exist.

The phrase a wooded ridge refers to a hilltop that has small trees and bushes growing on it. TWOT (#888a) defines the Hebrew word as “forest, woods, thicket.” It comments about Micah 3:12 that “the mountain of the temple will become high places of a forest, i.e. thick and overgrown.” ABC (page 1079) says: the hill on which it stood will be overgrown with weeds.” NICOT (page 316) calls it “a scrub-covered hill.” KD (page 318) says: “the ground upon which the city stood will be partly used as a ploughed field, and partly overgrown with bushes.” It probably does not refer to a forest with large trees.

Here are some other ways to translate 3:12d in English:

and the temple mount will become a hill overgrown with brush (NET)

and the hill on which the Temple stands will be covered with bushes (NCV)

A thicket will grow on the heights where the Temple now stands. (NLT)

General Comment (1) on 3:12

The phrase “Therefore because of you” gives the reason that these terrible things will happen to Jerusalem. In some languages, it may be clearer to put this phrase at the end of the verse. For example:

So in the future, Zion will become farmland that people plow. People will destroy Jerusalem so

that it becomes a heap of ruins. Thickets will grow on the hill where the temple used to be. All this will happen because of your wicked deeds.

General Comment (2) on 3:12

Verse 12c talks about the buildings and other structures in Jerusalem: they will become piles of rubble. Verse parts 12b and 12d talk about the land in Jerusalem: some will become farmland, and shrubs will grow on the temple hill. If it is clearer in your language, you can rearrange the verse parts so that 12b and 12d are together. For example:

^{12a}And so, because of your wicked deeds, ^{12c}people will destroy Jerusalem so that it becomes a pile of rubble. ^{12b}Zion will become farmland that people plow, ^{12d}and bushes will grow on the hill where the temple used to be.

Micah 4:1

Section 4:1–8: The LORD will rule the world as King from Jerusalem and cause all nations to be at peace

In the last verse of chapter 3, Micah described the destruction that would happen to the temple and to all of Jerusalem. But here in 4:1–8, he described the future importance of the city and the many good things that will result when the LORD rules as King over all the nations from that city.

The Notes have divided this section into two paragraphs (4:1–5 and 4:6–8) with one section heading. Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord's Future Reign (NLT)

The future reign of Yahweh in Zion (NJB)

The Lord Will Teach the Nations (GW)

Some versions use two section headings, one for 4:1–5 and another for 4:6ff. For example:

^{1–5}Peace and Security through Obedience

^{6ff}Restoration Promised after Exile (NRSV)

^{1–5}The Lord's Universal Reign of Peace

^{6ff}Israel Will Return from Exile (GNT)

^{1–5}Better Days Ahead for Jerusalem

^{6ff}Restoration Will Follow Crisis (NET)

You may use one or more section headings in your language.

Some versions, including the GNT and NRSV, make verse 5 a separate paragraph. Some versions, including the NRSV and NJB, make verse 8 a separate paragraph. Divide the paragraphs in a natural way in your language.

Paragraph 4:1–5

Here is a summary of Micah's predictions in this paragraph:

1. (4:1a–c) The temple hill will become higher than other mountains and hills.
2. (4:1d–2) Many people will go there to learn about God.
3. (4:3–4) God will rule the world from Jerusalem. He will cause all nations to be at peace with one another.
4. (4:5) Even though the people of other nations follow their own gods, the people of Israel will follow the LORD forever.

The first three verses in this paragraph are very similar to Isaiah 2:2–4. If you have already translated Isaiah, you will want to translate these verses in a similar way.

4:1a

In the last days

- ¶ In the future,
- ¶ This is what will happen at a later time:

In the last days: This phrase means “in the future.” The phrase “latter days” is a phrase that Old Testament prophets used when they predicted what would happen in the future. For example, Genesis 49:1; Numbers 24:14; Deuteronomy 4:30; Daniel 10:14; Hosea 3:5. It does not necessarily refer to the time near the “end of the world.” Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

In days to come (NRSV)

In the future (NET)

4:1b–c

These two lines are parallel. Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{1b}the mountain of the house of the LORD will be established as **the chief of the mountains**;

^{1c}it will be raised **above the hills**,

These verse parts do not refer to separate things that the LORD will do. In some languages, it may be better to combine these two verse parts. For example:

The LORD will raise up the mountain where his temple is so that it becomes higher than all the other hills and mountains. (4:1b–c)

4:1b the mountain of the house of the LORD will be established as the chief of the mountains;

- the mountain that is the location of Yahweh's house will become the highest mountain.
- The mountain on which the temple of Yahweh stands will become higher than all the other mountains.

the mountain of the house of the LORD: This refers to the hill in Jerusalem on which the temple was located. Verse 3:12c refers to the same place.

will be established as the chief of the mountains: Most English versions translate the verb will be established in one of two ways.

- Some versions translate it as “will be” or “will become.”

...the mountain where the Temple stands will be the highest one of all. (GNT)

...the mountain on which the Lord's Temple stands will become the most important of all mountains. (NCV) (GNT NJB, CEV, NCV, NLT, NET)

- Some versions translate it with a passive verb: “shall/will be established.”

...the mountain of the Lord's house will be established higher than all other mountains. (REB) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NIV, NRSV, REB)

You can follow either option in your translation. The first option is probably simpler.

With the second option, the implied agent is the LORD. It is he who will establish the temple mountain as the

highest mountain. You can make the agent explicit if it is necessary in your language. For example:

In the future, the LORD will cause the mountain where his temple is located to become the highest mountain.

4:1c it will be raised above the hills,

- It will become higher than other hills.
- He/Yahweh will raise it up so it becomes taller than all the other mountains and hills.

it will be raised above the hills: As with the parallel line 4:1b, English versions translate the verb will be raised above in one of two ways. You may follow either option. If you chose the simpler option in 4:1b, it will probably be better to choose the same option here. Use an intransitive verb such as “rise.” For example:

rise higher than the hills (NJB)

towering above other hills (REB)

It will rise up until it is taller than all the other hills.

General Comment on 4:1b–c

The hill where the temple was located was not a very high hill. There were other hills and mountains near Jerusalem that were higher. But in these two verse parts, Micah said that in the future the temple mountain will become higher than other mountains and hills.

So some versions and commentaries understand the words “higher/highest” to mean “higher/highest in importance, not in altitude.” NAC (pages 83–84) thinks that “Mount Zion and its temple will be elevated probably both physically and in prominence.” Waltke 2007 also acknowledges both aspects. But EBC (page 524) says: “Its greatness has nothing to do with its present physical features (it is, after all, a relatively small mountain), but rather with God's choice of it as his place of earthly dwelling.” UBS (page 186) says that the statement in v.1 “undoubtedly has a spiritual significance.” JFB (page 691) says that “its elevation is to be not that of situation, but of moral dignity, as the seat of God's universal empire.” ABC (page 1079) uses similar wording. KD (pages 309–310) says: “This exaltation is of course not a physical one...but a spiritual (ethical) elevation above all the mountains. This is obvious from v. 2, according to which Zion will

tower above all the mountains, because the law of the Lord issues from it.” The NCV (quoted above) is one example. Here are some other examples:

...the Temple of the Lord in Jerusalem will become the most important place on earth. (NLT96)

it will be more prominent than other hills (NET)

...the mountain of the Lord’s temple will be established as chief among the mountains (NIV)

Versions and commentaries are divided as to whether the height of the mountain refers to physical altitude or importance as the center of the Lord’s rule. You may translate either way. If your readers understand your translation to refer to physical/literal altitude, it is suggested that you supply a footnote that gives the other meaning. For example:

In the future, the mountain of the LORD’s house will become higher than all other mountains and hills. [footnote: This may mean that the temple in Jerusalem will become the most important place on earth.]

If your translation clearly refers to importance, it is suggested that you supply a footnote that gives the other possible meaning. For example:

In the future, the mountain where the LORD’s temple is located will be more important than any other place on earth. [footnote: In Hebrew, this literally says: “...will be higher than all other mountains and hills.”]

4:1d–2a

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{1d}and the peoples **will stream** to it.

^{2a}And many nations **will come** and say:

The terms “peoples” and “many nations” refer to the same people. The verbs “will stream” and “will come” refer to the same action.

4:1d

and the peoples will stream to it.

- Groups of people will continually come/go there.

- People from many nations will come daily to it just like the water in a river keeps flowing continually.
- People from everywhere in the world will make pilgrimages to that place.

peoples: The plural form here refers to people from many places. Some versions, as the NET, use the singular form “people.” Here are some other ways to express the meaning:

people from other nations (NCV)

people from all over the world (NLT96)

will stream to it: This is a metaphor. It compares people to water that streams or flows continuously in a river. It means that many people will keep coming to Jerusalem day after day.

In English, this is a common figure of speech, so many versions translate it literally. For example:

...peoples shall flow to it (ESV)

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Change it to a simile. For example:

People from many nations will keep coming to Jerusalem just like the water in a river keeps flowing continually.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

People from other countries will continually come/go to visit Jerusalem. If your language has a special term for people making a pilgrimage, you may want to use that here.

it: This refers to “the mountain of the LORD’s house” in verse 1a. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

there

to that mountain

to Jerusalem

Micah 4:2

Section 4:1–8: The LORD will rule the world as King from Jerusalem and cause all nations to be at peace

In the last verse of chapter 3, Micah described the destruction that would happen to the temple and to all of Jerusalem. But here in 4:1–8, he described the future importance of the city and the many good things that will result when the LORD rules as King over all the nations from that city.

The Notes have divided this section into two paragraphs (4:1–5 and 4:6–8) with one section heading. Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord's Future Reign (NLT)

The future reign of Yahweh in Zion (NJB)

The Lord Will Teach the Nations (GW)

Some versions use two section headings, one for 4:1–5 and another for 4:6ff. For example:

^{1–5}Peace and Security through Obedience

^{6ff}Restoration Promised after Exile (NRSV)

^{1–5}The Lord's Universal Reign of Peace

^{6ff}Israel Will Return from Exile (GNT)

^{1–5}Better Days Ahead for Jerusalem

^{6ff}Restoration Will Follow Crisis (NET)

You may use one or more section headings in your language.

Some versions, including the GNT and NRSV, make verse 5 a separate paragraph. Some versions, including the NRSV and NJB, make verse 8 a separate paragraph. Divide the paragraphs in a natural way in your language.

Paragraph 4:1–5

Here is a summary of Micah's predictions in this paragraph:

1. (4:1a–c) The temple hill will become higher than other mountains and hills.

2. (4:1d–2) Many people will go there to learn about God.
3. (4:3–4) God will rule the world from Jerusalem. He will cause all nations to be at peace with one another.
4. (4:5) Even though the people of other nations follow their own gods, the people of Israel will follow the LORD forever.

The first three verses in this paragraph are very similar to Isaiah 2:2–4. If you have already translated Isaiah, you will want to translate these verses in a similar way.

4:2a

And many nations will come and say:

- Yes, people from many nations will come there and say:
- These people will come to that mountain/temple. They will say to each other:

And many nations will come: This verse part means that people from many countries will come to Jerusalem. In some languages, it may be better to combine 4:1d and 4:2a. For example:

Day after day people from many countries will come there

and say: These words introduce Micah's quote of what the people will say to each other. Here are some other ways to introduce this quote:

This is what they will say to each other:

They will speak to each other, saying:

4:2b–e

There are two interpretations about the verse parts in which Micah quoted the people:

1. Micah quoted the people in 4:2b–e. Notice the closed quotes after 2e. For example:

^{2b} “Come on! Let's go up to the Lord's mountain,

^{2c} to the temple of Jacob's God,

^{2d} so he can teach us his commands

^{2e} and we can live by his laws.”

^{2f}For Zion will be the source of instruction;

^{2g}the Lord's teachings will proceed from Jerusalem. (NET) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. Micah quoted the people in 4:2b–g. For example:

^{2b} “Let us go up the hill of the Lord,

^{2c}to the Temple of Israel's God.

^{2d}He will teach us what he wants us to do;

^{2e}we will walk in the paths he has chosen.

^{2f}For the Lord's teaching comes from Jerusalem;

^{2g}from Zion he speaks to his people.” (GNT) (NJB, GNT)

According to interpretation (1), Micah does not quote the people in 4:2f–g. These two lines are his own explanation. According to interpretation (2), Micah quotes the people throughout 4:2b–g.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most English versions. There is almost no difference in meaning between these two interpretations.

4:2b–c (combined/reordered)

- “Come^(plur) with us^(excl) to the house/temple that is on Yahweh's mountain in Jerusalem.

These two lines are parallel. Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{2b}Come, let us go up to the mountain **of the LORD**,

^{2c} to the house **of the God of Jacob**.

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 4:2c. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing verb from 4:2b. For example:

^{2c} let us go up to the house **of the God of Jacob**.

In these two parallel lines (2b–c), the second line is more specific than the first. The people wanted to

go “to the mountain of the LORD.” Specifically, they wanted to go “to the house” (temple) that was on that mountain.

4:2b

“Come, let us go up to the mountain of the LORD,

- “Come^(plur) with us^(excl)! Let us^(incl) go to Yahweh's mountain.
- “Let us^(incl) go to the mountain in Jerusalem that Yahweh has chosen.

Come, let us go up to the mountain of the LORD:

The people from other nations who will say these words urged or invited other people to go with them to Jerusalem.

The two verbs Come and let us go up refer to the same action. The first verb functions primarily to introduce the second verb and to add emphasis. It does not imply that the people should first come to a particular location and then set out on the journey to Jerusalem. Here are some other ways to translate these two verbs:

Let's go to the mountain of the Lord (GW)

We^(excl) are going to the mountain where God's house is. You^(plur) come with us^(excl)!

Hey! Let us^(incl) go...

go up to the mountain...: These people may have spoken about going up to Jerusalem because the main part of Jerusalem was on top of some hills, or perhaps they were intending to honor the city. If it is more natural in your language, you can translate this simply as “go,” as in the GW quoted above.

of the LORD: This phrase has the same meaning as it does in the phrase “the mountain of the house of the LORD” in 4:1b. Here are some other ways to translate it:

where the LORD lives

where the LORD's temple is

4:2c

to the house of the God of Jacob.

- We^(incl) will go to the house/temple where the descendants of Jacob worship God,
- Let us go to the temple there. That is the place where the Jewish people worship God.

to the house of the God of Jacob: There are two main ways to translate the name God of Jacob:

- Use the name “Jacob.” For example:

the God of Jacob (NIV)

the God whom Jacob worshiped

- Use the name “Israel.” (Israel was another name for the man Jacob, and Jacob’s descendants were called the people of Israel or Israelites.) For example:

the God of Israel (NLT96)

Israel’s God (GNT)

the God whom the Israelite people worship

If you follow the second option, you may want to give the more literal wording in a footnote. For example:

the God whom the Israelite people worship [footnote: literally, the God of Jacob].

General Comment on 4:2b–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or rearrange the parts in these two parallel lines. For example:

“Come, let’s go to the house of the God of Jacob, which is on the mountain of the LORD.

4:2d–e

In both these parallel lines, the people told their purpose for going to Jerusalem:

^{2d}He will teach us His ways,

^{2e}so that we may walk in His paths.”

Here are some ways to express this purpose:

- Introduce 4:2d and/or 4:2e with a linking word or phrase like “that” or “so that.” For example:

^{2d} that he may instruct us in his ways,

^{2e} that we may walk in his paths.” (NAB)

^{2d} so that he can teach us his ways,

^{2e} and we can obey his teachings.” (NCV)

- Begin a new sentence here at 4:2d. In some languages, it may be more natural to leave the purpose implied. For example:

^{2d}He will teach us what he wants us to do;

^{2e}we will walk in the paths he has chosen. (GNT)

4:2d

He will teach us His ways,

- so that he will teach us^(incl) his commands
- There he will teach us the way he wants us to live/ behave,

He will teach us His ways: The word ways is an idiom. The Hebrew word used here is often translated “road.” God’s ways means “the ways/manner God wants people to live.” For example:

so that he can teach us his commands (NET)

4:2e

so that we may walk in His paths.”

- and we^(incl) can then obey them.”
- and we will live/behave that way.”

so that we may walk in His paths: The phrase His paths is a synonym of the phrase “His ways.” The phrase walk in His paths is also an idiom. To walk in God’s paths means “to follow his commands” or “to live the way that God wants.” For example:

and we can live by his laws (NET)

4:2f–g

(combined/reordered)

- For it is from Zion, which is also named Jerusalem, that Yahweh will cause people to learn his words that he will teach them.

In these two parallel verse parts, Micah explained the reason people will go to Jerusalem. Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning. Notice also that the parallel parts occur in the form of a chiasm (opposite order) in the two lines:

^{2f}For the law will go forth **from Zion**

^{2g}and the word of the LORD **from Jerusalem.**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) of the verb in 4:2g. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing verb from 4:2f. For example:

^{2g}and the word of the LORD shall go forth **from Jerusalem.**

For: This word introduces the reason that people will go to Jerusalem. In some languages, it may be more natural to leave the reason implied. For an example, see the NCV quoted below.

from Zion...from Jerusalem: Here are two ways to translate these parallel names:

- Translate the names separately. For example:

^{2f}For Zion will be the source of instruction;

^{2g}the Lord's teachings will proceed from Jerusalem. (NET)

- Translate the names separately, but make it clear that both names refer to the same city. For example:

^{2f}For the Lord will teach people from Zion.

^{2g} That is, he will utter his words from Jerusalem.

- Translate only one of the names to make it clear that Micah referred to one city, not two. For example:

^{2f}His teachings will go out from Jerusalem,

^{2g}the word of the Lord from that city. (NCV)

In Hebrew, these two phrases are emphatic. It will be "out of Zion/Jerusalem" that the LORD will instruct people and make known to them his word. Here are some ways to express this emphasis:

^{2f} Zion will be the place where the LORD teaches people his laws.

^{2g} It is from Jerusalem that the LORD will tell people his words.

4:2f

For the law will go forth from Zion

- For/Because Zion will be the source of Yahweh's teaching/instruction.
- The reason they will go there is because Zion will be the place from which Yahweh will teach people.
- It is from Zion that people will learn what Yahweh teaches.

For the law will go forth from Zion: The verb will go forth means here that Zion will be the source of law or instruction. See the NET quoted above.

In Hebrew, the word that the BSB translates as law (torah) is usually translated as "law." This Hebrew word (torah) is related to the Hebrew verb in 4:2d that the BSB translates "teach" (yarah). but can also be translated as "instruction." Here are some other ways to translate this word:

teaching (GNT)

teachings (GW)

instruction (NJPS)

4:2g

and the word of the LORD from Jerusalem.

- Yes, what Yahweh teaches will come from Jerusalem.
- Indeed, Yahweh will speak to all people from Jerusalem.

and the word of the LORD from Jerusalem: This line means almost the same thing as the parallel line 4:2f. For ways to translate it, see the examples that have already been given under 4:2f-g.

General Comment on 4:2f-g

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these two lines. For example:

For in those days the Lord's teaching and his word will go out from Jerusalem. (NLT96)

For from Zion, that is Jerusalem, the LORD will teach people his words that he wants them to learn.

Micah 4:3

Section 4:1-8: The LORD will rule the world as King from Jerusalem and cause all nations to be at peace

In the last verse of chapter 3, Micah described the destruction that would happen to the temple and to all

of Jerusalem. But here in 4:1-8, he described the future importance of the city and the many good things that will result when the LORD rules as King over all the nations from that city.

The Notes have divided this section into two paragraphs (4:1-5 and 4:6-8) with one section heading. Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord's Future Reign (NLT)

The future reign of Yahweh in Zion (NJB)

The Lord Will Teach the Nations (GW)

Some versions use two section headings, one for 4:1-5 and another for 4:6ff. For example:

¹⁻⁵Peace and Security through Obedience

^{6ff}Restoration Promised after Exile (NRSV)

¹⁻⁵The Lord's Universal Reign of Peace

^{6ff}Israel Will Return from Exile (GNT)

¹⁻⁵Better Days Ahead for Jerusalem

^{6ff}Restoration Will Follow Crisis (NET)

You may use one or more section headings in your language.

Some versions, including the GNT and NRSV, make verse 5 a separate paragraph. Some versions, including the NRSV and NJB, make verse 8 a separate paragraph. Divide the paragraphs in a natural way in your language.

Paragraph 4:1-5

Here is a summary of Micah's predictions in this paragraph:

1. (4:1a-c) The temple hill will become higher than other mountains and hills.
2. (4:1d-2) Many people will go there to learn about God.
3. (4:3-4) God will rule the world from Jerusalem. He will cause all nations to be at peace with one another.

4. (4:5) Even though the people of other nations follow their own gods, the people of Israel will follow the LORD forever.

The first three verses in this paragraph are very similar to Isaiah 2:2-4. If you have already translated Isaiah, you will want to translate these verses in a similar way.

4:3a-4:4b

Here is an overall view of the flow of thought in these verse parts. The relationships have been indicated with an underline:

The LORD will settle all disputes between nations.
(3:a-b)

Therefore nations will no longer need weapons
and will not fight one another, (3:c-d)

because, in fact, they will no longer learn to fight
wars. (3e-f)

Instead, everyone will live in peace without fear
(4a-b).

Most versions leave the relationships implied. Use an approach that is natural in your language.

4:3a-b (combined/reordered)

- He will settle arguments among all people groups, even people who live in great nations far away.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{3a}Then He will judge between **many peoples**

^{3b}and arbitrate for **strong nations** far and wide.

4:3a

Then He will judge between many peoples

- He will act as the judge to stop arguing between many peoples.
- Yahweh will settle arguments among many people,

Then He will judge between many peoples: The LORD will act as a judge. When people or nations have a disagreement, he will listen to both sides and decide what is the right thing to do.

many peoples: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

many people groups

many nations (NCV)

4:3b

and arbitrate for strong nations far and wide.

- He will act as a mediator to settle arguments between powerful nations all over the world.
- and when strong nations far away argue with each other, Yahweh will settle their arguments.

and arbitrate: The word arbitrate is a synonym of the word “judge” in 4:3a. Here are some other ways to translate it:

settle arguments (CEV)

make decisions about (NCV)

for strong nations far and wide: This phrase refers to strong nations that are far from Israel. Here are some other ways to translate strong:

mighty (NJB)

powerful (CEV)

far and wide: This is an English idiom which means “far away and extending over a great area.” It is implied that God will also settle disputes for nations that are near to Israel. For example:

among the great powers near and far (GNT)

General Comment on 4:3a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these two verse parts. For example:

He will settle arguments between distant and powerful nations. (CEV)

He will be the judge who will cause arguing to cease among all people groups, even people who live in great nations far away.

4:3c–d

(combined/reordered)

- Therefore the people of the nations will use hammers to pound the metal of their swords and spears to make plows and sickles.

- People will not need weapons any longer. So they will use their swords and spears to make farm tools like plows/hoes and sickles.

These parallel lines describe the next things that will happen as a result of 4:3a–b. Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{3c}Then they will beat their swords into **plow-shares**

^{3d}and their spears into **pruning hooks**.

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) of the verb in 4:3d. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing verb from 4:3c. For example:

^{3d}and they shall beat their spears into **pruning hooks**.

In Hebrew, 4:3c begins with a conjunction that is often translated by “and.” For example:

and they shall beat their swords... (ESV)

Other translations (including the BSB) use a conjunction that often introduces the next action. For example:

Then they will hammer their swords... (NASB)

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

Therefore

As a result

Many versions leave the Hebrew conjunction implied. Introduce the parallel results in 4:3c–d in a way that is natural in your language.

“Swords” and “spears” are two kinds of weapons that represent any weapons that people used in warfare. “Plowshares” and “pruning hooks” are two kinds of farm tools that represent any farm tools.

These verse parts refer to pounding iron to make tools. Blacksmiths usually do this kind of work. They heat (“smith/forged”) a piece of iron in a fire. Then they beat it with a hammer to change its shape. Micah said that

in the future, people will beat their iron weapons to make farm tools.

swords...spears: These words occur frequently in the Old Testament as well as the New Testament. Use the same terms in your language that you have used elsewhere.

plowshares: A “plowshare” Some scholars think that the Hebrew word for plowshares can also mean “hoes.” The REB translates the word as “mattocks.” A mattock is a digging tool, similar to a hoe. is a metal tip for a plow. Farmers in Israel made plows from wood. They put a metal tip on the part of the plow that dug up the dirt. Some versions make this explicit. For example:

plow blades (NCV)

The GNT uses the more general word “plows,” which also occurs frequently in the Old Testament as well as the New Testament. You may choose to use the same term here. Another option is to use a term that refers to similar tools. For example:

hoes

digging tools

pruning hooks: The word pruning hooks refers to tools with curved iron blades similar to small sickles. The blade was attached to a wooden handle. Farmers used pruning hooks to cut off small branches from grape vines and trees. Here are some other ways to translate this term:

pruning knives/shears (GNT/GW)

hooks for trimming trees (NCV)

If it is awkward or unnatural to use one or more of the translation suggestions mentioned above, here are some other ideas:

- Use borrowed words from a language of wider communication and provide pictures of each item.
- Use general terms. For example:

They will make their weapons into farming tools.

People will use parts of their weapons to make tools for farming.

- Substitute terms for weapons or tools used in your language area. For example:

weapons: arrows and darts

tools: rakes and shovels (CEV)

If you use any of the three bullet point options above, you may want to supply a footnote that gives a more literal translation.

4:3c

Then they will beat their swords into plowshares

- The people will beat their swords with hammers to make them into plows.

4:3d

and their spears into pruning hooks.

- They will beat their spears to make them into knives for pruning trees.

4:3e

Nation will no longer take up the sword against nation,

- One nation will not fight against another nation.
- At that time, people from different nations will no longer wage war against each other.

Nation will no longer take up the sword against nation: This idiom means that one nation will not wage war against another nation. Here are some other ways to translate this line:

Nations will never again go to war (GNT)

Nations will never fight against each other (GW)

4:3f

nor will they train anymore for war.

- From that time onward, people will not even learn how to fight wars.
- In fact, they will never again train to fight in battle.

nor will they train anymore for war: This means “they will not learn how to wage war” or “they will not train how to fight in a battle.” For example:

and they will never train for war again (GW)

they will never again be trained for war (REB)

Micah 4:4

Section 4:1–8: The LORD will rule the world as King from Jerusalem and cause all nations to be at peace

In the last verse of chapter 3, Micah described the destruction that would happen to the temple and to all of Jerusalem. But here in 4:1–8, he described the future importance of the city and the many good things that will result when the LORD rules as King over all the nations from that city.

The Notes have divided this section into two paragraphs (4:1–5 and 4:6–8) with one section heading. Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord's Future Reign (NLT)

The future reign of Yahweh in Zion (NJB)

The Lord Will Teach the Nations (GW)

Some versions use two section headings, one for 4:1–5 and another for 4:6ff. For example:

^{1–5}Peace and Security through Obedience

^{6ff}Restoration Promised after Exile (NRSV)

^{1–5}The Lord's Universal Reign of Peace

^{6ff}Israel Will Return from Exile (GNT)

^{1–5}Better Days Ahead for Jerusalem

^{6ff}Restoration Will Follow Crisis (NET)

You may use one or more section headings in your language.

Some versions, including the GNT and NRSV, make verse 5 a separate paragraph. Some versions, including the NRSV and NJB, make verse 8 a separate paragraph. Divide the paragraphs in a natural way in your language.

Paragraph 4:1–5

Here is a summary of Micah's predictions in this paragraph:

1. (4:1a–c) The temple hill will become higher than other mountains and hills.

2. (4:1d–2) Many people will go there to learn about God.
3. (4:3–4) God will rule the world from Jerusalem. He will cause all nations to be at peace with one another.
4. (4:5) Even though the people of other nations follow their own gods, the people of Israel will follow the LORD forever.

The first three verses in this paragraph are very similar to Isaiah 2:2–4. If you have already translated Isaiah, you will want to translate these verses in a similar way.

4:4a

And each man will sit under his own vine and under his own fig tree,

- But/Instead each person will live at home, sitting peacefully under his own grape vines and fig trees.
- Instead of fighting wars, people will live in peace and safety, taking care of their own grape vines and fig trees.
- Each person will stay on his own farm, and everyone will live peacefully.

And each man will sit under his own vine and under his own fig tree: In contrast to the nations needing to train for war (4:3e–f), people will live in peace (4:4a).

Some versions introduce this contrast with the word “but” (it is the same Hebrew conjunction that introduced 4:3c).

Many versions leave the relationship implied. For example:

Each man will sit... (REB)

Everyone will sit... (NCV)

This verse part is a Hebrew idiom. This same idiom is also in 1 Kings 4:25 where the writer also used the phrase “in safety” to clarify the meaning. Similar idioms are used in 2 Kings 18:31, Isaiah 36:16, and Zechariah 3:10. Literally, it says that every man (male) will sit under his own grape vine and under his own fig tree. The meaning is: “all people will live in peace and safety on their own land.” Here are some ways to translate this idiom:

- Translate the idiom literally, as the BSB does.
- Modify the idiom to make the meaning clearer. For example:

Everyone will live in peace among their own vineyards and fig trees (GNT)

Everyone will live in peace and prosperity, enjoying their own grapevines and fig trees (NLT)

- Translate the meaning without using an idiom. For example:

Everyone will live quietly in their own homes in peace and prosperity (NLT96)

Everyone will live peacefully on their own farm.

vine...fig tree: In Hebrew, the words vine and fig tree are singular. Farmers in Israel sometimes planted grape vines and fig trees together. So it is possible that a person could sit under his own grape vine and under his own fig tree at the same time. But if it is more natural in your language, you can use plural forms, as in the GNT and NLT (quoted above).

4:4b with no one to frighten him.

- No one will cause them to be afraid of anything/anybody.
- And people/they will not fear that others will attack them.

with no one to frighten him: In Hebrew, this verse part is more literally “and there will not be anyone/anything who causes fear.” It implies that people will not be afraid that an enemy army will attack them.

with: In Hebrew, this is the same conjunction that was used in 4:3c. Here it may indicate the implied result of living peacefully on one’s own farm.

Here are some ways to translate this line:

and no one will make them afraid (NIV)

for there will be nothing to fear (NLT)

without any fear (NET)

4:4c For the mouth of the LORD of Hosts has spoken.

- Yahweh of hosts himself has spoken this message.
- This will surely happen, because the Almighty/All-Powerful Yahweh himself has said it.
- Yahweh the Leader of the armies of heaven has promised that this will happen.

For the mouth of the LORD of Hosts has spoken: This clause refers to Micah’s message from the LORD in verses 4:1–4:4b. It emphatically gives the reason why this message is true. The reason is that the LORD of hosts himself said it.

For: Some versions translate this conjunction as For or “because.” For example:

because the Lord All-Powerful has said it (NCV)

Other versions leave implied that this clause is a reason. For example:

The Lord of Hosts himself has spoken. (REB)

Some versions use the word “promise” to make this statement emphatic. For example:

This is a solemn promise of the Lord All-Powerful. (CEV)

The Lord Almighty has promised this! (GNT)

the mouth...: This is a figure of speech in which the mouth represents the LORD’s whole being. In some languages, this figure of speech may be natural and clearly understood. In other languages, including English, it may be very unnatural. In such languages, it will be better to translate like the versions quoted above.

the LORD of Hosts: This is the only time that Micah used this name for God, but it is used frequently in other OT books. The word Hosts means “armies.” The CEV and GNT (quoted above) give two ways to translate this name of God. Here are some other ways:

the Lord of armies (GW)

the Lord of Heaven’s Armies (NLT)

the Lord who commands armies (NET)

Micah 4:5

Section 4:1–8: The LORD will rule the world as King from Jerusalem and cause all nations to be at peace
In the last verse of chapter 3, Micah described the destruction that would happen to the temple and to all of Jerusalem. But here in 4:1–8, he described the future importance of the city and the many good things that

will result when the LORD rules as King over all the nations from that city.

The Notes have divided this section into two paragraphs (4:1–5 and 4:6–8) with one section heading. Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord's Future Reign (NLT)

The future reign of Yahweh in Zion (NJB)

The Lord Will Teach the Nations (GW)

Some versions use two section headings, one for 4:1–5 and another for 4:6ff. For example:

¹⁻⁵Peace and Security through Obedience

^{6ff}Restoration Promised after Exile (NRSV)

¹⁻⁵The Lord's Universal Reign of Peace

^{6ff}Israel Will Return from Exile (GNT)

¹⁻⁵Better Days Ahead for Jerusalem

^{6ff}Restoration Will Follow Crisis (NET)

You may use one or more section headings in your language.

Some versions, including the GNT and NRSV, make verse 5 a separate paragraph. Some versions, including the NRSV and NJB, make verse 8 a separate paragraph. Divide the paragraphs in a natural way in your language.

Paragraph 4:1–5

Here is a summary of Micah's predictions in this paragraph:

1. (4:1a–c) The temple hill will become higher than other mountains and hills.
2. (4:1d–2) Many people will go there to learn about God.
3. (4:3–4) God will rule the world from Jerusalem. He will cause all nations to be at peace with one another.
4. (4:5) Even though the people of other nations follow their own gods, the people of Israel will follow the LORD forever.

The first three verses in this paragraph are very similar to Isaiah 2:2–4. If you have already translated Isaiah, you will want to translate these verses in a similar way.

4:5a–b

In 4:1–4, Micah spoke about the future. But here in 4:5, he spoke about the situation in his own time. Notice the parallel lines that contrast in meaning:

^{5a}Though each of the peoples may walk **in the name of his god**,

^{5b}yet we will walk **in the name of the LORD our God** forever and ever.

Though...yet...: There is a Hebrew conjunction at the beginning of this verse that introduces a reason for the promise of a peaceful life in 4:4.EBC (page 526). According to KD (page 311), "If, therefore, Israel rejoices for ever and ever in the strength of its God, the heathen nations cannot disturb the peace which He will create for Israel and all who accept His word. In this way is the promise in vv. 3 and 4 explained in v. 5." This conjunction is often translated as "for" (see NRSV). But 4:5 also makes a clear contrast between the nations who still worship their own gods (Though) and the Jews who will worship the true God forever (yet). There are several ways to express this combination of reason and contrast:

- Use explicit conjunctions such as "for" and "but" to introduce both the reason and the contrast. For example:

^{5a} For all the peoples walk, each in the name of its god,

^{5b} but we will walk in the name of the Lord our God forever and ever. (NRSV)

- Leave the reason implied, but use an explicit conjunction to express the contrast, as the BSB does. For example:

^{5a}All other nations may follow their own gods,

^{5b} but we will follow the Lord our God forever and ever. (NCV)

^{5a} Though all the peoples walk each in the name of his god,

^{5b}as for us, we will walk in the name of the Lord our God forever and ever. (NASB) Notice that the NASB adds to the contrast by using the phrase “as for us.”

- Leave both the reason and the contrast implied. For example:

^{5a}All the nations may walk in the name of their gods;

^{5b}we will walk in the name of the Lord our God for ever and ever. (NIV)

4:5a

Though each of the peoples may walk in the name of his god,

- For all the people of other nations follow their own god/gods,
- Even though all other people obey and worship their own gods/idols,

each of the peoples may walk in the name of his god: In Hebrew, the words “each...his” are singular. They imply that each of the other nations worships its own god. Some versions use plural pronouns here, because many of the other nations worshiped more than one false god or idol. For example:

Other peoples may be loyal to their own deities (REB)

Though the nations around us follow their idols (NLT)

All the nations live by the names of their gods (GW)

See also the NCV and NIV (quoted above in 4:5a-b).

You may use either singular or plural forms in your language.

walk in the name of his god: This phrase is a figure of speech. It means to worship a particular god in a way that is consistent with that god’s requirements and attributes. The REB “be loyal to” and NLT “follow” (quoted above) are two ways to express this idea.

4:5b

yet we will walk in the name of the LORD our God forever and ever.

- but as for us Jewish/Israelite people, we^(incl) will indeed continue to follow Yahweh our God forever.
- we^(incl) Jews will always worship and serve Yahweh our God with the strength that comes from him.

we: The pronoun we here is emphatic. If your language distinguishes between inclusive and exclusive pronouns, you should probably use the inclusive form here. Micah assumed that he and his audience will all worship the true God.

will walk in the name of the LORD our God forever

and ever: To walk in the name of the LORD...forever and ever may imply that the Jewish people persevere in following the LORD by using the strength that is one of his attributes. According to KD (page 311), walking in the name of God means “walking in the strength of God, in which the nature of this God is displayed.” EBC (page 526) says: To “walk in the name” is to enjoy the strength expressed in God’s attributes. NAC (pages 87–88) also mentions “walk in the strength of” as a possible meaning. If it is appropriate to make this implication explicit in your translation or to mention it in a footnote, you may do so.

You may decide to leave the figurative expression name of implied. For example:

we will follow the Lord our God forever (NET)

forever and ever: This phrase is an emphatic way to say “forever.” Some languages may have a way to emphasize the word “forever.” Otherwise, you may follow the example of versions such as the NET (quoted above).

Micah 4:6

Section 4:1–8: The LORD will rule the world as King from Jerusalem and cause all nations to be at peace

In the last verse of chapter 3, Micah described the destruction that would happen to the temple and to all of Jerusalem. But here in 4:1–8, he described the future importance of the city and the many good things that will result when the LORD rules as King over all the nations from that city.

The Notes have divided this section into two paragraphs (4:1–5 and 4:6–8) with one section heading. Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s Future Reign (NLT)

The future reign of Yahweh in Zion (NJB)

The Lord Will Teach the Nations (GW)

Some versions use two section headings, one for 4:1-5 and another for 4:6ff. For example:

¹⁻⁵Peace and Security through Obedience

^{6ff}Restoration Promised after Exile (NRSV)

¹⁻⁵The Lord's Universal Reign of Peace

^{6ff}Israel Will Return from Exile (GNT)

¹⁻⁵Better Days Ahead for Jerusalem

^{6ff}Restoration Will Follow Crisis (NET)

You may use one or more section headings in your language.

Some versions, including the GNT and NRSV, make verse 5 a separate paragraph. Some versions, including the NRSV and NJB, make verse 8 a separate paragraph. Divide the paragraphs in a natural way in your language.

Paragraph 4:6-8

In these verses, the LORD spoke about the future. He said that he will gather his people together again. He will make them a strong nation and he will rule over them forever.

This paragraph is similar to 2:12-13. In both 2:12-13 and 4:6-8, the LORD promised to gather together the remnant of his people. Also in both 2:12-13 and 4:6-8, the LORD compared his people to sheep (implied by the word "flock" in 4:8).

4:6a

"On that day," declares the LORD,

- ¶ Yahweh says: "At that future time,
- ¶ These are the words of Yahweh: "In that future time, this is what I will do:

On that day: The phrase On that day refers to the same time as the phrase "in the last days" in 4:1. The word day here refers to a period of time, not a literal 24-hour day. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

At that time (NCV)

The time is coming (GNT)

declares the LORD: In 4:6-7, Micah quotes the words of the LORD. In some languages, it is better to put this quote introducer at the beginning of the sentence. For example:

The LORD says: "At that future time..."

In other languages, it may be better to put the quote introducer at the end of the sentence. Do what is natural in your language.

4:6a-d (combined/reordered)

- This is what Yahweh says: "In the future, after I punish my people, they will be scattered and helpless. But then I will gather them together again.

4:6b

"I will gather the lame;

- I will gather together my people who are like lame sheep.
- My people will be weak and helpless like sheep that are lame, but I will cause them to come together again.

4:6c

I will assemble the outcast,

- I will assemble them like sheep that someone has chased away,
- They will be scattered, but I will gather them again,

4:6d

even those whom I have afflicted.

- whom I have punished.
- these people whom I caused to suffer.

4:6b-d

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{6b}I will gather **the lame;**

^{6c}I will assemble **the outcast,**

^{6d}even **those whom I have afflicted.**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted word) of the verb in 4:6d. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing verb from 4:6c. For example:

^{6d} I will even gather/assemble **those whom I have afflicted.**

In these parallel lines, the underlined parts have essentially the same meaning. The parts in bold print all refer to the people whom the LORD has punished.

the lame...the outcast...those whom I have afflicted: In Hebrew, the first two phrases are singular (the lame, the outcast). Both phrases refer to the LORD's people, the Jews. Except for the KJV ("her that halteth," "her that is driven out"), English versions translate these phrases as plural. Most scholars say that the LORD compared his people to lame and scattered sheep. In Hebrew the two phrases are feminine singular: "the one(fem) who is lame" and "the one(fem) who was driven away." Most scholars interpret these feminine forms as referring to sheep or a flock of sheep, because the Hebrew word *šōn* "sheep, flock" is feminine. NICOT (page 328) translated 4:6b-c like this: "I gather the limping flock, bringing the strays together..." Except for the NJPS, which has "I will assemble the lame [sheep]," English versions do not make it explicit that the LORD compared his people to sheep.

Here are two options for translating 4:6b-c:

- Leave the comparison of the LORD's people to sheep implicit.
- Make the comparison explicit. For example:

I will gather my people. They are like sheep who are lame and who have been driven away

the lame: The word lame here is a metaphor. God's people were like lame people or lame sheep because they were weak and helpless. They were unable to help themselves. They were not literally lame.

the outcast: God had allowed enemies to defeat the nations of Israel and Judah. Their enemies took them away as captives into exile. God did this to punish them. This is what he means when he says that they were outcast. The implied agent is the LORD.

those whom I have afflicted: The ones whom the LORD afflicted refer to the same group of people as the "lame" and those who have been driven away.

afflicted: This word means "injured, caused to suffer." Here are some other ways to translate it:

the people I punished (GNT)

whom I injured (NET)

those whom I caused to have trouble (NCV)

those whom I have treated harshly (NJB)

General Comment on 4:6a-d

In some languages, it may be clearer or more natural to combine and/or reorder these verse parts. See 4:6a-d combined/reordered in the Display.

Micah 4:7

Section 4:1-8: The LORD will rule the world as King from Jerusalem and cause all nations to be at peace

In the last verse of chapter 3, Micah described the destruction that would happen to the temple and to all of Jerusalem. But here in 4:1-8, he described the future importance of the city and the many good things that will result when the LORD rules as King over all the nations from that city.

The Notes have divided this section into two paragraphs (4:1-5 and 4:6-8) with one section heading. Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord's Future Reign (NLT)

The future reign of Yahweh in Zion (NJB)

The Lord Will Teach the Nations (GW)

Some versions use two section headings, one for 4:1-5 and another for 4:6ff. For example:

¹⁻⁵Peace and Security through Obedience

^{6ff}Restoration Promised after Exile (NRSV)

¹⁻⁵The Lord's Universal Reign of Peace

^{6ff}Israel Will Return from Exile (GNT)

¹⁻⁵Better Days Ahead for Jerusalem

^{6ff}Restoration Will Follow Crisis (NET)

You may use one or more section headings in your language.

Some versions, including the GNT and NRSV, make verse 5 a separate paragraph. Some versions, including the NRSV and NJB, make verse 8 a separate paragraph. Divide the paragraphs in a natural way in your language.

Paragraph 4:6-8

In these verses, the LORD spoke about the future. He said that he will gather his people together again. He will make them a strong nation and he will rule over them forever.

This paragraph is similar to 2:12-13. In both 2:12-13 and 4:6-8, the LORD promised to gather together the remnant of his people. Also in both 2:12-13 and 4:6-8, the LORD compared his people to sheep (implied by the word “flock” in 4:8).

**4:7a-b
(combined/reordered)**

- They are powerless, like lame sheep/people because I sent them far away into exile. But I will gather them together and make them the ancestors/beginning of a strong nation.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{7a}And I will make the lame into **a remnant**,

^{7b}and the outcast into **a strong nation**.

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) of the verb in 4:7b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing verb from 4:7a. For example:

^{7b}and I will make the outcast into **a strong nation**.

The underlined phrases and the phrases in bold print refer to the same people.

4:7a

And I will make the lame into a remnant,

- Those people who are like lame sheep/people, I will cause/help them to survive their exile/captivity.
- Those who remain/survive will be helpless, like lame people/sheep.

I will make the lame into a remnant: For the meaning of the word remnant, see the notes on 2:12b. This word refers to the people who survived when an enemy army took them away as prisoners into exile. Here the word is used in a positive way. It means that the LORD will preserve them or cause them to survive.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

They are crippled..., but I will make a new beginning with those who are left (GNT)

I will keep alive those who were crippled (NCV)

I will transform the lame into the nucleus of a new nation (NET)

Those who are weak will survive as a remnant (NLT)

the lame: For the metaphor lame, see the notes on 4:6b.

**4:7b
and the outcast into a strong nation.**

- The people that I sent far away as prisoners/captives, later I will make them a powerful/great nation.
- I will cause them to go far away as prisoners/exiles, but in the future, I will cause them to become the ancestors of a country that is united and strong.

and the outcast: To be outcast probably means “to be sent far away, to be exiled.” Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they are...far from home (GNT)

those who were cast off (NRSV)

those who were exiles (NLT)

a strong nation: This phrase means that the LORD’s people will once again live in their own land as a united nation with a strong government. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase: The NJPS has “a populous nation,” referring to a large population. The Hebrew phrase can have this meaning, but “a strong nation” is preferable. The phrase “a strong nation” also occurs in Genesis 18:18; and the plural “strong nations” occurs in Micah 4:3 and Zechariah 8:22.

a mighty nation (NJB)

a great nation (GNT)

4:7c

Then the LORD will rule over them in Mount Zion from that day and forever.

- And I, Yahweh, will be their king. I will rule them from Mount Zion, beginning at that time and until forever.”
- And I, Yahweh, will be the king who rules over them in Mount Zion in Jerusalem from then until/and forever.”

Then the LORD will rule over them in Mount Zion from that day and forever: The LORD himself is clearly the speaker in 4:7a–b. But in 4:7c, the name the LORD occurs as a third-person reference. There are three ways in 4:7c to interpret the identity of the speaker. English versions indicate their interpretation by their use of quotation marks and other means:

1. The LORD is the speaker. He referred to himself in the third person.
- Some English versions, such as the BSB, include 4:7c inside the quotation marks to show that the LORD is still the speaker. For some of these versions, the quote continues through 4:8.
- Some English versions use the pronoun “I” to show that the LORD is the speaker. For example:

I will rule over them on Mount Zion from that time on and forever.” (GNT)

Then I, the Lord, will rule from Jerusalem as their king forever.” (NLT) (BSB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT, GNT)

1. Micah is the speaker. The GW closes the quotation after 4:7b, leaving 4:7c outside the quote marks. (GW)
2. The identity of the speaker is ambiguous, because there are no quotation marks. (KJV, NJPS, NJB, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a slight majority of English versions. The meaning of 4:7c is the same whether the LORD or Micah is the speaker.

over them: The pronoun them refers to the LORD’s people, the same people as in 4:7a–b.

in Mount Zion: For the meaning of Zion, see the notes at 1:13b. Mount Zion was the area in Jerusalem where the temple was located. Almost all English versions translate this phrase literally, as in the BSB. The NLT translates this phrase as “Jerusalem.” It gives the literal translation “Mount Zion” in a footnote.

from that day and forever: The phrase from that day refers to the time when the LORD will make his people a strong nation. The word forever means that the LORD will never stop ruling as King.

Micah 4:8

Section 4:1–8: The LORD will rule the world as King from Jerusalem and cause all nations to be at peace

In the last verse of chapter 3, Micah described the destruction that would happen to the temple and to all of Jerusalem. But here in 4:1–8, he described the future importance of the city and the many good things that will result when the LORD rules as King over all the nations from that city.

The Notes have divided this section into two paragraphs (4:1–5 and 4:6–8) with one section heading. Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s Future Reign (NLT)

The future reign of Yahweh in Zion (NJB)

The Lord Will Teach the Nations (GW)

Some versions use two section headings, one for 4:1–5 and another for 4:6ff. For example:

^{1–5}Peace and Security through Obedience

^{6ff}Restoration Promised after Exile (NRSV)

^{1–5}The Lord’s Universal Reign of Peace

^{6ff}Israel Will Return from Exile (GNT)

^{1–5}Better Days Ahead for Jerusalem

^{6ff}Restoration Will Follow Crisis (NET)

You may use one or more section headings in your language.

Some versions, including the GNT and NRSV, make verse 5 a separate paragraph. Some versions, including the NRSV and NJB, make verse 8 a separate paragraph. Divide the paragraphs in a natural way in your language.

Paragraph 4:6–8

In these verses, the LORD spoke about the future. He said that he will gather his people together again. He will make them a strong nation and he will rule over them forever.

This paragraph is similar to 2:12–13. In both 2:12–13 and 4:6–8, the LORD promised to gather together the remnant of his people. Also in both 2:12–13 and 4:6–8, the LORD compared his people to sheep (implied by the word “flock” in 4:8).

4:8

Some versions make 4:8 a separate paragraph. The Notes and other versions keep 4:6–8 as one paragraph. Divide the paragraphs in a logical way for your language.

4:8a–b

In these parallel lines, Micah used two metaphors with similar meanings to describe the city. Both metaphors mean that Jerusalem was a strong, secure place where people were safe. Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{8a}And you, O watchtower **of the flock**,

^{8b} O stronghold **of the Daughter of Zion**—

In these lines, Micah spoke to the city of Jerusalem as if it were a person. This is a figure of speech called personification. It is also called apostrophe. He used the singular pronoun “you.” Some versions make the name Jerusalem explicit. For example:

You, Jerusalem,... (GW)

In some languages, it is not natural to speak to a city. It is more natural to speak to the people in the city, or to speak about the city. There are several ways to translate this figure of speech.

- Keep the original figure of speech: Micah spoke to the city. For example:

And you, Jerusalem... (GNT)

- Change the figure of speech: Micah spoke to the people in the city. For example:

And you^(plur), O people of Jerusalem...

- Change the figure of speech: Micah spoke about the city.

And as for the city of Jerusalem...

Do whatever is natural in your language.

4:8a

And you, O watchtower of the flock,

- ¶ And as for you^(sing) city of Jerusalem, you are like a tower from which a person/shepherd guards his flock of sheep.
- ¶ As for you^(plur) people of Jerusalem, the city where you live is like a strong tower that protects you.

And you: In Hebrew, this singular pronoun is emphatic. In Hebrew, this pronoun is masculine singular. It agrees with the words “tower” and “hill,” which are masculine singular nouns. Here is another way to express this emphasis:

As for you,... (NASB)

If your translation addresses the people of Jerusalem, you will want to use a plural pronoun.

O watchtower of the flock: Most versions translate the phrase watchtower of the flock in a way similar to the BSB. But the NJPS and NAB translate it as the name of a place: “O Migdal-eder” (NJPS), “O Magdal-eder” (NAB). (See also the footnotes in the NASB and NET.) At the time Jacob lived, there was a place near Bethlehem that had the name Migdal-eder (see Genesis 35:19–21). But in Micah 4:8, Micah spoke to Jerusalem, not Bethlehem. It is recommended that you translate the meaning of this Hebrew phrase rather than translating it as a proper name. A watchtower is a tall building. A shepherd could stand on top of a tower to watch his flock of sheep or goats. In this metaphor, Jerusalem was compared to this kind of tower. The word flock stands for the people who lived in and near Jerusalem.

In this metaphor, there are several points of similarity:

1. Jerusalem was like a tower, because from Jerusalem God watched over and protected his people.
2. Jerusalem was like a tower, because the city was strong and secure. People who lived in it were safe from their enemies.
3. Jerusalem was like a tower, because from Jerusalem the king and other leaders of Israel watched over their people to protect them.

You should translate in a way that any of these points of comparison can be understood. All three are compatible with Micah’s message.

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. Supply a footnote if you feel it will be helpful to your readers. For example:

And you, watchtower of the flocks (NCV)

Footnote in the NCV: [watchtower...flocks] This probably means a part of Jerusalem. The leaders would be like shepherds in a tower watching their sheep.

- Change the metaphor to a simile. Make one or more of the points of comparison explicit. For example:

And you, Jerusalem, where God, like a shepherd from his lookout tower, watches over his people... (GNT)

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example: And you, O people of Jerusalem, will be safe inside your strong city.

4:8b

O stronghold of the Daughter of Zion—

- You^(sing) are like a fortress for the people who live in Zion.
- Jerusalem is like the fortress that was built on Zion Hill long ago.

O stronghold of the Daughter of Zion: In this second metaphor, the word stronghold means “fort” or “fortress.” People made a fortress by building a wall around the top part of a hill. Inside this wall, they could defend themselves from their enemies. Here are some other ways to translate this word: In Hebrew, the word for “hill” is ‘*opel*. The NJB translates it as the name of a place “Ophel” within the city of Jerusalem (see 2 Chronicles 27:3; 33:14). But here in Micah 4:8, it is better to translate the meaning of this word, not translate it as a name.

fortress (NET)

citadel (NLT)

the Daughter of Zion: This phrase is a poetic way to refer to the people who live in Jerusalem. For the meaning of this phrase, see the notes at 1:13b.

General Comment on 4:8a–b

Here are several ways to translate these two metaphors. Some of them involve combining the two metaphors in various ways.

- Most English versions keep both metaphors. For example:

As for you, O watchtower of the flock, O stronghold of the Daughter of Zion... (NIV)

- The NLT combines both metaphors into one metaphor.

As for you, O Jerusalem, the citadel of God’s people... (NLT)

- The GNT combines both metaphors as one simile.

And you, Jerusalem, where God, like a shepherd from his lookout tower, watches over his people... (GNT)

- The CEV translates both of these metaphors with the word “guardian.” This is a different figure of speech (personification).

Mount Zion in Jerusalem, guardian of my people... (CEV)

Translate these metaphors in a way that is natural and clear in your language.

4:8c–d (combined/reordered)

- As for you^(sing), city of Jerusalem, in the future you will have a king who rules over a strong nation, just like in the past.
- In the future, you^(plur) people of Jerusalem will live in the capital of a powerful country.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{8c} **the former dominion will be restored** to you;

^{8d} **sovereignty will come** to the Daughter of Jerusalem.

Here is a more literal translation of the Hebrew. The translation is supplied from BART. The Hebrew structure is adapted from A&F (pages 437–438). arranged in six phrases that show the poetic structure:

to you

it-will-come

and-it-will-come

the former dominion

a kingdom

to the daughter of Jerusalem

The overall meaning is that Jerusalem will become the center of a strong nation, like it was in the past. There will again be a king ruling in Jerusalem.

will be restored...will come: Micah used two different Hebrew verbs that mean the same thing. The first verb ('atah) is a poetic word meaning "come." The second verb (bo') is the ordinary word for "come." The subject of these verbs is the phrase "the former dominion." The first verb "shall it come" (te'the) and the second verb "shall come" (ba'ah) are third feminine singular, agreeing with the feminine nouns "dominion" (memšalah) and "kingdom" (mamlakah).

4:8c

the former dominion will be restored to you;

- This is what will happen to you^(sing). You^(sing) will again be the capital/center of a strong nation, like you used to be.
- In the future, this is what you^(plur) inhabitants/people of Zion will experience. Your^(plur) capital city will once again be the center of a strong nation.

the former dominion: The word dominion means "the power that a king or other ruler has." When Micah used the phrase the former dominion, he was referring to the time when David and his son Solomon ruled in Jerusalem about 200 years previously. At that time, Israel was a strong nation. Micah was predicting that Jerusalem would again become the capital city of a strong nation, like it was in the time of David and Solomon.

Here are some other ways to translate the clause "the former dominion will be restored":

The former monarchy shall return (NJPS)

your former sovereignty will return (NJB)

your former government will come back to you (GW)

to you will come the kingdom as in the past (NCV)

your royal might and power will come back to you again (NLT)

to you: The pronoun you is emphatic. It repeats the emphatic pronoun you at the beginning of 4:8a.

4:8d

sovereignty will come to the Daughter of Jerusalem."

- There will once again be a king who rules over your^(sing) people in Jerusalem.
- The government in Jerusalem will rule the nation as it did in former times.

sovereignty...Daughter of Jerusalem: In this phrase, sovereignty is a synonym of "dominion," and Daughter of Jerusalem has the same meaning as "Daughter of Zion" in 4:8b. Both phrases refer to the people of Jerusalem. Some scholars think that the phrase Daughter of Jerusalem means that God loved that city and the people in it. This explains the following English versions: "my precious Jerusalem" (NLT); "Fair Jerusalem" (NJPS) For example:

The kingdom will return to the people of Jerusalem. (GW)

In some languages, it may not be natural to talk about a dominion and kingdom coming. In such languages, it is better to translate these words differently. For example:

And you, Jerusalem...will once again be the capital of the kingdom that was yours. (GNT)

A king will again rule/reign in Jerusalem. And Jerusalem will once again be the capital of a strong kingdom as in the past.

Micah 4:9

Section 4:9–13: The people of Jerusalem will suffer exile in Babylon, but in the future the LORD will deliver them from their enemies

In this section, the LORD spoke about the future. He said that he would punish his people. He would cause their enemies to take them as captives to Babylon. But the LORD also promised that in the future he would regather his people. He would make them a strong nation, and he would rule over them. Scholars analyze the structure of 4:9–5:15 in different ways. The Notes will list only a few of the analyses here; some of them have only minor variations. A&F (page 394) posit five sections, each beginning with *attâ* "now" (4:9–10a, 10b, 11–13, 14; 5:1–3) [5:4–5, 6, 7–9, 10–15]. In this analysis, 4:11–13 forms the center unit, with two units on either side. WBC (vol. 32, pages 11–12) has 4:9–10, 11–

13; 5:1–4, 5–6, 7–9, 10–15. NICOT (page 257), NAC (page 42) and Waltke 2007 (page viii) have 4:9–10, 11–13; 5:1–6, 7–9, 10–15. TOTC (page 150) and Waltke 1993 (page 598) has 4:9–13; 5:1–6, 7–9, 10–15.

In this section, as in the previous section, Micah quoted the words of the LORD and also sometimes referred to the LORD in the third person.

The Notes have divided this section into two paragraphs. If a separate paragraph heading will be helpful for your readers, here are some possible headings for each paragraph.

^{9–10}Why the Israelites Must Go to Babylon (NCV)

^{9–10}Current suffering and captivity, but future rescue

^{11–13}Her Enemies to Be Crushed on the Threshing-Floor (NJB)

^{11–13}Jerusalem will completely destroy its enemies

Paragraph 4:9–10

In this paragraph, Micah told the people of Jerusalem what would happen in the future. Enemies would capture Jerusalem and take away the people as captives to Babylon. The king, who was their counselor, would be unable to help them (4:9a–4:10e). After that, God would rescue his people (4:10f–g).

4:9a–d (combined/reordered)

- Why do you^(plur) inhabitants of Jerusalem cry out loudly and writhe like a woman who is suffering pain from giving birth to a child? Are you afraid because you have no wise king to rule you?

In this verse, Micah prophesied that the people of Jerusalem would cry in fear, because their counselor, the king, would be unable to help them. In the BSB, Micah's prophecy consists of three rhetorical questions (9a, 9b, and 9c–d):

^{9a}Why do you now cry aloud?

^{9b}Is there no king among you?

^{9c}Has your counselor perished

^{9d}so that anguish grips you like a woman in labor?

The last two questions (9b and 9c–d) suggest an answer to the first question: The people will cry aloud, because the king, who is their counselor, cannot help them.

Micah may have used these rhetorical questions for more than one purpose: to get the people's attention, to make them aware of what they were doing, to show sarcasm or to give rebuke. As with other rhetorical questions, these questions may be translated with another rhetorical question or with a statement.

4:9a

Why do you now cry aloud?

- ¶ Listen now to my words, O city of Jerusalem: Why are you^(sing) crying so loudly?
- ¶ I ask you people of Jerusalem: What is the reason that you^(plur) are shouting loudly in fear?

Why do you now cry aloud?: Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question:

OK now, let me ask you this: Why are you crying so loudly?

O people! Think about the reason that you are crying loudly.

you: In Hebrew, the pronoun here is feminine singular. It refers to the phrase “Daughter of Zion” in 4:10a. But that phrase is a figure of speech for the people who live in Jerusalem. So in many languages it may be clearer to translate you using a plural form.

now: This word refers to a future time, not to the present. Some versions do not translate this word. For example:

Why do you cry out so loudly? (GNT)

The CEV also omits this word. It addresses Jerusalem directly to introduce the rhetorical question:

Jerusalem, why are you crying? (CEV)

cry aloud: Some versions make explicit a reason why the people were shouting. For example:

But why are you now screaming in terror? (NLT)

Why are you now crying out in distress? (REB)

4:9b–c (combined/reordered)

- Does this city have no king who can give good advice?
- Do you^(plur) not have a king in your city who can counsel/advise you?

Is there no king among you? Has your counselor perished: There are two main interpretation issues in these two rhetorical questions. The first issue is whether the second question refers to the king or to a different counselor or counselors:

1. The second question refers to the king. He was considered the counselor or adviser for the nation. In Hebrew, the word for “counselor” is singular. The interpretation of the counselor being the same person as the king is supported by NICOT, EBC, NAC, Hillers, KD, Mays, and WBC. Pusey, TOTC, Waltke 1993, and Waltke 2007 understand these two titles to refer to the LORD himself rather than to an earthly king/counselor. See Waltke 2007 (pages 238–239) for three arguments in favor of his position. No English version follows this interpretation. For three arguments that support king/counselor as opposed to King/Counselor, see NAC (pages 90–91). For example:

Has your king disappeared? Has your wise leader been destroyed? (NET) (ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, BSB, NET, NIV, NJB, NRSV, REB)

1. The second question refers to various advisers who counseled the people. Commentaries that support multiple advisers include: UBS, JFB, and ABC. For example:

Have you no king to lead you? Have your wise people all died? (NLT) (CEV, NLT, GNT)

1. The second question refers to an adviser who counseled the king. CBC (page 325) comments: “The counselor or adviser was usually a member of the royal cabinet or part of the council of elders who advised the king.” A&F also support this interpretation. No English versions follow it. For example:

Are the king and his adviser not able to help you?

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most English versions and commentaries.

The second interpretation issue involves the date of the prophecy’s fulfilment and whether the king was literally absent or simply unable to help his people:

1. Micah may have referred to the period after 586 B.C. After that date, King Zedekiah and many of the people were taken into exile in Babylon, so the king was literally absent. Irrespective of the identity of the king/counselor(s), ABC, KD, EBC, A&F, and NAC appear to support the literal absence of a king. JFB, UBS, and NICOT appear to favor the literal presence of a king.
2. Micah may have referred to the period after 701 B.C. but before 586 B.C. During that time, the Assyrians attacked some cities in Judah and besieged Jerusalem. The king was still there, but he was not able to help the people or defeat their enemies.

No versions clearly support interpretation (2). Some versions listed in the previous interpretation issue appear to support interpretation (1). They speak of the king as having disappeared, being gone, or being destroyed. But Micah would have asked similar questions if he were speaking sarcastically. The commentaries are divided. According to this interpretation, Micah predicted what happened in 586 B.C. The Babylonian army captured King Zedekiah and took him away as a prisoner to Babylon. See 2 Kings 25:1–7. It is recommended that you translate so that either interpretation can be understood.

You may want to supply a footnote that summarizes the historical context in which Micah prophesied. See the section in the Introduction entitled “Micah’s message and its relation to the cultural and religious background of Israel.”

4:9b

Is there no king among you?

- Is there no king who rules in you^(sing)?
- Is it because you^(plur) no longer have a king?

4:9c

Has your counselor perished

- Has your^(sing) counselor/adviser disappeared/died?
- Perhaps you are fearful because you^(plur) no longer anyone to advise you.

4:9d

so that anguish grips you like a woman in labor?

- Is that the reason you^(sing) are groaning in pain like a woman who is having a baby?
- Perhaps that is the reason you^(plur) are shouting like a woman who has labor pains.
- You^(plur) are very afraid, so you are behaving like a woman who is in pain because she is giving birth.

so that anguish grips you like a woman in labor?: In the BSB, this verse part is a continuation of the third rhetorical question in 4:9c. Some other versions make it a separate question. For example:

Is this why pain grips you as if you were a woman in labor? (NET)

Are you suffering like a woman in childbirth? (CEV)

This last question is related to the first question in 4:9a. There Micah asked the people why they were crying out. Here he uses a simile to compare their cries to a woman who is having severe labor pains. The reason they are crying in such a way is because of their fear and distress at the disasters that threaten Jerusalem, their king, and themselves.

Some versions change this rhetorical question to a statement. For example:

Pain grips you like a woman in labor. (GW)

General Comment on 4:9a-d

In some languages, it may be clearer or more natural to combine and/or reorder parts of these lines. For example:

^{9a}Why do you cry out so loudly? ^{9d}Why are you suffering like a woman in labor? ^{9b}Is it because you have no king ^{9c}to counsel you? (adapted from GNT)

Micah 4:10

Section 4:9-13: The people of Jerusalem will suffer exile in Babylon, but in the future the LORD will deliver them from their enemies

In this section, the LORD spoke about the future. He said that he would punish his people. He would cause their enemies to take them as captives to Babylon. But the LORD also promised that in the future he would regather his people. He would make them a strong nation, and he would rule over them. Scholars analyze the structure of 4:9-5:15 in different ways. The Notes will list only a few of the analyses here; some of them have only minor variations. A&F (page 394) posit five sections, each beginning with *‘attâ* “now” (4:9-10a, 10b, 11-13, 14; 5:1-3) [5:4-5, 6, 7-9, 10-15]. In this analysis, 4:11-13 forms the center unit, with two units on either side. WBC (vol. 32, pages 11-12) has 4:9-10, 11-13; 5:1-4, 5-6, 7-9, 10-15. NICOT (page 257), NAC (page 42) and Waltke 2007 (page viii) have 4:9-10, 11-13; 5:1-

6, 7-9, 10-15. TOTC (page 150) and Waltke 1993 (page 598) has 4:9-13; 5:1-6, 7-9, 10-15.

In this section, as in the previous section, Micah quoted the words of the LORD and also sometimes referred to the LORD in the third person.

The Notes have divided this section into two paragraphs. If a separate paragraph heading will be helpful for your readers, here are some possible headings for each paragraph.

⁹⁻¹⁰Why the Israelites Must Go to Babylon (NCV)

⁹⁻¹⁰Current suffering and captivity, but future rescue

¹¹⁻¹³Her Enemies to Be Crushed on the Threshing-Floor (NJB)

¹¹⁻¹³Jerusalem will completely destroy its enemies

Paragraph 4:9-10

In this paragraph, Micah told the people of Jerusalem what would happen in the future. Enemies would capture Jerusalem and take away the people as captives to Babylon. The king, who was their counselor, would be unable to help them (4:9a-4:10e). After that, God would rescue his people (4:10f-g).

4:10

In this verse, Micah told the people of Jerusalem it was appropriate for them to writhe and groan (10a-b) because of the things that would happen to them (10c-e) before the LORD rescued them (10f-g).

4:10a

Writhe in agony, O Daughter of Zion,

- People of Zion, I tell you^(plur) to writhe and moan
- Yes, inhabitants of Jerusalem, it is appropriate that you contort your bodies and groan because you are sorrowful.

Writhe in agony, O Daughter of Zion: Writhe in agony is a command. Micah meant that it was okay for the people to Writhe in agony. It was appropriate. Here are some other ways to translate this command:

Keep on groaning with pain, you people of Jerusalem! (CEV)

Twist and groan, people of Jerusalem (GNT)

Writhe: People usually Writhe (twist or contort their bodies) because they are in pain or because they are very sad and distressed.

4:10b like a woman in labor.

- like a woman who is having labor pains,
- You^(plur) are like a woman who is in pain because she is giving birth.

like a woman in labor: See 4:9d.

4:10c For now you will leave the city

- for now you^(plur) must leave your city.
- It is appropriate for you to be sorrowful, because now I prophesy that your enemies will force you to leave your city.

For now you will leave the city: In this verse part as well as 4:10d–e, Micah gave the reasons that the people of Jerusalem should “writhe in agony.” The first reason is that the people would leave the city.

It is implied that an enemy army would capture Jerusalem and force the people to leave. One way to make this implication clear is to use a word such as “must.” For example:

for now you must leave the city (NIV)

4:10d and camp in the open fields.

- And then you^(plur) will have to camp outside in the fields/countryside.
- Then you will have to stay outside in open fields.

and camp in the open fields: When the Babylonian army destroyed Jerusalem, they forced many of the Jews to move to lands close to Babylon. The trip to Babylon took many days. On that long trip, the Jews camped or slept in fields.

open fields: In Hebrew, this phrase is a word that refers to land outside a city. It can be farm land, or it can be prairie. (See also 1:6; 2:2; 2:4; and 3:12, where the same Hebrew word is used.)

4:10e You will go to Babylon;

- You^(plur) must go to Babylon.
- You will go as exiles/prisoners to the city of Babylon.

You will go to Babylon: Micah predicted that the people of Jerusalem would go to Babylon. It is implied that the people would be forced to go there as cap-

tives. Here are some other ways to make this implied meaning clear:

to Babylon you must go (NJB)

You will soon be sent in exile to distant Babylon. (NLT)

Babylon: This is the name of a city.

4:10f–g

In contrast to the bad news in 4:10c–e, Micah predicted here that God would rescue them and bring them back again to their homeland. This was good news. Some versions use the conjunction “but” at the beginning of 4:10f to show this contrast. For example:

^{10e}You will go to Babylon, ^{10f}but there you will be rescued. (NET)

Notice the verse parts in these parallel lines that are similar in meaning:

^{10f} there **you will be rescued;**

^{10g} there **the LORD will redeem you...**

These lines refer to the same event.

there...there: The word there in 10f and 10g refers to Babylon. These two words are emphatic. The Jews would go as captives to Babylon. It was there that the LORD would rescue them.

4:10f there you will be rescued;

- There in Babylon you^(plur) will be rescued.
- From that place Yahweh will later deliver/save you.

you will be rescued: This verb is passive. The implied agent (explicit in 10g) is “the LORD.” For example:

But the Lord will rescue you there (NLT)

4:10g there the LORD will redeem you from the hand of your enemies!

- There Yahweh will redeem/ransom you^(plur) from the power of your enemies.
- There he will pay the price to set you free from your enemies.

the LORD will redeem you: In Hebrew, the word redeem means to liberate (set free) someone by paying a debt or a penalty for that person. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

there Yahweh will ransom you (NJB)

The Lord...will buy you back (NCV)

from the hand of your enemies: The word hand here is a figure of speech that represents power. To save someone from the hand of an enemy means to save them from that enemy's power. You can say "the LORD will redeem you from your enemies' power." Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

from the clutches of your enemies (NJB)

from the power of your enemies (NET)

General Comment on 4:10f–g

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine these parallel clauses. For example:

but there the Lord will save you from your enemies (GNT)

Micah 4:11

Section 4:9–13: The people of Jerusalem will suffer exile in Babylon, but in the future the LORD will deliver them from their enemies

In this section, the LORD spoke about the future. He said that he would punish his people. He would cause their enemies to take them as captives to Babylon. But the LORD also promised that in the future he would regather his people. He would make them a strong nation, and he would rule over them. Scholars analyze the structure of 4:9–5:15 in different ways. The Notes will list only a few of the analyses here; some of them have only minor variations. A&F (page 394) posit five sections, each beginning with *‘attâ* "now" (4:9–10a, 10b, 11–13, 14; 5:1–3) [5:4–5, 6, 7–9, 10–15]. In this analysis, 4:11–13 forms the center unit, with two units on either side. WBC (vol. 32, pages 11–12) has 4:9–10, 11–13; 5:1–4, 5–6, 7–9, 10–15. NICOT (page 257), NAC (page 42) and Waltke 2007 (page viii) have 4:9–10, 11–13; 5:1–6, 7–9, 10–15. TOTC (page 150) and Waltke 1993 (page 598) has 4:9–13; 5:1–6, 7–9, 10–15.

In this section, as in the previous section, Micah quoted the words of the LORD and also sometimes referred to the LORD in the third person.

The Notes have divided this section into two paragraphs. If a separate paragraph heading will be helpful for your readers, here are some possible headings for each paragraph.

^{9–10}Why the Israelites Must Go to Babylon (NCV)

^{9–10}Current suffering and captivity, but future rescue

^{11–13}Her Enemies to Be Crushed on the Threshing-Floor (NJB)

^{11–13}Jerusalem will completely destroy its enemies

Paragraph 4:11–13

In this paragraph, Micah told the people of Jerusalem that people of many nations had gathered together to attack Jerusalem. But actually, the LORD had a different plan. He had gathered those nations together to punish those nations. He would make his people strong so they could defeat their enemies.

In 4:11–12, Micah used a Hebrew verb tense that usually refers to events that have already happened or that are now happening. The verbs that are in perfect tense in 4:11–12 are: "have assembled" (11a), "saying" (11b), "know" (12a), "understand" (12a), and "has gathered" (12b).

Throughout this paragraph (4:11–13), Micah wrote as if many nations had already assembled to attack Jerusalem. But the time period to which he referred has similar uncertainties to 4:9b–c. See the notes on those verse parts. The recommendation here is the same: translate in a way that allows either a present time or a future time to be understood.

4:11a

But now many nations have assembled against you,

- ¶ City of Jerusalem, now soldiers from many nations have come together to wage war against you^(sing).
- ¶ But now enemies from many countries are gathering to attack you^(plur) people who live in Jerusalem.

But now many nations have assembled against you:

The current situation for the people in Jerusalem contrasts with their future exile in Babylon (4:10e). Right now, the armies of enemy nations are preparing to attack the city. They have come together in a large

group. The BSB and some other versions make this contrast explicit. For example:

But now many nations are massed against you
(REB)

But now many nations have come to fight against
you (NCV)

you: In Hebrew, this pronoun is singular. It refers to Zion (Jerusalem), which is mentioned in the next verse part (4:11b). As in previous verses, you may decide to use a singular pronoun that refers to the city or a plural pronoun that refers to the people of the city.

4:11b–c (combined/reordered)

- They say, “Let’s dishonor Zion and gloat over it.” (GW)
- They say, “We can hardly wait to see you disgraced.” (adapted from CEV)

These parallel lines both express the desire of the enemy troops who were preparing to attack the city. The underlined parts both refer to Zion. The parts in bold print express the enemies’ related desires.

^{11b}saying, “**Let her be defiled,**

^{11c}and **let us feast our eyes on Zion.**”

Let...let...: Usually in English, we use the word “let” to ask permission. For example, “Let them go” = “allow them to go.” But that is not the meaning here. When the enemy soldiers said these words, they meant that they wanted (wished, hoped) that these two things would happen.

4:11b saying, “**Let her be defiled,**

- They say, “May she/it be desecrated/defiled!
- Those people/enemies say, “Come on, we^(incl) will be happy to tear down the holy places in Jerusalem/Zion!
- They say, “We truly want to dishonor/disgrace your^(plur) city.

saying: This word introduces the quote in the next two parallel lines. Here are some other ways to introduce their words:

They say, “...

This is what those enemy soldiers are saying: “...

Let her be defiled: The first thing that they wanted to happen is for Zion (Jerusalem) to be defiled. To defile something means “to desecrate it.” It means “to treat a holy place with disrespect by making it dirty or by destroying it.”

Jerusalem was a holy place, because the temple was there. These people wanted to defile it with their presence and to destroy the city so it would no longer be holy. Here are some other ways to translate this desire:

May Zion be defiled/desecrated!

We^(incl) want her to suffer outrage (adapted from REB)

We will dishonor/disgrace Zion/Jerusalem

Let’s destroy Jerusalem. (NCV)

Let her be profaned (NRSV)

4:11c and let us feast our eyes on Zion.”

- We^(incl) will gloat as we watch Zion city be destroyed.”
- We want to watch people destroy that city.”
- It will make us happy to see the city in ruins.”

and let us feast our eyes on Zion: The word and links the two things that the enemies wanted to happen. Some versions leave this word untranslated. For example:

let our eyes gloat over Zion!” (NIV)

Link these two clauses in a natural way in your translation.

This is a figure of speech in which the eyes represent the person. It means that these people wanted to look at Zion and gloat as they defiled/destroyed it. Their desire was similar to a man who is filled with malicious delight as he gazes at or thinks about a woman that he has raped. UBS (pages 200–201), JFB (page 692). Here are some other ways to translate this line:

Let us gloat over Zion!” (NJB)

We will look at her and be glad we have defeated her.” (NCV)

We^(incl) will be happy to see Zion/Jerusalem after we^(incl) destroy it.

General Comment on 4:11b–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel lines. For example:

This is what they say: “We want to disgrace and destroy the city of Zion and to enjoy watching the humiliation of the people who live there.”

See 4:11b–c (combined/reordered) in the Display for other examples.

Micah 4:12

Section 4:9–13: The people of Jerusalem will suffer exile in Babylon, but in the future the LORD will deliver them from their enemies

In this section, the LORD spoke about the future. He said that he would punish his people. He would cause their enemies to take them as captives to Babylon. But the LORD also promised that in the future he would regather his people. He would make them a strong nation, and he would rule over them. Scholars analyze the structure of 4:9–5:15 in different ways. The Notes will list only a few of the analyses here; some of them have only minor variations. A&F (page 394) posit five sections, each beginning with *‘attâ* “now” (4:9–10a, 10b, 11–13, 14; 5:1–3) [5:4–5, 6, 7–9, 10–15]. In this analysis, 4:11–13 forms the center unit, with two units on either side. WBC (vol. 32, pages 11–12) has 4:9–10, 11–13; 5:1–4, 5–6, 7–9, 10–15. NICOT (page 257), NAC (page 42) and Waltke 2007 (page viii) have 4:9–10, 11–13; 5:1–6, 7–9, 10–15. TOTC (page 150) and Waltke 1993 (page 598) has 4:9–13; 5:1–6, 7–9, 10–15.

In this section, as in the previous section, Micah quoted the words of the LORD and also sometimes referred to the LORD in the third person.

The Notes have divided this section into two paragraphs. If a separate paragraph heading will be helpful for your readers, here are some possible headings for each paragraph.

^{9–10}Why the Israelites Must Go to Babylon (NCV)

^{9–10}Current suffering and captivity, but future rescue

^{11–13}Her Enemies to Be Crushed on the Threshing-Floor (NJB)

^{11–13}Jerusalem will completely destroy its enemies

Paragraph 4:11–13

In this paragraph, Micah told the people of Jerusalem that people of many nations had gathered together to attack Jerusalem. But actually, the LORD had a different plan. He had gathered those nations together to punish those nations. He would make his people strong so they could defeat their enemies.

In 4:11–12, Micah used a Hebrew verb tense that usually refers to events that have already happened or that are now happening. The verbs that are in perfect tense in 4:11–12 are: “have assembled” (11a), “saying” (11b), “know” (12a), “understand” (12a), and “has gathered” (12b).

Throughout this paragraph (4:11–13), Micah wrote as if many nations had already assembled to attack Jerusalem. But the time period to which he referred has similar uncertainties to 4:9b–c. See the notes on those verse parts. The recommendation here is the same: translate in a way that allows either a present time or a future time to be understood.

4:12

Verse 12 begins with an emphatic contrast: “But they....” In verse 11 Micah spoke about what foreign enemies planned to do to Jerusalem. Here in verse 12, he spoke about what the LORD planned to do.

Those enemies had gathered together to attack Jerusalem. That was their plan. But the LORD had a different plan: the LORD allowed those people to gather together in order to punish them.

The first two lines in this verse are parallel. Notice the parallel parts in 4:12a–b that are similar in meaning:

^{12a}But they do not know the **thoughts** of the LORD,

^{12b}or understand His **plan**,

Verse 4:12c explains the content of the “thoughts/plan of the LORD”:

^{12c}for He has gathered them like sheaves to the threshing floor.

4:12a

But they do not know the thoughts of the LORD

- But they do not know what Yahweh is thinking.

- But these people/enemies who talk like that do not know what is in Yahweh's mind.

But they: The words But they introduce an emphatic contrast. In Hebrew, this contrast is indicated by the conjunction *wā* and the emphatic independent pronoun *hemmah* "they." The plan of the foreign enemies was to defeat and humiliate the city of Zion and its inhabitants (4:11b–c). By contrast, the plan of the LORD was to punish these enemies (4:12c). A few versions do not indicate this contrast explicitly. Indicate the emphatic contrast in a natural way in your language.

do not know the thoughts of the LORD: The word thoughts refers to what the LORD is thinking. Specifically, it refers here to what he is planning in his mind to do. Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

But they don't know what the Lord is thinking
(NCV)

But these nations do not know what is in the
Lord's mind. (GNT)

4:12b or understand His plan,

- They do not know what he plans/intends to do.
- They do not understand what Yahweh's purpose is in allowing/causing this to happen.

or understand His plan: The word plan refers here to what the LORD has decided/determined to do. Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

they do not understand his design (NJB)

they do not understand his strategy (NET)

and they do not understand His purpose (NASB)

4:12c for He has gathered them like sheaves to the threshing floor.

- He is gathering them together like people gather sheaves of wheat in order to thresh them.
- Yahweh's plan is this: he has gathered together those people in order to punish them. It will be like people who gather newly-cut stalks/heads of wheat/grain so they can trample on them at the place where they separate the grain from the stalks.

- The truth is that it is Yahweh who gathered those enemy people together so that he can completely defeat them.

for He has gathered them like sheaves to the threshing floor: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew word *ki* (BSB *for*) that begins this verse part:

1. Micah used this word to identify the content of the LORD's plan. Most versions translate it with the word "that" or leave it implied.

These nations don't know that he is gathering them together to be beaten and trampled like sheaves of grain on a threshing floor. (NLT)

He has gathered them like bundles of grain to the threshing floor. (NCV) (CEV, ESV, GW, NCV, NET, NJB, NLT, NRSV, GNT)

1. A few versions translate it as *for*. Micah used this word to explain what Jerusalem's enemies do not understand. For example:

For He has gathered them like sheaves to the threshing floor. (NASB) (BSB, NASB, KJV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most English versions. Almost no commentaries discuss this issue. Only one commentary supports interpretation (2). KD (page 319) says that *ki* means "for:" "The sentence explains the assertion that they do not understand the counsel of the Lord." Waltke 2007 (page 254) translates *ki* as "surely," and identifies it as "an emphatic causal adverb." WBC (page 41) does not comment, but his translation supports the NRSV and the strong majority of English versions.

He has gathered them like sheaves to the threshing floor: The pronoun *He* refers to the LORD. The pronoun *them* refers to the soldiers of "many nations" who have gathered.

Micah used a simile here. He compared what the LORD did to what people do when they gather sheaves of grain to thresh them. There are at least two points of similarity:

1. The LORD gathered the nations to fulfill his own plans. People gather sheaves of grain in order to thresh them.
2. The LORD intended to treat the nations harshly and punish or destroy them. People treat sheaves of grain harshly by causing animals to trample on

them and pull hard, sharp threshing sledges over them.

sheaves: The word sheaves refers to heads of ripe grain. The two most common grains in Israel were wheat and barley. The Jews harvested grain by cutting the stalk below the head of ripe grain. Then they gathered these stalks of grain and carried them to a threshing floor.

threshing floor: A threshing floor is a flat smooth area of hard ground or rock. This is the place where people removed the grains from the stalks. People placed the harvested stalks of grain on the floor. Then they made cows walk on the stalks or pull a threshing sledge over the stalks. (A threshing sledge is a heavy piece of wood with bits of sharp metal or stones on the bottom.) This knocked the grains from the stalks. Then people separated the grain from the empty stalks by winnowing. Winnowing involves tossing the threshed chaff and grain into the air on a windy day. In many cultures, a wide, fairly flat winnowing basket is used for this purpose. The wind then blows away the chaff, leaving the grain in the basket.

Here are some ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Translate the simile without making any points of similarity explicit. For example:

He has gathered them as people gather stalks of grain at a threshing floor.

- Make one or more of the points of similarity explicit, as in the NLT (quoted above). Here is another example:

...they have been gathered together to be punished in the same way that grain is brought in to be threshed (GNT)

- Replace this simile with a comparison that people in your area will understand. For example:

The LORD has gathered them together in order to destroy them. It will be like when people gather snail shells and burn them and crush them to make lime.

- Translate without a simile. For example:

The LORD plans to gather them together to utterly destroy them.

Use an option that will be acceptable and well understood in your language area.

Micah 4:13

Section 4:9–13: The people of Jerusalem will suffer exile in Babylon, but in the future the LORD will deliver them from their enemies

In this section, the LORD spoke about the future. He said that he would punish his people. He would cause their enemies to take them as captives to Babylon. But the LORD also promised that in the future he would regather his people. He would make them a strong nation, and he would rule over them. Scholars analyze the structure of 4:9–5:15 in different ways. The Notes will list only a few of the analyses here; some of them have only minor variations. A&F (page 394) posit five sections, each beginning with *‘attâ* “now” (4:9–10a, 10b, 11–13, 14; 5:1–3) [5:4–5, 6, 7–9, 10–15]. In this analysis, 4:11–13 forms the center unit, with two units on either side. WBC (vol. 32, pages 11–12) has 4:9–10, 11–13; 5:1–4, 5–6, 7–9, 10–15. NICOT (page 257), NAC (page 42) and Waltke 2007 (page viii) have 4:9–10, 11–13; 5:1–6, 7–9, 10–15. TOTC (page 150) and Waltke 1993 (page 598) has 4:9–13; 5:1–6, 7–9, 10–15.

In this section, as in the previous section, Micah quoted the words of the LORD and also sometimes referred to the LORD in the third person.

The Notes have divided this section into two paragraphs. If a separate paragraph heading will be helpful for your readers, here are some possible headings for each paragraph.

^{9–10}Why the Israelites Must Go to Babylon (NCV)

^{9–10}Current suffering and captivity, but future rescue

^{11–13}Her Enemies to Be Crushed on the Threshing-Floor (NJB)

^{11–13}Jerusalem will completely destroy its enemies

Paragraph 4:11–13

In this paragraph, Micah told the people of Jerusalem that people of many nations had gathered together to attack Jerusalem. But actually, the LORD had a different plan. He had gathered those nations together to punish those nations. He would make his people strong so they could defeat their enemies.

In 4:11–12, Micah used a Hebrew verb tense that usually refers to events that have already happened or that are now happening. The verbs that are in perfect tense in 4:11–12 are: “have assembled” (11a), “saying” (11b), “know” (12a), “understand” (12a), and “has gathered” (12b).

Throughout this paragraph (4:11–13), Micah wrote as if many nations had already assembled to attack Jerusalem. But the time period to which he referred has similar uncertainties to 4:9b–c. See the notes on those verse parts. The recommendation here is the same: translate in a way that allows either a present time or a future time to be understood.

4:13

In TN and most versions, 4:11–13 is one paragraph. Some versions make 4:13 a separate paragraph. The following English translations begin a new paragraph at 4:13: NCV, NIV, NLT96, RSV, and GNT. The NIV also divides 4:13 into two paragraphs. You may do whatever fits the paragraph structure of your language.

4:13a

Rise and thresh, O Daughter of Zion,

- “People of Jerusalem! Go^(plur) attack your enemies! Attack them severely like people thresh wheat!
- Yahweh says: “O people of Jerusalem! Go ahead! Attack and destroy your enemies!

Rise and thresh, O Daughter of Zion: Micah here quoted the words of the LORD. The LORD’s command to the Daughter of Zion has two actions: Rise and thresh. In the Old Testament, the word Rise is often used in commands that summon people to fight their enemies. After the people rise, they are to thresh. Here are some other ways to translate this command:

Get up and thresh (GW)

Start your threshing (NJB)

thresh: For the meaning of thresh and for translation advice, see the notes on 4:12c. In this verse, thresh is a metaphor that compares the action of attacking an enemy to threshing grain.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Rise and thresh (NIV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

Rise up and thresh like a cow threshing grain.

Get up and crush your enemy as a cow threshes grain.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

go and punish your enemies! (GNT)

Smash them to pieces (CEV)

4:13b–c

(combined/reordered)

- You will be able to do this, for I will make you^(plur) strong. You will be as strong as a bull with horns made of iron and hooves made of bronze.

In these lines, the LORD used two metaphors to assure the people of Zion that he will give them the strength they need to destroy their enemies. KD (pages 319–321) and NICOT (pages 334–338).

Notice the parallel lines that are similar in meaning:

^{13b}for I will give **you horns of iron**

^{13c}and **hooves of bronze**

In Hebrew, there is an ellipsis (deliberate omission) of the words “I will give” in the second line. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words. For example:

^{13c}and I will give you **hooves of bronze**

I will give you horns of iron and hooves of bronze:

These metaphors compare the people of Jerusalem to a very strong ox or bull.

Here are some other ways to translate these metaphors:

- Keep the metaphors. For example:

I will give you horns of iron; I will give you hooves of bronze (NIV)

- Change the metaphors to similes. For example:

I shall make your horn like iron, I shall make your hooves like bronze. (NJB)

- Change the metaphors to similes and make some aspects of the meaning explicit. For example:

I will make you as strong as a bull with iron horns and bronze hoofs. (GNT)

I will make you strong as if you had horns of iron and hoofs of bronze. (NCV)

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

I will make you strong so that your enemies will be unable to defend themselves against you.

iron...bronze: Iron and bronze were the strongest metals available in the time of the Old Testament prophets. UBS (pages 202–203). In these metaphors, they symbolize great strength as well as hardness. Waltke 2007 (page 255–256).

4:13b

for I will give you horns of iron

- You will be able to do this, because I will make your^(plur) horns as strong and hard as iron,
- I will make you as strong as a bull with iron horns

for: This word introduces the reason that the people of Israel can be confident.

horns: Here horns refers to the horn of an ox or bull. In the first metaphor, it symbolizes strength. EBC (page 528).

4:13c

and hooves of bronze

- and I will make your^(plur) hoofs as hard as bronze.
- and bronze hoofs.

hooves: Oxen or bulls threshed grain under their hooves. In the second metaphor, hooves symbolized the people's ability to kick, maim, and crush their enemies. NICOT (pages 334–338).

4:13d

to break to pieces many peoples.

- You^(plur) will crush/trample many nations,
- You will utterly defeat the armies/soldiers of many countries,

to break to pieces many peoples: This line is probably a continuation of the metaphor of threshing. It compares the action of people killing the enemy soldiers to the action of oxen or bulls crushing and breaking stalks of grain into many pieces.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

so you can trample many nations to pieces (NLT)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

You will crush many nations like a bull that crushes stalks of grain into many pieces.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

You will completely destroy the enemy armies that surround you.

There are two main ways to understand the relationship of this line to the preceding lines. Either way is acceptable.

- This action is part of the command of the LORD to the people to arise and thresh. Here he tells them how and who to thresh. For example:

You will beat many nations into small pieces (NCV)

- This action is the reason why the LORD will make their horns like iron and their hoofs like bronze. He will do this so that they can defeat their enemies. For example:

so that you can crush many peoples (NJB)

break to pieces: In Hebrew, this is a verb that means “crush,” “grind,” “break in pieces.” TWOT (#448). Here it implies crushing the grain into powder. Waltke 2007 (page 256) uses the phrases “totally pulverizing the grain into powder and nothingness” and “grinding them as fine as dust.” If you translate this line as part of the threshing metaphor, use a word that fits the action of threshing. See UBS (pages 202–203). HALOT (electronic edition, page 230) lists Micah 4:13 as metaphorical. For example:

crush (NJB)

pulverize (NASB)

break to pieces (NIV)

trample (NLT)

many peoples: Here this phrase refers specifically to the soldiers/armies of other countries that are gathered together to fight against the people of Jerusalem.

4:13e–f (combined/reordered)

- and you will offer/dedicate the wealth that they unjustly gained to me, Yahweh, the lord/ruler of all the nations on earth.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{13e}Then you will devote their gain **to the LORD**,

^{13f} their wealth **to the Lord of the whole earth**.

In Hebrew, there is an ellipsis (deliberate omission) of the words “and will devote” in the second line. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words. For example:

^{13f} and will devote their wealth **to the Lord of the whole earth**.

In these lines, the LORD told the people of Zion what to do with the plunder that they will collect from the armies of the nations that they destroy.

Then you will devote: There is a textual issue here:

1. The LXX (Septuagint) has “and you will dedicate to the LORD.” For example:

You will devote their ill-gotten gains to the Lord (NIV) (CEV, ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB, BSB, GNT)

1. The Masoretic Text has “and I will totally destroy for Yahweh.” For example:

and I will consecrate their gain unto the Lord (KJV) (KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and commentaries. A footnote in NICOT (pages 334–338) says that *wāhaharamti* is an archaic form of the second feminine singular. It cites in support the LXX, the Peshitta, the Vulgate, the Targum and Gesenius’ Hebrew Grammar. An NJPS footnote also concurs with this analysis of the word form.

devote their gain...their wealth to the Lord: The phrases their gain and their wealth refer to the possessions of the enemy. The phrase their gain refers specifically to items that they had taken from people unjustly and through violence. Derivative under BDB (#1214). The phrase their wealth is a more general term for possessions of value. BDB (#2428).

The LORD told the people of Jerusalem not to keep for themselves the items that they capture from their enemies. They were told to devote their gain/wealth to the LORD. Here are some other ways to translate the first phrase:

You will present their stolen riches to the Lord (NLT)

You will claim their loot for the Lord (GW)

the wealth they got by violence you will present to me... (GNT)

This phrase probably means that they were to transfer valuable metal objects to the sanctuary and destroy everything else by burning it in honor of the LORD. See NICOT (pages 334–338), UBS (pages 202–203), KD (pages 319–321), and NAC (pages 93–94). Waltke 2007 (pages 256–257) focuses on the meaning of destruction: “Israel gave the *herem* over to I AM by totally destroying it (Isa 43:28). By consecrating it to unholiness and destruction, not taking anything of the booty for themselves, Israel bore testimony that the spoils belong to I AM and rid the earth of their illicit gain.” It is suggested that you supply this information in a footnote rather than in your translation itself.

the LORD...the Lord of all the earth: In Hebrew, the word for Lord is literally “Yahweh.” The word for Lord is literally “lord” (Hebrew *ʾadon*).

The phrase Lord of all the earth indicates that Yahweh is the ruler over all nations, whether or not they recognize him as their ruler. UBS (pages 202–204).

4:13e

Then you will devote their gain to the LORD,

- and you will present/offer the riches they stole from others to me, Yahweh.

4:13f

their wealth to the Lord of all the earth.

- You will offer their wealth to me, the master/lord of the whole earth.

Micah 5:1

Section 5:1–6: A ruler will be born in Bethlehem

In this section, Micah told the people of Jerusalem that an enemy would come against them who would cause them to suffer. But their suffering would end when a strong ruler came from Bethlehem. He would enable the people to defeat their enemies and would bring peace.

Here are some other examples of section headings: Some versions place a similar heading before verse 2. For example, the NRSV has “The Ruler from Bethlehem,” and the NET has “A King Will Come and a Remnant Will Prosper.”

A Promised Ruler (CEV)

The Ruler to Be Born in Bethlehem (ESV)

Birth of the King in Bethlehem (NASB)

Note: TN and most English versions number the verses in this chapter as 5:1–15. The NAB, NJB, and NJPS number the verses according to the Hebrew Text (BHS): 4:14–5:14. NET footnote (a). When TN quotes one of these four versions, it will adjust the numbering to follow the BSB and most English versions.

Paragraphs: In some cases, the paragraph divisions are not indicated or else differ between Paratext, TW, Logos, and Bible Gateway. In such cases, TN has tried to follow the majority. The Notes will divide this section into the following paragraphs: 5:1, 2–4, 5–6 (NJB). Divide the paragraphs in a way that will be appropriate and acceptable to the readers in your language area.

Paragraph 5:1

There are two main ways to interpret the connection of Micah 5:1 to the verses before and after it:

1. Micah 5:1 connects more closely to the verses after it. It begins a new prophecy that contrasts a current bad situation for the people of Jerusalem with a future good situation. For example:

^{5:1} Marshal your troops now, city of troops, for a siege is laid against us. They will strike Israel's ruler on the cheek with a rod. ^{5:2a} But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah... out of you will come for me one who will be ruler over Israel... (NIV11) (CEV, ESV, KJV, NABRE, NASB, BSB, NIV11, NJB, NLT96, NRSV, REB, VOICE)

1. Micah 5:1 connects more closely to the verses before it. It is the last part of the preceding prophecy or else it returns to a theme from earlier verses. Micah tells the people to prepare to fight the enemy that has begun to attack them. For example:

^{4:13a} “Get up and beat them, people of Jerusalem. I will make you strong...” ^{5:1a} So, strong city, gather your soldiers together.... (NCV) (NCV, NET) Both the NCV and the NET indicate this connection by placing 5:1 in the same paragraph with the previous material and by inserting a new paragraph and section heading following 5:1. The NCV also indicates this connection with the word “So.”

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

In this verse, Micah is probably the speaker. The pronoun “us” in 5:1b suggests that Micah here identified himself with the people of Jerusalem who were under siege.

5:1a

Now, O daughter of troops, mobilize your troops;

- ¶ Now gather your^(sing) troops, city of soldiers,
- ¶ O fighting men of Jerusalem, now is the time to make ready your^(plur) troops.

Now, O daughter of troops, mobilize your troops:

There is a textual issue here:

1. The MT has “now you will gather your troops (or cut yourself) O daughter of troops.” For example:

Now muster yourselves in troops, daughter of troops (NASB) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NABRE, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, GNT)

1. The LXX has “Now a daughter will be blocked with a blockage.” For example:

Now you are walled around with a wall (NRSV) (NAB, NJB, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions.

There are two main interpretations of the recommended textual option (MT):

1. The clause means “now you will gather yourselves in a troop, O daughter of troops.” BDB #1413 2. gather in troops, or bands. For example:

Now muster your troops, O daughter of troops (ESV) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NLT, GNT)

1. The clause means “now you will cut yourself, O daughter of troops.” BDB #1413 1. cut oneself, as religious (heathen) practice. It refers to the middle-eastern cultural practice of cutting oneself to demonstrate grief. For example:

Now you gash yourself in grief. (NJPS) (NABRE, NET, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

Now: The word Now introduces a description of the present (Micah’s) time. It also marks the start of a new prophecy.

O daughter of troops: The Hebrew phrase daughter of troops is a term of address (vocative). Some versions have added the word O to indicate this. Use a vocative that is natural in your language when a person speaks to a group of people.

The phrase daughter of troops is also a figure of speech. Its meaning is related to the word troops. The meaning of the figure of speech “daughter of...” depends on the meaning of the following word. For example, the expression “daughter of Zion,” refers to the people of Zion. See BDB #1323 sense 3 and the notes on this expression in 1:13b. Sometimes the following word may indicate a quality or characteristic of the people. For example, “daughter of a strange god” refers to people who worship idols. See BDB #1323 sense 5. There are two main interpretations:

1. It refers to troops of fighting men from Jerusalem. For example:

Now muster yourselves in troops, daughter of troops (NASB) (ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, BSB, NIV, NLT, GNT)

1. It refers to enemy troops of fighting men that surround the city of Jerusalem. Favored by WBC (pages 42–44) and NICOT (pages 339–347). For example:

daughter surrounded by soldiers (NET) (NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. Figures of speech that begin with the phrase daughter of... generally refer to a characteristic of the daughter rather than the daughter’s situation. According to JFB (page 692), the expression

refers to Jerusalem’s many troops. According to Pusey (page 67), it refers to Jerusalem’s marauding, violent bands. Also EBC (page 529), and BDB #1323 sense 5.

In some languages, this figure of speech may be unnatural. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a different idiom or figure of speech that conveys the right meaning in your language. For example:

city of troops (NIV11)

- Translate the meaning directly without using a figure of speech. For example:

Jerusalem with your many fighting men
Some versions translate only part of the meaning. For example, the GNT has “People of Jerusalem.”

- Leave this term of address implied. For example:

Mobilize! Marshal your troops! (NLT)

mobilize your troops: This phrase is a command. Micah told the people of Jerusalem to gather themselves or their fighting men into one or more groups to defend the city from attacks by the enemy. Here is another way to translate this command:

gather your soldiers together (NCV)

5:1b for a siege is laid against us!

- because enemy soldiers have laid siege to us^(incl)!
- Your^(plur) enemies have surrounded you^(plur)!

a siege is laid against us: This clause describes a blockade of Jerusalem by enemy soldiers. The purpose of a siege is to force the people to surrender. According to UBS (pages 204–205), those that attacked a city often built a wall around it to cut off its communications and protect their own troops.

This is a passive clause. In some languages, it may be necessary to use an active clause and to make explicit a subject of the verb. For example:

The enemy is laying siege to Jerusalem. (NLT)

Jerusalem, enemy troops have surrounded you (CEV)

5:1c**With a rod they will strike the cheek of the judge of Israel.**

- They will strike the leader of Israel on his face with a stick/rod.
- These enemies will shame the ruler of Israel. They will slap him on the side of his face with their leader's scepter/rod.

With a rod they will strike the cheek of the judge of Israel:

This clause describes an act of extreme humiliation and insult by the enemies against the king of Israel. See NICOT (pages 339–347), Pusey (page 67), and WBC (pages 42–44).

In some languages, it may be helpful to make explicit the referent of they in your translation. For example:

Enemies will strike the judge of Israel on the cheek with a stick. (GW)

rod: This word is literally “stick,” “staff,” or “scepter.” Many versions translate this word as rod or “stick.” However, here it may refer to a scepter, which indicates the authority of the one holding it. HALOT (electronic edition, page 1388). In this context, it may imply that the enemies have power over the king of Israel. For example:

With a scepter they strike Israel's ruler (NET)

cheek: This word refers to the side of the face. Here are some other ways to translate it:

in the face (NLT)

on the side of his face (NET)

the judge of Israel: The BSB translation here is very literal. However, here the word judge refers to Israel's ruler. At that time, the king had the responsibility to judge the people with justice. NICOT (pages 339–347). Most versions translate this phrase as the ruler or leader of Israel. For example:

they will strike Israel's leader (NLT)

Micah 5:2**Section 5:1–6: A ruler will be born in Bethlehem**

In this section, Micah told the people of Jerusalem that an enemy would come against them who would cause them to suffer. But their suffering would end

when a strong ruler came from Bethlehem. He would enable the people to defeat their enemies and would bring peace.

Here are some other examples of section headings: Some versions place a similar heading before verse 2. For example, the NRSV has “The Ruler from Bethlehem,” and the NET has “A King Will Come and a Remnant Will Prosper.”

A Promised Ruler (CEV)

The Ruler to Be Born in Bethlehem (ESV)

Birth of the King in Bethlehem (NASB)

Note: TN and most English versions number the verses in this chapter as 5:1–15. The NAB, NJB, and NJPS number the verses according to the Hebrew Text (BHS): 4:14–5:14. NET footnote (a). When TN quotes one of these four versions, it will adjust the numbering to follow the BSB and most English versions.

Paragraphs: In some cases, the paragraph divisions are not indicated or else differ between Paratext, TW, Logos, and Bible Gateway. In such cases, TN has tried to follow the majority. The Notes will divide this section into the following paragraphs: 5:1, 2–4, 5–6 (NJB). Divide the paragraphs in a way that will be appropriate and acceptable to the readers in your language area.

Paragraph 5:2–4

These verses describe the birthplace and origin of the coming ruler, the Messiah. They also identify the time of his coming in relation to the return of his kindred from exile, and describe the way in which he will lead and care for his people like a shepherd.

5:2

In this verse, the phrase “for Me” in 2c refers to the LORD, so the LORD is probably the speaker.

5:2a**But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah,**

- ¶ “But you^(sing), town of Bethlehem Ephrathah,
- ¶ But Yahweh says, “O Bethlehem Ephrathah,
- ¶ Nevertheless, Yahweh says that from Bethlehem Ephrathah,

But you: This phrase introduces a strong contrast between the helpless ruler of Israel in 5:1c and the strong ruler that 5:2c–e describes. See NAC (page 96), TOTC (pages 198–199), and Pusey (page 67). In Hebrew, the placement of this phrase first in the clause also gives it emphasis. Introduce this contrast and emphasis in a natural way in your language.

Bethlehem Ephrathah: This refers to the birthplace of King David mentioned in Ruth 4:11 and 1 Sam. 17:12. Here it is used as a term of address (vocative) in which the LORD speaks to the town of Bethlehem in Judah. Some versions have added the word “O” to indicate this.

In some languages, it may be more natural to use indirect speech here. For an example, see the third meaning line for 5:2a in the Display.

The word Ephrathah may refer to the region where Bethlehem is located (NRSV “of Ephrathah” and REB “in Ephrathah”). The word may also refer to a clan/family name rather than a region (NJPS “Bethlehem of Ephrath” has a footnote: “The clan to which the Bethlehemites belonged”).

TN will follow most versions, which translate the name of the town as Bethlehem Ephrathah. Here are some other ways to translate 5:2a:

But you, O Bethlehem Ephrathah (ESV)

But as for you, Bethlehem Ephrathah (NASB)

The Lord says, “Bethlehem Ephrathah (GNT)

5:2b–c

Verse 5:2c describes the unexpected result of 5:2b. People did not expect that a ruler over the nation of Israel would come from a small and insignificant town such as Bethlehem Ephrathah. Here are some ways to indicate the relationship between the true statement that Bethlehem was small and the unexpected result:

- Begin 5:2b with a conjunction such as “though.” For example:

though you are small... (NIV)

- Begin 5:2c with a conjunction such as “yet” or “but.” For example:

Yet, from you Israel’s future ruler will come for me. (GW)

But the Lord will choose one of your people to rule the nation (CEV)

- Leave the relationship implied. For example:

who are one of the little..., from you shall come forth for me... (NRSV)

Express this relationship in a clear and natural way in your language.

5:2b

who are small among the clans of Judah,

- although you^(sing) are not highly regarded among the towns of Judah,
- even though people do not regard you as important in Judah,
- an insignificant place compared to others in Judah,

The GNT has been used as the source line for 5:2b, because it follows the two recommended interpretations.

(GNT) you are one of the smallest towns in Judah:

In Hebrew, this verse part is more literally “insignificant to be among the thousands of Judah.” There are at least two interpretation issues. The Notes will first consider the issue of the size or significance of Bethlehem Ephrathah:

1. Bethlehem Ephrathah is small. It is unimportant compared to other cities/towns or clans. For example:

Bethlehem Ephrathah, you are one of the smallest towns in the nation of Judah. (CEV)

As for you, Bethlehem Ephrathah, seemingly insignificant among the clans of Judah (NET) (CEV, KJV, NABRE, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB, BSB, GNT)

1. Bethlehem Ephrathah is too small/insignificant to be a city/clan. For example:

You, Bethlehem Ephrathah, are too small to be included among Judah’s cities. (GW)

But you. O Bethlehem Ephrathah, who are too little to be among the clans of Judah (ESV) (ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a majority of versions. According to Waltke 2007 (page 268), the meaning “too small” requires the Hebrew word to have a comparative min affix. That affix is not present here.

(GNT) towns: In Hebrew, this word is literally “thousands,” (as in the KJV). It often refers to large groups of people, such as groups of soldiers, clans or kinship/family groups. Mounce #548: 3 ^{ʿelep} “by extension from ‘thousand,’ this refers to any large unit or group: (family) clan, (military) unit.” Also, DCH (p 300): 13.0.2 “clan—...tribal unit smaller than tribe, sometimes loosely equivalent to family...or tribe.” See also NIDOTTE vol. 2 (page 419), which discusses more than one sense of ^{ʿelep} as well as ^{ʿallup} “chief” in relation to a hierarchy of categories from nation and tribe down to family. The NCV has “army groups from Judah.” Here, however, the word probably refers to non-military groups whose size would be appropriate for a small town or a clan or an extended group of relatives. ZIBBC (page 136) says that although the town and clan are not equivalent, one was often used as shorthand for the other.

The Notes will now consider the issue of whether Bethlehem Ephrathah is a town or a clan. Versions from either of the two interpretations above will be listed:

1. Bethlehem Ephrathah is the name of a town. For example:

are only a small village among all the people of Judah (NLT) (CEV, GW, The GW has been listed here, because its rendering “too small...among Judah’s cities” clearly implies a comparable unit such as a town or village. NLT, GNT)

1. Bethlehem Ephrathah is the name of a clan. For example:

small as you are among Judah’s clans (REB) (BSB, ESV, NABRE, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NRSV, REB)

You may follow either interpretation. TN will follow interpretation (1). Although more versions follow interpretation (2), there is significant commentary and lexicon support for (1). A&F (page 466) identifies this verse as the only one in which “the originally kin-oriented unit ^{ʿelep}” has been designated as a town. HALOT (electronic ed. page 60) identifies this verse as referring to a “settlement > region” in Judah. UBS (page 207) says that the word refers to a social unit (clan), but that this is a case of metonymy in which the clan represents “the town where the clan members lived.” It recommends the “plain meaning” of the GNT “one of the smallest towns in Judah,” and says that “smallest probably refers both to size and to importance.” Interpretation (1) is also much simpler and

avoids the confusion over who belonged to a clan and how big a clan was in relation to other groups.

5:2c

out of you will come forth for Me One to be ruler over Israel—

- from you^(sing) will come one who rules for me over Israel.
- yet out of you will be born a ruler of Israel who represents me.
- from there will come one who will rule on his behalf over Israel.

out of you will come forth for Me One to be ruler over Israel: This clause is a prophecy about the coming of a future ruler. He will rule over Israel for the LORD. In the New Testament, Matthew (1:6) quoted this verse to indicate that Jesus fulfilled this prophecy.

out of you will come forth: The pronoun you in this phrase refers to Bethlehem Ephrathah. That is the place where the ruler will come from. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a ruler of Israel will come from you (NLT)

out of you will come (NIV)

for Me: The pronoun Me refers to the LORD. The phrase for Me means “on my behalf.” Waltke 2007 (page 272) affirms this understanding of the Hebrew word as “dative of advantage to whom the action is directed, and of referring the pronoun to God...” Here are some implications of this phrase:

1. The ruler will act on behalf of the LORD.
2. The ruler will truly obey the LORD. Both a) and b) are suggested by UBS (page 207).
3. The ruler will follow the plan of the LORD and will promote His kingdom. KD (page 324).
4. The ruler (the Messiah) will come to serve the LORD and not himself. Waltke 2007 (page 272) and ABC (page 1080).

Some versions make one or more of these implications clearer. Consider if it will be helpful to do the same in your translation. For example:

will rule over Israel on my behalf (NET)

will rule Israel for me (NCV)

One to be ruler over Israel: The Hebrew word for ruler rather than the more specific word “king” is used

here. If your language has a general word or phrase that refers to a person who rules a country, you should use it here. Some scholars believe there is no essential meaning difference between the Hebrew words for “ruler” and “king.” For example, NAC (page 97) mentions that both words can refer either to humans or to God in Micah as well as elsewhere in the OT. A&F (page 467) makes the same point and cites Genesis 37:8 in which both words are used to refer to Joseph. Others believe it is significant that the Hebrew word for “ruler” is used instead of the word for “king.” For example, NICOT (page 343) suggests that the word “ruler” indicates a lesser, subordinate status to the divine “king.” Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

But out of you will come for me a ruler out of Israel. (NIRV)

from you will come one who will rule Israel for me (NCV)

5:2d

One whose origins are of old,

- He came from long ago,
- His family line/origin is from the distant past.

5:2e

from the days of eternity.

- in the distant past.”
- It goes back many generations.”

5:2d–e

Notice the parallel lines that are similar in meaning:

^{2d}One whose origins are **of old**,

^{2e} **from the days of eternity.**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 5:2e. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 5:2d. For example:

^{2e} whose origins are **from days of eternity.**

One whose origins are of old, from the days of eternity: In Hebrew, the word origins can refer to the place or the time period that something is from. A form of this word is translated as “come forth” in 5:2c. There it refers to the place that the ruler comes from. In 5:2d–e the word origins refers to the time period.

This time period is indicated by the words of old and from the days of eternity.

There is more than one way to interpret this verse part:

1. The ruler is ancient. He is the son of God and he has always existed. JFB (page 692) says that “as the Son of God, His goings forth are from everlasting.” KD (page 325), says that the Hebrew word for “origins” “can only affirm the going forth from God at the creation of the world....” For example:

His goings forth are from long ago, from the days of eternity. (NASB)

1. The lineage of the ruler is ancient. His coming from Bethlehem implies that his ancestry goes back to the time of David. According to Waltke 2007 (page 275), the meaning of the Hebrew word for “origins” should be connected to the meaning in the first part of the verse. He comes from Bethlehem, which implies his ancestral origin from Jesse and the house of David. A&F (page 467) also states that his lineage is the more likely meaning here. For example:

I will bring a ruler for Israel, whose family line goes back to ancient times. (GNT)

The LORD (speaking through Micah) may have meant both (1) and (2) here. If possible, translate these lines in a way that allows either or both interpretations to be understood. For example:

His origins go back to the distant past, to days long ago. (GW)

Micah 5:3

Section 5:1–6: A ruler will be born in Bethlehem

In this section, Micah told the people of Jerusalem that an enemy would come against them who would cause them to suffer. But their suffering would end when a strong ruler came from Bethlehem. He would enable the people to defeat their enemies and would bring peace.

Here are some other examples of section headings: Some versions place a similar heading before verse 2. For example, the NRSV has “The Ruler from Bethlehem,” and the NET has “A King Will Come and a Remnant Will Prosper.”

A Promised Ruler (CEV)

The Ruler to Be Born in Bethlehem (ESV)

Birth of the King in Bethlehem (NASB)

Note: TN and most English versions number the verses in this chapter as 5:1–15. The NAB, NJB, and NJPS number the verses according to the Hebrew Text (BHS): 4:14–5:14.NET footnote (a). When TN quotes one of these four versions, it will adjust the numbering to follow the BSB and most English versions.

Paragraphs: In some cases, the paragraph divisions are not indicated or else differ between Paratext, TW, Logos, and Bible Gateway. In such cases, TN has tried to follow the majority. The Notes will divide this section into the following paragraphs: 5:1, 2–4, 5–6 (NJB). Divide the paragraphs in a way that will be appropriate and acceptable to the readers in your language area.

Paragraph 5:2–4

These verses describe the birthplace and origin of the coming ruler, the Messiah. They also identify the time of his coming in relation to the return of his kindred from exile, and describe the way in which he will lead and care for his people like a shepherd.

5:3a

Therefore Israel will be abandoned until she who is in labor has given birth;

- So Yahweh will abandon the Israelites until the pregnant one gives birth to the ruler.
- Yahweh will leave the people unprotected only until the time that the ruler is born.

Therefore: This word introduces a consequence of the coming of the ruler talked about in 5:2. The consequence is that their current suffering will be temporary. It will end when the ruler comes. See EBC (page 530) and UBS (page 208) in support of this explanation. Other scholars give other explanations. For example, Pusey (pages 72) suggests that God chose both to punish the people and to redeem them. Therefore, he will punish them until the time comes to redeem them. Here are some other ways to introduce this consequence:

So (NET)

That is why (GW)

In some languages, it may be more natural to leave this word implied. For example:

The people of Israel will be abandoned to their enemies until the time when the woman in labor gives birth to her son. (NLT)

Introduce this consequence in a natural way in your language.

Israel will be abandoned: In the Hebrew, this clause is more literally “he will give them.” This clause indicates that the LORD (“he”) will not protect his people (“them”). He will allow their enemies to capture them. Pusey (page 72). Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the Lord will hand the people of Israel over to their enemies (NET)

He will leave them [helpless] (NJPS)

the Lord will abandon Israel (GW)

until: Here the Hebrew phrase indicates duration of time. The length of time during which the LORD will abandon Israel is from that time until the time when the ruler is born. Waltke 2007 (page 278) explains that the Hebrew preposition here “is not allative (movement toward) but rather terminative (movement up to).” In this verse, it indicates up to the time the Messiah comes, when Israel’s misfortunes will be reversed. In some languages, it may be advisable to emphasize that the LORD will abandon Israel only up to a certain point in time. For example:

Yahweh will abandon them only until she who is in labor gives birth (NJB)

she who is in labor: This phrase refers to the mother who will give birth to the future ruler. The phrase “she who is in labor” may also have a figurative meaning. Some suggestions are that it refers to: Zion/Jerusalem, Bethlehem, Judah, or all Israel. See, for example, NAC (page 99) and EBC (page 530). Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the woman in labor (NET)

the woman who is to give birth (GNT)

she who is pregnant (REB)

has given birth: This phrase means that the mother has given birth to a baby. In this verse, the baby is a son. UBS (page 209) suggests that “it is clear from the general background of Hebrew prophetic thought that the one who was to deliver the nation would be a male...” Many English versions have expressions that leave “son” implied. In some languages, it may be more natural to make this meaning explicit. For example:

gives birth to her son (NLT96)

In some languages, the phrase “she who is in labor” may draw more attention to the mother than to the birth of the ruler. If that is true in your language, consider translating in a way that leaves the mother implied. For example:

The Lord will abandon Israel only until this ruler is born (CEV)

5:3b

then the rest of His brothers will return to the children of Israel.

- Then his relatives who were forced to live in other countries will return to be reunited with their people in Israel.
- After that, his fellow Israelites will return from other nations to the land of Israel to join their countrymen.

then: In Hebrew, this verse part is introduced by a conjunction (waw) that can be translated here as either then or “and.” It indicates how this clause connects to the previous clauses. There are two main interpretations:

1. This word introduces an event that follows the birth of the Messiah. After his birth, the message of salvation will begin to spread to all nations and at various times, the rest of his kindred will return. For example:

until the time when she who is in labor has given birth; then the rest of his brothers shall return to the people of Israel (ESV) (GW, ESV, KJV, NABRE, BSB, NASB, NCV, NET, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB, GNT)

1. This word introduces an event that is in addition to the birth of the Messiah. The rest of his kindred will return during the same period of time. For example:

until the time when she who is in labor bears a son, and the rest of his brothers return to join the Israelites (NIV11) (CEV, NAB, NIV11)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The LORD showed that he no longer abandoned his people by sending his own Son to live among them. Historically, after that time, people began to spiritually join the kingdom of God, and groups of Jews, his literal kindred, began to return to the nation of Israel. The return of exiles described in Ezra and Nehemiah occurred long before the birth of the Messiah. If Micah 5:3 had been referring to these groups of exiles, the order of events would have been given in the opposite order.

the rest of His brothers: The pronoun His refers to the ruler that will be born. UBS (page 209) notes that grammatically the pronoun could refer to the LORD. However, the most natural way to understand it is as a reference to the son, the ruler to be born. See also EBC (page 530). The phrase the rest of His brothers probably refers to Israelites in exile. This understanding is supported by UBS (page 210), EBC (page 530) and A&F (page 469). Some other suggestions are that the brothers are from the clans of Judah (Davis, page 106 and KD, page 327), or from the ten northern tribes (Elman, page 665 footnote).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

his fellow countrymen (NLT)

those Israelites who are in exile (GNT)

will return to the children of Israel: This phrase probably refers to returning home to the land of Israel. The Israelites who were originally exiled to other countries will rejoin their fellow Israelites who were not taken into exile. UBS (page 210), WBC (page 44), and EBC (page 530). See also Micah 4:6–7.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

will return from exile to their own land (NLT)

will be reunited with their own people (GNT)

Micah 5:4

Section 5:1–6: A ruler will be born in Bethlehem

In this section, Micah told the people of Jerusalem that an enemy would come against them who would cause them to suffer. But their suffering would end

when a strong ruler came from Bethlehem. He would enable the people to defeat their enemies and would bring peace.

Here are some other examples of section headings: Some versions place a similar heading before verse 2. For example, the NRSV has “The Ruler from Bethlehem,” and the NET has “A King Will Come and a Remnant Will Prosper.”

A Promised Ruler (CEV)

The Ruler to Be Born in Bethlehem (ESV)

Birth of the King in Bethlehem (NASB)

Note: TN and most English versions number the verses in this chapter as 5:1–15. The NAB, NJB, and NJPS number the verses according to the Hebrew Text (BHS): 4:14–5:14. NET footnote (a). When TN quotes one of these four versions, it will adjust the numbering to follow the BSB and most English versions.

Paragraphs: In some cases, the paragraph divisions are not indicated or else differ between Paratext, TW, Logos, and Bible Gateway. In such cases, TN has tried to follow the majority. The Notes will divide this section into the following paragraphs: 5:1, 2–4, 5–6 (NJB). Divide the paragraphs in a way that will be appropriate and acceptable to the readers in your language area.

Paragraph 5:2–4

These verses describe the birthplace and origin of the coming ruler, the Messiah. They also identify the time of his coming in relation to the return of his kindred from exile, and describe the way in which he will lead and care for his people like a shepherd.

5:4

This verse describes the way in which the ruler will rule his people.

5:4a–b

Notice the parallel lines that are similar in meaning:

^{4a} He will stand and shepherd his flock **in the strength of the LORD,**

^{4b} **in the majestic name of the LORD his God.**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 5:4b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 5:4a. For example:

^{4b} he will stand and shepherd them **in the majestic name of the LORD his God.**

5:4a

He will stand and shepherd His flock in the strength of the LORD,

- And he will become the shepherd of his flock and will begin to lead them with the strength that comes from Yahweh.
- He can be compared to a person who cares for sheep. He will assume/begin his work as their leader, and he will govern/rule the people of Israel. Yahweh will give him the strength/ability to do this.

In some versions this verse starts with a word that indicates how this clause connects to the previous clauses. In those versions, it introduces a further description of the ruler who is talked about in the previous verses.

Here are some ways to indicate how this clause connects to the previous clauses:

- Use a general (non-specific) connection word such as “and.” For example:

And He will arise and shepherd his flock (NASB)

- Leave the connection implied. For example:

He will rise up to lead them (REB)

- Make the connection more explicit. For example:

When he comes, he will rule his people (GNT)

Indicate this clause connection in a natural way in your language.

He will stand and shepherd His flock: This clause is a metaphor that compares the future ruler to a shepherd. It describes the way he will rule over his people. He will lead, protect, and care for them in the same way that a shepherd cares for sheep. NAC (page 100). Also, this metaphor probably reminded people of King David, who was a shepherd as a young man. See UBS (page 210) and Waltke 2007 (page 283).

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Use a metaphor. For example:

he shall stand and feed his flock (NRSV)

- Use a simile. Make the similarity or topic explicit if it will be helpful. For example:

Like a shepherd taking care of his sheep, this ruler will lead and care for his people (CEV)

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

he will rule his people (GNT)

stand: In this context, there are two main ways to interpret the Hebrew word for stand:

1. It means “arrive” or “appear on the scene” and assume his responsibilities. BDB (page 764) #5975 Qal 6.a; Waltke 2007 (page 282), NAC (page 100), and NICOT (page 346). For example:

He will become the shepherd of his flock (adapted from GW)

He will assume his post and shepherd the people (NET)

He shall take his place as shepherd (NABRE) (CEV, GW, NABRE, NASB, NET, NJB, REB, GNT) The NJB (“take his stand”) and the REB (“rise up to lead them”) have been listed here with some uncertainty. The NJB may imply taking his stand against opponents. Similarly, the REB may imply rising up against an enemy, such as the Assyrians (5:5).

1. It means to “be firm” or “be unmovable.” NAC (page 100), A&F (page 469), and Waltke 2007 (page 282). For example:

He shall stand firm and shepherd his flock (NAB) (NAB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Some scholars think that “stand” may include the aspect of standing firm as well as the aspects of arriving and assuming his responsibilities. For example, see Waltke 2007 (page 282). Many versions, including the BSB, translate stand literally. Try to translate it so that one or more aspects of interpretation (1) will be clearly understood.

shepherd His flock: Here this phrase refers to the ruler governing his people. KD (page 328).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

shepherd the people (NET)

lead his flock (NLT)

take care of his people (NCV)

rule his people (GNT)

in the strength of the LORD: This phrase describes the way in which the future ruler will rule. It means that the ruler’s ability and strength to rule comes from the LORD.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

with the strength that comes from the Lord (GNT)

by the might of the Lord (NJPS)

The LORD will give him the ability to do this.

5:4b

in the majestic name of the LORD His God.

- He will rule them with excellence by the power of Yahweh, his God.
- He will rule with the power and authority of Yahweh’s name.

in the majestic name of the LORD His God: This phrase also describes the way in which the future ruler will rule. It means that the ruler will govern his people with the kind of excellence/highness that characterizes the LORD his God.

majestic: This word is literally “height.” When it refers to God, as in this phrase, it means “exultation,” “majesty,” or “excellence.” BDB #1347 (pages 144-145).

Since this phrase is parallel with 5:4a, God’s being majestic here may refer especially to his great power. For example:

^{4a}...with the Lord’s strength ^{4b}and with the power of the name of the Lord his God. (NCV)

^{4a}...by the might of the Lord ^{4b}by the power of the name of the Lord his God (NJPS)

name of the LORD: This phrase may be a title for Yahweh. It is another way to refer to him. HALOT (electronic edition, pages 1550-1551) calls the phrase “an interchangeable expression for Yahweh.” NAC (page

100) says it refers to the LORD himself or to his manifested character. His name implies his character and his attributes, such as his power and authority. NICOT (page 346), Waltke 2007 (page 283), and CBC (page 328) all suggest that this phrase refers to the LORD delegating his authority to the ruler.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Lord God himself (GNT)

the sovereign authority of the Lord his God (NET)

his God: This phrase indicates that there is a very close relationship between the ruler and the LORD. Some of the commentators that talk about the implication of an especially close relationship are Waltke 2007, NICOT and KD.

5:4c

And they will dwell securely,

- And they will be safe/secure,
- His people will live without danger.

And they will dwell securely: This clause talks about the time when the ruler will govern in the strength and majesty of the LORD. His people will be able to live securely. They will no longer have to struggle with war and exile.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

His people will live in safety (GNT)

Then his people will live there undisturbed (NLT)

and they will be secure (NJB)

5:4d

for then His greatness will extend to the ends of the earth.

- because at that time, people will highly honor him everywhere on earth.
- That is because all over the earth people will acknowledge that he is great.

for then His greatness will extend to the ends of the earth: This clause gives the reason why his people will live securely. It is because the ruler will be great throughout the whole earth.

for then: This phrase indicates the connection of this clause to the previous one. The word for indicates that the clause is a reason. The word then refers to the

future time when the ruler will come. Here are two other ways to translate it:

- Leave this word implied. For example:

because his greatness will reach all over the earth (NCV)

- Use a word or phrase that indicates a future time. For example:

because at that time he will be great to the ends of the earth (NASB)

His greatness will extend to the ends of the earth:

Here the word greatness means to be very important like a king. BDB #1431.

Here are some things that this clause implies:

1. His kingdom and authority will reach everywhere on earth. Waltke 2007 (pages 285–286), NICOT (page 347), Achtemeier (page 340), and KD (page 328).
2. He will defeat all his enemies. Waltke 2007 (pages 285–286).
3. He will have the omnipotence (unlimited power) of the LORD. Waltke 2007 (pages 285–286).
4. People everywhere will recognize that he is great. UBS (page 211).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

people all over the earth will acknowledge his greatness (GNT)

he will be highly honored all around the world (NLT)

Micah 5:5

Section 5:1–6: A ruler will be born in Bethlehem

In this section, Micah told the people of Jerusalem that an enemy would come against them who would cause them to suffer. But their suffering would end when a strong ruler came from Bethlehem. He would enable the people to defeat their enemies and would bring peace.

Here are some other examples of section headings: Some versions place a similar heading before verse 2. For example, the NRSV has “The Ruler from Bethlehem,” and the NET has “A King Will Come and a Remnant Will Prosper.”

A Promised Ruler (CEV)

The Ruler to Be Born in Bethlehem (ESV)

Birth of the King in Bethlehem (NASB)

Note: TN and most English versions number the verses in this chapter as 5:1–15. The NAB, NJB, and NJPS number the verses according to the Hebrew Text (BHS): 4:14–5:14.NET footnote (a). When TN quotes one of these four versions, it will adjust the numbering to follow the BSB and most English versions.

Paragraphs: In some cases, the paragraph divisions are not indicated or else differ between Paratext, TW, Logos, and Bible Gateway. In such cases, TN has tried to follow the majority. The Notes will divide this section into the following paragraphs: 5:1, 2–4, 5–6 (NJB). Divide the paragraphs in a way that will be appropriate and acceptable to the readers in your language area.

5:5–6

In these two verses, 5a–c form a unit at the beginning, and the parallel lines 6:c–e form another unit at the end. One function of this structure is to show that the shepherd-rulers (5:d–e) who will rule Assyria (6:a–b) are under the leadership of the highest ruler, the Messiah, who has been described in 5:2–4. Some scholars identify the repetition of lines that start and end this literary unit as an inclusio. See Waltke 2007 (page 304), Waltke 1993 (page 708), NAC (pages 101–102), and A&F (page 473). These scholars also mention the chiasmic structure. Waltke 1993, 2007 says the combination of inclusion and chiasm functions to highlight the Messiah's role. This structure can be clearly seen in the NIV11 (indentations adjusted). Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{5a} And he will be our peace

^{5b} **when the Assyrians invade our land**

^{5c} **and march through our fortresses.**

^{5d} **We will raise against them seven shepherds,**

^{5e} **even eight commanders,**

^{6a} **who will rule the land of Assyria with the sword,**

^{6b} **the land of Nimrod with drawn sword.**

^{6c} He will deliver us from the Assyrians

^{6d} **when they invade our land**

^{6e} **and march across our borders.**

5:5a**And He will be our peace**

- ¶ And he will bring peace.
- ¶ There will be peace because of him.

And He will be our peace: There are two main ways to interpret the way this clause connects to the surrounding clauses:

1. It is in the same paragraph as the other clauses in 5:5–6. It introduces the topic of peace through victory over Assyria by identifying the ruler who will be source of that peace. The NIV11 quoted earlier is one example. (BSB, KJV, NASB, NET, NIV11, NJB, NJPS, RSV)
2. It is in the same paragraph as the preceding clauses. It concludes the topic of the Israelites living peacefully in their land (5:2–4) by identifying the ruler who will be the source of that peace. UBS (page 211). The next paragraph (5:5b–6) introduces the new topic of victory over Assyria. Four versions use a heading before 5:5b in addition to a paragraph break to indicate the division. For example:

^{5a}and he will bring peace.

Deliverance and Punishment

^{5b}When the Assyrians invade our country... (GNT)
(CEV, ESV, GW, NAB, NCV, NIV, NLT, NRSV, REB, GNT)

The Notes will follow interpretation (1). It more clearly shows the Hebrew structure illustrated in the note on 5:5–6. The MT places in one paragraph all the verses in chapter 5 up to and including this verse. It does not mark this clause as the start or end of a separate paragraph as do some modern versions. It also allows 5:5–6 to be seen as a smaller unit within 5:1–6. Interpretation (2) does not show the Hebrew structure as clearly as the first interpretation, but it is followed by more English versions. It also forms a natural conclusion to the topic in 5:2–5a and allows readers to more easily identify the new topic of winning a victory over Assyria.

This clause is more literally “and this [one/he] will be peace.”BART (adjusted to normal English SVO order). There are three main interpretations of this clause:

1. The ruler will be the source of peace. The word “this” refers to a person, “this one,” the ruler. For example:

And he shall be their peace. (ESV)

He will bring peace. (NCV)

And he will be the source of peace. (NLT) (ESV, BSB, CEV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, GNT)

1. The word “this” refers to an event, the coming and rule of the ruler that will result in peace. For example:

And that shall afford safety. (NJPS)

Then there will be peace. (REB) (NJPS, REB)

1. The word “this” refers to an event, the future conquest that 5:5–6 describes. For example:

⁵And this shall be peace, when the Assyrian comes.... that we will raise against him seven shepherds and eight princes...⁶...and they shall deliver us from the Assyrian... (RSV) (RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most commentaries and versions.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

And he will be our peace (NIV11)

He will give us peace. (NET)

peace: The Hebrew word for peace can mean physical well-being and security, such as no more war. It can also mean spiritual well-being in relationship to God.NAC (page 102) and CBC (page 328). In these verses, both aspects of meaning may be intended.

5:5b–e

The remainder of the verse is a single conditional sentence that is assumed will be true. When the condition “when Assyria invades our land and tramples our citadels” is true, the result is that the people will raise up leaders to confront them.

In this clause, Micah expresses confidence that the future leader will help the people defend and save Israel whenever other nations attack them. See especially NICOT (page 347) and NAC (pages 102–103). It is probably not a prediction of specific, future attacks.

5:5b–c

Notice the parallel lines that are similar in meaning:

^{5b} when Assyria **invades our land**

^{5c} **and tramples our citadels.**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 5:5c. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 5:5b. For example:

^{5c} **and** when Assyria **tramples our citadels.**

5:5b

when Assyria invades our land

- If the Assyrian soldiers enter our^(incl) country
- If/When the Assyrians invade the land of Israel

when Assyria invades our land: Here is another way to introduce this condition:

If the Assyrians come into our land (NRSV)

Assyria: The nation of Assyria was the main oppressor of Israel in Micah’s time. However, here the name Assyria is probably also a figure of speech that represents the future enemies of Israel.JFB (page 693) states that “Assyria is made the representative of all the foes of Israel in all ages....” See also Hays (page 315), KD (page 329), NAC (page 102), and EBC (page 532).

In Hebrew, the reference to Assyria is singular. It is more literally “Assyria it/he will come.” However, in some languages, it is more natural to describe an attack by a country by referring to the people from that country. Here many versions translate Assyria as “Assyrians.” Translate Assyria in a natural way in your language.

invades: This means the Assyrians come into Israel to attack it.

our land: This refers to the land of Israel. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

our country (GNT)

5:5c and tramples our citadels.

- and break into our^(incl) walled cities,
- and march through our strongest/fortified buildings,

and tramples our citadels: There is a textual issue here:

1. The MT has: “and if he tread on our citadel fortresses.” For example:

and treads in our palaces (ESV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, REB, GNT)

1. The LXX has: “and when he treads upon our country.” For example:

If the Assyrians come into our land and tread upon our soil (NRSV) (NAB, NJB, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. The phrase tramples our citadels probably implies that the Assyrians broke through Israel’s defenses, marched into the cities, and captured their most important buildings. A&F (page 477).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and break through our defenses (NLT)

and marches through our fortresses (NIV)

tramples: In this context, the word tramples means “march” or “advance.” DCH (page 462) 1a. tread, trample, march, advance.

our citadels: The word citadels means “strong, fortified buildings of a city.” BDB (#759) citadel, castle, palace.

5:5d-e (combined/reordered)

- we will send our strongest leaders to fight them. (GNT)

5:5d-e is a numerical expression. It is similar to a numerical proverb. Some examples of numerical proverbs are found in Proverbs 30:15, 18, 21 and 29. A numerical expression lists things that are similar in some way. In a numerical expression, the second line contains a number (in this case, eight) that is one greater than the parallel number (seven) in the first line. The two numbers function together as a pair and are primarily a poetic feature. According to UBS (page 214), the numbers themselves probably have no special signif-

icance. However, according to Pusey (page 75), the numbers do have significance. He suggests that the number seven denotes a great, complete multitude, and that the number eight designates an almost countless multitude. For the meaning of the expression in this verse see the note below on “seven... eight.”

The parallel parts are similar in meaning:

^{5d} We will raise against it **seven shepherds**,

^{5e} even **eight leaders of men**.

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 5:5e. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing phrase from 5:5d. For example:

^{5e} and we will raise against it even **eight leaders of men**.

These parallel lines are the last part of the conditional sentence that was introduced in 5:b-c. The apodosis of the conditional sentence. They explain the result if the Assyrians come into their land to attack them. Some versions make explicit that this is the last part of the conditional sentence. For example:

then we will raise against him (NASB)

We will raise against it: This phrase means that the people will appoint DCH (pages 232-233). leaders to defend them against the Assyrian attackers.

seven...eight: This numerical expression means that the number of leaders will be sufficient to successfully defend the people against the Assyrians. As a numerical expression, the numbers seven and eight should not be understood literally.

Here are two ways to avoid wrong implications:

- Translate the numbers seven and eight. Explain the meaning of the numerical expression in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

The numbers seven and eight here symbolize completeness and emphasize that Israel will have more than enough military leadership and strength to withstand the Assyrian advance. (NET footnote)

- Use a general phrase instead of the exact numbers. This suggestion comes from UBS (page 214). For example:

We will counterattack, led by a number of rulers (CEV) You can also add a footnote to indicate that Hebrew has the numbers seven and eight.

shepherds...leaders of men: The Hebrew words are more literally “shepherds...princes of man.” In this verse, the word shepherds and the phrase “princes of man” are in parallel lines and have the same meaning. They are two ways to refer to the appointed leaders who will rule and protect the people of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this pair of words:

shepherd-rulers...commanders (NET)

rulers...princes (NLT)

General Comment on 5:5d–e

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the parallel parts. For example:

we will send our strongest leaders to fight them (GNT)

5:5d

We will raise against it seven shepherds,

- we^(incl) will appoint plenty of men who know how to take charge of others.
- then we will fight against them. They will be led into battle by our many leaders

5:5e

even eight leaders of men.

- Our^(incl) best commanders will lead our^(incl) soldiers in battle against them.
- who are commanders of men.

Micah 5:6

Section 5:1–6: A ruler will be born in Bethlehem

In this section, Micah told the people of Jerusalem that an enemy would come against them who would cause them to suffer. But their suffering would end when a strong ruler came from Bethlehem. He would enable the people to defeat their enemies and would bring peace.

Here are some other examples of section headings: Some versions place a similar heading before verse 2. For example, the NRSV has “The Ruler from Bethlehem,” and the NET has “A King Will Come and a Remnant Will Prosper.”

A Promised Ruler (CEV)

The Ruler to Be Born in Bethlehem (ESV)

Birth of the King in Bethlehem (NASB)

Note: TN and most English versions number the verses in this chapter as 5:1–15. The NAB, NJB, and NJPS number the verses according to the Hebrew Text (BHS): 4:14–5:14. NET footnote (a). When TN quotes one of these four versions, it will adjust the numbering to follow the BSB and most English versions.

Paragraphs: In some cases, the paragraph divisions are not indicated or else differ between Paratext, TW, Logos, and Bible Gateway. In such cases, TN has tried to follow the majority. The Notes will divide this section into the following paragraphs: 5:1, 2–4, 5–6 (NJB). Divide the paragraphs in a way that will be appropriate and acceptable to the readers in your language area.

5:6

This verse describes how the appointed leaders/shepherds will rescue Israel when the armies of Assyria invade their nation.

5:6a–b

Notice the parallel lines that are similar in meaning:

^{6a}And they will rule **the land of Assyria with the sword,**

^{6b}and **the land of Nimrod with the blade drawn.**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 5:6b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 5:6a. For example:

^{6b}and they will rule **the land of Nimrod with the blade drawn.**

5:6a

And they will rule the land of Assyria with the sword,

- They will defeat the nation of Assyria with the sword and rule over them.

- They will use their weapons to conquer Assyria and then rule it.

And they will rule the land of Assyria with the sword: This clause indicates that the territory the appointed leaders will rule will extend beyond the borders of Israel. They will also rule the nation of Assyria.

rule...with the sword: This phrase is literally “and they will shepherd...with the sword.” Here the word “shepherd” means to rule. HALOT (electronic edition, page 1260) 6.c. The phrase “shepherd with the sword” is a figurative expression that indicates what they will use to rule. Since the word sword refers to a military weapon, the expression here indicates that the appointed leaders will fight and conquer the Assyrians before they rule over them. According to Waltke 2007 (page 291), Micah may include the word “sword” here to intensify that it will be the instrument of subjugation of the Assyrians. The chiefs/leaders will move from the defense of their homeland against Assyria to the offensive posture of ruling Assyria’s homeland.

Here are some ways to translate this verse part:

- Make the action and means of ruling explicit. Leave the action of conquering implied. For example:

They will rule Assyria with the sword (REB)

- Make the action of conquering explicit and leave the action of ruling implied. For example:

We will counterattack, led by a number of rulers whose strong army will defeat the nation of Assyria. (CEV)

- Make both actions explicit. For example:

They will conquer and rule over the nation of Assyria.

5:6b

and the land of Nimrod with the blade drawn.

- They will govern this land of Nimrod at its city gates.
- They will control every entrance to the Assyrian nation, the land of Nimrod.

The ESV has been used as the source line for 6b, because it follows the recommended textual options.

(ESV) and the land of Nimrod at its entrances: This clause is parallel to 6a. It indicates that the appointed rulers will rule over the land of Nimrod.

(ESV) the land of Nimrod: Nimrod is the name of the founder of Assyria and Babylon and several other places (see Genesis 10:8–12). The preceding parallel line 5:6a explicitly refers to Assyria, so the phrase the land of Nimrod is probably another way to refer to Assyria. Some that favor a reference to Assyria here are UBS and KD. Some scholars suggest that the phrase “the land of Nimrod” refers to Babylon. For example, CBC, Pusey, and Waltke 2007. Others suggest that the phrase may refer to either or both places. For example, WBC, NAC and JFB. However, no version translates the phrase as “the land of Babylon.”

Here are some translation options:

- Translate this phrase literally. Leave the referent implied. For example:

the land of Nimrod (NASB)

- Translate the referent “Assyria” explicitly. For example:

the land of Assyria (NCV)

Consider adding a cross-reference to Genesis 10:8–12 here.

(ESV) at its entrances: This phrase has a textual issue:

1. The Masoretic Text has “at its entrances/gates.” KD (page 329) suggests that the Hebrew word for “entrances/gates” is parallel to the word “fortresses” in 5:5c, which may refer to city gates or entrances. In that verse, the Assyrians enter the city gates/entrances of Israel. In this verse, the Israelite leaders enter the city gates/entrances of Assyria. Alternately, JFB (page 693) suggests that this line is parallel to 5:5b, in which the Assyrians enter the land of Israel. As the Assyrians invade the borders of Israel, so will the Israelites invade the borders of Assyria. Either parallel is possible. For example:

The land of Nimrod at its entrances (NASB) (ESV, KJV, NASB, NJPS, NLT)

1. Some scholars think that the original text was “with a drawn sword.” For example, see A&F (page 480) and Davis (page 92). For example:

the land of Nimrod with drawn sword (NIV) (BSB, GW, NABRE, NCV, NET, NJB, NRSV, NIV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It makes sense without making any changes to the Hebrew text. Option (2) “with drawn sword” requires emending the Hebrew text to make it clearly parallel to “sword” in the previous line. However, no textual evidence exists to support this emendation.

The phrase at its entrances means “entrances to a country.” BDB #6607 (pages 835–836): “entrances to a country.” Here the phrase refers to the country of Assyria. It may also imply the gates of a city or the public buildings from which the appointed leaders will govern the people. KD (page 329).

5:6c

So He will deliver us when Assyria

- Thus our^(incl) ruler will save us^(incl) from the Assyrians if
- In this way, our king will free us from the power/might of the Assyrian empire if/when

So He will deliver us when Assyria: There is a textual issue with the Hebrew word that the ESV translates as So He will deliver us:

1. The Masoretic Text has “and he will deliver.” For example:

Thus he will deliver [us] from Assyria (NJPS) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NASB, NIV, NET, NJB, NJPS, NLT)

1. Some scholars think that the original text had “and they will deliver.” For example:

and they will save us from the Assyrians (GNT) (CEV, GW, NLT96, NRSV, REB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It is supported by a majority of commentaries and a slight majority of versions, including the early versions, the LXX, and the Peshitta.

One way to make it clearer that the word He refers back to the ruler in 5:5a is to make the referent explicit. For example:

Our king will rescue us from the Assyrians (NET)

He will use the appointed leaders to rescue the people from their enemy, the nation of Assyria.

This clause part refers back to the same situation that 5:5 describes. It does not refer to a separate Assyrian invasion. One way to make it clearer that this is not a

new invasion is to make a backward reference explicit. For example:

Thus he will deliver [us] from Assyria (NJPS)

In this way he will save us from the Assyrians

deliver us when Assyria: This phrase is literally “and he will deliver [us] from Assyria.”

The word deliver means “deliver,” “rescue,” or “save.” TWOT #1404. This phrase probably means that the one of peace will use the appointed leaders to drive away Israel’s enemies and keep the people safe.

As in 5:5b, it is more natural in some languages to describe an attack by the people of a country rather than an attack by a country. For example:

and he shall deliver us from the Assyrian (ESV)

Our king will rescue us from the Assyrians (NET)

Translate this phrase in a natural way in your language.

5:6d–e

(combined/reordered)

- they invade our territory (GNT)

Notice the parallel lines that are similar in meaning:

^{6c-d} So He will deliver us when Assyria **invades our land**

^{6e} **and marches into our borders.**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 5:6e. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 5:6c–d. For example:

^{6e} **and when Assyria marches into our borders.**

These lines describe the situation in which the deliverance in 6c will occur. It will happen if or when the Assyrians invade Israel.

General Comment on 5:6d–e

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these two parallel lines. For example:

if those Assyrians dare to invade our land (CEV)

5:6d invades our land

- their soldiers enter our^(incl) country
- their armies invade the land of Israel

5:6e and marches into our borders.

- and march inside the borders of our^(incl) land.
- and wage war against us within our borders.

Micah 5:7

Section 5:7–9: The future role of the exiles that the LORD has delivered

In this section, Micah described events that would happen after the coming of the ruler who was born in Bethlehem (5:1–6). He told the people of Israel that a remnant of Israelites would survive. The LORD would influence people of other nations through the remnant. He would bring blessing to some people, but he would bring destruction to others. NICOT (page 352) points out that two different roles of the remnant are to be a channel of divine blessing and also an agent of divine judgment. See also ABC (page 1081) and Waltke 2007 (page 203).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

A Remnant Shall Be Delivered (ESV)

The Future Role of the Remnant (NRSV)

The Survivors Will Be Safe

5:7–8

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in structure:

^{7a} Then the remnant of Jacob will be in the midst of many peoples

^{7b} like dew from the LORD, ^{7c} like showers on the grass,

^{7d} which do not wait for man ^{7e} or linger for mankind.

^{8a} Then the remnant of Jacob will be among the nations, ^{8b} in the midst of many peoples,

^{8c} like a lion among the beasts of the forest, ^{8d} like a young lion among flocks of sheep,

^{8e} which tramples and tears as it passes through, with no one to rescue them.

The lines in 7a–e are similar in structure to the lines in 8a–e. “Antithetic parallelism” is the technical name for the symmetrical but contrasting images in verses 7 and 8, of refreshing dew and a destructive lion. See NICOT (page 352). Lines 7a and 8a–b both introduce the remnant of Jacob as the topic. Lines 7b–c and 8c–d both compare the remnant to objects in the natural world, dew and a lion. Lines 7d–e and 8e both describe a characteristic of these objects that will be similar to the remnant.

5:7a

Then the remnant of Jacob will be in the midst of many peoples

- ¶ The descendants of Jacob who survive and are surrounded by many other people groups
- ¶ The remaining Israelites will have many others living around them.

Then the remnant of Jacob will be in the midst of many peoples: This clause introduces the subject of the prophecy. This prophecy is about the effect that the remnant of Jacob will have on other people groups.

Then: In Hebrew, this word is literally “and it will be.” It does not indicate that the events in this prophecy immediately follow those described in 5:6. It introduces a new prophecy that is separate but related to those that precede it. Some versions do not use a connecting word like Then. Instead, they allow the context to imply the change. For example:

The people of Israel who survive (GNT)

The remnant of Jacob (NJPS)

Indicate this change of prophecy in a natural way in your language.

remnant of Jacob: The word remnant refers to people who remain alive after many others have died. TWOT #2307b states that the Hebrew word is about those who survive after a previous elimination process or catastrophe. It implies a small number of people compared to a larger population in past times. NIDOTTE (Volume 4, pages 11–16) says that Micah speaks of a tiny historical remnant.

The phrase of Jacob means “descended from Jacob.” In Micah, this phrase is a way to refer to all Israelites. The reference includes people from all twelve tribes. Some are from the northern kingdom of Israel, and some are

from the southern kingdom of Judah.NAC (page 103) and UBS (pages 215–216).

Here are some other ways to translate remnant of Jacob:

The people of Israel who survive (GNT)

A few of Jacob's descendants survived (CEV)

in the midst of many peoples: In some contexts, this phrase describes the situation of Israelites who live as prisoners or refugees in various countries outside their homeland of Israel.A&F (page 485) and UBS (pages 215–216).

However, this prophesy speaks of a time in the future when the remnant is no longer scattered in various places outside of Israel. They return to Israel to live.This is more clearly the situation described in verse 5:8. The parallelism between verses 7 and 8 suggests that the same situation pertains to both verses. See NIDOTTE (Vol. 4, pages 11–16), JFB (page 638) and Waltke 2007 (page 306). So it is reasonable to conclude that here the words many peoples refer to the non-Israelite people who live in countries that surround the land of Israel.

5:7b–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{7b} like dew from the LORD,

^{7c} like showers on the grass

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 5:7b–c. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 5:7a. For example:

^{7b} they will be like dew from the LORD,

^{7c} they will be like showers on the grass

These parallel lines are similes that compare the remnant of Jacob to dew and to showers. There are two main interpretations of how the remnant is similar to dew and showers:

1. The LORD will bless people of other nations through the remnant. This is comparable to how he blesses the earth and vegetation through dew and showers.JFB (page 693), ABC (page 1081), TOTC (page 204), Waltke 2007 (page 307), NICOT (pages 353–354), KD (page 330), NAC (pages 103–104), UBS

(pages 216–217), WBC (pages 46–47) and Davis (page 112). For example:

Then the people of Jacob who are left alive will be to other people like dew from the Lord or rain on the grass (NCV) (NCV, GNT)

1. It is certain that the LORD will restore the population and/or the status of Israel among the nations. This is comparable to the certainty that the LORD sends dew and showers. No one can stop it from happening.CBC (page 331). For example:

Then the remnant left in Israel will take their place among the nations. They will be like dew sent by the Lord or like rain falling on the grass, which no one can hold back and no one can restrain. (NLT) (NLT, CEV)

Most versions are ambiguous as to which interpretation they follow.Two other interpretations also have support from multiple commentators but are not included in this note because no version appears to follow them. One is that the point of similarity between dew, showers and the remnant is that all are under divine control. This interpretation is similar to the meaning of the parallel lines that follow these similes. Variations of this interpretation are proposed by A&F (page 485) and Margolis (pages 55–56). Another interpretation is that the LORD will judge Israel's enemies through the remnant. Restored Israel will overwhelm her enemies the way dew completely covers grass. This interpretation is similar to the meaning of verse 8. See McKeating (page 180), EBC (pages 533–534) and the NET footnote for this verse. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with many commentaries.A main support for this interpretation is that it fits the most common figurative meaning of “dew” and “showers.” See more detail in the note for “dew...showers” below. Another support for this interpretation is that the context of verse 8 clearly refers to Israel's influence on other nations (in that case not beneficial). The parallel of verse 7 to verse 8 suggests that this verse also refers to Israel's influence on others, not just God's blessing on Israel. See NICOT (pages 353–354). These similes may refer back to the prophecy in Micah 4:1–4, which also talks about how other nations will be blessed through Israel. See ABC (page 1081). However, interpretation (2) is also acceptable. Both interpretations fit the context. Interpretation (2) is probably implied in interpretation (1).This part of the chapter is about the future strength of Israel and its leaders. So this prophecy probably refers to the

LORD's blessing on Israel along with his blessing on other nations through Israel.

dew...showers: These two words are similar in meaning. The word dew refers to water droplets that collect on plants or on the ground during the night. It can also refer to light rain. Dew was very important in that part of the world. It kept plants alive in seasons that had no rain.UBS (pages 216–217).

The word showers generally refers to a large amount of rain.BDB #7241 page 914).

In the Old Testament dew and showers are often used as figures of speech to indicate something beneficial.For example, NAC (pages 103–104) cites Psalms 72:6, 16–19. Also see Waltke 2007 (page 307). Here they indicate refreshment and fertility.NAC (pages 103–104) and NICOT (pages 353–354).

5:7b

like dew from the LORD,

- will be like refreshing dew from Yahweh.
- Through his people, Yahweh will bless these other nations the way he blesses plants, by sending dew

from the LORD: This phrase indicates that the LORD is the source of the dew.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

dew sent by the Lord (NLT)

dew the Lord sends (NET)

5:7c

like showers on the grass,

- They will be like rain upon grass/plants,
- and rain showers.

on the grass: This phrase indicates where the rain showers fall. The Hebrew word translated as grass means “green plants” or “grass.” Since the word describes plants that are valuable to both humans and animals, it is used in figures of speech to indicate blessing.NIDOTTE (Volume 3, page 546).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

showers on growing plants (GNT)

showers on vegetation (NASB)

5:7d

which do not wait for man

- which do not require the help of people
- The dew and rain do not rely on human beings

5:7e

or linger for mankind.

- or put their hope in humans.
- or need to wait for help from anyone.

5:7d–e

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{7d} which do not wait for **man**

^{7e} or linger for **mankind.**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 5:7c. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 5:7b. For example:

^{7c} neither do they linger for **mankind.**

These lines are more literally “which does not wait for man and does not wait patiently for the sons of mankind.”Grammatically, the verbs are singular and point to a singular referent. Probably that referent is “dew.” Other possible referents are “remnant” or “grass.” “Remnant” is probably not the intended direct referent because it is only indirectly referred to via the similes. “Grass” is also unlikely. The similes compare the remnant to dew and showers, not to grass. Here are two suggestions for the singular verbs in the MT: According to KD (page 330), the verbs refer to the principle idea of the preceding clause, the “dew,” to which “showers” are explanatory and subordinate. UBS (pages 216–217) suggests that “dew was recognized as a direct gift of God which man could do nothing to provide for himself, and the description here is probably an allusion to this.”

These lines describe the dew and showers in 7b–c. The meaning of the lines is probably that these processes of nature occur with no need for human involvement. The LORD is the one who controls them. By implication, the LORD is also in control of what will happen to the remnant.

Here are some ways to translate these lines:

- Make explicit that “dew” and “showers” are the referents.”This option is followed by the Peshitta and by most modern versions. For example:

The remnant of Jacob will be in the midst of many peoples like dew from the Lord, like showers on

the grass, which do not wait for anyone or depend on man. (NIV11)

- Leave implicit a singular referent. This option follows the Masoretic Text forms. However, in some languages it may wrongly imply that the referent is “grass” rather than “dew” or “dew” and “showers.” For example:

it does not wait for human beings; it does not pause for any person. (NCV)

- Make “remnant” the direct referent instead of “dew” and “showers.” This option is different from the Masoretic Text, which gives an indirect reference to the remnant by means of the similes of dew and showers. However, the overall meaning of the verse remains the same. In some languages it may not be natural to personify dew and showers as waiting for humans. This may be a useful alternative translation option in those languages. For example:

The people of Israel who survive will be like refreshing dew sent by the Lord for many nations, like showers on growing plants. They will depend on God, not people. (GNT)

which: The relative pronoun which refers back to the referent in the previous lines. In some languages, it will be more natural to translate this line without using a relative pronoun. For example:

They do not put their hope in humans or wait for mortals. (GW)

wait for...linger for: In Hebrew, these verbs are more literally “wait...wait patiently.” Both words can be translated in this context as “wait,” “hope,” or “depend.” See TWOT #1994 I “wait, look for, hope.” See also NIDOTTE #859 (page 373) “wait, hope.”

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

put their hope in...wait (GW)

need...require

man...mankind: These terms are two ways to refer to human beings. One meaning of the word “mortal” is human limits (see Merriam Webster “mortal” #5). Mortal/limited human beings have no control over the dew and the showers. Some versions translate these

words in a way that more clearly indicates the inability of human beings to control dew and showers. For example:

which do not depend on human agency and are beyond human control (NJB)

They do not put their hope in humans or wait for mortals. (GW)

Micah 5:8

Section 5:7–9: The future role of the exiles that the LORD has delivered

In this section, Micah described events that would happen after the coming of the ruler who was born in Bethlehem (5:1–6). He told the people of Israel that a remnant of Israelites would survive. The LORD would influence people of other nations through the remnant. He would bring blessing to some people, but he would bring destruction to others. NICOT (page 352) points out that two different roles of the remnant are to be a channel of divine blessing and also an agent of divine judgment. See also ABC (page 1081) and Waltke 2007 (page 203).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

A Remnant Shall Be Delivered (ESV)

The Future Role of the Remnant (NRSV)

The Survivors Will Be Safe

5:8a–b (combined/reordered)

- Those who are left among the nations (GNT)

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{8a}Then the remnant of Jacob will be among the nations,

^{8b} in the midst of many peoples,

These lines introduce the second part of the prophecy of 5:7–9. They are very similar to 5:7a, which introduces the first part of the prophecy. A difference is that the phrase “among the nations” does not occur in 5:7a.

5:8a
Then the remnant of Jacob will be among the nations,

- And among other nations, the descendants of Jacob who survive as the nation of Israel
- Located in the middle of Gentile nations, the remaining Israelites are one small country

Then the remnant of Jacob will be among the nations: The meaning of the phrase among the nations is very similar to the parallel phrase “in the midst of many peoples.”

Most versions translate this phrase as among the nations. However, the Hebrew word for nations often refers to pagan/gentile peoples, in contrast to the people of Israel. HALOT (electronic edition, page 183). The context indicates that pagans/gentiles is the referent here. Some versions make that referent explicit. For example:

And the remnant of Jacob shall be among the Gentiles (KJV)

5:8b in the midst of many peoples,

- and are surrounded by many people groups
- with large numbers of people all around them.

in the midst of many peoples: This phrase is the same as in 5:7a. See the note on this phrase in 5:7a for more information.

General Comment on 5:8a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the parallel parts. For example:

Those who are left among the nations (GNT)

5:8c–d (combined/reordered)

- will be like a lion hunting for food in a forest or a pasture. (GNT)

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{8c} like a lion **among the beasts of the forest,**

^{8d} like a young lion **among flocks of sheep,**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 5:8c–d. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 5:8a. For example:

^{8d} they will be like a lion **among the beasts of the forest,**

^{8d} they will be like a young lion **among flocks of sheep,**

These parallel lines are similes that compare the remnant of Jacob to a lion.

Here are two ways that the remnant is like a lion:

1. Lions cause great fear in the animals they attack. This similarity is suggested by JFB (page 693). Likewise, the remnant will cause great fear in the people they attack.
2. Lions attack with great force. The animals they attack cannot escape from them. EBC (page 534) suggests that the comparison is to the relentless force with which a lion captures its prey such that no one can rescue it/them. Similarly, NICOT (pages 354–355) suggests the comparison indicates the irresistible conquest of all opposition. Likewise, the remnant will attack with great force. The people they attack will not escape from them.

lion...young lion: In Hebrew, the word lion is a general term that usually refers to an adult lion. The word that many versions translate as young lion has a very similar meaning. In this context, these parallel words for lion are used for poetic effect. The age of the lion is not important. TWOT #1025a. Here is another way to translate these two words:

lion...a fierce lion (NJB)

If lions are not known in your language area, it is suggested that you provide a picture or describe it in a footnote.

among the beasts of the forest...among flocks of sheep: There are two main interpretations of these parallel phrases: A third interpretation, proposed by A&F (page 486), is that the phrase “among animals of a forest” refers to domesticated animals that graze in the woodlands. This interpretation is not included in the Notes, because no versions clearly follow it.

1. The phrase among the beasts of the forest implies that the lion attacks and kills forest animals. The parallel phrase among flocks of sheep implies that the lion also attacks and kills flocks of sheep/goats. For example:

Those who are left among the nations will be like a lion hunting for food in a forest or a pasture (GNT) (GW, ESV, KJV, NAB, NASB, BSB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB, GNT) This is a straightforward, natural way to understand the syntax and punctuation in these versions.

1. The phrase among the beasts of the forest implies that the lion is a fierce, wild animal. It does not necessarily imply that the lion attacks and kills forest animals. The phrase among flocks of sheep implies that the lion attacks and kills flocks of sheep/goats. According to TOTC (page 203), the similes compare “the remnant among the rest of the nations to a fierce and fearsome lion (the NIV’s ‘young lion’ is doubtful) wreaking a terrible carnage among sheep.” For example:

...they will attack as though they were fierce lions pouncing on sheep. (CEV) (CEV, NLT96, NJB) The CEV and the NLT96 may follow this interpretation. Neither has the word “forest.” This omission may indicate that they regard the reference to the forest here only to imply that the lion is strong or fierce (i.e. wild). The NJB’s comma placement may indicate that the description of the lion’s attack applies only to an attack on the flocks of sheep.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It best fits the parallelism, which depicts two types of prey, wild animals and domesticated animals. These parallel phrases may be a figure of speech. In this figure of speech, the two types of prey indicate all animals. Therefore, the similes imply that the remnant will conquer all surrounding nations, whether they are large and powerful or small and weak. Waltke 2007 (pages 310–312).

Here are some ways to translate the parallel lines:

- Translate 5:8c–d as a single sentence. The parallel lines describe the lion. The remainder of the verse describes what the lion does. For example:

They will be like a lion among the animals of the forest, like a strong young lion among flocks of sheep and goats, pouncing and tearing as they go with no rescuer in sight. (NLT)

- Translate 5:8c–d as two sentences. The parallel lines about the lion are in one sentence. The remainder of the verse is a separate sentence that refers back to the lion. For example:

They will be like a lion among animals in the forest, like a young lion among flocks of sheep. When a lion hunts, it tramples its victims and tears them to pieces and there is no one to rescue them. (GW)

- Combine and/or reorder the parallel lines. Translate the remainder of 5:8c–d as a separate clause that refers back to the lion. For example:

Those who are left among the nations will be like a lion hunting for food in a forest or a pasture: it gets in among the sheep, pounces on them, and tears them to pieces—and there is no hope of rescue. (GNT)

5:8c

like a lion among the beasts of the forest,

- will be like a lion that hunts animals in a forest.
- But they will be like a lion stalking its prey in a thicket

like a lion among the beasts of the forest: See the notes above for the overall meaning of this verse part.

beasts of the forest: This phrase refers to wild animals that live and hide in forests. These animals are in contrast to domesticated flocks in the parallel line (5:8d).

forest: In Hebrew, this word can also refer to a thicket. TWOT #888a and BDB #3264 (page 420).

5:8d

like a young lion among flocks of sheep,

- They will be like a fierce lion among flocks of sheep.
- or among flocks of sheep in a pasture.

like a young lion among flocks of sheep: See the notes for 8:c–d above for the overall meaning of this verse part.

flocks of sheep: In Hebrew, the word for flocks means “herds” or “groups.” The word for sheep can refer to either sheep, goats, or cattle. However, in this phrase it probably refers to sheep. BDB #5739 (page 727). The phrase flocks of sheep may be a part of speech (synecdoche) that represents domesticated animals in contrast to wild animals. Waltke 2007 (pages 310–312).

5:8e

which tramples and tears as it passes through, with no one to rescue them.

- If/When it hunts and pounces and tears them apart, then there is no one who can save them.
- As the lion approaches to attack its prey, it jumps on them, rips, and mangles them. There is no hope that they will be rescued.

which tramples and tears as it passes through, with no one to rescue them: This is a conditional clause that is more literally “which if it has passed through and it will trample and it will tear and there is not a

deliverer.” This clause describes the actions of the lion and their result.

which tramples and tears as it passes through: This clause part describes how the lion hunts and kills its prey.

which...: Many other versions introduce the condition with the word “when” or “if” The technical term for the word “if” or “when” is the “protasis.” placed after the which at the beginning of 5:8e.

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate 5:8e without using a conditional clause, as the BSB does. For example:

like a fierce lion among flocks of sheep trampling as he goes, mangling his prey which no one takes from him (NJB)

it gets in among the sheep, pounces on them, and tears them to pieces—and there is no hope of rescue (GNT)

tramples: In Hebrew, this word means “trample with one’s feet” or “crush to pieces.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 1245).

Here are some other ways to translate it:

pounces on them (GNT)

jumps on them (NCV)

tears: In Hebrew, this word means “tear” or “rend.” It describes the action of capturing an animal, tearing its flesh, and eating it. TWOT #827.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

mangles (NIV)

rips his prey (NET)

as it passes through: In Hebrew, this word means “travel or pass through a place.” BDB #5674 (page 717).

Here are some other ways to translate it:

When a lion hunts (GW)

As it goes (NCV)

it gets in among the sheep (GNT)

with no one to rescue them: This phrase is the result in this conditional clause. The technical term for the result is the “apodosis.” It is grammatically possible to understand one of the other preceding phrases as the apodosis. However, Waltke 2007 (pages 310–312) offers convincing reasons from the Hebrew syntax and accents that this phrase, “then there is not a deliverer,” is the apodosis. When the lion attacks its prey, then no one is able to rescue it from the lion.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

and there is no one to stop it (NET)

and there is no hope of rescue (GNT)

Micah 5:9

Section 5:7–9: The future role of the exiles that the LORD has delivered

In this section, Micah described events that would happen after the coming of the ruler who was born in Bethlehem (5:1–6). He told the people of Israel that a remnant of Israelites would survive. The LORD would influence people of other nations through the remnant. He would bring blessing to some people, but he would bring destruction to others. NICOT (page 352) points out that two different roles of the remnant are to be a channel of divine blessing and also an agent of divine judgment. See also ABC (page 1081) and Waltke 2007 (page 203).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

A Remnant Shall Be Delivered (ESV)

The Future Role of the Remnant (NRSV)

The Survivors Will Be Safe

5:9a–b (combined/reordered)

- Yes/Indeed, you^(sing) will defeat all your enemies and destroy them.
- Likewise, Israel will defeat the nations that oppose her. Her enemies will be no more.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{9a} Your hand will be lifted **over your foes**,

^{9b}and **all your enemies** will be cut off.

These parallel lines are a chiasm in which the parallel parts in the second line are in reverse order from those in the first line.

There is a textual issue here regarding the verbs in 5:9a–b:

1. The LXX has indicative mood. Future indicative is a standard mood of regular imperfect verb forms in Biblical Hebrew. Gesenius' Hebrew Grammar (page 323) states that in some cases the jussive is used for the ordinary imperfect form, as in Micah 3:4 and 5:8. It is also possible that the LXX based its translation on a Hebrew manuscript with regular imperfect rather than jussive forms here. For example:

Your hand will be lifted up over your adversaries, and all your enemies shall be cut off. (ESV) (CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, BSB, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB, GNT)

1. The Masoretic Text has jussive. Hebrew Jussive verbs express a wish, request, or command. See Van der Merwe (electronic edition, page 152). mood. For example:

Lift your hand triumphantly against your adversaries; may all your enemies be destroyed! (NET) Note that the NET translates both verbs as jussives. It translates the first verb as a command and the second verb as a wish. (NET)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with almost all versions.

These lines mean that the remnant will defeat its enemies. They are similar in meaning to the lion similes in 5:8. However, 5:9 states the meaning more directly.

5:9a

Your hand will be lifted over your foes,

- You^(sing) will use your power to fight against your enemies,

Your hand will be lifted over your foes: This line is more literally “your hand shall be high over your foes.” This is the gloss from the Lexham Discourse Hebrew Bible. An uplifted hand is a symbolic gesture that indicates might or power. BDB #7311 (page 926) and NIDOTTE (Volume 3, page 1079). In this context, to have a high hand over one's foes means to have power to fight and defeat them.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

You will be victorious over your foes (NJB)

You will use your power against your opponents (GW)

Your: Another way to refer to the remnant is to use the name “Israel.” For example:

Israel will conquer her enemies (GNT)

- **foes:** Here this word refers to the political or military enemies of Israel or Judah. HALOT (electronic edition., page 1052). For example:

Your hand shall be lifted up over your adversaries (ESV, NRSV)

5:9b

and all your enemies will be cut off.

- and you^(sing) will defeat them all.

and all your enemies will be cut off: This line refers to the defeat of Israel's enemies.

will be cut off: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates figuratively as will be cut off means “eliminate” or “destroy.” TWOT #3772. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate the meaning directly. For example:

and all your enemies shall be destroyed (NAB)

The Hebrew word is passive in form. In some languages, it may be more natural to use an active verb here. For example:

Israel will conquer her enemies and destroy them all. (GNT)

Micah 5:10

Section 5:10–15: The LORD will cause all sorcery and idolatry in Israel to end

This section is another prophecy. In this prophecy, the LORD spoke directly to the people of Israel. This is the interpretation of a large majority of commentators. These include NICOT, A&F, NAC, UBS, EBC, CBC, WBC, ZIBBC, Waltke 2007 and others. Some commentators suggest that the referent here is not Israel but ungodly nations. For example, see Achtemeier. However the latter interpretation has little to support it and is not clearly followed in versions. In 5:10–11, he told them that he would take away the military equipment

and other things that they relied on instead of him. In 5:12–14, he said that he would end all sorcery and idol worship in Israel in order to purify their worship of him. In 5:15, he told about his intention to punish other nations that did not obey him. UBS (page 222).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord will Purify His People (NET)

Idols Will Be Destroyed in Israel (CEV)

5:10a

“In that day,” declares the LORD,

- יי Yahweh declares, “At that time
- יי “In that future time,” says Yahweh,

“In that day,” declares the LORD: This phrase starts the new prophecy. The same phrase is also in 4:6a (“On that day”). See the notes there for more information. Many commentators believe that this prophecy refers to the Messianic age talked about in 5:2–5. For example, Davis (page 114), TOTC (page 206), and ABC (page 1081).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The Lord says, “At that time (GNT)

“When that day comes,” declares the Lord (GW)

5:10b–c

(combined/reordered)

- I will destroy the horses and chariots that you use when you wage war.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{10b} I will remove **your horses** from among you

^{10c} and wreck **your chariots**.

In these parallel lines, the LORD spoke about objects that the people relied on in war. He will take them away so that they will instead rely on him.

remove...from among you: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I will destroy the horses from your midst (NAB)

I will take your horses from you (NCV)

Some versions leave the phrase from among you implied. For example:

I will slaughter your horses (NLT)

remove...wreck: The word remove is the same Hebrew word translated as “cut off” in 5:9b. See the notes there for more information. In this context, both terms mean “destroy.”

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

I will destroy your horses from your midst, and smash your chariots. (NET)

I will take your horses from you and destroy your chariots. (NCV)

horses...chariots: Both horses and chariots were used in war. A chariot was like a cart that carried a soldier and his weapons. Horses pulled the chariots and were sometimes ridden by soldiers. UBS (page 220) and NIDOTTE #5324 (Volume 3, pages 1109–1110).

General Comment on 5:10b–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel lines. For example:

The Lord said: At that time I will wipe out your cavalry and chariots (CEV)

5:10b

“I will remove your horses from among you

- I will take away your^(sing/plur) horses from you
- “I will destroy your war horses

5:10c

and wreck your chariots.

- and destroy the chariots that you^(sing/plur) use for war.
- and will break your chariots into pieces.

Micah 5:11

Section 5:10–15: The LORD will cause all sorcery and idolatry in Israel to end

This section is another prophecy. In this prophecy, the LORD spoke directly to the people of Israel. This is the interpretation of a large majority of commentators. These include NICOT, A&F, NAC, UBS, EBC, CBC, WBC, ZIBBC, Waltke 2007 and others. Some commentators suggest that the referent here is not Israel but ungodly nations. For example, see Achtemeier. However the latter interpretation has little to support it and

is not clearly followed in versions. In 5:10-11, he told them that he would take away the military equipment and other things that they relied on instead of him. In 5:12-14, he said that he would end all sorcery and idol worship in Israel in order to purify their worship of him. In 5:15, he told about his intention to punish other nations that did not obey him. UBS (page 222).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord will Purify His People (NET)

Idols Will Be Destroyed in Israel (CEV)

5:11a-b (combined/reordered)

- I will also destroy your cities and your fortresses.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{11a}and I will remove **the cities of your land**

^{11b}and tear down **all your strongholds**.

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 5:11b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 5:11a. For example:

^{11b}and I will tear down **all your strongholds**.

In these parallel lines, the LORD spoke about places that the people relied on to protect them in war. He will take them away so that they will instead rely on him to defend them.

remove...tear down: In this context, the phrases tear down and remove are very similar. To tear down refers to breaking walls and buildings into pieces so they no longer stand.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

I will destroy the cities of your land and demolish all your fortresses. (NJPS)

I will demolish the cities of your land and tear down all your fortresses. (NAB)

cities of your land...strongholds: The word cities refers to population centers such as villages, towns or cities. Mounce #6551. In the context of the parallel word strongholds, it probably refers to cities in Israel

that were also strongholds that protected people in times of war. Waltke 2007 (page 323) and NICOT (page 357). These strongholds were surrounded by strong walls and had strong buildings to help defend the residents from attack by enemies. UBS (page 220).

Some versions make explicit that this verse refers to structures used for defense or protection from enemies. For example:

I will tear down your walls and demolish your defenses. (NLT)

General Comment on 5:11a-b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel lines. For example:

...as well as your cities and your fortresses. (CEV)

5:11a I will remove the cities of your land

- I will destroy the cities of your^(sing/plur) land
- I will demolish the fortified cities/towns in your country.

5:11b and tear down all your strongholds.

- and tear down all the fortified/strengthened places you^(sing/plur) go to for protection.
- Indeed, I will break apart all the strong walls and buildings where you hide when war comes.

Micah 5:12

Section 5:10-15: The LORD will cause all sorcery and idolatry in Israel to end

This section is another prophecy. In this prophecy, the LORD spoke directly to the people of Israel. This is the interpretation of a large majority of commentators. These include NICOT, A&F, NAC, UBS, EBC, CBC, WBC, ZIBBC, Waltke 2007 and others. Some commentators suggest that the referent here is not Israel but ungodly nations. For example, see Achtemeier. However the latter interpretation has little to support it and is not clearly followed in versions. In 5:10-11, he told them that he would take away the military equipment and other things that they relied on instead of him. In 5:12-14, he said that he would end all sorcery and idol worship in Israel in order to purify their worship of him. In 5:15, he told about his intention to punish other nations that did not obey him. UBS (page 222).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord will Purify His People (NET)

Idols Will Be Destroyed in Israel (CEV)

5:12a–b (combined/reordered)

- I will stop you from telling fortunes and practicing witchcraft. (CEV)

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{12a} I will cut **the sorceries** from your hand,

^{12b} and you will have no **fortune-tellers**.

In these parallel lines, the LORD spoke about types of divination that the people relied on to gain control over nature or people. CBC (pages 331–332) and EBC (page 536). He will stop the people from relying on divination so that they will rely on him instead.

cut...from your hand: Here cut is part of a longer phrase “cut the sorceries from your hand.” The phrase from your hand is a common expression in the Old Testament. Often it has a figurative meaning of “from your use/power” or simply “from you.” Waltke 2007 (pages 323–324) suggests the expression means “from your power.” JFB (page 693) suggests that it means “which you now use.” Some commentators speculate that “from your hand” refers to occult objects held in the hand. However, there is no actual evidence to support this interpretation. A figurative meaning is probably intended here. Some versions translate the meaning of this expression directly. For example:

I will abolish the means of divination from your use (NAB)

Some versions leave the phrase from your hand implied. For example:

I will put an end to all witchcraft (NLT)

cut...have no: In this context, the phrases cut off and have no have a similar function. They are two ways to say that the LORD will stop the people from doing divination.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

I will put an end to all witchcraft, and there will be no more fortune-tellers. (NLT)

I will remove the sorcery that you practice, and you will no longer have omen readers living among you. (NET)

sorceries...fortune-tellers: In Hebrew, the word for sorceries refers to sorceries or magic arts. BDB #3785 (page 506) and NIDOTTE (Volume 2, page 735). Some versions translate this word as “magic charms” or “sorcerers.” However, it is recommended that you translate this word as a general reference to sorcery. Other Hebrew words exist that mean sorcerer or charms. Here the generic word is used.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

witchcraft (NLT)

divination (NAB)

In Hebrew, the word for fortune-tellers refers to people that tell fortunes, interpret signs and/or use magic. HALOT (electronic edition, page 857) and NIDOTTE (#6726).

Here are some other ways to translate it:

soothsayers (NRSV)

omen readers (NET)

General Comment on 5:12a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel lines. For example:

I will stop you from telling fortunes and practicing witchcraft. (CEV)

5:12a

I will cut the sorceries from your hand,

- I will abolish divination/magic from among you^(sing/plur),
- I will put an end to your witchcraft,

5:12b

and you will have no fortune-tellers.

- and you^(sing/plur) will no longer have omen readers.
- and there will be no more fortune tellers.

Micah 5:13

Section 5:10–15: The LORD will cause all sorcery and idolatry in Israel to end

This section is another prophecy. In this prophecy, the LORD spoke directly to the people of Israel. This is the interpretation of a large majority of commentators. These include NICOT, A&F, NAC, UBS, EBC, CBC, WBC, ZIBBC, Waltke 2007 and others. Some commentators suggest that the referent here is not Israel but ungodly nations. For example, see Achtemeier. However the latter interpretation has little to support it and is not clearly followed in versions. In 5:10–11, he told them that he would take away the military equipment and other things that they relied on instead of him. In 5:12–14, he said that he would end all sorcery and idol worship in Israel in order to purify their worship of him. In 5:15, he told about his intention to punish other nations that did not obey him. UBS (page 222).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord will Purify His People (NET)

Idols Will Be Destroyed in Israel (CEV)

5:13a–b (combined/reordered)

- You will no longer worship the idols or stone images you have made—I will destroy them, (CEV)

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{13a} I will cut off **the carved images** and **sacred pillars** from among you,

^{13b} so that you will no longer bow down **to the work of your own hands**.

In these parallel lines, the LORD spoke about types of idols that the people relied on instead of him. He will destroy the images and sacred pillars that they made with their own hands so they will no longer worship them.

5:13a

I will also cut off the carved images and sacred pillars from among you,

- I will destroy your^(sing/plur) idols and the sacred stone pillars in your^(sing/plur) midst.
- I will remove your statues of gods and the memorial stones you have set up,

cut off...from among you: Here are some other ways to translate 5:13a:

I will abolish your carved images and the sacred pillars from your midst (NAB)

I will destroy your idols and the sacred pillars in your midst (NJPS)

Some versions leave the phrase from among you implied. For example:

I will destroy all your idols and sacred pillars (NLT)

carved images and sacred pillars: The words carved images refers to idols. Many idols were carved from wood or stone or cast in a mold. Some were covered with metal. NIDOTTE #7181 (Volume 3, page 645).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

idols (NLT)

statues of gods (NCV)

The word for sacred pillars refers here to stones that are set upright as a monument. In this context, the stone represents Canaanite gods. EBC (page 57). The people poured drink-offerings over the stone as an act of worship. CBC (page 332).

5:13b

so that you will no longer bow down to the work of your own hands.

- You^(sing/plur) will no longer bow down in worship to things you have made with your^(sing/plur) own hands.
- so that you can no longer worship the idols you have made.

so that you will no longer bow down to the work of your own hands: In this context, the phrase no longer refers to people's worship of these objects.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

I will destroy all your idols and sacred pillars, so you will never again worship the work of your own hands. (NLT)

I will remove your idols and sacred pillars from your midst; you will no longer worship what your own hands have made. (NET)

I will destroy your idols and sacred stone pillars;
no longer will you worship the things that you
yourselves have made. (GNT)

General Comment on 5:13a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel lines. See 5:13a–b combined/reordered in the Display.

Micah 5:14

Section 5:10–15: The LORD will cause all sorcery and idolatry in Israel to end

This section is another prophecy. In this prophecy, the LORD spoke directly to the people of Israel. This is the interpretation of a large majority of commentators. These include NICOT, A&F, NAC, UBS, EBC, CBC, WBC, ZIBBC, Waltke 2007 and others. Some commentators suggest that the referent here is not Israel but ungodly nations. For example, see Achtemeier. However the latter interpretation has little to support it and is not clearly followed in versions. In 5:10–11, he told them that he would take away the military equipment and other things that they relied on instead of him. In 5:12–14, he said that he would end all sorcery and idol worship in Israel in order to purify their worship of him. In 5:15, he told about his intention to punish other nations that did not obey him. UBS (page 222).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord will Purify His People (NET)

Idols Will Be Destroyed in Israel (CEV)

5:14a–b (combined/reordered)

- together with the sacred poles and even your towns. (CEV)

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{14a} I will root out **the Asherah poles from your midst**

^{14b} and demolish **your cities**.

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 5:14b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 5:14a. For example:

^{14b} and I will demolish **your cities**.

In these parallel lines, the LORD spoke about another kind of idol that the people relied on instead of relying on him. He will destroy these idols and the towns that contained them so that the people will no longer worship them.

5:14a

I will root out the Asherah poles from your midst

- I will pull out the Asherah poles from your^(sing/plur) land.
- I will tear out your sacred poles

I will root out: The words root out means “pull out” or “remove.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 737).

the Asherah poles from your midst: This kind of pole was used in the worship of the Canaanite goddess Asherah.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

I will uproot from among you your Asherah poles (NIV)

I will tear out the sacred poles from your midst (NAB)

Some versions leave the phrase from your midst implied. For example:

I shall pull up your sacred poles (REB)

I will pull down the images of the goddess Asherah in your land (GNT)

I will abolish your idol shrines with their Asherah poles (NLT)

5:14b

and demolish your cities.

- I will also destroy your^(sing/plur) cities.
- and demolish the cities/towns where you bow down to them.

and demolish your cities: The Hebrew word for cities is the same as in 5:12. Some scholars propose that the original Hebrew word did not mean cities but “idol.” Some others suggest emending the Hebrew word to one that means “idols” or “altars.” However, these suggestions lack evidence to support such a change. Ancient versions translate the word as “cities.” In the context of the parallel line, 5:14a, the reference is probably to towns or cities in Israel that were centers

for the worship of Asherah.JFB (page 693), EBC (page 536), and NAC (page 106).

Here are some other ways to translate 5:14b:

and destroy your towns (NRSV)

and destroy your pagan cities (NLT)

General Comment on 5:14a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel lines. See 5:14a–b combined/reordered in the Display.

Micah 5:15

Section 5:10–15: The LORD will cause all sorcery and idolatry in Israel to end

This section is another prophecy. In this prophecy, the LORD spoke directly to the people of Israel. This is the interpretation of a large majority of commentators. These include NICOT, A&F, NAC, UBS, EBC, CBC, WBC, ZIBBC, Waltke 2007 and others. Some commentators suggest that the referent here is not Israel but ungodly nations. For example, see Achtemeier. However the latter interpretation has little to support it and is not clearly followed in versions. In 5:10–11, he told them that he would take away the military equipment and other things that they relied on instead of him. In 5:12–14, he said that he would end all sorcery and idol worship in Israel in order to purify their worship of him. In 5:15, he told about his intention to punish other nations that did not obey him. UBS (page 222).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord will Purify His People (NET)

Idols Will Be Destroyed in Israel (CEV)

5:15

I will take vengeance in anger and wrath upon the nations that have not obeyed Me.”

- In my great/fierce anger and rage, I will also punish the nations that have not obeyed me.”
- I will be extremely angry at/with the people of other nations that have refused to do what I said, and I will take proper revenge.”

I will take vengeance in anger and wrath upon the nations that have not obeyed Me: In this verse the LORD spoke about his judgment against disobedient nations. Both the subject and the type of writing are different from the rest of the prophecy. In this verse,

the subject is nations other than Israel. The type of writing is a single prose statement instead of poetic parallel lines.

I will take vengeance in anger and wrath: This sentence part describes the manner in which the LORD will judge the nations.

I will take vengeance: In this phrase, the LORD said that he will punish. UBS (page 222). The LORD’s vengeance is different than human vengeance. His vengeance is just and righteous, based on his holiness. WBC (page 49), CBC (pages 332–333), NAC (page 106).

in anger and wrath: The Hebrew words for anger and wrath often occur together with a single meaning of “great anger.” UBS (page 222). The word for wrath gives emphasis to the severity of the anger. See West “Divine Wrath,” Lexham Theological Wordbook.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

anger and fury (REB)

become furious (CEV)

upon the nations: This phrase probably refers to nations that surround Israel. NAC (page 106) suggests that Israel had learned corrupt and pagan behavior from some of these nations.

that have not obeyed Me: The Hebrew word for “obey” has a wide range of meanings related to hearing, listening to, and heeding what is said. In situations where the listener is under the authority of the speaker, it means “obey.” NIDOTTE #9048 (pages 175–178).

Some versions make explicit that it is the LORD whom the nations do not obey. For example:

I will take vengeance in anger and wrath on the nations that have not obeyed me.” (NIV)

See Overall structure of the book in the Introduction for more details about the three divisions.

Micah 6:1

Section 6:1–8: The LORD brought a lawsuit against his people

In this section, the LORD (speaking through Micah) conducted a lawsuit or a court trial against the people of Israel. The LORD accused the people of Israel of failing to keep his requirements. Some scholars refer

to this accusation as a “covenant lawsuit” because his requirements were based on his covenant with Israel. For example, ZIBBC (pages 140–141), Hays (page 315), and CBC (page 334). Scholars point out, however, that this lawsuit was not conventional in some ways. For example, there was no judge, the witnesses were silent, and there was no pronouncement of punishment. ZIBBC (pages 140–141) and A&F (page 513). Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s case against Israel (NIV)

God Challenges Israel (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:1–2

The lawsuit/trial began with these verses. Micah called on the people to hear the LORD’s case against them and called on the mountains/hills to be witnesses.

6:1a

Hear now what the LORD says:

- ¶ Listen, people of Israel to what Yahweh has to say:
- ¶ People of Israel, pay attention to the charges Yahweh has against you^(plur):

Hear now what the LORD says: This command to hear/listen starts a new prophecy/oracle in which Micah introduced the LORD’s lawsuit.

Hear: The word Hear is plural. Micah was speaking to the people of Israel. In some languages, it may be more natural to make the addressee explicit. For example:

Listen to what the LORD says to his people

In Hebrew, the word Hear is followed by a particle that indicates emphasis or insistence. The literal command is “šim ū-nā’.” The particle nā’ is defined by TWOT #1269 as “particle of entreaty or exhortation,” and by HALOT (electronic edition, page 656) as “particle giving emphasis.” A&F (page 514) state that the particle makes the command “peremptory and insistent rather than pleading.” Many versions leave this particle implied. Some English versions translate it as “now.” For example:

Now listen to what Yahweh says: (NJB)

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

what the LORD says: This phrase refers to the charge/case that the LORD will present. Some versions make this meaning explicit. For example:

Listen to the Lord’s case against Israel. (GNT)

6:1b–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning. The NIV11 has been used as the source line for 6:1b, because it follows the recommended interpretation:

^{1b}(NIV11) “Stand up, plead my case before **the mountains**;

^{1c}and let **the hills** hear your voice.

These lines are more literally “Arise conduct a case with the mountains and let hear the hills your voice.” The literal Hebrew commands in 6:1b do not have an explicit pronoun such as “my” or “your.” Most versions supply one of these pronouns in 6:1b to make their interpretation clearer.

There are three main interpretations of the identity of the participants in these parallel commands:

1. The LORD commanded Micah to rise and conduct the LORD’s case against the people of Israel. The mountains and hills were to hear Micah’s voice. For example:

Come, present [My] case before the mountains, and let the hills hear you pleading (NJPS) (NIV11, NJPS)

1. The LORD commanded Israel to rise and conduct Israel’s case against him. The main context for this interpretation is 6:3. Israel’s complaint is implied by the rhetorical questions “what have I done to you? and How have I burdened you?” Commentaries that support interpretation (2) include NAC (pages 108–109), JFB (page 693), and CBC (page 334). The mountains and hills were to hear Israel’s voice. For example:

Stand up and state your case against me. Let the mountains and hills be called to witness your complaints. (NLT) (CEV, NCV, NET, NLT) These versions make explicit this interpretation.

1. Micah told the LORD to rise and conduct the LORD’s case against the people of Israel. The main context for this interpretation is 6:2. In 6:1b–c Micah tells the

LORD to conduct his case. In 6:2 the LORD complies by opening the case, referring to himself in 3rd person. Commentaries that support interpretation (3) include A&F (page 514) and UBS (page 225). The mountains and hills were to hear the LORD's voice. For example:

Arise, O Lord, and present your case; let the mountains and the hills hear what you say. (GNT) (GNT)

Some versions that translate 6:1b with "your case" are ambiguous. In these versions, the referent of "your" could be either Israel or the LORD.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with the majority of commentaries. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include NICOT, KD, EBC, Waltke 2007, and TOTC.

the mountains...the hills: In 6:1-8, the mountains and the hills are parallel figures of speech (personification). JFB (Volume 1, page 693), NAC (pages 108-109), and KD (page 333). Here they represented witnesses at a trial in a court of law. They were fitting witnesses because they were present throughout all of Israel's history. Thus, they had figuratively seen everything good that the LORD has done for Israel as well as the people's acts of disloyalty. UBS (page 225).

Here are some ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the personification. This is the best option if the figure is natural in your language and people will understand the meaning correctly. For example:

Stand up, plead my case before the mountains; let the hills hear what you have to say. (NIV)

- Change the personification to a simile. Consider making the similarity of the mountains and hills to witnesses explicit. For example:

Arise and state my case. Speak as if the mountains and hills can hear you like witnesses in the trial.

6:1b

"Arise, plead your case before the mountains,

- He says to me, "Arise to present my case before the mountains,
- He tells me to stand and conduct a lawsuit in the presence of the mountains

(NIV11) Stand up: This command often functions as a call to action. A&F (page 514). In the context of a

legal case the gesture signifies the start of the court session. CBC (page 334).

(NIV11) plead my case: This phrase means "to fight with words," as in a quarrel or a legal case. Here it refers to a legal case or lawsuit. In Hebrew, *rîb*.

6:1c

and let the hills hear your voice.

- and the hills need to hear what you^(sing) are about to say."
- and the hills.

and let the hills hear your voice: In this clause, the phrase let the hills hear does not mean to allow or give permission to hear. This is a Hebrew jussive form that indicates a desire or wish. It means that the LORD wanted the hills to hear his case against Israel. The words your voice refer to the voice of Micah as he presented the LORD's case.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Present my case before the hills

and also before the hills

General Comment on 6:1b-c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel statements. For example:

Rise and plead my case before the mountains and hills.

Micah 6:2

Section 6:1-8: The LORD brought a lawsuit against his people

In this section, the LORD (speaking through Micah) conducted a lawsuit or a court trial against the people of Israel. The LORD accused the people of Israel of failing to keep his requirements. Some scholars refer to this accusation as a "covenant lawsuit" because his requirements were based on his covenant with Israel. For example, ZIBBC (pages 140-141), Hays (page 315), and CBC (page 334). Scholars point out, however, that this lawsuit was not conventional in some ways. For example, there was no judge, the witnesses were silent, and there was no pronouncement of punishment. ZIBBC (pages 140-141) and A&F (page 513).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord's case against Israel (NIV)

God Challenges Israel (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:1–2

The lawsuit/trial began with these verses. Micah called on the people to hear the LORD's case against them and called on the mountains/hills to be witnesses.

6:2a–b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{2a}“Hear, **O mountains, the LORD's indictment,**

^{2b} **you enduring foundations of the earth.**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 6:2b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 6:2a. For example:

^{2b} hear **you enduring foundations of the earth the LORD's indictment.**

In these parallel lines, Micah began conducting the case of the LORD against Israel. He first called/summoned the mountains and the foundations of the earth to be witnesses in the case.

6:2a

Hear, O mountains, the LORD's indictment,

- O mountains, hear Yahweh's case.
- So listen as witnesses in Yahweh's lawsuit, you^(plur) mountains

Hear: This is the same Hebrew word as in 6:1a.

O mountains: Here Micah addressed the mountains directly, as if they could hear and understand him. Some versions have added the word “you” or O to make it clear that O mountains, is a term of address (vocative).

Use a term of address (vocative) that is natural in your language when a person speaks to a group of listeners. In some languages, it may be helpful to use a simile here. For example:

Mountains, I call on you as witnesses to listen to the accusation of the LORD.

the LORD's indictment: In Hebrew, the word for indictment is a form of the same word as “plead my case” in 6:1b. See the note there for more detail.

6:2b

you enduring foundations of the earth.

- Listen, you^(plur) firm foundations of the earth,
- that hold up the earth.

you enduring foundations of the earth: This phrase may refer to the bottoms of the mountains. NAC (page 109). It indicates the very old, unchanging parts of the land that had witnessed Israel's entire history. UBS (page 226) and EBC (page 538).

Here are some other examples:

You firm foundations of the earth! (NJPS)

Listen, you strong foundations of the earth. (GW)

Micah addressed the enduring foundations of the earth directly. For more information on how to translate the vocative you see “O mountains” in 6:2a.

6:2c

For the LORD has a case against His people,

- because Yahweh has a dispute with his people Israel,
- Yahweh has an accusation to bring against his people.

6:2d

and He will argue it against Israel:

- and he will now argue his case against them.
- He will prosecute Israel for its/her crimes.

6:2c–d

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{2c}For the LORD has a case **against his people,**

^{2d}and He will argue it **against Israel:**

These lines give the reason why Micah asked the mountains and foundations of the earth to hear. The reason was to hear the lawsuit.

For: This word introduces a reason.

Here are some ways to introduce this clause:

- Use a conjunction such as For or “because.” For example:

because the Lord has a case against His people (NASB)

- Leave implied that the clause is a reason. For example:

The Lord has a case against his people. (GNT)

Use a natural way in your language to introduce a reason.

has a case against...will argue it against: These parallel phrases are very similar in meaning. The word case against means an “argument.” Here both phrases refer to the legal case that the LORD (through Micah) was about to argue against the people of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

He has a case against his people. He will bring charges against Israel. (NLT)

The Lord has a legal case against his people, and he will accuse Israel. (NCV)

The Lord has filed a lawsuit against his people. He is arguing his case against Israel. (GW)

against His people...Israel: Here the word against introduces the defendants in the case. Waltke 2007 (page 348 citing Renaud La Formation, page 292). The defendants in the LORD’s case were his people, Israel.

Both of the terms His people and Israel refer to the people of Israel. However, Micah may have used the phrase His people to remind them that they were obligated to live according to their covenant with the LORD. The phrase may also indicate that the LORD had the right to make this case against them. KD (page 333).

Micah 6:3

Section 6:1–8: The LORD brought a lawsuit against his people

In this section, the LORD (speaking through Micah) conducted a lawsuit or a court trial against the people of Israel. The LORD accused the people of Israel of failing to keep his requirements. Some scholars refer to this accusation as a “covenant lawsuit” because his requirements were based on his covenant with Israel. For example, ZIBBC (pages 140–141), Hays (page 315), and CBC (page 334). Scholars point out, however, that this lawsuit was not conventional in some ways. For example, there was no judge, the witnesses were silent, and there was no pronouncement of punishment. ZIBBC (pages 140–141) and A&F (page 513).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s case against Israel (NIV)

God Challenges Israel (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:3–5

In 6:3–5, the LORD stated his charge/accusation against the people. In 6:3, he asked how he had wronged them. The people had no answer. In 6:4–5, he related significant events from Israel’s past that show how he had blessed them, not wronged them. The implicit charge/accusation is that the LORD had kept the covenant but they had not. WBC (page 50) and TOTC (pages 211–212).

6:3a

‘My people, what have I done to you?’

- ¶ He asks, “My people, what have I done against you^(sing/plur)?”
- ¶ “My people, in what way have I wronged you?”

My people: Starting with this clause, the LORD addressed his people directly. Some versions make it explicit that the LORD is speaking. For example:

The Lord says, “My people...” (GNT)

Here the phrase My people is a term of address (vocative). Some versions have added the word “O” to make it explicit that this is a vocative. Use a term of address that is natural in your language when a person speaks to a group of people.

The pronoun My probably drew attention to the covenant relationship between the LORD and his people. He was their LORD and they were his people. NICOT (page 365), NAC (page 109), and JFB (page 693).

what have I done to you?: In this question the meaning of the Hebrew word for done is broad and can refer to many actions. TWOT #1708 and Waltke 2007 (page 349). However, in this context the phrase to you means “against you.” Waltke 2007 (page 349). So with this question the LORD asked in what way he had done something against them. Some versions make this meaning explicit. For example:

“My people! What wrong have I done you? (NJPS)

“My people, how have I wronged you? (NET)

6:3b

Testify against Me how I have wearied you!

- For what reason have you^(sing/plur) become tired of me? Answer me!
- Tell me how I have overburdened you!

Testify against Me: In Hebrew, this phrase means “respond to me” in many contexts. However, in the context of legal actions it means “give evidence against me.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 852) and BDB #6030 (page 773). Also A&F (page 518) and TOTC (pages 211–212).

Many versions translate this phrase as “Answer me.” However, if your language has a specific legal term for a response during a court trial, consider using that term here. For example:

Testify against Me. (NJPS)

Bring your charges! (REB)

how I have wearied you!: In Hebrew, the word wearied means to cause someone to become impatient or frustrated. BDB #3811 (page 521) “exhaust patience of” and Mounce (page 962) “to wear someone out, try one’s patience, frustrate.” The LORD asked in what way he had done this to them.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

What have I done to make you tired of me? (NLT)

How have I been a burden to you? (GNT)

Micah 6:4

Section 6:1–8: The LORD brought a lawsuit against his people

In this section, the LORD (speaking through Micah) conducted a lawsuit or a court trial against the people of Israel. The LORD accused the people of Israel of failing to keep his requirements. Some scholars refer to this accusation as a “covenant lawsuit” because his requirements were based on his covenant with Israel. For example, ZIBBC (pages 140–141), Hays (page 315), and CBC (page 334). Scholars point out, however, that this lawsuit was not conventional in some ways. For example, there was no judge, the witnesses were silent, and there was no pronouncement of punishment. ZIBBC (pages 140–141) and A&F (page 513).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s case against Israel (NIV)

God Challenges Israel (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:3–5

In 6:3–5, the LORD stated his charge/accusation against the people. In 6:3, he asked how he had wronged them. The people had no answer. In 6:4–5, he related significant events from Israel’s past that show how he had blessed them, not wronged them. The implicit charge/accusation is that the LORD had kept the covenant but they had not. WBC (page 50) and TOTC (pages 211–212).

6:4a

For I brought you up from the land of Egypt

- In fact, I brought you^(sing/plur) out of the land of Egypt.
- The truth is that I rescued you from Egypt,

6:4b

and redeemed you from the house of slavery.

- I rescued you^(sing/plur) from that place of slavery.
- freeing you from where you lived as slaves.

6:4a–b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{4a}For I brought you up **from the land of Egypt**

^{4b}and redeemed you **from the house of slavery.**

In these lines, the LORD began to give evidence that he had not wronged the people of Israel. Rather, he had been good to them. There is a Hebrew word play here. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as “have I wearied you” in 6:3b sounds similar to the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as “I brought you up” in 6:4a. This word play may have emphasized a contrast, as if the LORD were saying “I have not wearied you. Rather I have rescued you from slavery and brought you to the promised land.” See NAC (page 110), NICOT (pages 365–367) and WBC (page 51). His goodness was shown in the significant events of Israel’s past. The first event he talked about was that he rescued them. It was the ancestors of the people of Israel that the LORD rescued. However, Israelites of every generation identified with that past event almost as if it happened to them. The Exodus pointed to their relationship to the LORD, which defined who they were as a people. See NICOT, Waltke, WBC, EBC, KD, and UBS. out of slavery in Egypt.

For: Here this word introduces the LORD’s answer to the questions in 6:3. He had not wronged or wearied them. On the contrary, he had shown them kindness. JFB (page 693).

Here are some ways to translate this word:

For (ESV)

Indeed (NASB)

In fact (NJPS)

Some versions leave this word implied. For example:

I brought you out of Egypt (GNT)

brought you up...redeemed you: Both phrases refer to the LORD's rescue of the people from slavery in Egypt. UBS (page 228). The phrase brought you up describes it as a change of their location. The phrase redeemed you describes it as a change of their circumstances from being slaves to being free people.

brought you up: The Hebrew word for brought you up literally means to bring someone upward from a lower to a higher place. It also has a figurative meaning of raising someone up from the underworld, giving life to someone dead. LTW "Resurrection." In this context, it may have both literal and figurative meanings. Literally, Egypt was at a lower elevation than the places where the LORD brought them. Figuratively the LORD rescuing them from Egypt was comparable to his raising them from death to new life.

Some languages will not have a single word or phrase with both these meanings. If that is true in your language it is recommended that you translate the literal meaning and leave the figurative meaning implied. There are other Old Testament references to the same event that use the Hebrew word for "bring out" rather than "bring up." An example is in Exodus 6:26. These other references suggest that the primary meaning of these similar phrases is the literal removal of the people from Egypt. For example:

For I brought you out of Egypt (NLT)

redeemed you: In Hebrew, the word that the BSB translates as redeemed you is literally "I ransomed you." The word "ransom" means "transfer ownership of a person or object to another through payment of a price or an equivalent substitute." TWOT (#1734) explains that when God delivered Israel from servitude to Egypt, the price he paid was the slaughter of the firstborn in Egypt, man and beast. Another suggestion is made by NICOT (pages 365–357). He says that here the Hebrew word for "I ransomed you," has the general sense of release without thought of payment to the Egyptians.

Here are some other ways to translate the word in this context:

and ransomed you from the house of slavery (NASB)

from the place of slavery I released you (NAB)

and freed you from slavery (NCV)

the land of Egypt...the house of slavery: Both phrases refer to Egypt. The phrase the land of Egypt describes the literal location. The phrase the house of slavery describes Egypt figuratively with reference to the circumstances of the people while they were there. UBS (page 228).

house of slavery: In this phrase, the word house refers to a place, the land of Egypt. It does not indicate a literal house.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the place where you were forced to work very hard This suggestion is from UBS (page 228).

the place of slavery (NAB)

the land of slavery (NIV)

the place of slave-labour (NJB)

Some versions leave the word house implied. For example:

I rescued you from slavery (GNT)

6:4c

I sent Moses before you, as well as Aaron and Miriam.

- Indeed, I sent Moses, Aaron and Miriam to lead you^(sing/plur).
- To help you I sent Miriam, Aaron, and Moses.

I sent Moses before you, as well as Aaron and Miriam: The LORD gave the people effective leaders. This was a second significant event in Israel's past that gave evidence of the LORD's goodness to his people.

I sent...before you: This phrase probably indicates that the LORD chose and sent Moses, Aaron and Miriam to lead the people out of Egypt, through the

wilderness of Sinai, and to the promised land. Some commentators point out that Moses, Aaron, and Miriam each served a prophetic role. This role is not made explicit here but their role as the representatives and spokesmen for the LORD is probably an implication of this phrase. See A&F (page 519), and Davis (page 123).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I sent Moses, Aaron, and Miriam to lead you. (GNT)

I sent Moses, Aaron, and Miriam to help you. (NLT)

I sent Moses, Aaron, and Miriam to you. (NCV)

Moses...Aaron and Miriam: The Hebrew is more literally, “I sent before you Moses, Aaron, and Miriam.” In some languages it is natural to list the most important name first, as is shown here. The BSB and some other translations separate Moses to stylistically show his importance. Others follow the Hebrew more closely. The birth order of these siblings was probably Miriam, Aaron, and Moses. In some other languages, it is natural to list the oldest first. Translate these three names in the order that is most natural in your language. For this suggestion see UBS (page 228).

Micah 6:5

Section 6:1–8: The LORD brought a lawsuit against his people

In this section, the LORD (speaking through Micah) conducted a lawsuit or a court trial against the people of Israel. The LORD accused the people of Israel of failing to keep his requirements. Some scholars refer to this accusation as a “covenant lawsuit” because his requirements were based on his covenant with Israel. For example, ZIBBC (pages 140–141), Hays (page 315), and CBC (page 334). Scholars point out, however, that this lawsuit was not conventional in some ways. For example, there was no judge, the witnesses were silent, and there was no pronouncement of punishment. ZIBBC (pages 140–141) and A&F (page 513).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s case against Israel (NIV)

God Challenges Israel (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:3–5

In 6:3–5, the LORD stated his charge/accusation against the people. In 6:3, he asked how he had wronged them. The people had no answer. In 6:4–5, he related significant events from Israel’s past that show how he had blessed them, not wronged them. The implicit charge/accusation is that the LORD had kept the covenant but they had not. WBC (page 50) and TOTC (pages 211–212).

6:5

In verse 6:5, the LORD asked his people to remember two more significant events in Israel’s past that gave evidence of his goodness to his people. One event was his rescue of the people from Balak, the king of Moab. Another was when he brought the people from Shittim to Gilgal.

6:5a

My people, remember what Balak king of Moab counseled

- My people, remember what King Balak of Moab planned
- Do not forget, my people, that King Balak of Moab schemed to do you harm,

My people, remember what Balak king of Moab counseled:

This clause refers to the plan of Balak to hire Balaam to curse the people of Israel. WBC (page 51), CBC (page 335), and NAC (page 111). Consider placing a cross-reference here to Numbers 22–24.

My people: Use a term of address (vocative) that is natural in your language when a person speaks to a group of people.

remember: In Hebrew, the word remember is followed by a particle that indicates emphasis or insistence. The particle *nā’* is defined by TWOT #1269 as “particle of entreaty or exhortation,” and by HALOT (electronic edition, page 656) as “particle giving emphasis.” Many versions including the BSB leave this word implied. Some English versions translate it as “now.” Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

what Balak king of Moab counseled: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally a direct question, “What did Balak the king of Moab plan?”

In some other languages, it may also be natural to translate this clause (and the next clause in 5b) as a direct question. For example:

My people, please remember: what was Balak king of Moab’s plan and how did Balaam son of Beor answer him? (NJB)

However, be sure your translation does not imply that the LORD is asking the people for information. He is asking them to remember this event.

In some languages, it is more natural to translate this clause as a statement rather than as a question. The Hebrew word *mah* is tagged in BART as an interrogative pronoun. However, BDB #4078 (page 552) indicates that in Micah 6:5 the word meaning approximates that of a relative pronoun “what/that which.” For example:

My people, remember what Balak king of Moab plotted (NIV11)

My people, recall how King Balak of Moab planned to harm you (NET)

Translate this clause in a natural way in your language.

This clause leaves implicit that King Balak’s plan was to put a curse on the people of Israel. Micah’s listeners at that time knew this information. However, the readers of your translation may not know it.

Here are some ways to translate this implicit information:

- Leave it implicit.
- Leave it implicit in the translation but provide the information in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

King Balak hired Balaam to put a curse on the people of Israel.

- Make it explicit in the translation. For example:

...King Balak of Moab tried to have you cursed (NLT)

Balak king of Moab: Balak was the king of Moab at the time the people of Israel were ready to cross the Jordan river. He regarded the people as a threat. For more information about King Balak, see Numbers 22–24.

counseled: In Hebrew, this word means “planned” or “decided.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 421).

In this context, the word refers to Balak’s plan that was directed against the people of Israel. Some versions make this information more explicit. For example:

Remember what Balak king of Moab

Plotted against you (NJPS)

6:5b

and what Balaam son of Beor answered.

- and how Balaam son of Beor responded to him.
- but Balaam son of Beor blessed you instead.

what Balaam son of Beor answered: This clause refers to Balaam’s pronouncement of blessings on the people of Israel instead of curses. CBC (page 335) and NAC (page 111).

In Hebrew, this clause is a direct question, “and what did Balaam the son of Beor answer him?” See the discussion of the clause “what Balak king of Moab counseled” in 6:5a for suggestions on whether to translate this clause as a statement or as a question.

This clause leaves implicit that Balaam’s answer was to bless the people of Israel.

Here are some ways to translate this implicit information:

- Leave it implicit.
- Leave it implicit in the translation but provide the information in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

Balaam blessed the people of Israel instead of cursing them.

- Make it explicit in the translation. For example:

and how Balaam son of Beor blessed you instead (NLT)

Balaam son of Beor: Balaam son of Beor was a prophet (not an Israelite). He hired out his services to others for personal gain. For more information about him, see Numbers 22–24, 2 Peter 2:15–16.

answered: In Hebrew, this phrase means “answered,” “replied,” or “responded.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

how Balaam son of Beor responded to him (NET)

what Balaam son of Beor said to him (CEV)

6:5c

Remember your journey from Shittim to Gilgal,

- And remember all that happened from Shittim to Gilgal,
- Recall your journey from Shittim to Gilgal,

Remember your journey from Shittim to Gilgal: In Hebrew, this is a clause with no verbs. It is more literally “from (the) Shittim to (the) Gilgal.” Most versions supply additional words such as “and what happened” in order to make the translation sound more natural.

This clause is probably a reference to the people’s journey from Shittim to Gilgal. It is another event from Israel’s history that the LORD wanted the people to remember. Davis (page 124) suggests that the verb ‘remember’ from 6:5a probably applies here also. See also Pusey (page 81), UBS (page 229), and NAC (page 111). Consider placing a cross-reference here to Joshua 3–4.

The miraculous crossing of the Jordan river is probably the main event that the LORD referred to here. This is the majority view of commentators. For example, NICOT, UBS, NAC, Davis, Waltke 2007, and TOTC. Some versions make this referent explicit. For example:

consider the crossing from Shittim to Gilgal (REB)

However, it is possible that the reference is both to the crossing of the Jordan river and to other events as well. Some commentators suggest that the reference may include Israel’s unfaithfulness at Baal Peor, the defeat of the Midianites, and the circumcision at Gilgal. See CBC (page 335) and KD (pages 334–335). Most versions translate this clause in a way that leaves the specific events implicit. The BSB above is one example. Here is another example:

[Recall your passage]

From Shittim to Gilgal (NJPS)

Shittim: Shittim was a location on the east bank of the Jordan river. The people of Israel camped there before they crossed the river. Some versions translate this location as Acacia, which is an alternative name for Shittim.

Gilgal: Gilgal was a location on the west bank of the Jordan river. It was the first place they camped in the promised land after they crossed the river.

6:5d

so that you may acknowledge the righteousness of the LORD.”

- so that you^(sing/plur) will know the many ways Yahweh was good to you^(sing/plur).
- and realize what I, Yahweh, did to save you.”

so that you may acknowledge the righteousness of the LORD: The LORD wanted the people to remember the events described in 5a–c so that they would know what he did for their benefit.

These actions show that he kept his promise to care for them. In this lawsuit/trial, these actions were evidence that he had done no wrong to them. The people’s complaints against the LORD in 6:3 had no merit. UBS (pages 229–230), NAC (page 111), and KD (pages 334–335).

so that: These words may introduce a reason/purpose or a result. Waltke 2007 (page 356).

The first example below introduces the clause as purpose/reason. The second example implicitly introduces the clause as result:

so that you might know the righteous acts of the Lord (NASB)

and as a result you will realize what I did in order to save you

In this context there is only a slight difference in meaning between purpose/reason and result, and each implies the other. Translate this word in a way that is natural in your language.

you may acknowledge: This phrase is literally “to know.” Most versions supply a phrase such as you may or “you might” as natural ways to introduce a result or a purpose clause in English. Here the phrase you may or “you might” does not indicate permission or uncertainty.

In Hebrew, the verb that the BSB translates as acknowledge has more than one meaning related to knowing, experiencing, and understanding. In this context, the word may have more than one aspect of meaning. Aaron C. Fenlason, “Belief,” Lexham Theological Wordbook, Lexham Bible Reference Series (Bellingham, WA: Lexham Press, 2014) notes that the Hebrew word “indicates cognizance or mental awareness of something usually by means of personal experience.”

The following examples are all acceptable ways to translate this phrase:

for you to know (NJB)

And you will recognize (NJPS)

and you will realize (GNT)

the righteousness of the LORD: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “the righteousness(es) of Yahweh.” The righteousness(es) of the LORD were his actions that were faithful to the terms of his covenant with the people of Israel. Waltke 2007 (page 357), NICOT (pages 367–369), and EBC (page 539).

The LORD showed his righteousness by saving his people. Waltke 2007 (page 357) cites Achtemeier, who says “In short, Yahweh’s righteous judgments are saving judgments.... Yahweh’s salvation of Israel is his righteousness, his fulfillment of his covenant with her.” Some versions make this connection between his righteousness and his saving acts explicit. For example, the NRSV and some other versions translate “the righteousness(es) of Yahweh” as “the saving acts of the LORD” or something similar.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

...the Lord has treated you fairly.” (NET)

...the Lord does what is right.” (NCV)

the LORD: Here the LORD referred to himself using third person, the LORD. In some languages, it may be more natural to use a first-person form or a combination of first- and third-person forms. For example:

...what I did in order to save you.” (GNT)

...when I, the Lord, did everything I could to teach you about my faithfulness.” (NLT)

Micah 6:6

Section 6:1–8: The LORD brought a lawsuit against his people

In this section, the LORD (speaking through Micah) conducted a lawsuit or a court trial against the people of Israel. The LORD accused the people of Israel of failing to keep his requirements. Some scholars refer to this accusation as a “covenant lawsuit” because his requirements were based on his covenant with Israel. For example, ZIBBC (pages 140–141), Hays (page 315), and CBC (page 334). Scholars point out, however, that this lawsuit was not conventional in some ways. For example, there was no judge, the witnesses

were silent, and there was no pronouncement of punishment. ZIBBC (pages 140–141) and A&F (page 513).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s case against Israel (NIV)

God Challenges Israel (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:6–8

In 6:4–5, the LORD presented evidence that he had not wronged the people. Rather, he had blessed them.

In 6:6–8, the people (or a representative of the people) gave their response to this evidence. Their response in 6:6a–b was to ask a general question about what to bring to the LORD to please him. In 6:6c–d through 6:7, they asked about specific offerings. The offerings in 6:7 had higher value than those in 6:6.

In 6:8, Micah answered the people’s questions by reminding them of the LORD’s requirements.

The number and kind of offerings talked about in 6:7 appear to be exaggerated and unrealistic. This exaggeration may indicate that the people were insincere. For example, NICOT (pages 369–370) regards the questions as satirical. or that they were truly unaware of what the LORD desired of them. Many commentators suggest that the questions were sincere. For example, A&F (page 523), KD (page 335), Pusey (page 82), and UBS (page 231). If possible, translate the questions in 6:6–7 in a way that allows either option to be understood. A fairly literal, non-explicit translation will be the closest match to the Masoretic Text, in which the sincerity or insincerity of the people is suggested only by the context.

If your readers will find it useful to have a paragraph heading here, here are some examples:

What the Lord Requires (GNT)

What God requires (NRSV)

True obedience (CEV)

6:6a–b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{6a} With what shall I **come before the LORD**

^{6b} when I **bow before the God on high?**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 6:6b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 6:6a. For example:

^{6b} what shall I bring when **I bow myself before God on high?**

In these parallel lines, the people of Israel asked Micah what offering was appropriate for them to bring to the LORD in their worship.

6:6a

With what shall I come before the LORD

- ¶ “What gift, then, can I bring when I come before Yahweh
- ¶ You^(sing) ask, “What offering should I present to Yahweh,

With what: Here this phrase is a general question about the item(s) they need to bring to the LORD. Waltke 2007 (page 358) suggests that verses 6–7 may be an adaptation of a liturgy in which a petitioner asks what is required to enter into the temple. In this line, the specific kind of item(s) is left implicit. However, 6:6c–d and 6:7 make clear that this phrase refers to sacrificial offerings.

shall I come before the LORD: This phrase means to spiritually “meet” with the LORD. TWOT #1988. Here it probably means to pray and worship him. NAC (page 112).

I: The pronoun I refers to the speaker of this question. Some commentators suggest that the speaker, “I,” is Micah, representing the people. For example, see NICOT (pages 369–370). This is possible. However, in this trial setting, Micah speaks on behalf of the LORD rather than on behalf of the people. For that reason, it is more probable that here the people are given the opportunity to speak instead of Micah speaking for them. The pronoun may refer to the people of Israel as a group or to a representative of the people. Many commentators favor this understanding. For example, TOTC (page 213) suggests the speaker is a representative worshipper. Similarly, A&F (page 523) suggest that “The individual speaker of verses 6–7 is a representative Israelite.” KD (page 335) regards the speaker as “the congregation.”

In some languages, it may be necessary to make explicit that the speaker has changed from Micah to the people or a representative of the people. Many versions translate this line as a direct quote to indicate this change of speaker. For example:

You say, “What can I bring with me when I come before the Lord (NCV)

6:6a–d

(combined/reordered)

- When I worship Yahweh, our^(incl) God in heaven, shall I bring burnt offerings of year old calves?

6:6b

when I bow before the God on high?

- to bow before him, God on high?
- when I bow down to God in heaven?

when I bow before the God on high?: This line is more literally “I will bow myself down to [the] God of height.” Both 6:6a and 6:6b describe the action of meeting with God through prayer and worship.

when: In Hebrew, this line does not start with the word when. Some other versions supply a word like “when” or “and” to make the line sound more natural in English. Translate this line in a way that makes clear that 6:6a and 6:6b are two descriptions of the same action.

bow before the God: This line describes a common posture of a worshiper in the Old Testament. Waltke 2007 (page 358) and CBC (page 335). The posture of bowing to God indicates humility. Waltke 2007.

God on high: This is an expression that refers to God in his dwelling place in heaven. EBC (page 539), Waltke 2007 (page 358), KD (page 335), and Margolis (page 61). In this expression, the Hebrew word for God is *elohim* and not *YHWH*. Some versions translate *elohim* as God instead of “LORD.” Use your general term for God here.

6:6c–d

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{6c} Should I come to Him **with burnt offerings,**

^{6d} **with year-old calves?**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 6:6d. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 6:6c. For example:

^{6d} Should I come to Him **with year-old calves?**

In these lines, the people asked if burnt offerings, specifically burnt offerings of calves, were appropriate gifts to bring to the LORD.

6:6c

Should I come to Him with burnt offerings,

- Shall I give burnt offerings when I worship him,
- Should I present burnt offerings to him,

Should I come to Him: In Hebrew, the verb that the BSB translates as come to is the same as “come before” in 6:6b. It also has the same meaning, which is to spiritually “meet” with the LORD.

with burnt offerings: This phrase refers to animal sacrifices that were completely burned as offerings to the LORD. A worshiper presented this kind of offering to show their total dedication and commitment to the LORD. WBC (page 51), NAC (page 112), and NICOT (pages 369–370).

6:6d

with year-old calves?

- my best, year old calves?
- offerings of year old calves?

with year-old calves: This line is similar to 6:6c, however it is even more specific regarding the kind of burnt offering to bring to the LORD. According to UBS (page 231) the burnt offerings in 6c and the year old calves in 6d are not separate offerings. Together they are a hendiadys, a figure of speech that expresses an idea in two ways. See also Waltke 2007 (page 359) and Pusey (page 82). One year old calves represented the best, most desirable kind of animal to sacrifice. This is the majority view of commentators. For example, UBS, Waltke 2007, EBC, NICOT, KD, WBC, and Pusey.

General Comment on 6:6a–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel lines. For example:

^{6a-b}What shall I bring to the Lord, the God of heaven, when I come to worship him? ^{6c-d}Shall I bring the best calves to burn as offerings to him? (GNT)

Micah 6:7

Section 6:1–8: The LORD brought a lawsuit against his people

In this section, the LORD (speaking through Micah) conducted a lawsuit or a court trial against the people of Israel. The LORD accused the people of Israel of failing to keep his requirements. Some scholars refer to this accusation as a “covenant lawsuit” because his requirements were based on his covenant with Israel. For example, ZIBBC (pages 140–141), Hays (page 315), and CBC (page 334). Scholars point out, however, that this lawsuit was not conventional in some ways. For example, there was no judge, the witnesses

were silent, and there was no pronouncement of punishment. ZIBBC (pages 140–141) and A&F (page 513).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord’s case against Israel (NIV)

God Challenges Israel (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:6–8

In 6:4–5, the LORD presented evidence that he had not wronged the people. Rather, he had blessed them.

In 6:6–8, the people (or a representative of the people) gave their response to this evidence. Their response in 6:6a–b was to ask a general question about what to bring to the LORD to please him. In 6:6c–d through 6:7, they asked about specific offerings. The offerings in 6:7 had higher value than those in 6:6.

In 6:8, Micah answered the people’s questions by reminding them of the LORD’s requirements.

The number and kind of offerings talked about in 6:7 appear to be exaggerated and unrealistic. This exaggeration may indicate that the people were insincere. For example, NICOT (pages 369–370) regards the questions as satirical. or that they were truly unaware of what the LORD desired of them. Many commentators suggest that the questions were sincere. For example, A&F (page 523), KD (page 335), Pusey (page 82), and UBS (page 231). If possible, translate the questions in 6:6–7 in a way that allows either option to be understood. A fairly literal, non-explicit translation will be the closest match to the Masoretic Text, in which the sincerity or insincerity of the people is suggested only by the context.

If your readers will find it useful to have a paragraph heading here, here are some examples:

What the Lord Requires (GNT)

What God requires (NRSV)

True obedience (CEV)

6:7

In this verse, the people continued to ask Micah what offerings would please the LORD. However, the amounts and kinds of offerings they asked about were extreme. These questions suggest that the people thought devotion to the LORD was limited to the

offering of sacrifices. NICOT (page 371), TOTC (pages 212–213), and ABC (page 1802).

6:7a–b (combined/reordered)

- Will Yahweh be pleased with countless herds of sheep and oceans of oil?

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{7a} Would the LORD be pleased **with thousands of rams**,

^{7b} **with ten thousands of rivers of oil?**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 6:7b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 6:7a. For example:

^{7b} Would the LORD be pleased **with ten thousands of rivers of oil?**

In these lines, the people asked if large numbers of offerings would please the LORD. These amounts indicate costly gifts that were far beyond the ability of most worshipers to give. UBS (pages 231–231) and Waltke 2007 (page 360). Waltke suggests that the speaker of the questions may be a king, since only a king could provide such large numbers of sacrifices.

thousands...ten thousand: The numbers thousands and ten thousand were figures of speech (hyperbole) that indicated a very large number. Waltke 2007 (page 360).

In some languages, it may be more natural to use a different word or phrase in place of one or both of these numerical expressions. For example:

Will the Lord be pleased with thousands of rams, with myriad streams of oil? (NAB)

Will the LORD be pleased if I bring him large herds of sheep or endless rivers of olive oil?

6:7a Would the LORD be pleased with thousands of rams,

- Will thousands of rams please Yahweh,
- Will he be satisfied if I bring an offering of vast herds of male sheep,

rams: rams were animals used for sin offerings. See Leviticus 5:15. A ram is a male sheep. In your language group, you may want to add a picture. In some lan-

guage groups, it may also be necessary to make this information explicit. UBS (page 231). For example:

Will the Lord be pleased with a thousand male sheep? (NCV)

6:7b with ten thousand rivers of oil?

- along with ten thousand rivers of oil?
- and with them, streams beyond number flowing with olive oil?

rivers of oil: This phrase refers to large amounts of olive oil. Olive oil was used to accompany other offerings, such as grain offerings. See Numbers 15:1–16. In Hebrew, the word rivers refers to a large amount of water that fills a dry river bed or ravine in the rainy season. Waltke 2007 (page 360).

If olive oil is unknown in your language, you may want to choose a word that refers to oil used in cooking. Also choose a word or expression in your language that suggests a large amount of liquid. UBS (page 232). For examples, see the note on “thousands...ten thousand” above.

General Comment on 6:7a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel lines. For example:

Will the LORD be pleased if I bring him sheep and oil in amounts beyond what a person can measure?

6:7c–d (combined/reordered)

- Should I sacrifice my firstborn son to Yahweh to pay for my personal sins?”

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{7c} Shall I present my firstborn **for my transgression**,

^{7d} the fruit of my body **for the sin of my soul?**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 6:7d. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 6:7c. For example:

^{7c} Shall I present the fruit of my body **for the sin of my soul?**

This question was about the sacrifice of a firstborn child. Would that sacrifice be enough to atone for sin?NAC (pages 112–113). This question shows that the people did not truly know the will of the LORD.KD (pages 335–336). Human sacrifice was forbidden by the LORD. See Deuteronomy 18:10.

It is possible that some readers may misinterpret this question to be about the dedication of a child to the LORD or something similar. Make sure that the meaning of human sacrifice is clear in your translation. For example:

Shall I kill my firstborn child as an offering?Suggestion by UBS (page 232).

my firstborn...the fruit of my body: Both phrases refer to a person's oldest son.UBS (page 232) and KD (pages 335–336). A firstborn son was a person's most valuable possession.WBC (pages 50–51) and EBC (pages 539–540).

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

my eldest son...the child of my own body (NJB)

my firstborn child...my offspring—my own flesh and blood (NET)

for my transgression...for the sin of my soul: Both phrases refer to making a payment to atone for sin. The meaning of the phrases is similar. The word transgression means to do wrong by acts that break relationships in a community or with God.HALOT (electronic edition, pages 981–982). The word sin means to disobey God's will and/or to disregard the rights of other people.TWOT #638e.

The word soul means "person as a whole: self or body."Mounce (page 996). The phrase sin of my soul probably means "my own personal sin."UBS (page 232).

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

as payment for my rebellion...for my sin (NET)

for my wrongdoing...for the sin I have committed (REB)

for the evil I have done...for my sin (NCV)

General Comment on 6:7c–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel lines. For example:

Shall I offer him my first-born child to pay for my sins? (GNT)

Should I sacrifice to the Lord my first-born child as payment for my terrible sins? (CEV)

6:7c

Shall I present my firstborn for my transgression,

- Shall I offer my firstborn son as payment for my rebellion,
- Should I kill my firstborn child as an offering for my wrongs,

6:7d

the fruit of my body for the sin of my soul?

- the child of my own body for the sin I have committed?"
- my own precious son to atone for my sins?"

Micah 6:8

Section 6:1–8: The LORD brought a lawsuit against his people

In this section, the LORD (speaking through Micah) conducted a lawsuit or a court trial against the people of Israel. The LORD accused the people of Israel of failing to keep his requirements. Some scholars refer to this accusation as a "covenant lawsuit" because his requirements were based on his covenant with Israel.For example, ZIBBC (pages 140–141), Hays (page 315), and CBC (page 334). Scholars point out, however, that this lawsuit was not conventional in some ways. For example, there was no judge, the witnesses were silent, and there was no pronouncement of punishment.ZIBBC (pages 140–141) and A&F (page 513).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Lord's case against Israel (NIV)

God Challenges Israel (NRSV)

Paragraph 6:6–8

In 6:4–5, the LORD presented evidence that he had not wronged the people. Rather, he had blessed them.

In 6:6–8, the people (or a representative of the people) gave their response to this evidence. Their response in 6:6a–b was to ask a general question about what

to bring to the LORD to please him. In 6:6c–d through 6:7, they asked about specific offerings. The offerings in 6:7 had higher value than those in 6:6.

In 6:8, Micah answered the people's questions by reminding them of the LORD's requirements.

The number and kind of offerings talked about in 6:7 appear to be exaggerated and unrealistic. This exaggeration may indicate that the people were insincere. For example, NICOT (pages 369–370) regards the questions as satirical, or that they were truly unaware of what the LORD desired of them. Many commentators suggest that the questions were sincere. For example, A&F (page 523), KD (page 335), Pusey (page 82), and UBS (page 231). If possible, translate the questions in 6:6–7 in a way that allows either option to be understood. A fairly literal, non-explicit translation will be the closest match to the Masoretic Text, in which the sincerity or insincerity of the people is suggested only by the context.

If your readers will find it useful to have a paragraph heading here, here are some examples:

What the Lord Requires (GNT)

What God requires (NRSV)

True obedience (CEV)

6:8

In this verse, Micah answered the questions that the people asked in 6:6–7. His answer was to remind the people what the LORD required of them.

Some versions begin this verse with the word “No,” to make the connection of this verse to the previous questions more explicit. For example:

No, O people, the Lord has told you what is good (NLT)

There are three main ways to translate the structure of the clauses in this verse:

- Translate 6:8a as a statement. Translate 6:8b–c as a rhetorical question. The implied answer to the question is “nothing else is required.” For example:

^{8a}He has told you, O man, what is good;

^{8b–c}and what does the Lord require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God? (ESV)

- Translate 6:8a as a statement. Translate 6:8b as a question and 6:8c as the answer to the question. For example:

^{8a}He has shown you, O mortal, what is good.

^{8b}And what does the Lord require of you?

^{8c}To act justly and to love mercy and to walk humbly with your God. (NIV)

- Translate 6:8a–c as parallel statements. For example:

^{8a} The Lord has told you, human, **what is good**;

^{8b} he has told you **what he wants from you**:

^{8c} **to do what is right to other people, love being kind to others, and live humbly, obeying your God.** (NCV)

6:8a

He has shown you, O man, what is good.

- Yahweh has told you^(sing), O human, what things are good.
- No! You have already been told what is right to do,

He has shown you, O man, what is good: In this clause Micah reminded the people that the LORD had already made known the good that he wanted from them. He had told it to them through his law, the prophets, and priests. DRD (page 128), Pusey (page 82), and TOTC (page 213).

O man: Here Micah addressed the questioner(s) directly. Some versions have added the word O to make it clear that O man is a term of address (vocative). Use a vocative that is natural in your language when a person speaks to a group of people or a representative of a group.

In Hebrew, the phrase O man is literally the word “adam.” Here “adam” is the word for “human.” DCH (pages 126–127). It is not a name. This vocative may imply a contrast between finite human beings and the infinite God. NICOT (page 371).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

He has told you, O mortal, what is good (NRSV)

wants (NJB)

The Lord has told you, human, what is good (NCV)

require (ESV)

what is good: This phrase means “that which is good.” BDB #4078 says that in some cases the question word “what” approximates in meaning to the simple relative. In Hebrew, the word good has a wide range of meaning. Here it probably means “moral good.” UBS (page 233) and Waltke 2007 (page 363). It is the kind of good that is described in the rest of this verse.

demands (CEV)

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

what is right (NJB)

what is good for us to do Suggestion by UBS (page 233).

6:8b

And what does the LORD require of you

- What does he require of you?^(sing)
- and you have been told what things he requires from you.

And what does the LORD require of you: This clause introduces the answer to the people’s questions about what will please the LORD.

In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “and what Yahweh asking from you.” It is ambiguous whether it is a question or a statement. For examples of each form of the clause, see the Note on 6:8 “three main ways to translate the structure of the clauses.”

The connecting word And begins this clause. It may indicate that the phrase in 6:8a “He has told you” applies to this clause as well. Not only has the LORD told the people what is good, he has also told them what he requires of them. For example:

^{8b}and he has told you what he requires of you:

Some versions leave this connection implied. For example:

What he requires of us is this: (GNT)

Indicate the connection of this clause to the previous one in a natural way in your language.

require: This word can mean “ask for,” “require,” or “demand.” BDB #1875 (page 205). For example:

6:8c

but to act justly, to love mercy, and to walk humbly with your God?

- He requires you^(sing) to be just, to love being kind, and to live humbly with your^(sing/plur) God.
- He has not asked you for excessive offerings, instead he has asked for you to be fair, to be committed to loving others, and to submit always to your God.

but to act justly, to love mercy, and to walk humbly with your God?: In this clause, Micah reminded the people of the LORD’s requirements by giving examples.

The people thought that the LORD required only sacrifices. However he also required good, moral attitudes and behavior. In this clause the word but contrasts these two thoughts. Waltke 2007 (page 364) says the full thought is this: “You thought I AM requires sacrifice, but rather he requires ethical behavior.” Most versions leave this contrast implicit.

If you wish to make this contrast more explicit in your translation, here are some examples:

So what does the Lord require of you? He requires not only sacrifices but/rather for you to be just, to love mercy, and to live humbly with your God.

He has told you what he wants from you. He does not want more offerings, but for you to do what is right, to love being kind to others, and to live in humble obedience to your God.

act justly: In Hebrew, the word translated as act justly has a broad range of meanings related to actions that are right and just. It can refer to judicial process as well as an attribute of man in general. TWOT (#2443c). In this phrase, it may refer especially to fair and honest treatment of those who are weak or powerless. TOTC (page 213) and NICOT (page 373).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

do what is right (NLT)

do what is just (GNT)

promote justice (NET)

love mercy: This phrase means to show kindness even when it is not required or deserved. It refers to both activities and attitudes.CBC (pages 336–338).

The word that the BSB translates as love means to “like” or “love” a thing. It can refer to love for either physical/concrete or abstract things.TWOT (#29). Here the meaning is to love to do kind deeds.

In Hebrew, the word that the BSB translates as mercy has several aspects of meaning:

1. steadfastness, loyalty
2. kindness, mercy

Translate this phrase in a way that fits naturally in the context. Here it may refer particularly to showing a concern for the needs of others. The LORD’s covenant with Israel required them to have this concern in response to the love that the LORD had shown to them.TWOT (#698a) says God was obviously in a covenant relationship with Israel, and he expressed this relationship in eternal *hesed*, but *hesed* does not necessarily involve a covenant nor does it mean loyalty to a covenant. Rather, it is a kind of love, including mercy, close to the KJV rendering “lovingkindness.” Vine (page 142) insists that three basic meanings of the word always interact: kindness, steadfastness, and love. He says that *hesed* is not only a matter of obligation within a relationship; it is also generosity. It is not only a matter of loyalty, but also of mercy.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

let mercy be your first concern (CEV)

show constant love (GNT)

love being kind to others (NCV)

walk humbly with your God: In this phrase the word walk is a figure of speech that means “follow a pattern of conduct or a lifestyle.”Mounce (page 924).

In Hebrew, the word humbly has a range of meanings related to being careful, wise, and prudent.HALOT (electronic edition, page 1039). These qualities depend upon a person having an attitude of submission/humility to God and a desire to conform to his will.EBC (page 540) and TOTC (page 214).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

humbly obey your God (CEV)

live in humble fellowship with our God (GNT)

Micah 6:9

Section 6:9–16: The LORD will punish his people for their dishonesty

This section has three parts. In 6:9–12, the LORD charged the people of Jerusalem and the tribe of Judah with theft, dishonesty, deception, and violence. In 6:13–15, he stated how he will punish them. In 6:16, the LORD restated in a short summary the people’s sin and their punishment. In this section, the LORD was the speaker except for 6:9, in which Micah told the people of the city to listen.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Cheating and Violence to Be Punished (NRSV)

Israel’s Guilt and Punishment (NIV)

Accusations and Covenant CursesSuggestion by A&F (pages 541–544)

Paragraph 6:9–16

In this paragraph, the LORD accused the people of committing several kinds of sin. Most were sins committed by wealthy people. Some were sins by the general population.

6:9

In the first and third clauses of verse 6:9, Micah told the people to pay attention. He told them that the LORD was calling out to the city and the tribe of Judah to listen. This function of calling attention is similar to the first clause of 6:1, in which Micah told the people to listen to the LORD’s case against them. The second clause of verse 6:9 has a style of writing that resembles a wisdom saying.

6:9a

The voice of the LORD calls out to the city

- ¶ Hear the voice of Yahweh that cries out to the city.
- ¶ Listen, people of the city, to what Yahweh has to say

The voice of the LORD calls out to the city: This clause is a statement. However, it functions as a call by Micah to the residents of the city. He urged them to give attention to what the LORD was about to say to them. Some versions supply a word such as “hear” or “listen” to make this function clear.Hebrew grammarians differ in their analysis of the phrase “the

voice of Yahweh.” Some regard it as the subject of the verb “cries out.” Others propose that either the word “voice” or the entire phrase “the voice of Yahweh” is an exclamation. Regardless of the grammatical understanding, the phrase serves the function of securing attention. See Waltke 2007 (page 395) and A&F (page 545). For example:

Listen! The Lord is calling to the city! (NET)

calls out: In Hebrew, this word means “call” or “summon” someone. NIDOTTE #7924 (page 971) and DCH (pages 289–290). EBC (page 542) suggests that here the word may connote “call out a warning.” Waltke 2007 (page 396) suggests it may connote “make a proclamation.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

The Lord calls to the city (REB)

Hark! The Lord summons the city (NJPS)

the city: This phrase refers to Jerusalem. This is the view of a majority of commentators. For example, UBS, NAC, KD, JFB, and Waltke 2007. Some versions make this identification explicit. For example:

So listen to my message for the city of Jerusalem. (CEV)

6:9a–c (combined/reordered)

- It is wise to fear Yahweh. He calls to the city and nation: Listen, all of you people assembled here in the city!

6:9b (and it is sound wisdom to fear Your name):

- (The fear of your^(sing) name is wisdom.)
- (for it is wise to respect you).

(and it is sound wisdom to fear Your name): There are three main interpretations of the meaning of this clause: There is also a textual issue. The Masoretic Text has “and success/wisdom it will see your name” and the LXX has “and he will save those fearing his name.” However, this textual issue is not included in the Notes because nearly all modern versions follow the Masoretic Text here.

1. It is a definition or description of wisdom. For example:

and to fear your name is wisdom (NIV) (BSB, ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NIV, NRSV)

1. It is a statement about wise behavior. For example:

It is wise to fear the Lord. (GNT) (KJV, The KJV has “and the man of wisdom shall see thy name.” It may fit under this interpretation. NET, GNT)

1. It is an exhortation to wise people to fear the LORD. For example:

Fear the Lord if you are wise! (NLT) (NLT)

You may follow any of these interpretations. Interpretation (1) is followed by more versions. However, the difference in meaning between the interpretations is very slight. All of them indicate a connection between wisdom and fear of the LORD. All of them also imply an exhortation to fear the LORD, even though only interpretation (3) makes it explicit.

This clause is similar to a proverb or wisdom saying. The words in 6:9b are not the words that the LORD cries to the city. Rather, this clause briefly interrupts the message here and is probably parenthetical. This is indicated by the change of focus from the LORD calling to the city in the previous clause to a proverbial style wisdom saying here by someone apparently addressing the LORD with the phrase “your name.” A&F (page 546) refers to this clause as a “pious aside.”

Here are some ways to indicate that these are not the words that the LORD cries to the city:

- Mark this clause as parenthetical. The BSB above is an example.
- Move this clause to another part of the verse that does not interrupt the flow of logic. For example:

^{9b}It is wise to fear the Lord. He calls to the city, ^{9a,c}“Listen, you people who assemble in the city!” (GNT)

This clause addresses the LORD directly using the second-person phrase “your name.” In some languages it may be more natural to express this saying with third-person forms such as “the LORD” or “his name.” For example:

It is wise to fear the Lord (GNT)

the fear of his name brings success (REB)

Use a natural way in your language to translate this saying.

sound wisdom: In Hebrew, the word that the BSB translates as sound wisdom refers to the wisdom or practical good sense that leads to a successful result. This note is taken in full from the glossary entry “sound judgment (Hebrew: *tušiyah*)” in Translator’s Notes on Proverbs. The word includes two ideas:

1. competence, good sense, ability to plan what to do
2. the success that results from this ability.

The word focuses more on making an effective plan than on understanding a complicated situation.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

prudence

discernment

fear Your name: There is a textual issue with the word that the BSB translates as fear:

1. The LXX has “fear.” For example:

and it is sound wisdom to fear your name (ESV)
(ESV, GW, BSB, NAB, NASB, NIV, NLT, NRSV, REB, GNT)

1. The Masoretic Text has “see.” For example:

and the man of wisdom shall see thy name (KJV)
(KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions.

fear: The LXX word translated as fear indicates both real fear and reverential awe. It also involves submitting to the LORD and obeying him.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

respect (NET)

revere

Your name: This phrase may be a title for Yahweh. It is another way to refer to him. HALOT (electronic edition, pages 1550–1551) calls the phrase “an interchangeable expression for Yahweh.” NAC (page 100) says it refers to the LORD himself or to his manifested character.

The phrase Your name implies his character and his attributes, such as his power and authority.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Lord (NLT)

O Lord (NET)

6:9c

“Heed the rod and the One who ordained it.

- Hear his voice, O nation and assembly of the city!
- Tribe of Judah and people assembled in Jerusalem, listen to what Yahweh has to say!

The NRSV has been used as the source line for 6:9c, because it follows the recommended interpretation.

(NRSV) Hear, O tribe and assembly of the city!: There is a textual issue with this clause:

1. Some scholars think that the original text was “Hear, O tribe, and the assembly of the city.” For example:

Listen, you tribe assembled in the city. (GW) (CEV, GW, NAB, NET, NJB, NRSV, REB, GNT)

1. The Masoretic Text has “Hear rod BART and LDHB gloss this Masoretic Text word as “tribe” rather than “rod.” TWOT (#1352b) provides helpful historical insight on the relationship between these two words. In the past each tribal ruler led his group with a staff/rod. That staff may have been a symbol of the tribe and in time came to represent leadership and authority. and who appointed it/her.” For example:

Heed the rod and the One who appointed it. (NIV)
(BSB, ESV, KJV, NCV, NIV, NJPS, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). Both options have support from commentaries and versions. However, elsewhere in the Old Testament, the command “hear” calls attention to what a person says, as in option (1). A&F (page 545) notes that the Hebrew word for “hear,” especially after the Hebrew word for “voice,” must mean “listen (to words).” It does not call attention to an inanimate object or to what the object represents, as in option (2).

In this command, Micah summons the people of the tribe and the city to hear. The implicit object of the verb Hear is the voice of the LORD from the first clause of 6:9.

(NRSV) O tribe and assembly of the city: There are two main interpretations of the referent(s) of this phrase:

1. The tribe and the assembly of the city are two distinct groups of people. For example:

Listen, O nation, and those assembled in the city!
(NET) (NAB, NET, NRSV, REB)

1. The tribe and the assembly of the city are one group of people. For example:

Listen, tribe of assembled citizens (NJB) (GW, NJB)

Either interpretation is acceptable. It is possible that the assembly refers to people from throughout Judah who were gathered in Jerusalem for a feast or other celebration. UBS (page 237) proposes that the word “assemble” may suggest that not all the people addressed lived in the city. They may be from smaller towns or villages but gathered in Jerusalem for important occasions. It is also possible that Micah expected people from the city to spread his words to others throughout the nation.

(NRSV) O tribe: Here Micah addressed the people directly. Some versions have added the word O to make it clear that tribe is a term of address (vocative). Use a vocative that is natural in your language when a person speaks to a group of people.

Here the word tribe probably refers to the tribe of Judah. NAC (page 120), UBS (page 237), JFB (page 694), and WBC (page 53).

(NRSV) the city: This phrase refers to Jerusalem as in 6:9a. The phrase “the city” is a reinterpretation of the first word of 6:10. In the Masoretic Text it is the word for “still.” However, in this recommended textual option scholars suggest that the original Hebrew word was “city,” and that it belongs with the phrase “assembly of the city,” which begins in 6:9c. The Hebrew words for “still” and “city” look very similar.

General Comment on 6:9a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these lines. See the example under the second bullet in the Note for 6:9b (“it is sound wisdom to fear Your name”).

Micah 6:10

Section 6:9–16: The LORD will punish his people for their dishonesty

This section has three parts. In 6:9–12, the LORD charged the people of Jerusalem and the tribe of Judah with theft, dishonesty, deception, and violence. In 6:13–15, he stated how he will punish them. In 6:16, the LORD restated in a short summary the people’s sin and their punishment. In this section, the LORD was the speaker except for 6:9, in which Micah told the people of the city to listen.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Cheating and Violence to Be Punished (NRSV)

Israel’s Guilt and Punishment (NIV)

Accusations and Covenant Curses
Suggestion by A&F (pages 541–544)

Paragraph 6:9–16

In this paragraph, the LORD accused the people of committing several kinds of sin. Most were sins committed by wealthy people. Some were sins by the general population.

6:10

Can I forget any longer, O house of the wicked, the treasures of wickedness and the short ephah, which is accursed?: This verse is a rhetorical question. Its function is to express two accusations of the LORD against the people. It is not a request for information.

Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As one or more rhetorical questions. You may use slightly different questions if that is more natural in your language. For example:

...can I forgive the false measure, the accursed short bushel? (REB)

How can I forget dishonest gain by wicked people?
How can I ignore the fraudulent scales that I hate so much?

- As a statement. For example:

You store up stolen treasures and use dishonest scales. (CEV)

6:10a**Can I forget any longer, O house of the wicked, the treasures of wickedness**

- Can I forget the treasures of evil in the houses of wicked people
- I cannot overlook the stolen valuables that dishonest people keep in their homes

Can I forget any longer: There is a textual issue with the word that the BSB translates as forget. There are three main options:

1. Some scholars think that the original word was “forget/overlook.” BDB #5378 (page 674) and NAC (page 117). For example:

Can I overlook the false measure (NJB) (BSB, ESV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NRSV)

1. The Masoretic Text has “there is/are.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 92) and EBC (page 542). For example:

In the houses of evil people are treasures (GNT) (KJV, NCV, GNT)

1. Some scholars say that the original word was “forgive/bear.” Waltke 2007 (pages 397–398). For example:

Am I to bear any longer criminal hoarding (NAB) (NAB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with a slight majority of versions. However, option (2) and (3) are also acceptable. All have support from scholars and fit the context well.

O house of the wicked: There are two main interpretations of the referent of the word house:

1. It refers to a literal house where wicked people store their stolen treasures. For example:

In the houses of evil people are treasures which they got dishonestly. (GNT) (NJPS, NLT, GNT)

1. It refers to the wicked people. For example:

O wicked house (NIV) (NET, NIV, BSB)

Some versions, such as the NRSV, are ambiguous.

You may follow either interpretation. The word house can refer to either a building or to a group of people. NAC (page 117) and Waltke 2007 (pages 397–398).

the treasures of wickedness: This phrase probably refers to wealth or luxuries that people obtained by wicked means. UBS (page 53). It does not specify the kind of wickedness. The following context suggests that it refers to cheating, dishonesty, violence, deceit, and lying.

6:10b**and the short ephah, which is accursed?**

- and the smaller than standard measures that I despise?
- and inaccurate measures for cheating that I have condemned.

and the short ephah: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “and an ephah of scantness.” The standard dry measure of that time was the ephah. Equal to about half a bushel. An ephah of scantness was a container that held less than an ephah of grain or other product. Some merchants cheated their customers by saying that the container held a full ephah. ABC (page 1082).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the smaller-than-standard measure (NET)

They use false measures (GNT)

they cheat their customers by giving them less than they have paid for Suggested by UBS (pages 237–238).

which is accursed: In this context, the word accursed probably means that this kind of cheating was a violation of the law of Moses and was detestable to God. CBC (page 339). See Leviticus 19:35–36.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

I hate so much (NET)

a thing that I hate (GNT)

that abomination (NJB)

Micah 6:11

Section 6:9–16: The LORD will punish his people for their dishonesty

This section has three parts. In 6:9–12, the LORD charged the people of Jerusalem and the tribe of Judah with theft, dishonesty, deception, and violence. In 6:13–15, he stated how he will punish them. In 6:16, the LORD restated in a short summary the people's sin and their punishment. In this section, the LORD was the speaker except for 6:9, in which Micah told the people of the city to listen.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Cheating and Violence to Be Punished (NRSV)

Israel's Guilt and Punishment (NIV)

Accusations and Covenant Curses
Suggestion by A&F (pages 541–544)

Paragraph 6:9–16

In this paragraph, the LORD accused the people of committing several kinds of sin. Most were sins committed by wealthy people. Some were sins by the general population.

6:11a–b (combined/reordered)

- How can I approve of deceptive scales and weights?

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{11a} Can I excuse **dishonest scales**

^{11b} or **bags of false weights?**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 6:11b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 6:11a. For example:

^{11b} or can I excuse **bags of false weights?**

This verse is another rhetorical question. Its function is to express the next accusation of the LORD against the people.

Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As one or more rhetorical questions. You may use slightly different questions, if that is more natural in your language. For example:

Can I justify wicked scales and a bag of deceptive weights? (NASB)

How can I ignore the use of fraudulent scales?
How can I close my eyes to inaccurate weights used to deceive?

- As a statement. For example:

I do not condone the use of rigged scales, or a bag of deceptive weights. (NET)

Can I excuse: All versions understand that the Piel word form meaning “acquit/justify” is used here. BART mentions the Qal word form meaning “pure.” In that case, the rhetorical question would be “Will I be clear/pure?” No version follows this rendering, so the Notes have not discussed the issue. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Can I justify (NASB)

Shall I acquit (ESV)

dishonest scales...bags of false weights: Each phrase describes a way that a merchant cheated a customer. The phrase dishonest scales refers to measuring balances that were made to be inaccurate in a way that benefitted the merchant. The phrase bags of false weights refers to bags or pouches of inaccurate weights. They may have been lighter or heavier than the true weight. A footnote in the NET says the weights were smaller than standard weights. CBC (page 339) says that the weights were heavier than the standard weight. NAC (page 117) suggests that the bag contained both lighter and heavier than standard weights. A person would use whichever weights benefitted them, depending on whether he or she was buying or selling. Together these measuring devices were used to deceive others. KD (page 337) suggests that scales and a bag with stones belong together.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

misleading scales or a bag of fraudulent weights (REB)

I do not condone the use of rigged scales, or a bag of deceptive weights. (NET)

General Comment on 6:11a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these parallel lines. For example:

How can I tolerate your merchants who use dishonest scales and weights? (NLT)

6:11a**Can I excuse dishonest scales**

- Can I say it is right for a person to use misleading scales
- I cannot ignore the use of fraudulent measuring scales

6:11b**or bags of false weights?**

- and carry a bag of inaccurate weights?
- and weights used to deceive.

Micah 6:12**Section 6:9–16: The LORD will punish his people for their dishonesty**

This section has three parts. In 6:9–12, the LORD charged the people of Jerusalem and the tribe of Judah with theft, dishonesty, deception, and violence. In 6:13–15, he stated how he will punish them. In 6:16, the LORD restated in a short summary the people's sin and their punishment. In this section, the LORD was the speaker except for 6:9, in which Micah told the people of the city to listen.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Cheating and Violence to Be Punished (NRSV)

Israel's Guilt and Punishment (NIV)

Accusations and Covenant Curses
Suggestion by A&F (pages 541–544)

Paragraph 6:9–16

In this paragraph, the LORD accused the people of committing several kinds of sin. Most were sins committed by wealthy people. Some were sins by the general population.

6:12a**For the wealthy of the city are full of violence,**

- The rich people there are very violent.
- People have become rich by doing harm to others.

For the wealthy of the city are full of violence: This clause is an accusation of the LORD against the rich people of Jerusalem.

This clause is more literally “that/which its rich are full [of] violence.” The word “that/which” refers back to the city or city and nation. However, its function here is unclear. Here are some ways to translate this word:

- As a relative pronoun that refers back to the city or city and nation. For example:

Whose rich men are full of lawlessness (NJPS)

- As a word that introduces more information about the wicked people described in 6:10–11. For example:

For the rich men of the city are full of violence (NASB)

Many versions leave this word implied. For example:

Your rich men are full of violence (ESV)

Translate the connection of this clause to the previous verses in a natural way in your language.

the wealthy of the city: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “its^(fem) rich.” This phrase refers to the wealthy men and women of high status in the city or the city and nation. NIDOTTE #6938 and TOTC (page 216).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The city's rich men (NET)

The rich among you (NLT)

Your rich people (GNT)

full of violence: This phrase is a figurative expression that means there was much violence throughout the city. NIDOTTE #4848 says that the special sense of the word depicts the filling or abundance of things with particular objects. In Hebrew, the word violence refers to wrongful actions motivated by sin. It may include physical force, brutality, and violation of the personal rights of others. Here it may refer particularly to the brutal exploitation of the weak in Israelite society by the ruling class and rich landowners. NIDOTTE #2805.

The phrase full of violence may be unnatural in some languages. Here are some other ways to translate it:

become wealthy through extortion and violence
(NLT)

do cruel things (NCV)

6:12b–c (combined/reordered)

- All your^(sing/plur) people are liars.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{12b}and its residents **speak lies;**

^{12c} **their tongues are deceitful in their mouths.**

In these lines, the LORD accused the inhabitants of Jerusalem of speaking lies. Waltke 2007 (page 400) says that these inhabitants should be distinguished from the rich people. However, ABC (page 1082) includes the rich among those who speak lies.

speak lies...their tongues are deceitful in their mouths: The phrase speak lies means to lie, deceive or defraud instead of speaking truth. NIDOTTE #9214. The phrase their tongues are deceitful in their mouths is another way to say that they speak lies. However, the longer phrase uses a figure of speech (metonymy) about the tongue and mouth. This figure of speech gives emphasis to how utterly corrupt their speech is. Waltke 2007 (page 400). Try to keep this figure of speech in your translation if possible.

If this figure of speech is unnatural in your language or it gives the wrong meaning, here are some other ways to translate it:

General Comment on 6:12b–c

- Translate the figure of speech using an expression in your language that has the same meaning.
- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

they do not tell the truth (NCV)

and their words are deceitful

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these lines. For example.

^{12b–c}and everyone tells lies (CEV)

6:12b and its residents speak lies;

- The people who live there tell lies.
- Everyone there is a liar

6:12c

their tongues are deceitful in their mouths.

- The tongues in their mouths speak words of deceit.
- and a deceiver.

Micah 6:13

Section 6:9–16: The LORD will punish his people for their dishonesty

This section has three parts. In 6:9–12, the LORD charged the people of Jerusalem and the tribe of Judah with theft, dishonesty, deception, and violence. In 6:13–15, he stated how he will punish them. In 6:16, the LORD restated in a short summary the people's sin and their punishment. In this section, the LORD was the speaker except for 6:9, in which Micah told the people of the city to listen.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Cheating and Violence to Be Punished (NRSV)

Israel's Guilt and Punishment (NIV)

Accusations and Covenant Curses
Suggestion by A&F (pages 541–544)

Paragraph 6:9–16

In this paragraph, the LORD accused the people of committing several kinds of sin. Most were sins committed by wealthy people. Some were sins by the general population.

6:13a–b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{13a}Therefore I am striking you severely,

^{13b} to ruin you because of your sins.

In these parallel lines, the LORD gave his response to the people's sin. He would punish them.

6:13a

Therefore I am striking you severely,

- So I will strike you^(sing/plur) severely,
- As for me, I will punish you harshly,

Therefore: In Hebrew, the phrase that the BSB translates as Therefore is literally “and I on my part.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 196) 11b, DRD (page 134), and

Waltke 2007 (pages 400–401). It introduces and gives emphasis to the LORD’s response to the sins described in 6:10–12.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

I, in turn (NRSV)

As for me (NCV)

I am striking you severely: There is a textual issue with this clause:

1. The LXX has “I will begin to strike you.” Of the versions listed under option (1), the CEV, NAB, NET, and NLT use future tense, BSB, ESV, and REB use present, GW, NIV, NJB, NJPS, and NRSV have past/perfect. All versions listed under option (2) use future. In Hebrew, “I have made sick” has perfect tense/aspect. However, it probably has a future sense, and that is the way it is glossed in BART. Waltke 2007 (page 401) says the perfective signifies resolve. For example:

I will begin to strike you (NAB) (BSB, CEV, GW, NAB, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB, GNT)

1. The Masoretic Text has “I have made sick by striking you.” For example:

So also I will make you sick, striking you down (NASB) (KJV, NASB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. This clause is probably an idiom that meant “I will strike you severely.” EBC (page 543) and Waltke 2007 (page 401).

In Hebrew, this clause can be understood either as past or future. Either time frame makes sense in this context. The verb has perfect tense/aspect. It may indicate that the action has already occurred or that it definitely will occur (prophetic perfect).

you: The referent is probably the people of Jerusalem and Judah. NAC (page 118) and KD (page 338). The Hebrew pronoun is singular. Here the singular probably indicates that the referent is regarded to be a singular collective.

6:13b

to ruin you because of your sins.

- making you^(sing/plur) an appalling/dreadful ruin because of your sins.
- leaving you with nothing, on account of your sins.

to ruin you: This phrase means “make deserted” or “appalled.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 1565) and TWOT #2409. It refers to physical destruction of a place. TWOT #2409 and TOTC (page 216). This phrase is connected to the verb “strike you” in 6:13a. It describes how Jerusalem and Judah would be struck down. It would happen by making them desolate. KD (page 338) and Waltke 2007 (page 401). According to Waltke this word functions as an adverbial complement that describes the attendant circumstances of the idiom “to make sore the smiting of you.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

destroy you (NET)

bringing you to ruin (REB)

because of your sins: This phrase indicates the reason for the punishment. It was because of the people’s sins as described in 6:10–12.

Micah 6:14

Section 6:9–16: The LORD will punish his people for their dishonesty

This section has three parts. In 6:9–12, the LORD charged the people of Jerusalem and the tribe of Judah with theft, dishonesty, deception, and violence. In 6:13–15, he stated how he will punish them. In 6:16, the LORD restated in a short summary the people’s sin and their punishment. In this section, the LORD was the speaker except for 6:9, in which Micah told the people of the city to listen.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Cheating and Violence to Be Punished (NRSV)

Israel’s Guilt and Punishment (NIV)

Accusations and Covenant Curses Suggestion by A&F (pages 541–544)

Paragraph 6:9–16

In this paragraph, the LORD accused the people of committing several kinds of sin. Most were sins committed by wealthy people. Some were sins by the general population.

6:14–15

Verses 14 and 15 consist of a series of curses. Each curse describes a hypothetical situation in which a

normal activity, such as eating or farming, has an unexpected, undesirable outcome.

These curses are figures of speech that add emphasis to the previous statements in 6:13.A&F (pages 543–544) identify 6:14–15 as a threefold curse that uses the figure of speech known as “sorites.” The curses indicate how complete and serious the punishment from the LORD will be.

Each curse is addressed to “you^(sing),” which continues to refer collectively to the people of Jerusalem and Judah as in 6:9–13. In some languages, it will be more natural to use “you^(plur)” for a group of people.

6:14a–b

Notice the parallel lines that are similar in meaning:

^{14a} You will eat **but not be satisfied**,

^{14b} **and your hunger will remain with you.**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 6:14b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 6:14a. For example:

^{14b} you shall eat, **and your hunger will remain with you.**

Together, these parallel lines are a curse about hunger. The underlined part describes the normal activity of eating food. The parts in bold print describe the unexpected, undesirable result.

6:14a

You will eat but not be satisfied,

- You^(sing/plur) will eat, but you will not be full.
- Although you will eat, the food will not be enough.

You will eat but not be satisfied: This clause probably means that a person will remain hungry after eating.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

You will eat, but you won’t become full (NCV)

You will eat but never have enough. (NLT)

6:14b

and your hunger will remain with you.

- You^(sing/plur) will still be empty inside.
- You will remain very hungry.

and your hunger will remain with you: The phrase your hungerThe Hebrew word occurs only here in the

Old Testament. The meaning “hunger” is a best guess that fits the context well and makes good sense. See TWOT #924a, DRD (page 135), NAC (pages 118–119), and KD (page 338). will remain with youThe Hebrew word is literally “in your midst.” Here it has the sense of the inside of a person, not the midst of a group of people. BDB #7130 lists this sense as 1a “inward part of the human body.” is another way to describe a lack of satisfaction from the food.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

So you will always be hungry. (GW)

your stomach will still be empty (NIV)

General Comment on 6:14a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these lines. For example.

You will eat, but still be hungry (CEV)

6:14c–d

The REB has been used as the source line for 6:14c–d because it allows for the recommended interpretation.

6:14c

What you acquire, you will not preserve;

- Your^(sing/plur) time to have a child will come, but the child will not be safely born.
- You will become pregnant, but you will miscarry.
- You will be able to carry a child in your womb, but not deliver it alive.

(REB) you will come to labour: There is a combined textual and interpretation issue with the Hebrew word that the REB translates as you will come to labour. Here are the two main options:

1. The Hebrew word is a form of nāśag, “to reach,” or “attain to.” Here it means to reach the time for a child to be conceived or born. For example:

You have been conceiving without bearing young, and what you bore I would deliver to the sword. (NJPS, REB)

1. The Hebrew word is a form of sūg, “to remove, carry away.” Here it means “put away” as in storing food or property for safekeeping. For example:

you will store up but never keep safe; what you do keep safe I shall hand over to the sword (NJB) (BSB, ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NLT, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option/interpretation (1). It has good support from commentators, both traditional and modern. Waltke 2007 (pages 402–403) cites support in favor of *nāsag* as the word root from ancient versions, medieval Jewish commentators and modern Jewish exegetes. All interpreted the word in this way. See also NICOT (page 380) and TOTC (pages 216–217). Option/interpretation (2) assumes an unattested meaning for the Hebrew word. Waltke 2007 (pages 402–403) notes that elsewhere the root *sûg* in the *hiphil* means “to displace,” always with the object “boundary marker.” The extension of meaning “to remove” an implied object such as goods or articles lacks a parallel. This same point is made by BDB #5381 which states that in *hiphil* the usual meaning of *sûg* is “displace or move back a boundary mark.” Micah 6:14 is the only instance in the Old Testament for which this unique meaning is proposed. See also TOTC (pages 216–217).

This phrase is part of a curse on childbirth. It describes the process of pregnancy that normally would result in childbirth.

(REB) but not bring forth: This phrase is more literally “and/but not you will bring to safety.” There is an interpretation issue with the Hebrew word that the REB translates as bring forth. The same Hebrew word also occurs in 6:14d. Both occurrences are underlined below. Here are the main interpretations:

1. The word means “bring an infant to safety” as in a safe delivery from a womb. For example:

^{14c}You will come to labour, but not bring forth;

^{14d}even if you bear a child I shall give it to the sword (REB) (NJPS, REB)

1. The word means “bring something to store in safety” as in storing food or treasures in a safe place. For example:

^{14c}you will store up but never keep safe; ^{14d}what you do keep safe I shall hand over to the sword (NJB) (BSB, ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NLT, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It has good support from commentators. Waltke 2007 (pages 402–403), TOTC (pages 216–217), and Pusey

(page 87). Waltke 2007 and TOTC both cite Job 21:10 which refers to delivering in birth. See also Job 21:10.

This phrase describes the undesirable outcome of the pregnancy. The child is not safely born. Some language groups may have euphemisms to refer to miscarriage or to a stillborn child. Translate this phrase in a culturally appropriate way.

6:14d

and what you save, I will give to the sword.

- Even if somehow you^(sing/plur) do bear a child, I will give it to an enemy to be killed by the sword.
- Whatever children you manage to have, I will make sure they die in war.

(REB) even if you bear a child I shall give it to the sword: This clause continues the curse on childbirth from 6:14c. This is a conditional clause. When the condition, you bear a child, is true, the result is that the LORD will give it to the sword.

Verse 6:14c says that no more children will be born. This verse part, 6:14d, describes an imagined situation in which someone was still able to give birth to children. Even if that could happen, the children would nevertheless be killed. See Hosea 9:11–12, 16 for similar curses.

(REB) give it to the sword: This expression means to give the child to an enemy to be killed. Waltke 2007 (page 403) notes that life, not property, is what is given over to the sword.

(REB) the sword: This phrase refers to violence and destruction in war. NAC (page 119). Some versions make the context of war explicit without using the word sword. For example:

I will give it to those who conquer you (NLT)

I will destroy in war (GNT)

Micah 6:15

Section 6:9–16: The LORD will punish his people for their dishonesty

This section has three parts. In 6:9–12, the LORD charged the people of Jerusalem and the tribe of Judah with theft, dishonesty, deception, and violence. In 6:13–15, he stated how he will punish them. In 6:16, the LORD restated in a short summary the people’s sin and their punishment. In this section, the LORD was the speaker except for 6:9, in which Micah told the people of the city to listen.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Cheating and Violence to Be Punished (NRSV)

Israel's Guilt and Punishment (NIV)

Accusations and Covenant Curses Suggestion by
A&F (pages 541–544)

Paragraph 6:9–16

In this paragraph, the LORD accused the people of committing several kinds of sin. Most were sins committed by wealthy people. Some were sins by the general population.

6:15a

You will sow but not reap;

- You^(sing/plur) will sow seed but not reap a crop.
- Although you plant crops, you will not harvest them.

You will sow but not reap: This is a curse on farming. It describes the normal activity of a farmer sowing and reaping. He will be able to sow, but the unexpected outcome is that he will not reap a harvest. NAC (page 119) suggests that the reason for the inability to reap is because of an enemy invasion.

sow: This word means to plant seeds to grow a crop. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

plant (GW)

plant crops (NLT)

reap: This word means to harvest a crop. For example:

harvest (NCV)

The word reap can refer in general to the gathering-in of grain or other agricultural products. However, in this context it may refer specifically to the spring harvest. Suggested by Waltke 2007 (page 403). If your language has specific words for harvests at different times of the year, consider using your word for a springtime harvest or the first harvest of the year.

6:15b

you will press olives but not anoint yourselves with oil;

- You^(sing/plur) will press olives but not put the oil on your skin.
- You will squeeze oil from olives, but you will not use the oil for yourselves.
- Although you will make olive oil, you won't use it.

6:15c

you will tread grapes but not drink the wine.

- You^(sing/plur) will tread grapes but not drink the wine you produce.
- You will squeeze juice from grapes, but you won't drink the wine you make from it.
- Although you will make wine, you won't drink it.

6:15b–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{15b} you will press olives **but not anoint yourselves with oil;**

^{15c} you will tread grapes **but not drink wine.**

These parallel lines highlight two agricultural products that were important to the people. These lines either express two curses on these products or they are two parts of one curse on the autumn harvest. Waltke 2007 (page 403) suggests that here the focus shifts to the loss of oil and wine in the fall harvest. Each line describes the normal activity of producing oil or wine. The people will be able to produce them, but the unexpected, undesirable outcome is that they will not use the oil or drink the wine.

press olives...tread grapes: These words are more literally “tread olives...and new wine.” In Hebrew, the verb tread refers to both olives and new wine/grapes. There is an interpretation issue with this verb. There are two main interpretations:

1. The Hebrew word means “press” when the referent is olives and “tread/crush” when the referent is grapes. For example:

you will press olives but not use the oil, you will crush grapes but not drink the wine (NIV11) (NET, NIV11, NJB, NLT, REB, BSB)

1. The Hebrew word means “tread/crush” for both olives and grapes. For example:

you shall tread olives, but not anoint yourselves with oil; you shall tread grapes, but not drink wine (ESV) (ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, NJPS, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It has majority commentary support and good version support. Waltke 2007 (page 403) and NAC (page 119, footnote 37) suggest that that the verb is a zeugma. A zeugma is a literary feature where a verb is used that

is normally appropriate for only one of the objects, in this case “grapes.” However, a zeugma may have multiple meanings. According to NAC (page 119) and BDB #1869 (page 202) sense 3, this verb can mean “tread” for wine or “press” for oil. There is no conclusive evidence from the Old Testament that people tread olives to make oil. NICOT (page 381) cites Deuteronomy 33:24 as supporting evidence. That verse is a blessing that Asher may bathe his feet in oil. However, there is no indication that the blessing refers to Asher treading on olives. It may refer to the use of oil as a skin lotion for Asher’s feet.

The way olive oil was extracted at that time was to squeeze olives in an oil press under a heavy beam or to turn them into pulp with a millstone. NICOT (page 381).

The way wine was made was to stomp with bare feet on grapes in a vat. The juice was collected and fermented to make wine. UBS (page 241).

In this verse the Hebrew word for “new wine” is a figure of speech (metonymy) for grapes. Waltke 2007 (page 403) calls it a metonymy of effect. A&F (page 549) suggest that the choice of this word rather than the more correct “grapes” or winepress telescopes the stages of the work. Most modern versions translate this word as grapes.

Here are some ways to translate these phrases:

- Use a generic word that refers to extracting liquid from fruit, if you have such a word in your language. For example:

You will squeeze oil from the olives...you will squeeze juice from the grapes (NET)

- Use a separate word for each process. For example:

You will press your olives...You will trample the grapes (NLT)

- Describe the process of making oil and wine in a general way. For example:

You will make oil and wine

but not anoint yourselves with oil...but not drink the wine: Olive oil and wine were important products at that time. One use of olive oil was as a lotion to rub on skin. NICOT (page 381). The word anoint has that meaning here. For example:

but you will have no oil to rub on your bodies (NET)

Wine was especially important in places where water supplies were scarce and impure. UBS (page 241). Times of wine making were festive occasions. Having an abundance of wine was a cause of joy. NICOT (page 381).

These descriptions were vivid, striking ways to express disruption of normal life. It is recommended that you keep these descriptions explicit in your translation if they will be understood.

However, in some language groups these products may be unknown. If that is true in your language, another option is to translate these descriptions in a general way. For example:

You won’t...use the oil from your olive trees or drink the wine from grapes you grow. (CEV)

Micah 6:16

Section 6:9–16: The LORD will punish his people for their dishonesty

This section has three parts. In 6:9–12, the LORD charged the people of Jerusalem and the tribe of Judah with theft, dishonesty, deception, and violence. In 6:13–15, he stated how he will punish them. In 6:16, the LORD restated in a short summary the people’s sin and their punishment. In this section, the LORD was the speaker except for 6:9, in which Micah told the people of the city to listen.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Cheating and Violence to Be Punished (NRSV)

Israel’s Guilt and Punishment (NIV)

Accusations and Covenant Curses Suggestion by A&F (pages 541–544)

Paragraph 6:9–16

In this paragraph, the LORD accused the people of committing several kinds of sin. Most were sins committed by wealthy people. Some were sins by the general population.

6:16

There are two main ways to interpret the relationship between 6:16 and the previous verses:

1. Verse 6:16 repeats the main themes of the previous verses in a more concise way. The repeated themes are sin, and the judgment that results. People sinned by following the practices of King Omri and

Ahab. As a result the LORD will judge them. For example:

You have kept Omri's laws and all the practices of the descendants of Ahab, and you have followed their advice. That is why I will ruin you. Your people will be ridiculed. You will bear the disgrace of my people." (GW) (BSB, GW, NAB, NASB, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, REB)

1. Verse 6:16 gives the reason for the LORD's judgment described in 6:13–15. The reason for that judgment is that the people followed the practices of Omri and Ahab. The second part of 6:16 announces another judgment. For example:

Jerusalem, this will happen because you followed the sinful example of kings Omri and Ahab. Now I will destroy you and your property. Then the people of every nation will make fun and insult you. (CEV) (CEV, ESV, KJV, NCV, NJB, NRSV, REB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It has good commentary and version support. For example, JFB (page 694) says that this verse recapitulates what was more fully stated before, Judah's sin and resulting punishment. See also Mays (page 148) and A&F (pages 549–550). It also does not conflict with 6:13a. Verse 6:13a has two explicit indicators of the reason for the LORD's judgment that is described in 6:13–15. The word "Therefore" and the phrase "because of your sins" make clear that he will judge the people because of the sins listed in 10–12.

6:16a–c (combined/reordered)

- You follow the pattern of evil living set by Kings Omri and Ahab and their descendants.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{16a} You have kept **the statutes of Omri**

^{16b} and **all the practices of Ahab's house;**

^{16c} you have followed **their counsel.**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 6:16b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 6:16a. For example:

^{16b} and you have kept **all the practices of Ahab's house;**

These parallel lines give examples from Israel's history to show how the people had sinned. Omri and his son Ahab were the longest ruling kings in the northern kingdom and were known for their wickedness. They abused their power, they exploited others, and they worshiped idols. See 1 Kings 16:25–33.

6:16a

You have kept the statutes of Omri

- You^(sing/plur) have followed the customs of Omri
- You have copied the evil practices of King Omri

You have kept the statutes of Omri: This line is more literally "and it has been kept the statutes of Omri." BART parses the word as a conjunction plus imperfect verb in passive voice. However, LDHB understands the verb as waw-conjunctive plus imperfect verb in active voice: "and he observed the statutes/customs of Omri." Many versions, such as the BSB, translate this line with an active verb. In some languages, it will be more natural to use passive forms. For example:

The statutes of Omri and all the works of the house of Ahab are observed (NASB)

In Hebrew, this sentence starts with "and." Here the word may indicate that this clause is the concluding indictment against the people. Waltke 2007 (page 404). In this context, it does not indicate "because." For more details, see the note above on "the relationship between 6:16 and the previous verses." Many versions, such as the BSB, leave this word implied.

the statutes of Omri: This line means that the people did the same kinds of things that Omri had done. In this context, the word statutes probably does not refer to laws or ordinances but to customs and practices/behaviors. CBC (pages 339–340) and Pusey (page 88) mention that the Old Testament does not record specific laws or rulings that exemplify the evil character of Omri's reign. DCH (page 302) sense 2. indicates that the meaning in 6:16 is "custom of human beings" rather than laws or decrees. In 2 Kings 17:7–11, 19–20 the NIV translates this word as "practices" that it elaborates in 2 Kings 17:9 as "things against the Lord their God that were not right." For more details see 2 Kings 17:7–20.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

the evil practices of King Omri (GNT)

you have followed the wicked customs of Omri

6:16b

and all the practices of Ahab's house;

- and all the evil deeds of Ahab's house.
- and those of Ahab and his descendants.

and all the practices of Ahab's house: This parallel line means that the people also did the kinds of deeds that King Ahab and his family had done.

The practices of Ahab's house may include the following evil acts: Each of the following resources mentions one or more of the evil acts listed in (a-g): CBC (pages 339–340), KD (page 339), WBC (page 53), NICOT (pages 381–382), NET footnote on “policies,” TOTC (page 217).

1. Marriage to an idolater
2. Baal worship
3. Robbery and murder
4. Persecution of true prophets
5. Child sacrifice
6. Unjust and oppressive measures
7. Apostasy, depravity, greed and injustice

Ahab's house: This phrase means “Ahab's family/ household.” His household included his wife, children, dependent relatives, officials and slaves. Waltke 2007 (page 404). The phrase probably also included his descendants who later became kings. UBS (page 242).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Ahab's dynasty (NET)

the descendants of Ahab (GW)

Ahab's family (NCV)

6:16c

you have followed their counsel.

- You^(sing/plur) have followed their way of life.
- You live and act as they did.

you have followed their counsel: This line means that the people followed the bad example of Omri and Ahab and his family by continuing the same kinds of evil practices.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

You have continued their policies (GNT)

by modelling yourselves on their standards (NJB)

you have followed their traditions (NIV)

counsel: In Hebrew, this word means “plans” or “decisions.” Waltke 2007 (page 405). It refers to a person's usual way of living/acting. UBS (page 242).

General Comment on 6:16a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these three lines into one or two lines. For example.

^{16a–c}you followed the sinful example of kings Omri and Ahab (CEV)

^{16a–b}you have followed the evil practices of King Omri and of his son, King Ahab. ^{16c}You have continued their policies (GNT)

6:16d

Therefore I will make you a desolation,

- Therefore I will make you^(sing) a desolate ruin,
- That is why I will destroy you.

6:16e

and your inhabitants an object of contempt;

- and your^(sing) inhabitants an object of mockery.
- Your citizens will be ridiculed by those who hate you.

6:16d–e

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{16d}Therefore I will make **you a desolation,**

^{16e}and **your inhabitants an object of contempt;**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 6:16e. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 6:16d. For example:

^{16e}and I will make **your inhabitants an object of contempt;**

These two parallel lines and the next line are three parts of a judgment against the city of Jerusalem and the kingdom of Judah. NAC (page 120). This judgment was the LORD's response to the sin described in 16a–c.

Therefore: In Hebrew, this word is more literally “so that” or “to the end that.” The meaning is that judgment was the inevitable consequence of people's disobedience. EBC (page 543) and NICOT (page 382). It may imply that the LORD had no alternative other than to judge. TOTC (page 217).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

That is why (GW)

you force me (NJB)

you...your inhabitants: The referent of you and your is probably the city of Jerusalem and/or the entire kingdom of Judah. Waltke 2007 (page 405) suggests the referent is the city. UBS (page 242) and KD (page 339) suggest the referent is the nation. NAC (page 120) mentions both Jerusalem and Judah. The references to both you and your inhabitants probably indicates that the judgment would be against the people as well as the places where they lived.

Here are some other ways to translate these referents:

you and your property (CEV)

you...your citizens (NJB)

a desolation...an object of contempt: Both phrases describe a situation that is so awful or appalling that people react to it with astonishment and horror. Waltke 2007 (page 405) and EBC (page 543).

In Hebrew, the word desolation means both “ruin/waste” and “appalment/horror.” TWOT #2409d and BDB #8047 (page 1031).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

an appalling sight (NET)

an object of horror (NJPS)

give you over to ruin (NIV)

let you be destroyed (NCV)

The phrase an object of contempt is more literally, “an object of hissing.” This means that people will make a hissing sound in response to the ruin. At that time the act of hissing indicated scorn and ridicule.

If your language group has this custom with the same meaning, you may be able to translate this phrase literally. However, if this custom is unknown or has a different meaning in your language group, here are some other ways to translate it:

will be taunted derisively (NET)

will be treated with contempt (NLT)

will be laughed at (NCV)

6:16f

you will bear the scorn of the nations.”

- Yes, the scorn of others against my people is what you^(sing) will endure.
- You^(plur), my people, will be disgraced.

you will bear the scorn of the nations: There is a textual issue with the word that the BSB translates as nations:

1. The Masoretic Text has “my people.” The word refers to the LORD’s people. They are scorned by other people. The identity of the scorers is left implicit. For example:

and you will endure the insults aimed at my people (REB) (ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NRSV, REB)

1. The LXX has “of peoples.” The word refers to people of other nations. They scorn Yahweh’s people. For example:

and other nations will make fun of you (NCV) (BSB, CEV, NAB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, GNT)

The Display will follow option (1). It makes good sense and has good support from commentators, the Peshitta, and modern versions. Commentary support includes KD, JFB, A&F, Waltke 2007, Pusey. However, option (2) also has good support from modern versions and some commentators. You may want to follow this option if it is followed by a major language translation in your area.

This is the third part of the LORD’s judgment against the city of Jerusalem and the kingdom of Judah. The LORD’s people who live there will bear/endure scorn from people of other nations. Some commentators suggest that it is the leaders of Judah that are addressed here. A&F (page 550) say that the leaders are to blame and will be punished most. Waltke 2007 (pages 405–406) agrees. However, the Hebrew text itself does not offer explicit evidence in support of this suggestion.

scorn: This word means “reproach” or “contempt.” In this context, it indicates that other nations insult, taunt, or mock the LORD’s people. TWOT # 749a.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

bear the disgrace of my people (GW)

suffer taunts and mocking directed against my people

you, my people will be jeered and shamed

Micah 7:1

Section 7:1–7: Micah lamented about the wickedness of God’s people

This section is a lament of Micah that expresses his sorrow about the lack of righteous people in the land. In 7:1–6, he talked about the wickedness of the people using a combination of figures of speech and direct speech. In 7:7, he concluded the lament by expressing his own hope in the LORD.

Some scholars and versions place 7:7 in the next section. However, expressions of both sorrow and hope are features in some other laments, such as in the Psalms. Psalm 55 is one example. NICOT (pages 383–385). Also, both 7:1 and 7:7 have first-person pronouns and verbs that enclose third-person descriptions in 7:2–6. This change of word forms probably indicates the start and end of the lament. UBS (pages 244–256).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Total Corruption of the People (NRSV)

Israel’s Misery (NIV)

Misery Turned to Hope (NLT)

7:1

This verse begins Micah’s lament. He uses similes to describe his disappointment that he cannot find any fruit at harvest time.

There are two main interpretations of the situation depicted by the similes:

1. There was no fruit left to pick after the fruit and grapes were harvested. Waltke 2007 (pages 416–417) suggests that the harvest was gathered several times so that no gleanings remained. Others that support this interpretation include NAC, WBC, EBC, JFB, and UBS. For example:

I am depressed! indeed, it is as if the summer fruit has been gathered, and the grapes have been harvested. There is no grape cluster to eat, no fresh figs that I crave so much. (NET) (CEV, ESV, BSB, GNT, KJV, NAB, NCV, NET, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. There was no harvest of fruit and grapes. A&F (pages 565–566) suggest that the vintage had failed. Alternatively, TOTC (page 218) suggests that vandals had stripped the grapes and figs from the vines and trees and left them bare. For example:

Woe is me! For I am like the fruit pickers, like the grape gatherers. There is not a cluster of grapes to eat, Or a first-ripe fig which I crave. (NASB) (GW, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It has support from most commentators and versions.

7:1a

Woe is me!

- ¶! How sad I am!
- ¶! I am in misery!

Woe is me!: This expression indicates despair. Feelings of despair, not just disappointment, are explainable in light of the farming practices described in Leviticus 19:9–10. Land owners were required to leave behind any grain or fruit that was missed in the main harvest, so that the poor could gather it for their food. A poor person could starve without this food supply. UBS (pages 244–245) and A&F (pages 565–566). Here are some other ways to express the meaning:

I am depressed! (NET)

It’s hopeless! (GNT)

I feel very sad Suggested by UBS (page 244).

7:1a–e

(combined/reordered)

- I feel so empty inside—like someone starving for grapes or figs, after the vines and trees have all been picked clean. (CEV)

7:1b–e

The ESV has been used as the source line for 7:1b–c because it maintains both similes and follows the recommended interpretation.

Notice the two sets of parallel lines that follow the underlined part. The lines in bold have similar meaning and the lines in italics have similar meaning:

^{1b}For I have become **as when the summer fruit has been gathered**, (ESV)

^{1c} **as when the grapes have been gleaned**: (ESV)

^{1d} **there is no cluster to eat**, (ESV, BSB)

^{1e} **no early fig that I crave**. (BSB)

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 7:1c. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 7:1b. For example:

^{1c} I have become **as when the grapes have been gleaned**:

There are two similes in 7:1b–e. The lines are arranged as a chiasm. Lines 7:1b and 7:1e are parts of a simile about summer fruit. Lines 7:1c and 7:1d are parts of a simile about grapes.

In each simile, Micah compares himself to a person who looks for fruit that is left behind after the fruit harvests are done. In the first simile he looks for summer fruit. In the second simile he looks for grapes.

Some versions combine the two similes into one. See the General Comment on 7:1 for examples.

7:1b

For I am like one gathering summer fruit

- I am like someone who searches for summer fruit after it has already been picked,
- I am like a fruit picker after a summer harvest,

For: The word For introduces the reason why Micah is in despair. He explains the reason in the verses that follow, 7:1b–6.

(ESV) I have become as...: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “I have become like harvests of summer fruit...” The implied meaning of the phrase is that Micah compared himself to a person who found no fruit to eat following a harvest. The way they are similar is that both feel despair.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Keep the simile. For example:

I am like the fruit pickers (NASB)

I am like a hungry person who... (GNT)

I am like those gathering... (GW)

- Change the simile into a metaphor. For example:

How wretched I am, a harvester... (NJB)

(ESV) when the summer fruit has been gathered:

This line describes the setting or situation of the simile. The harvest of summer fruit has already been completed.

The phrase summer fruit may refer to fruit that grew in the summer season or it may refer to ripe fruit in general. Mounce (page 1033). Some versions leave the word summer implied.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

and all the summer fruit has been picked (NCV)

when the fruit is gathered (NAB)

7:1c

at the gleanings of the vineyard; there is no cluster to eat,

- and after all the grapes have been gathered.
- and after the grapes have been harvested twice.

(ESV) as when the grapes have been gleaned: This line is more literally “like gleanings of [the] grape harvest.” It describes the setting or situation of the second simile. The harvest of grapes has already been completed.

The word gleaned means that the grapes have been picked a second time after the main harvest. BDB #5955 (page 760) and A&F (page 566).

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

and the grapes have been harvested (NET)

as when the vines have been gleaned (NAB)

7:1d

there is no cluster to eat,

- I find none to eat.
- There is nothing left to eat!

there is no cluster to eat: This line is the final part of the simile about the grape harvest. The person looks for grapes to eat, but he does not find any.

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as cluster means “a cluster/bunch of grapes.” BDB #811 (page 79).

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

- Make the word “grapes” explicit along with cluster. For example:

not a cluster of grapes (NLT)

- Translate the word “grapes” instead of cluster. For example:

there are no grapes left to eat (NCV)

7:1e

no early fig that I crave.

- There are no early ripened figs that I crave.
- Not even a fresh fig to enjoy!

no early fig that I crave: This line is the final part of the simile about the summer fruit harvest. The person looks for figs to eat but he does not find any.

The phrase early fig refers here to the first figs of the season that appear on the tree in early summer. These figs are especially delicious. HALOT (electronic edition, page 130), BDB #1063 (page 114), and A&F (page 566–568)

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

none of the early figs I love (NCV)

no fresh figs that I crave so much (NET)

all the tasty figs have been picked (GNT)

If grapes and figs are unknown in your language group, you may want to add pictures. You may also want to include descriptions in a footnote.

General Comment on 7:1a–e

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the verse parts, as in the BSB. For example.

What misery is mine! ^{1b–c}I feel like the fruit picker after the harvest who can find nothing to eat. ^{1d–}

^eNot a cluster of grapes or a single fig can be found to satisfy my hunger. (NLT96)

^{1a–e}I feel so empty inside—like someone starving for grapes or figs, after the vines and trees have all been picked clean. (CEV)

Micah 7:2

Section 7:1–7: Micah lamented about the wickedness of God’s people

This section is a lament of Micah that expresses his sorrow about the lack of righteous people in the land. In 7:1–6, he talked about the wickedness of the people using a combination of figures of speech and direct speech. In 7:7, he concluded the lament by expressing his own hope in the LORD.

Some scholars and versions place 7:7 in the next section. However, expressions of both sorrow and hope are features in some other laments, such as in the Psalms. Psalm 55 is one example. NICOT (pages 383–385). Also, both 7:1 and 7:7 have first-person pronouns and verbs that enclose third-person descriptions in 7:2–6. This change of word forms probably indicates the start and end of the lament. UBS (pages 244–256).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Total Corruption of the People (NRSV)

Israel’s Misery (NIV)

Misery Turned to Hope (NLT)

7:2a–b

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{2a} The godly man **has perished from the earth;**

^{2b} **there is no one** upright among men.

These parallel lines explain why Micah was in despair. The lack of fruit he described in the similes of 7:1 represented the lack of faithful people in the land.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

The faithful have been swept from the land; not one upright person remains. (NIV)

The faithful are gone from the earth, among men the upright are no more! (NAB)

The godly people have all disappeared; not one honest person is left on the earth. (NLT)

The godly...upright: In Hebrew, the words godly and upright are two ways to describe a person who followed the standards of Yahweh's covenant. "The faithful" are people "who keep covenant with God and his community" (TOTC page 218). They show "faithful covenant love" (NAC page 122). The upright are "those who maintain the moral rectitude of the covenant" TOTC (page 218).

The word godly means "a person who obeys God and shows mercy toward others." HALOT (electronic edition, page 111) "faithful, devout." The word indicates a responsibility to God and to his people, and has a distinctly social emphasis (NICOT page 385). The phrase the godly means "faithful people."

The word upright means "a person who is morally straight and deals fairly with others." Mounce (page 954) "morally straight: right, upright, innocent." "One who conforms his life to the 'straight' standard of Yahweh's covenant law" (Davis page 142).

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

faithful...honest (NJB)

godly people...fair-minded (NLT)

loyal to God...does right (CEV)

has perished from the earth...there is no one upright among men: Both phrases mean that there are no faithful, upright people. These phrases do not specify the way that the people disappeared, only that there are none.

7:2a

The godly man has perished from the earth;

- There are no more faithful people in the land.
- In the same way, those who are faithful to God are no longer here.

from the earth: There are two main interpretations of the referent of earth in this phrase:

1. The referent of the word earth is left implied. Here it probably refers to the land of Israel. For example:

the faithful have vanished from the land (REB)
(GNT, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, REB)

1. The referent of the word earth is the earth. For example:

The godly has perished from the earth (ESV) (ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, BSB)

Either interpretation is acceptable. Interpretation (1) fits well with the similes in 7:1 that depict a local, agricultural setting of fig and grape harvests, and with the description of Micah's contemporaries in 7:3-6. USB (page 245) suggests that Micah is concerned with his own nation in particular rather than the whole world. Also Waltke 2007 (page 417). However, interpretation (2) fits well with the parallel line that may have an application beyond Israel. KD (page 341). (See the next note).

7:2b

there is no one upright among men.

- Upright people have disappeared.
- Those who are righteous are gone.

there is no one upright among men: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally "and an upright [person] among humankind there [is] not." The phrase may refer to the absence of upright people among humans. JFB (page 694) notes the similarity of these lines to Psalm 12:1 "no one is faithful anymore, those who are loyal have vanished from the human race." Or, it may be a figure of speech (hyperbole) that refers to the people of Israel. It is acceptable to translate the phrase either way.

Here are some examples:

- Translate the phrase more literally. For example:

there is no one upright among mankind (ESV)

- Leave implied the words "among humankind." For example:

no one does right (CEV)

not one honest person is to be found (REB)

7:2c

They all lie in wait for blood;

- Everyone lies in wait to shed blood; (NIV)
- The people who remain are anxious to kill each other.
- They are all murderers, (NLT)

7:2d**they hunt one another with a net.**

- they use traps to capture each other.
- They are eager to deceive and harm their fellowmen.
- setting traps even for their own brothers. (NLT)

7:2c–d

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{2c} They all **lie in wait for blood**;

^{2d} they **hunt one other with a net**.

In these parallel lines Micah gives examples of the people's evil behavior to show that the people in the land are not faithful or upright.

They all...they: The phrase They all and the word they refer to the same people. The reference is probably to every person in the land. According to Waltke 2007 (page 417), the Hebrew phrase “all of them” indicates totality. However, A&F (page 568) and NAC (page 122) suggest that in this context the reference is to those listed in 7:3, which are rulers, judges and the powerful. Micah highlights especially the officials, judges and powerful people in 7:3. It may be that the corruption began in these groups and spread to the entire population. NAC (page 122).

Here are some other ways to translate these pronouns:

Everyone...everyone (NCV)

All people...They (GW)

All of them...every man (NJB)

lie in wait for blood...hunt one another with a net:

These parallel expressions are both figures of speech. The expression lie in wait for blood means “to attack and kill someone.” The expression hunt one another with a net is more literally “each hunts his brother [with] a net.” It compares how a person captured a fellow Israelite to the way a hunter trapped and killed animals.

These expressions describe the behavior of the people of Israel at that time. The expressions may refer to people who killed others for personal gain. It is also possible that they are hyperboles (exaggerations) that refer to people who took advantage of others to benefit themselves in various ways. Both ideas are suggested by commentators. KD (page 341) and WBC

(page 545) suggest that excessive mistreatment of others may be meant, not necessarily murder. However, UBS (page 245) suggests that “the people are pictured as being so bad that everyone is waiting for a chance to commit murder.” TOTC (page 218) comments that the expression “hunters who lie in wait” means that “their practices are sinister and covert” and the expression “hunt with a net” means that they are “effectively deadly.”

Here are some ways to translate these expressions:

- Keep the figures of speech. For example:

They all wait in ambush so they can shed blood...
they hunt their own brother with a net (NET)

- Translate the meaning of the expressions more directly. The first example shows that the meaning is evil behavior, but not necessarily murder. The second example regards the meaning to be actual murder. For example:

Everyone is brutal and eager to deceive everyone else. (CEV)

Everyone is waiting for a chance to commit murder. Everyone hunts down their own people. (GNT)

blood: In Hebrew, this word means “blood that is shed through violence.” BDB #1818 (pages 196–187).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

shed blood (NIV)

commit murder (GNT)

net: In Hebrew, this word means “a device with holes that is used to capture fish or other animals.” TWOT #745a.

Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Translate as net or something similar. For example:

net (NJPS)

trap (NCV)

- Translate as behavior associated with the use of a net. For example:

hunts down (GNT)

ensnares (NAB)

Micah 7:3

Section 7:1–7: Micah lamented about the wickedness of God’s people

This section is a lament of Micah that expresses his sorrow about the lack of righteous people in the land. In 7:1–6, he talked about the wickedness of the people using a combination of figures of speech and direct speech. In 7:7, he concluded the lament by expressing his own hope in the LORD.

Some scholars and versions place 7:7 in the next section. However, expressions of both sorrow and hope are features in some other laments, such as in the Psalms. Psalm 55 is one example. NICOT (pages 383–385). Also, both 7:1 and 7:7 have first-person pronouns and verbs that enclose third-person descriptions in 7:2–6. This change of word forms probably indicates the start and end of the lament. UBS (pages 244–256).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Total Corruption of the People (NRSV)

Israel’s Misery (NIV)

Misery Turned to Hope (NLT)

7:3

In this verse Micah continued to describe the evil behavior of the people of Israel. He gives three examples of corrupt people of influence: officials, judges and powerful people.

7:3a

Both hands are skilled at evil;

- They are skillful at using their power to do evil.
- They know how to use their influence to take advantage of others.

Both hands are skilled at evil: This clause introduces the three examples of corrupt types of people in 3b–d.

The word hands has a figurative meaning of the use of power. NIDOTTE (page 686) and Mounce (page 959). That is probably the meaning here. The word skilled is literally “do well.” The full clause means that the people in each example were experts at using their power to do evil. They were clever and successful at it. JFB, UBS, and Davis.

7:3b

the prince and the judge demand a bribe.

- Rulers and judges demand bribes.
- For example, community leaders, such as officials and judges, require that people give them bribes.

the prince and the judge demand a bribe: This clause combines two examples. Both the prince and the judge ask for bribes. This clause is more literally “the official [is] asking and the judge for (the) bribe.” Waltke 2007 (page 419) proposes that the words “ruler” and “judge” are a hendiadys, “the judging ruler.” However, the majority of commentators and versions regard “ruler” and “judge” to refer to two different kinds of people. The phrases the prince and the judge refer to two classes/types of people. Their roles in society provided them with many opportunities to influence and manipulate people. In some languages it may be more natural to translate these phrases as plural forms. For example:

Officials and judges alike demand bribes. (NLT)

prince: In Hebrew, the word prince means “a leader in government, the military or religion.” Mounce (page 1049).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

official (NRSV)

rulers (NCV)

judge: In Hebrew, the word judge is a person who makes decisions or arbitrates disagreements of various kinds. HALOT (electronic edition, page 1624) says that in Micah 7:3 the sense is a judge concerned with the law. BDB # 8199 (page 1047) notes that a judge might also make decisions that concern civil, political, domestic and religious questions.

bribe: See the note on “for a bribe” in 3:11a.

7:3c

When the powerful utters his evil desire, they all conspire together.

- Powerful/Rich people say what they want, and wicked people scheme together to grant it.
- Important people make known their evil desire, and they get it, even though they use unjust means.

When the powerful utters his evil desire: This clause gives the third example of an influential class/type of person. It may be more natural in some languages

to translate the phrase the powerful with plural word forms. for example:

Powerful people dictate what they want. (GW)

powerful: In Hebrew, this word means “great” or “distinguished.” In this context it probably refers to a rich person who was able to influence others.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

prominent men (NET)

people with influence (NLT)

Rich people (NCV)

the important man Suggested by UBS (page 246).

utters his evil desire: In Hebrew, the word utters means “say,” “tell” or “command.” People with power could get what they want simply by telling someone that they want it.

The phrase his evil desire means more literally “mischievousness or lust of his soul.” JFB (page 695). It refers to the hurt or destruction or other kind of evil that the powerful person wants to happen so that he can attain his selfish goals. EBC (page 546) says that the Hebrew word is always used in a bad sense and commonly means “calamity” or “destruction.” Also see KD (page 341) and NICOT (page 387).

Here are some ways to translate this clause part:

- Translate the action of speaking, and make explicit that the desire is for evil. For example:

the great man utters the evil desire of his soul (ESV)

The rich man makes his crooked plea (NJPS)

- Translate the end result. Leave implied the action of speaking and that the desire is for evil. For example:

The people with influence get what they want (NLT)

they all conspire together: In Hebrew, this clause is literally “he and they weave it.” Here this expression means that corrupt officials, judges and powerful

people scheme together to give the powerful people what they want. JFB (695) comments that the Hebrew expression means to intertwine cords together. “Here the prince, the judge, and the great man are the three in guilty complicity.” “...They conspire together to carry out the great man’s desire at the sacrifice of justice.” Also NICOT, EBC, Waltke 2007, UBS, and KD. The Hebrew expression “he and they weave it” leaves implicit that the evil scheming is unjust. Other translations of the clause make this aspect of meaning explicit. For example:

they pervert justice (NRSV)

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

And they grant it. (NJPS)

and they do what is necessary to satisfy them (NET)

they all conspire together (NIV)

So they scheme together. (GW)

and together they scheme to twist justice (NLT)

Micah 7:4

Section 7:1-7: Micah lamented about the wickedness of God’s people

This section is a lament of Micah that expresses his sorrow about the lack of righteous people in the land. In 7:1-6, he talked about the wickedness of the people using a combination of figures of speech and direct speech. In 7:7, he concluded the lament by expressing his own hope in the LORD.

Some scholars and versions place 7:7 in the next section. However, expressions of both sorrow and hope are features in some other laments, such as in the Psalms. Psalm 55 is one example. NICOT (pages 383-385). Also, both 7:1 and 7:7 have first-person pronouns and verbs that enclose third-person descriptions in 7:2-6. This change of word forms probably indicates the start and end of the lament. UBS (pages 244-256).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Total Corruption of the People (NRSV)

Israel’s Misery (NIV)

Misery Turned to Hope (NLT)

**7:4a-b
(combined/reordered)**

- The most honest of them is worse than a thorn patch. (CEV)

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{4a} The best of them is like **a brier**;

^{4b} the most upright is sharper than **a hedge of thorns**.

In Hebrew, there is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 7:4b (bracketed in the BSB above). In some languages, you may not need to do this, or it may be more natural to supply missing words that match 7:4a more closely. For example:

^{4b} the most upright is like **a hedge of thorns**.

In these parallel lines Micah continues to describe the widespread evil among the people of that time. Each line is a figure of speech that compares the best of the people to undesirable weeds.

The best of them...the most upright: In Hebrew, these phrases are more literally “their good person” and “an upright [person].” In Hebrew, the word “good” means “ethical.” BDB #2895 (page 374). In Hebrew, the word upright means “morally straight” or “just.” BDB #3477 (page 449) and Mounce (page 954). However, in this context these words are meant as sarcasm. UBS (pages 246–247). The people are not truly good and upright. The similes indicate that the level/standard of moral goodness and responsibility among the people is very low. NICOT (page 387) and UBS (pages 246–247).

Here are some ways to translate these phrases:

- Use sarcasm. Rely on the comparison of the people to weeds to indicate that the words for “good” and upright are meant negatively here. This example uses superlatives, best and most. A superlative is a word that means “surpassing all others.” See Merriam-Webster “Superlative.” In these phrases the superlatives indicate that these are the most responsible people among them. It gives attention to the most responsible people among them.

The best of them is like a briar. The most decent person is sharper than thornbushes. (GW) This ex-

ample uses normal words for “good” and upright. It gives attention to the people as a group.

Their goodness is twisted like rank weeds and their honesty like briars. (REB)

- Translate the negative meaning of the words “good” and upright in this context. For example:

The so called good person is really as bad as a brier. The one they say is upright is dangerous like a thorn bush that pricks and scratches.

Some of them are as bad as briars and thorns, and the rest of them are even worse. Modified from a suggestion by UBS (pages 246–247).

brier...hedge of thorns: In Hebrew, the words brier and hedge of thorns refer to plants with thorns. Here the similes compare the people to these thorny plants. The way they are similar is that they are both harmful.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

thornbush...prickly plant (NCV)

rank weeds...briars (NEB)

sharper than a hedge of thorns: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “more than a thorn hedge.” A hedge is a row of plants that may line the boundary of a property. The phrase probably means that the upright person of this simile causes even more harm/injury to other people than a thorn hedge would cause. Pusey (page 91) and the NET footnote on “a row of thorn bushes.” Some versions, including the BSB, make this meaning clear. For example:

the most godly among them are more dangerous than a row of thorn bushes (NET)

The [most] upright, worse than a barrier of thorns (NJPS)

General Comment on 7:4a-b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the parallel lines. For example:

The most honest of them is worse than a thorn patch. (CEV)

Even the best and most honest of them are as worthless as weeds. (GNT)

7:4a

The best of them is like a brier;

- The best of them is like an overgrown patch of weeds/thorns,
- Even the so-called good people are as bad/dangerous as prickly weeds,

7:4b

the most upright is sharper than a hedge of thorns.

- and their honesty like briars. (REB)
- and the upright people are worse than thorn bushes.

7:4c

The day for your watchmen has come, the day of your visitation.

- God warned you through the prophets that he would come to punish you. That day has arrived!
- The time of God's punishment has come,

The day for your watchmen has come, the day of your visitation: The phrases The day for your watchmen and the day of your visitation, are two ways to refer to the same event. The word day does not refer to a literal 24-hour day. Here it refers to the time when the LORD would punish the people of Israel. The phrase has come indicates that the time had arrived.

The day for your watchmen: There is a textual issue about the word watchmen:

1. The Masoretic Text has watchmen. For example:

The day of your watchmen (ESV) (CEV, ESV, GNT, KJV, NAB, NASB, BSB, NCV, NIV, NRSV)

1. Some scholars say that the original word was "judgment." See CBC (page 343). For example:

But your judgment day is coming swiftly now. (NLT) (NLT, REB)

1. Some scholars say that the original word was "from the north." See Waltke 2007 (page 421). For example:

Now from the north their punishment approaches! (NJB) (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and commentaries.

At the time of Micah, a "watchman" or "sentinel" was a person who gave a warning to the residents of a town

or city when he saw potential danger. In this verse the word watchmen referred to the prophets. In the past the prophets had warned the people that this time of punishment was coming. UBS, KD, and A&F.

Here are some ways to translate the phrase The day for your watchmen:

- Make some aspects of meaning more explicit. Both examples below make explicit that the people were previously warned. The second example also makes explicit the identity of the sentinels/watchmen:

The day that your watchmen warned you about has come. (NCV)

The day has come when God will punish the people, as he warned them through their watchmen, the prophets. (GNT)

- Translate the phrase literally and leave the aspects of meaning implied. For example:

The day of their watchmen, of their punishment, has come. (RSV)

- Leave the entire phrase The day for your watchmen implied. Allow the reference to punishment to provide the meaning. For example:

The day of their punishment has come (REB)

But your judgment day is coming swiftly now. Your time of punishment is here (NLT)

your: In 7:4a–b and 7:4d Micah uses the pronouns "them" and "their" to talk about the people. He used the pronoun your in this line and in 7:5 to address the people directly. Some commentators propose that a change of speaker and/or addressee occurs here. For example, A&F suggest that the speaker is the LORD and the addressee is the people. NICOT proposes that the speaker is Micah and the addressee is the LORD. These notes will follow the suggestion of UBS, NAC, KD and Waltke 2007, all of whom regard Micah to be the speaker and the addressee to be the people. In Hebrew poetry, it is common for an author to alternate pronouns in this way, even though the pronoun referent remains the same.

One way that versions reduce the potential confusion to readers is to reduce the number of times the pronouns alternate. For example, the NRSV has "their" in

this line to match the other pronouns in 7:4. The NIV does it differently. It has “you/your” in this line and in 7:4d:

^{4c}The day God visits you has come, the day your watchmen sound the alarm. ^{4d}Now is the time of your confusion. (NIV)

Use the most natural and least confusing way in your language to translate the pronouns in this verse.

the day of your visitation: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “your visitation.” Here the phrase means “the LORD’s judgment of the people.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 958), BDB #6486 (page 824). Waltke 2007 (page 421) calls the phrase “a metonymy for judgment.” Also see Davis, NAC, and CBC.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

your doom (NJPS)

your judgment day...Your time of punishment (NLT)

7:4d

Now is the time of their confusion.

- Now a time will begin when you will be terrified/confused.
- and it will be a time of panic/confusion.

Now is the time of their confusion: This line means that the punishment from the LORD will cause confusion among the people.

Now: This word indicates “at that time.” Here are some other ways to translate it:

Then (NASB)

That will be when (NJB)

is the time: This phrase is not in the Hebrew text. It is an expression in English that the BSB and some other versions supply. It reinforces that the time of punishment would happen at that time. If this expression is not natural in your language, it is best to leave it untranslated.

confusion: This word refers to chaos or disorder or panic that results from an attack by an enemy. NAC, Davis, and CBC. The LORD probably allowed this kind of attack as his means of punishment.

Micah 7:5

Section 7:1–7: Micah lamented about the wickedness of God’s people

This section is a lament of Micah that expresses his sorrow about the lack of righteous people in the land. In 7:1–6, he talked about the wickedness of the people using a combination of figures of speech and direct speech. In 7:7, he concluded the lament by expressing his own hope in the LORD.

Some scholars and versions place 7:7 in the next section. However, expressions of both sorrow and hope are features in some other laments, such as in the Psalms. Psalm 55 is one example. NICOT (pages 383–385). Also, both 7:1 and 7:7 have first-person pronouns and verbs that enclose third-person descriptions in 7:2–6. This change of word forms probably indicates the start and end of the lament. UBS (pages 244–256).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Total Corruption of the People (NRSV)

Israel’s Misery (NIV)

Misery Turned to Hope (NLT)

7:5a–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning (these lines are from the RSV):

^{5a} Put no trust in **a neighbor**,

^{5b} have no confidence in **a friend**;

^{5c} guard the doors of your mouth from **her who lies in your bosom**;

In these lines, Micah warns the people to trust no one. He gives this warning in three parallel clauses. The degree of closeness to the other person increases in each clause.

The RSV has been used as the source line for 7:5a–c, because it better follows the word choices in most versions.

7:5a

Do not rely on a friend;

- Do not trust your neighbor,
- Do not believe what people tell you,

(RSV) Put no trust in a neighbor: In Hebrew, the word trust can also mean “believe,” “have confidence,” or “rely” on another person. Mounce (page 896) and Waltke 2007 (page 42). In Hebrew, the word neighbor can also mean “associate,” “companion,” or “friend.” Mounce (page 1042). It indicates a low level relationship with another person. They know each other to some extent, but they are not close friends.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

Don't trust anyone (CEV)

Don't believe your neighbor (GNT)

7:5b

do not trust in a companion.

- or rely on your friend.
- not even a close friend.

(RSV) have no confidence in a friend: In Hebrew, the word confidence can also mean “trust,” “have confidence,” or “rely” on another person. This word is very similar in meaning to the Hebrew word for “trust” in 5a. Mounce (page 904). In Hebrew, the word friend means “close friend,” “partner,” “ally,” or “companion.” Mounce (page 894). It indicates a stronger relationship with another person than the word “neighbor.” They know each other fairly well and are close friends.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

not even your best friend (CEV)

or trust your friend (GNT)

7:5c

Seal the doors of your mouth from her who lies in your arms.

- Be cautious about what you^(sing) share with the one who lies in your arms.
- Take care what you^(plur) make known even to your wives.

(RSV) guard the doors of your In Hebrew, the addressee alternates between plural in 5:a-b and singular in 5:c. However, the same group of people is addressed in both places. Waltke 2007 (page 422) notes that the alternation between plural and singular is acceptable Hebrew. In many languages, it will be more natural to translate this pronoun as “your(pl).”
mouth from her who lies in your bosom: In Hebrew,

the phrase guard the doors of your mouth is a figure of speech that means to be careful not to say something that will put you in danger. Waltke 2007 (page 422) and UBS (pages 247–248).

In Hebrew, the word bosom refers to the part of the body between the arms. The phrase her who lies in your bosom is a way to say “your wife.” BDB #2436 (page 300), JFB (page 695), and Waltke 2007 (page 422). This warning indicates the most intimate kind of relationship.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

Don't even share secrets with the one who lies in your arms! (NET)

Be careful what you say even to your husband or wife. (GNT)

Micah 7:6

Section 7:1–7: Micah lamented about the wickedness of God's people

This section is a lament of Micah that expresses his sorrow about the lack of righteous people in the land. In 7:1–6, he talked about the wickedness of the people using a combination of figures of speech and direct speech. In 7:7, he concluded the lament by expressing his own hope in the LORD.

Some scholars and versions place 7:7 in the next section. However, expressions of both sorrow and hope are features in some other laments, such as in the Psalms. Psalm 55 is one example. NICOT (pages 383–385). Also, both 7:1 and 7:7 have first-person pronouns and verbs that enclose third-person descriptions in 7:2–6. This change of word forms probably indicates the start and end of the lament. UBS (pages 244–256).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Total Corruption of the People (NRSV)

Israel's Misery (NIV)

Misery Turned to Hope (NLT)

7:6a–d

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{6a} For a son **dishonors his father,**

^{6b} a daughter **rises against her mother,**

^{6c} and a daughter-in-law **against her mother-in-law.**

^{6d} **A man's enemies** are the members of his own household.

In this verse Micah gave the reason for his warnings to the people in 7:5 not to trust even the people close to them. It was because members of their own households were their enemies.

Micah gives three examples. In each example he describes a relationship between a member of a family to another member. In each relationship the younger member behaves in a way that dishonors and opposes the authority of an older family member. Each was an example of a serious offense in that society. ZIBBC (page 144).

The examples use singular forms: “son,” “daughter,” “daughter-in-law,” etc. However, each phrase represents a large group of people: “sons,” “daughters,” “daughters-in-law,” etc. In some languages it will be more natural to use plural forms. For example:

Sons refuse to respect their own fathers, daughters rebel against their own mothers, daughters-in-law despise their mothers-in-law. (CEV)

7:6a

For a son dishonors his father,

- For a son has contempt for his father,
- Because sons insult their fathers,

For: This word introduces a reason for Micah's warnings in 7:5. See the previous note for more explanation.

Some versions indicate the connection of this verse to the previous ones in a different way. For example, the GNT refers back to the time period that is described in 7:1–5:

In these times sons treat their fathers like fools (GNT)

Some other versions do not have an explicit connecting word or phrase. Instead they leave the connection implied. For example:

A son treats his father with contempt (GW)

a son dishonors his father: In Hebrew, the word dishonors is related to the word for “fool.” In Hebrew, the word *nābal* means “fool.” Here the participle of the word, *mānabbēl* is used. In this clause the word means that the son insults and/or dishonors his father by treating him like a fool. Mounce (page 990), BDB #5034 (page 614), NAC, KD, and Waltke 2007.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

A son will not honor his father (NCV)

For son insults father (NJB)

For a son thinks his father is a fool (NET)

7:5–6

(combined/reordered)

- Sons disrespect their fathers, daughters rebel against their mothers, and daughters-in-law defy their mothers-in-law. Your enemies are in your own house! So don't trust anyone, not your friends and not even your own wife!

7:6b

a daughter rises against her mother,

- a daughter rebels against her mother,
- daughters challenge their mothers,

a daughter rises against her mother: In Hebrew, the phrase rises against is an expression that means “to rebel and be defiant.” BDB #6965 (page 878) and NICOT (page 389).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

A daughter will turn against her mother (NCV)

daughter rebels against mother (NJB)

a daughter challenges her mother (NET)

The daughter defies her mother (NLT)

7:6c

and a daughter-in-law against her mother-in-law.

- a daughter-in-law does the same thing against her mother-in-law,
- and daughters-in-law defy their mothers-in-law.

and a daughter-in-law against her mother-in-law: There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase)

in this verse part. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 7:6b. For example:

^{6c}and a daughter-in-law rises against her mother-in-law

The description of the expression “rises against” in 7:6b applies to this verse part also.UBS (page 249).

In that society a daughter-in-law normally joined her husband’s family.UBS (page 249). The daughter-in-law was expected to respect the authority of her mother-in-law. Here she did not show that respect.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and a daughter-in-law will be against her mother-in-law (NCV)

The daughter-in-law defies her mother-in-law (NLT)

a daughter-in-law rebels against her mother-in-law (GW)

7:6d

A man’s enemies are the members of his own household.

- a person’s enemies are the members of his own household.
- People are enemies of their own family members!

A man’s enemies are the members of his own household: There are three main interpretations of the referent of the phrase members of his own household:A fourth interpretation is that the phrase refers to the extended family, which included sons-in-law and household servants. See NAC (pages 123–124). This interpretation was not listed in the notes because no versions clearly follow it.

1. The phrase refers to family members.This interpretation is favored by A&F, Davis, UBS, NICOT, and ABC. For example:

People’s enemies are the members of their own families. (GW) (CEV, GNT, GW, NCV)

1. The phrase refers to all the males in a household.This interpretation is favored by Waltke 2007. The MT word “people” in the phrase “people of his own household” is masculine plural. This

gender marking is compatible with the interpretation of “males” here. However, this form alone is not conclusive evidence. The masculine plural form did not necessarily mean males only. It was also the standard form used to designate a mixed group of males and females. For example:

A man’s enemies are the men of his own household (NASB) (KJV, NASB)

1. The phrase refers to the servants in a household.This interpretation is favored by Margolis and KD. For example:

a man’s enemies are his own servants (NET) (NET)

Some versions are ambiguous. They translate the word household literally which leaves implied the referents of the word. However, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It best fits the context of the three relationships described in this verse.The examples in the verse include both male and female relationships among family members. The wider context supports this view also. See Jesus’ quote of this verse in Luke 12:51–53 and Matthew 10:35.

This line is probably a summary statement that refers to the relationships described in 7:6a–c.

enemies: This word refers to people hostile towards others, “foe.”BDB #340 (page 33), Mounce (page 892).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

a person’s enemies will be members of his own family (NCV)

Your family is now your enemy (CEV)

General Comment on 7:5–6

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder the verses. For example, in reverse order 7:6 describes the situation first and 7:5 then gives advice on how to respond to the situation.UBS (pages 248–249).

^{7:6}Sons disrespect their fathers, daughters rebel against their mothers, and daughters-in-law defy their mothers-in-law. Your enemies are in your own house! ^{7:5}So don’t trust anyone, not your friends and not even your own wife!

Micah 7:7

Section 7:1–7: Micah lamented about the wickedness of God’s people

This section is a lament of Micah that expresses his sorrow about the lack of righteous people in the land. In 7:1–6, he talked about the wickedness of the people using a combination of figures of speech and direct speech. In 7:7, he concluded the lament by expressing his own hope in the LORD.

Some scholars and versions place 7:7 in the next section. However, expressions of both sorrow and hope are features in some other laments, such as in the Psalms. Psalm 55 is one example. NICOT (pages 383–385). Also, both 7:1 and 7:7 have first-person pronouns and verbs that enclose third-person descriptions in 7:2–6. This change of word forms probably indicates the start and end of the lament. UBS (pages 244–256).

Here are some other examples of section headings:

The Total Corruption of the People (NRSV)

Israel’s Misery (NIV)

Misery Turned to Hope (NLT)

7:7a–c

But as for me, I will look to the LORD; I will wait for the God of my salvation. My God will hear me.

- But I will watch for Yahweh. I will wait for God to save me. He will hear me.
- But even though it is like that, I put my confidence in Yahweh, my God and savior. He will hear my voice.

7:7a

But as for me: In this part of the lament the tone/mood changes from negative to positive. NICOT (page 389) notes that the change from general pessimism to personal optimism is typical of the lament form. This phrase introduces a strong contrast between the unfaithful people and Micah’s own hope in the LORD. NAC (pages 124–125) and Waltke 2007 (page 429).

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- Translate the strong contrast. For example:

But as for me (ESV)

But I (GNT)

- Leave the contrast implied. This option is only recommended when the implied contrast will be clearly understood. For example:

...I (GW)

I will look to the LORD: In this clause part, Micah indicated that he expected the LORD to fulfill his promises to the people of Israel and had faith that he would do so. TWOT #1950 states that the word expresses the posture of faith. Also, NAC, EBC, and TOTC.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause part:

I will look to the Lord for help (NCV)

I will watch for the Lord (GNT)

I will keep watching for the Lord (NET)

I will wait for the God of my salvation: In this clause part, Micah indicated that he had confidence that God would save him. In Hebrew, the word wait has a form that means “to be committed/resolved to wait.” NAC (page 125) describes the verb form as a “cohortative of resolve,” meaning “I am resolved to wait for God my Savior to act.”

The phrase God of my salvation is a title that describes God as the savior/deliverer. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the title in a different way. For example:

I will wait for God to save me (NCV)

I will put my trust in God my savior (NAB)

God: In this title, the Hebrew word for God is a form of *elohim* and not *Yahweh*. Some versions translate as God instead of “LORD.” Use your general term for God here.

7:7c

My God will hear me: In this clause part, Micah indicated his certainty that God would hear his prayer. The phrase My God indicates a close relationship with God. Again, the Hebrew word for God is a form of *elohim* here.

Here are some ways to translate this clause part:

- Translate more literally. For example:

my God will hear me (ESV)

- Make explicit some implicit aspects of meaning. For example:

and I will wait for him to answer my prayer (CEV)

My God will hear my lament. (NET)

and my God will certainly hear me (NLT)

Micah 7:8

Section 7:8–13: The LORD will restore his people

In this section, the speaker expressed his trust that the LORD would restore and bless his people again after a time of suffering for their sin. Their borders would be enlarged and people would come there from other nations.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Penitence and Trust in God (NRSV)

Israel Will Rise (NIV)

The Lord Brings Salvation (GNT)

Paragraph 7:8–10

This paragraph talks about confession of sin, faith in the LORD, and victory over enemies. UBS (pages 244–256). The pronouns “I” and “me” are used to refer to the speaker, whose identity is not made explicit. Most versions also leave the speaker implied. However, in some languages it may be necessary to make the referent of “I” and “my” explicit. The majority of commentators propose that the city of Jerusalem/Zion was figuratively speaking here (personification). This proposal is favored by NICOT, NAC, A&F, TOTC, Waltke 2007, and Carson. Another proposal, favored by WBC, is that the speaker was “the nation.” It is also possible that Micah spoke here as a representative of the godly remnant of the people of Israel. This proposal is favored by EBC and is listed as an option by UBS. The Notes will follow the majority opinion.

Since a city has many residents, it may be more natural in some languages to translate the first-person pronouns in this paragraph as plurals, “we,” “our,” and “us.” See the second and/or third meaning lines in the Display for examples.

7:8a

Do not gloat over me, my enemy!

- ¶ Do not rejoice over me, O my enemy; (NRSV)

- ¶ You^(sing), my enemy, should not laugh at our^(excl) misfortune.

Do not gloat over me, my enemy!: In Hebrew, the phrase gloat over me means “rejoice arrogantly, exult.” BDB #8055 (page 970).

In this clause the speaker addressed an enemy directly. Some versions have added the word “O” to make it clear that my enemy is a term of address (vocative). Use a vocative that is natural in your language when a person speaks to a group of people.

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- Translate as a command. For example:

Enemy, don’t laugh at me. (NCV)

Do not gloat over me, my enemies! (NLT)

- Translate as a statement. For example:

Our enemies have no reason to gloat over us.
(GNT)

my enemy: In Hebrew, the words my and enemy are singular. However, both words have a collective reference to a group of people. UBS (page 250). In some languages, it may be more natural to translate these words with plural forms. See the GNT example above.

Based on 7:8b, the enemy was probably a literal city or nation whose army had defeated the city of Jerusalem. In Hebrew, the word enemy is feminine. However, use the gender that is natural in your language to refer to an enemy city or nation.

7:8b–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{8b} Though I have fallen, **I will arise;**

^{8c} though I sit in darkness, **the LORD will be my light.**

In each line, the underlined part states a negative situation. The part in bold print states a positive outcome. Together, these lines give the reason why the speaker (Jerusalem) tells the enemy not to rejoice. It is because the city will not remain destroyed. The LORD will bring restoration and salvation.

Though I have fallen...though I sit: In this verse, both phrases refer to a past event, the defeat of the city

by an enemy. However, the same phrases can apply to other, future negative situations also.

Here are some ways to translate these phrases:

- Translate in a way that refers to the situation in Jerusalem at that time. Leave implied that the same phrases can also apply to other negative situations. For example:

Although I've fallen...although I sit in the dark (GW)

We have fallen...We are in darkness now (GNT)

- Translate in a way that has general application to any negative situation. Leave implied that these phrases refer initially to the city's defeat at that time. For example:

when I fall...when I sit in darkness (ESV)

Though I fall...Though I dwell in darkness (NASB)

7:8b

Though I have fallen, I will arise;

- although I have fallen, I will rise.
- We^(excl) are like people who have fallen, but we^(excl) will stand up again.
- We are defeated now, but we will recover.

Though I have fallen, I will arise: These phrases are metaphors that compare defeat in war. NAC (page 127) suggests that the reference here is to the fall of Jerusalem in 586 BC. Similarly, A&F (page 582) suggests "war casualties." See also Waltke 2007 (page 433). and recovery from defeat. NIDOTTE (page 904). to a person who falls and then stands up. The word fallen means "experience calamity." BDB #5307 (page 657). Here the word arise means "come back to life." A&F (page 582).

Here are some ways to translate these phrases. If possible, keep the references to falling and rising in your translation, as in the first two bulleted options below. The strong contrast may give the translation greater impact:

- Keep the metaphors. For example:

Though I have fallen, I will rise. (NIV)

- Change the metaphors into a simile. For example:

I am like a person who has fallen but will stand again.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

Although I have been defeated, I will recover.

7:8c

though I sit in darkness, the LORD will be my light.

- Although I sit in darkness, Yahweh will be my light.
- It is as if we^(excl) are surrounded by darkness, but Yahweh will be like light to us^(excl).
- Now we feel despair, but Yahweh will rescue us from our sadness.

though I sit in darkness: This clause is the first of two metaphors about darkness and light. This metaphor compares the difficult situation of distress and humiliation to a person sitting in a dark place, like a prisoner confined to a dark cell. Margolis (page 73) and the ESV Study Bible (page 1707).

the LORD will be my light: This clause part is the second metaphor about darkness and light. It compares deliverance/salvation by the LORD to light. NAC (page 127) notes that "light frequently symbolizes well-being, life, freedom, and salvation (deliverance)." See also Waltke 2007 (page 433) and NET footnote on "light."

Here are some ways to translate 7:8c. If possible, keep the references to darkness and light in your translation, as in the first two bulleted options below. The strong contrast may give the translation greater impact.

- Keep the metaphors. For example:

Though I sit in darkness, the Lord will be my light. (NIV)

- Change the metaphors into similes. For example:

I am like a person who sits in a dark place. But the LORD will be like light that dispels the darkness.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

Although I am now in despair, the LORD will deliver me.

Micah 7:9

Section 7:8–13: The LORD will restore his people

In this section, the speaker expressed his trust that the LORD would restore and bless his people again after a time of suffering for their sin. Their borders would be enlarged and people would come there from other nations.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Penitence and Trust in God (NRSV)

Israel Will Rise (NIV)

The Lord Brings Salvation (GNT)

Paragraph 7:8–10

This paragraph talks about confession of sin, faith in the LORD, and victory over enemies. UBS (pages 244–256). The pronouns “I” and “me” are used to refer to the speaker, whose identity is not made explicit. Most versions also leave the speaker implied. However, in some languages it may be necessary to make the referent of “I” and “my” explicit. The majority of commentators propose that the city of Jerusalem/Zion was figuratively speaking here (personification). This proposal is favored by NICOT, NAC, A&F, TOTC, Waltke 2007, and Carson. Another proposal, favored by WBC, is that the speaker was “the nation.” It is also possible that Micah spoke here as a representative of the godly remnant of the people of Israel. This proposal is favored by EBC and is listed as an option by UBS. The Notes will follow the majority opinion.

Since a city has many residents, it may be more natural in some languages to translate the first-person pronouns in this paragraph as plurals, “we,” “our,” and “us.” See the second and/or third meaning lines in the Display for examples.

7:9

In this verse, the speaker is the personification of Jerusalem, as in 7:8. The speaker first describes the consequences of his sin. He then expresses faith that the LORD will justly punish Jerusalem’s enemies for their wrongs, and restore the (people of the) city to a right relationship with him.

7:9a

Because I have sinned against Him, I must endure the rage of the LORD,

- It is necessary that I endure the anger of Yahweh, because I have sinned against him.

- It is because we^(exc) have sinned against Yahweh that we^(excl) must accept his punishment for a while,

Because I have sinned against Him, I must endure the rage of the LORD: The speaker (personified Jerusalem) accepts that its people have sinned and therefore deserve the anger of the LORD.

In Hebrew, the first clause part gives the result, and the second clause part gives the reason. In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of these clause parts, as in the BSB. Here is another example:

We have sinned against the Lord, so now we must endure his anger for a while (GNT)

Because: This word introduces the reason why Jerusalem must bear the indignation of the LORD. The reason is because the people have sinned against him.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Since (NJPS)

for (NET)

sinned against Him: This phrase makes explicit that the sins of the people were directed against the LORD. The people failed to respect him. TWOT #638 and NAC (page 51).

I must endure: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

be patient (NLT)

tolerate

accept

rage: In Hebrew, the word rage means “anger” or “wrath.” Mounce (page 928). Waltke 2007 (page 434). In this context, the word refers both to wrath and to punishment, which is the result of his wrath. NAC (page 127) calls “wrath” a metonymy of cause for effect. Wrath is the cause and punishment is the effect. See also Waltke 2007 (page 434) and UBS (page 252).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

wrath (NLT)

fury (GW)

anger (NJPS)

punishes (NLT)

7:9b

until He argues my case and executes justice for me.

- But then he will plead my case and judge my enemy on my behalf.
- until he defends us and punishes our^(excl) enemies for the wrongs they have done to us^(excl).

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

until He argues my case

and executes judgment for me

These lines indicate how long Jerusalem must bear the indignation of the LORD. It would be until the time when he defends them.

until: This time word indicates the end of the time of wrath and introduces the next event that is described in these lines.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

But after that, he will take up my case (NLT)

But in the end he will defend us (GNT)

But then he will defend my cause (NET)

He argues my case...executes justice for me: These lines are more literally “he will conduct my case and he will do my justice.” In Hebrew, the first line has the same word for case as in Micah 6:1–2. NAC (page 127) and CBC (page 344) say that the LORD will plead their case, that is, he will defend their cause as their defense attorney, for the purpose of reparation and restoration. See the notes there for more details.

These lines mean that the LORD would defend Jerusalem as if in a legal case or lawsuit. He would defend the rights of the people of Jerusalem while judging their enemy. Waltke 2007 (page 434) states that he would execute justice for the victim by punishing the oppressor. KD (page 343) suggests that God used enemy nations to punish his people, but

these nations attributed their victories to their own strength, defied God, and wanted to destroy Israel, violating their rights.

Here are some other ways to translate these lines:

He pleads my case and executes justice for me (NASB)

he will defend us and right the wrongs that have been done to us (GNT)

he will defend my cause and accomplish justice on my behalf (NET)

7:9d–e

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{9d} He will bring me into the light;

^{9e} I shall see His righteousness.

These lines are two ways to say that the LORD would save them.

7:9d

He will bring me into the light;

- He will bring me out of darkness into the light.
- It will be as if he brings us^(excl) out of darkness into light.
- He will deliver us from our troubles.

He will bring me into the light: This line repeats the word light from 7:8c. It probably refers back to the same situation. The LORD would bring Jerusalem out of darkness into his light. Waltke 2007, Mays, UBS, and NAC. As in 8c, this line is a metaphor that compares deliverance/salvation by the LORD to his bringing the people into the light. See the translation options under 7:8c for ideas of how to translate this line.

7:9e

I will see His righteousness.

- I will see his justice.
- We^(excl) will experience his righteous acts.

I will see His righteousness: In Hebrew, the word see means “see,” “view,” “realize,” or “know.” Mounce (page 1025). Here it may mean that the speaker will see the LORD’s vindication figuratively, through eyes of faith, and/or literally through firsthand experience.

In Hebrew, the word righteousness has two aspects of meaning. It refers to the LORD’s “attribute of

righteousness/justness.” It also refers to the action of saving his people, which shows his righteousness/justness. HALOT (electronic edition, page 1006) sense 3. “justness of the divine judge,” a. “as action which rescues, sets to right Mi 7:9.” Also UBS and NAC.

Here are some ways to translate this line:

- Translate His righteousness as the LORD’s attribute of justness. For example:

I will see His righteousness (NASB)

I will see his justice (NAB)

- Translate His righteousness as the LORD’s action that vindicates the speaker. For example:

I will experience firsthand his deliverance (NET)

I will enjoy vindication by Him (NJPS)

Micah 7:10

Section 7:8–13: The LORD will restore his people

In this section, the speaker expressed his trust that the LORD would restore and bless his people again after a time of suffering for their sin. Their borders would be enlarged and people would come there from other nations.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Penitence and Trust in God (NRSV)

Israel Will Rise (NIV)

The Lord Brings Salvation (GNT)

Paragraph 7:8–10

This paragraph talks about confession of sin, faith in the LORD, and victory over enemies. UBS (pages 244–256). The pronouns “I” and “me” are used to refer to the speaker, whose identity is not made explicit. Most versions also leave the speaker implied. However, in some languages it may be necessary to make the referent of “I” and “my” explicit. The majority of commentators propose that the city of Jerusalem/Zion was figuratively speaking here (personification). This proposal is favored by NICOT, NAC, A&F, TOTC, Waltke 2007, and Carson. Another proposal, favored by WBC, is that the speaker was “the nation.” It is also possible that Micah spoke here as a representative of the

godly remnant of the people of Israel. This proposal is favored by EBC and is listed as an option by UBS. The Notes will follow the majority opinion.

Since a city has many residents, it may be more natural in some languages to translate the first-person pronouns in this paragraph as plurals, “we,” “our,” and “us.” See the second and/or third meaning lines in the Display for examples.

7:10

This verse talks about the result of the LORD’s action of saving his people. The enemy had previously taunted the people. But after the LORD saves them, the enemy will be shamed and disgraced. UBS, Pusey, ABC, and TOTC. Throughout this verse, the NIV and some versions use singular pronouns and nouns, such as “my enemy.” Other versions, such as the REB, use plural forms such as “my enemies” (7:10a). In some languages, it may be confusing to use singular forms when the topic is the inhabitants and “the enemy” is a group of soldiers. If that is the case in your language, you should use plural forms.

7:10a

Then my enemy will see

- Then my enemy will see it too,
- You^(plur), our^(excl) enemies, will see him rescue us^(excl) with your^(plur) own eyes,

Then my enemy will see: This line refers back to the LORD’s vindication in 7:9. In Hebrew, the word see is used once in 7:9 and twice in this verse, with both literal and figurative meanings. Here the enemy will literally see with her own eyes that the LORD saves his people. The enemy will also see figuratively. She will “know” that the LORD is able to save his people, contrary to her taunt.

Then: This time word introduces the next event after the LORD’s vindication in 7:9e.

Here is another way to translate this word:

When my enemies see it (REB)

my enemy: See the note on “my enemy” in 7:8a. That information and translation advice applies here also.

7:10b

and will be covered with shame—she who said to me, “Where is the LORD your God?”

- and she will be very ashamed, the one who said to me, “Where is Yahweh your God?”
- and you^(plur) will be disgraced because you taunted us^(excl), saying that Yahweh our^(excl) God can’t help us^(excl).

and will be covered with shame: This line describes the reaction of the enemy to the LORD's vindication of his people. The phrase covered with shame means that the enemy will be overwhelmed with feelings of confusion, embarrassment and dismay. Mounce (page 958) "cover," "overwhelm" and TWOT #222a "shame."

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

Now each of you will be disgraced and put to shame (CEV)

and they will be ashamed (NCV)

she who said to me, "Where is the LORD your God?":

This line indicates the reason why the enemy was covered with shame. It was because she had taunted the people of Jerusalem with these words. But afterwards, the LORD will prove that her taunt was mistaken when he vindicates his people.

The words she who refers back to "my enemy" in 7:10a. The phrase who said to me introduces the words that the enemy spoke to Jerusalem. In some languages it may be unnatural or confusing to use a relative pronoun here. Some of the examples at the end of this note show other translation options.

The question, "Where is the LORD your God?" is rhetorical. The expected answer of the question is "Nowhere." The rhetorical question implied either that the LORD was not real or that he had no power to save them. The purpose of the question was to taunt or mock the LORD and the people of Jerusalem. UBS, NAC, NICOT, A&F, and ABC.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

- Make explicit the referent of the relative pronoun, who. For example:

—the same enemies who taunted us by asking, "Where is the Lord your God?" (GNT)

- Use a conjunction to introduce this line as a reason for the enemy's shame. For example:

...because they asked me, 'Where is the Lord your God?' (GW)

- Make this line a separate sentence. Allow the following lines, 7:10c–e, to make clear the reason for the enemy's shame. For example:

They say to me, "Where is the Lord your God?" (NET)

You, my enemies, said, "The Lord God is helpless." (CEV)

7:10c–e

Notice that these three lines have the same topic:

^{10c}My eyes will see her;

^{10d}at that time she will be trampled

^{10e} like mud in the streets.

These lines describe what would happen to the enemy after she taunted the people of the LORD. The enemy would be defeated, and the people of the LORD would see it happen. The Hebrew text does not make explicit how the enemy was defeated or who defeated her/ them. One possibility is suggested by Pusey (page 94), who proposes that the enemy was Babylon and that the city would be defeated by the Medes and Persians.

7:10c

My eyes will see her;

- My eyes will see her defeat!
- We^(excl) will watch your^(sing) downfall.
- We will see your^(plur) destruction.

My eyes will see her: This line is more literally "my eyes they will see her." The Notes will understand the referent of "her" to be the enemy city or nation that had earlier taunted Jerusalem. This understanding is supported by NAC and JFB and is followed by most versions. Waltke 2007 (page 436) proposes that the referent of "her" is "his righteousness." The difficulty with his proposal is that it does not fit well with the context of the rest of the verse. There are two main interpretations of this verse part:

1. It means that the people of Jerusalem will witness the downfall of the enemy. For example:

With my own eyes I will see their downfall (NLT) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. It means that the people of Jerusalem will take pleasure in the downfall of the enemy. For example:

I will gloat over them. (NET) (NCV, The NCV has "I will look down on them." It may express a negative attitude of some kind. NET, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most English versions. In Hebrew, the attitude of the people of Jerusalem is not made explicit here. It is best to leave it implied.

My eyes: This phrase may refer to literal eyes. However, the phrase is also a Hebrew expression for “I,” the one who sees. Some versions translate it as “I.” Either translation is acceptable. For example:

I shall be watching (NJB)

The word “downfall” is supplied by several versions to make explicit what Jerusalem will see. The phrase “be trampled” means “defeat” or a change from a high to a low status. This kind of misfortune is indicated by the description in 10d–e.

Here are some ways to translate 7:10c:

- Translate literally. Leave implied what the eyes will see. For example:

My eyes will look on her (NASB)

- Supply the word downfall or another word with a similar meaning. For example:

My eyes will see her downfall (NIV)

We will see them defeated (GNT)

7:10d

at that time she will be trampled like mud in the streets.

- I will see her trampled underfoot like mud in the streets.
- Very soon you^(sing) will become a street of mud, stomped on by the feet of those who defeat you^(sing).
- Soon your enemy/enemies will step on you as if you were filth on a street.

7:10d–e

at that time she will be trampled like mud in the streets: This verse part describes the defeat of the enemy by her own enemies. It is a simile that compares the enemy to mud that people walk on. The simile implies total humiliation and weakness. Waltke 2007 (pages 436–437) and UBS (page 253).

at that time: In Hebrew, this time word indicates the immediate future. Waltke 2007 (pages 436–437) and A&F (page 585).

Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Use a word that means “immediately” or “in the near future.” For example:

now (ESV)

very soon

- Translate as a future event. Leave implied how soon it will occur. For example:

They will get walked on (NCV)

as she is trampled (NJB)

she will be trampled: In Hebrew, these words are more literally “she will become a trampling place.” This describes a location where people walk or step. UBS (page 253). In this simile that location is a street.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

she will be trampled underfoot (NIV)

she shall be for trampling (NJPS)

They will get walked on (NCV)

like mud in the streets: This part of the simile compares the “trampling place” to mud in the streets as on the streets of ancient towns. Waltke 2007 (pages 436–437). At that time streets of mud were filthy places where people dumped garbage and excrement. This comparison to mire was a very vivid way to depict how humiliating the defeat of the enemy was. ZIBBC (page 144) and Waltke 2007 (pages 436–437).

Here are some ways to translate 7:10d–e. If possible, keep this figure of speech in your translation, as in the first two bulleted options below:

- Keep the simile. For example:

even now she will be trampled underfoot like mire in the streets (NIV)

- Change the simile into a metaphor. For example:

Now she will be brought low, no more than (or Now she will become) a street of mud under the

feet of (or a street of mud stepped on by the feet of) those who will defeat her.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

Soon she will be completely humiliated by those who defeat her.

Micah 7:11

Section 7:8–13: The LORD will restore his people

In this section, the speaker expressed his trust that the LORD would restore and bless his people again after a time of suffering for their sin. Their borders would be enlarged and people would come there from other nations.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Penitence and Trust in God (NRSV)

Israel Will Rise (NIV)

The Lord Brings Salvation (GNT)

Paragraph 7:11–13

In this paragraph, Micah gives a prophecy about the restoration of Jerusalem. The prophecy may also have a secondary reference to the future salvation of individuals from all the peoples of earth. ABC (pages 1083–1084), and TOTC (page 223).

Some versions place a heading here. For example:

A Prophecy of Restoration (NRSV)

A Bright Future (CEV)

7:11a

The day for rebuilding your walls will come—

- ¶ The day is coming for you^(sing) to build your^(sing) walls.
- ¶ The time will come when you^(plur), people of Israel, will rebuild your^(plur) walls.

The day for rebuilding your walls will come: In this clause, Micah tells the city of Jerusalem that a time will come when she will build her walls. Some versions regard the addressee here to be “Israel” (NLT) or “Judah” (CEV). These versions may base their translations on a more metaphorical understanding of the clause, which has a wider reference beyond the city.

This could be correct as a prophetic, secondary application of the meaning to a future time. However, it is recommended that the plain meaning of the Hebrew text be translated here.

The day: In Hebrew, the word day means “day” or “time.” BDB #3117 (page 399). There are two main interpretations of the day or time indicated in this clause:

1. The day for building walls is left implied. It may or may not be the same day as the downfall of the enemy in 7:10. For example:

The time will come when your walls will be built again (NCV) (CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NCV, NIV, NJPS, NRSV, BSB)

1. The day for building walls is the same day as the downfall of the enemy in 7:10. Waltke 2007 (page 437) suggests that the time in view is specified by the Hebrew word for “now” in 7:10. For example:

That will be the day for rebuilding your walls! (NJB) (NAB, NASB, NET, NJB, NLT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a majority of English versions. In Hebrew, the specific day is not made explicit here. It is best to leave it implied.

rebuilding: In Hebrew, this word can mean either “build” or “rebuild.” Here the word may be used in a general way that refers to either action. Either translation is acceptable. For example:

It is the day for building your walls (NAB)

It will be a day for rebuilding your walls (NET)

your walls: In Hebrew, this phrase has a collective singular pronoun your^(sing). This form suggests that the city of Jerusalem is the addressee. However, the addressee, “city of Jerusalem,” actually refers to the people of Jerusalem. UBS (pages 253–254). Some versions make this information explicit. For example:

People of Jerusalem, the time to rebuild... (GNT)

In some languages, it may be unnatural for a person to address a city. In those languages, this (GNT) translation example may be a good option to follow.

walls: In Hebrew, the word walls means a “wall,” “fence,” “wall made of loose stones from the field

without mortar.”Mounce (page 912). The word usually refers to a stone wall around a vineyard or other property. This meaning is favored by A&F, KD, TOTC, and Pusey. Some scholars propose that the word refers here to the walls that surround the city of Jerusalem. NAC (page 129) and NICOT (pages 396–397) propose that the reference here is to the city walls of Jerusalem. NAC bases this proposal on the word pointing to a metaphorical use, to refer to restoration of the Jews to Judah and Jerusalem. However, it is possible that more than one kind of wall is meant. For that reason, it is recommended that you leave the specific referent implied in your translation. Some examples are the BSB and the two examples under the previous note on “rebuilding.”

7:11a–b (combined/reordered)

- The day for rebuilding your walls and extending your borders is coming. (GW)

7:11b the day for extending your boundary.

- On that day your^(sing) boundary will be enlarged.
- At that time the size of your^(plur) territory will become larger,

the day for extending your boundary: There are three main interpretations of this clause:

1. On that day the city of Jerusalem will become larger in size. This interpretation is favored by Waltke 2007, A&F, and UBS. For example:

At that time your territory will be enlarged. (GNT)
(CEV, ESV, BSB, GNT, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. On that day a law will be rescinded/removed. Commentators propose various options for the referent of “law” here. Pusey (page 96) says it could be “the decree either of God or of the enemy.” JFB (page 695) says it is the “tyrannical decree or rule of Babylon.” KD (page 344) says it is “apparently used here for the ordinance or limit which God has appointed to separate Israel from the nations.” For example:

In that day shall the decree be far removed (KJV)
(KJV, NAB) The NAB has, “on that day the boundary shall be taken away.” It may fit under this interpretation since the boundary is taken away rather than extended.)

1. That day is far in the future. For example:

That is a far-off day. (NJPS) (NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with the majority of versions.

the day: In Hebrew, there is a pronoun “that” in this phrase makes explicit that it refers to the same day as in 7:11a.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

On that day (NASB)

At that time (GNT)

for extending your boundary: In Hebrew, the word boundary means “prescribed limit,” “boundary.” BDB #2706 (page 349) and Waltke 2007 (pages 437–438). In Hebrew, the word extending means “be/become far,” “distant.” In this clause part these words refer to the territory being enlarged. BDB #7368 (pages 934–935), UBS (pages 253–254), Waltke 2007 (page 438).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause part:

expanding your frontiers! (NJB)

your borders will be extended (NLT)

your boundaries enlarged (CEV)

General Comment on 7:11a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these lines. For example:

The day for rebuilding your walls and extending your borders is coming. (GW)

Micah 7:12

Section 7:8–13: The LORD will restore his people

In this section, the speaker expressed his trust that the LORD would restore and bless his people again after a time of suffering for their sin. Their borders would be enlarged and people would come there from other nations.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Penitence and Trust in God (NRSV)

Israel Will Rise (NIV)

The Lord Brings Salvation (GNT)

Paragraph 7:11–13

In this paragraph, Micah gives a prophecy about the restoration of Jerusalem. The prophecy may also have a secondary reference to the future salvation of individuals from all the peoples of earth. ABC (pages 1083–1084), and TOTC (page 223).

Some versions place a heading here. For example:

A Prophecy of Restoration (NRSV)

A Bright Future (CEV)

7:12a

On that day they will come to you

- At that time people will come to you^(sing)
- and people from distant lands will come to you^(plur).

On that day: This phrase refers to the same day, or time period, as in 7:11a and 7:11b. See the note on the same phrase under 7:11b for other translation examples.

they will come to you: In Hebrew, the word come means either come or “return.” HALOT (electronic edition, page 113). In Hebrew, the word they is literally indefinite “someone/he.” In this verse the word refers collectively to people from various locations. There are three main interpretations of who the people are:

1. The reference is to Gentiles and/or to Jewish exiles. Favored by Pusey (page 97). For example:

In that day people will come to you. (NET) This interpretation is indicated by the NET footnote on “people.” (CEV, ESV, NAB, NASB, NET, NIV, NLT, NRSV, BSB)

1. The reference is to Jewish exiles. Favored by UBS, Mays, and WBC. For example:

At that time your people will come back to you (NCV) (GNT, GW, NCV, REB)

1. The reference is to Gentiles. Favored by KD, JFB, and NAC. For example:

The day when others come to you. (NJB) The NJB fits here if the word “others” indicates other people = non-Jewish people. However, the word “others” is actually ambiguous, as it could mean

additional Jewish exiles other than those already present. (NJB, NJP) The NJPS has “[Trampers] will come streaming...” This translation may point to Gentile enemies who attack and trample down the people of Jerusalem or Israel.)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). All the versions listed under interpretation (1) leave the identity of the people implied. These versions translate the word they either as they or as “people.” The implied reference could be either “Gentiles,” “Jewish exiles,” or both groups.

to you: The referent of you in this phrase is probably the city of Jerusalem as in the phrase “your walls” in 7:11a. The context of the paragraph suggests that the city of Jerusalem remains the referent here. However, in Hebrew, the pronoun you is masculine singular here, but is feminine singular in 7:11a. This difference in form is probably stylistic in nature. See the note there for more details.

7:12b–e

Notice the similarity between these parallel lines:

^{12b} from Assyria **and the cities of Egypt,**

^{12c} even from Egypt **to the Euphrates,**

^{12d} from sea **to sea**

^{12e} and mountain **to mountain.**

Each of these four lines describes a separate large region. Travelers from each of these regions will journey to Jerusalem. The large size of these regions, and the unnamed regions, “from sea to sea and mountain to mountain” may indicate that these lines together are a figure of speech (synecdoche) that represents the entire known world at that time. For example, the GNT translates it this way, “Your people will return to you from everywhere....” See also TOTC (page 223). However, it is uncertain that these lines are figurative. For that reason it is not recommended that you follow this interpretation. If readers are unfamiliar with these places, it may be helpful to include a map.

from...to: In Hebrew, these words, used together, are an expression that indicates the boundaries of an area. DCH (page 343) gives the example “from Dan to Beer-sheba” in Judges 20:1. In Hebrew, the word from means “from/from out of” a place. DCH (page 343) and Waltke 2007 (page 439). In Hebrew, the word to means “to/as far as” a place. DCH (page 343). The place names

of each boundary are also part of the expression, as shown in each of the examples above.

7:12b

from Assyria and the cities of Egypt,

- from the region that extends from Assyria to Egypt
- They will travel from the countries of Egypt and Assyria and in-between,

from Assyria and the cities of Egypt: In Hebrew, the word *māṣṣōr* “Egypt” is a less common, poetic name of Egypt. See KD (page 345). All versions translate this word as “Egypt.” There is a textual issue regarding this phrase:

1. Some scholars think that the original text was “from Assyria to Egypt.” The Hebrew word *וְעַרְי* “and the cities [of Egypt]” looks very similar to the word *וְעַד* “to/as far as.” The NET footnote on “as far as” suggests that the following parallel line indicates that *וְעַרְי* is a corrupt form of *וְעַד*. Also JFB (page 695). For example:

from Assyria to Egypt (REB) (NET, NRSV, REB)

1. Some scholars think that the original text was “from Assyria and [from] Egypt.” For example:

all the way from Assyria, from Egypt (NJB) (CEV, NAB, NJB, GNT)

1. The Masoretic Text has “from Assyria and the cities of Egypt.” Favored by KD (page 345). For example:

From Assyria and the towns of Egypt (NJPS) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJPS, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It is the best match to the parallel line 12c.

The nation of Assyria was northeast of Jerusalem. The nation of Egypt was southwest of Jerusalem. In some languages it may be helpful to include these directions. For example:

from Assyria in the east, from Egypt in the south (GNT)

7:12c

even from Egypt to the Euphrates,

- and the area from Egypt to the River,
- from lands bordered by Egypt on one side and the river Euphrates on the other side.

even from Egypt to the Euphrates: There is a textual issue regarding this phrase:

1. The Masoretic Text has “and from Egypt and to [the] River.” Favored by Cheyne, UBS, NICOT, Waltke 2007, and TOTC. For example:

and from Egypt to the River (ESV) (ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, BSB, REB)

1. The LXX and the Peshitta have “from Tyre as far as the river.” UBS (page 254) notes that in Hebrew, the words for “from Egypt” and “from Tyre” look similar. For example:

from Tyre even to the River (NAB) (NAB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with the majority of versions. This line refers to the entire region from Egypt to the Euphrates river.

Here is another way to translate this referent:

From [every land from] Egypt to the Euphrates (NJPS)

the Euphrates: This phrase is literally “the river.” It may be helpful to make this referent explicit in your translation as in the BSB. Here is another example:

the Euphrates River (NET)

7:12d

from sea to sea and mountain to mountain.

- from distant seas/oceans and far away mountains.
- They will come from lands near seas and others on mountains.

from sea to sea and mountain to mountain: These phrases are more literally “and sea from sea and mountain the mountain.” These phrases probably do not refer to specific seas or mountains. Rather they refer to any seas and any mountains. Some commentators regard the referent of these phrases to be the entire earth. For example, Pusey, Mays, UBS, and KD. Some others regard the referent to be regions closer to the nation of Israel. For example, the phrase “sea to sea” may refer to the Mediterranean Sea to the Persian Gulf and the phrase “mountain to Mountain” may refer to Sinai to Lebanon. See Cheyne, and NICOT. Most versions supply extra words to make these phrases sound more natural. For example:

from sea to sea and from mountain to mountain
(ESV)

from the seacoasts and the mountains (NET)

from distant seas and far-off mountains (GNT)

Micah 7:13

Section 7:8–13: The LORD will restore his people

In this section, the speaker expressed his trust that the LORD would restore and bless his people again after a time of suffering for their sin. Their borders would be enlarged and people would come there from other nations.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Penitence and Trust in God (NRSV)

Israel Will Rise (NIV)

The Lord Brings Salvation (GNT)

Paragraph 7:11–13

In this paragraph, Micah gives a prophecy about the restoration of Jerusalem. The prophecy may also have a secondary reference to the future salvation of individuals from all the peoples of earth. ABC (pages 1083–1084), and TOTC (page 223).

Some versions place a heading here. For example:

A Prophecy of Restoration (NRSV)

A Bright Future (CEV)

7:13a–b (combined/reordered)

- But the land will become empty and desolate because of the wickedness of those who live there. (NLT)

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{13a}Then the earth will become desolate **because of its inhabitants,**

^{13b} **as the fruit of their deeds.**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 7:13b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 7:13a. For example:

^{13b} the earth will become desolate **as the fruit of their deeds.**

These lines talk about a future desolation of the earth. The reason for the desolation is because of the doings/actions of the people. This verse is probably a description of a future judgment from the LORD, since only he has authority and power to know and to judge people's actions in this way. The first line is a summary statement. The second line gives more detail.

7:13a

Then the earth will become desolate because of its inhabitants,

- Then/But the earth will become a wasteland because of the people who live there,
- The land will be ruined because of those who live there.

Then the earth will become desolate: In Hebrew, the word become indicates the action of change from its present condition into a desolate condition. Waltke 2007 (pages 439–440) notes that this word form has the sense of “become” or “turn into.”

Then...will become: In Hebrew, this word is more literally “and it will become.” The function of the Hebrew word form is to introduce the next event after the preceding event. Waltke 2007 (pages 439–440) parses this word as a waw-consecutive form that indicates sequence.

Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Use a word or phrase that introduces contrast between this verse and the preceding material. For example:

But the earth will be desolate (ESV)

In contrast, the earth will become a desolate wasteland

- Use a word that introduces the next event and leaves contrast implied. For example:

And the earth will become desolate (NASB)

Then the earth will be ruined

- Let the context imply that this is the next event. For example:

The earth will become desolate (NIV)

The earth will become a wasteland (GW)

the earth: In Hebrew, this word has various meanings. Mounce (page 900) includes among them: “world,” “earth,” “all inhabited lands,” “country,” “region,” “territory.” Here it follows the list of regions in 7:12. In this context, the word earth probably refers to the various regions of the earth outside of Israel. Both UBS (pages 254–255) and KD (page 345) state that the word “earth” here does not include the land of Israel, since this verse speaks of the punishment of enemy nations. Waltke 2007 (pages 439–440) suggests that, since nations representing the entire known world are in view [in 7:12], the word here refers to the earth, not a specific “land.” Most versions translate this word as the earth or “the land.”

desolate: In Hebrew, this word means “desolation,” “ruin,” “wasteland.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

a desolation (NJPS)

a wasteland (GW)

a disaster (CEV)

because of its inhabitants: In this clause part, the word because introduces the reason why the earth will become desolate. It is on account of its inhabitants. In Hebrew, “on,” which here means “on account of.” HALOT II (page 825) and Waltke 2007 (pages 439–440). In 7:13a, the details of what the inhabitants have done to deserve desolation is left implied.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause part:

Because of those who dwell in it (NJPS)

by reason of its inhabitants (NJB)

7:13b

as the fruit of their deeds.

- for their deeds are wicked.
- Their actions are evil.

as the fruit of their deeds: This clause makes more explicit what the inhabitants did to deserve punishment. Here the word as introduces the reason. In Hebrew, “from.” It is because of the fruit of their doings. The phrase fruit of their deeds refers to the consequences of their “actions.” Here the phrase refers to their evil deeds. Waltke 2007 (page 440) and Mounce (page 980).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause part:

as the fruit of their misdeeds (NJPS)

because of their deeds (NCV)

as their deeds deserve (REB)

General Comment on 7:13a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these lines. For example:

But the land will become empty and desolate because of the wickedness of those who live there. (NLT)

The earth will become desolate because of what its inhabitants have done. (NET)

Micah 7:14

Section 7:14–20: A prayer to the LORD for restoration, and praise for his mercy

This section has two main parts. The first part, 7:14–17, contains prayers to the LORD for the restoration of his people and the defeat of their enemies. The second part, 18–20, is a hymn of praise to the LORD for his compassion and his faithful relationship with Israel. These Notes and the Display will assume that the main speaker is Micah, who speaks as a representative of the people. This suggestion is favored by EBC, JFB, TOTC, Mangum, and Waltke 2007. Commentators who suggest that the speaker is the people, collectively, include Achtemeier, NICOT, WBC, and UBS. However, in 7:15 and in 18–20 there are brief changes of speaker and/or addressee. See the notes under paragraph 7:14–17 and under paragraph 7:18–20 for more detailed discussion.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Prayer and Praise (NIV)

The Lord's compassion on Israel (NLT)

Paragraph 7:14–17

The Notes and the Display will follow the paragraph description below:

- In 7:14 Micah prayed to the LORD on behalf of the people.
- In 7:15 the LORD told how he would answer the prayer.
- In 7:16–17 Micah prayed again based on the answer that the LORD gave in 7:15.
- Some versions place paragraph headings here. These are some examples:

A prayer for the Confusion of Zion's Enemies (NJB)

Micah's Prayer and the Lord's Answer (CEV)

7:14

In this verse Micah prayed to the LORD using agricultural figures of speech that the people at that time understood.

He asked the LORD to rule over his people and to restore the blessings that they enjoyed in the past.

7:14a

Shepherd with Your staff Your people,

- ¶ Care for your^(sing) people with your shepherd's staff.
- ¶ Yahweh, rule your people. Guide and protect them, like a shepherd does with his staff.

Shepherd with Your staff Your people: Here Micah used a metaphor to ask the LORD to rule over his people. TOTC (page 224) says that the metaphor of a shepherd was common in the ancient Near East to represent an ideal king. See also Mounce (page 1043), "to care for flocks...by extension: to rule, with a focus on care and concern." This metaphor compares the activities of a ruler to those of a shepherd. A shepherd cared for his sheep by guiding, leading, feeding and protecting them.

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Shepherd your people with your shepherd's rod.
(NET)

- Keep part of the metaphor and make some of the meaning explicit. For example:

With your shepherd's staff, take care of your people (GW)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make some of the meaning explicit. For example:

LORD, rule your people. Guide and protect them, like a shepherd with his staff.

- Translate the meaning directly. For example:

O Lord, come and rule your people (NLT96).

with Your staff: A staff was a rod that a shepherd used to guide his sheep and to protect them from wild animals. In this metaphor, the phrase with Your staff highlighted Micah's request that the LORD would guide and protect his people. Waltke 2007, UBS, CBC, and JFB.

7:14b

the flock of Your inheritance.

- They are your^(sing) very own flock
- They are the people you have chosen.

the flock of Your inheritance: This phrase continues the metaphor from 14a. In this part of the metaphor the LORD's people are compared to a flock of sheep or other domesticated animal. The phrase of Your inheritance gives attention to the special relationship that the LORD has with Israel. They are the people he chose to be his own. In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally "the flock of your inheritance." UBS (page 257) warns translators that in some languages the word "inheritance" may suggest that someone has to die before the heir can take possession of the flock. That is not the correct meaning here. In this verse, the correct meaning of the word "inheritance" is "belonging to you in a special way."

Here are some ways to translate this part of the metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Your very own flock (NJPS)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

who are like your own flock of sheep

- Translate the meaning directly. For example:

the people you have chosen (GNT)

7:14c**They live alone in a woodland,**

- that lives isolated in a woodland,
- They live alone, as if confined to a thicket,

They live alone in a woodland: This line describes the setting where the flock lives. There are two main interpretations of the phrase live alone in a woodland:

1. The setting is undesirable. The people live in a wooded place that is not good for grazing or farming. The word alone implies that the area is isolated from other people. Favored by NICOT, NAC, and UBS. For example:

the one that lives alone in a thicket (NET) (CEV, GNT, NET, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB)

1. The setting is desirable. The people live in a place with wood and pasture land. The word alone implies that the area is secure and protected from negative influences of other people. Favored by KD, TOTC, Waltke 2007, and JFB. For example:

which lives by itself in a forest, in fertile pasturelands (NIV) (GW, NIV)

Some versions are ambiguous and have not been listed above. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with more versions and commentators. It provides a reason why Micah asked the LORD to allow the people to move from their present location to fertile pasturelands in 7:14d.

woodland: In Hebrew, this word means “thicket,” “undergrowth,” “wood.” HALOT (electronic edition, pages 422–423). Here the reference is probably to a thicket or other kind of poor land for grazing. NICOT, UBS, and NAC. Some versions make this meaning explicit. For example:

they live alone in a thicket (NLT)

7:14d**surrounded by pastures.**

- surrounded by fertile grasslands.
- with lush meadows all around them.

surrounded by pastures: This line is part of the clause that starts in 7:14c. It describes the location of the forest. There are two main interpretations of the phrase surrounded by:

1. The forest is surrounded by good pasture land. The phrase pastures indicates a contrast to forest land, which is less fertile. Favored by NICOT, NAC, and UBS. For example:

Grasslands surround us (CEV) (CEV, GNT, NET, NJB, NJPS, REB)

1. The forest is part of the good pasture land. Both places are fertile. Favored by KD, TOTC, Waltke 2007, and JFB. For example:

they live alone in the woods, in fertile pasturelands (GW) (GW, NIV)

Some versions are ambiguous and have not been listed above. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with more versions and commentators.

pastures: There are two main interpretations of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as pastures:

1. The word means “garden land.” It refers to land that is very fertile and good for pasture. Mounce (page 951), NICOT, NAC, and UBS. For example:

Grasslands surround us (CEV) (CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, REB, BSB)

1. The word means “Carmel/Mount Carmel.” It is a location in the northern part of Israel. EBC, NAC, ABC, TOTC, and Pusey. For example:

...on the heights of Mount Carmel (NLT) (KJV, NAB, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with the majority of versions and commentators.

Here are some other ways to translate pastures:

farmland (NJPS)

fertile pastures (GW)

meadows (REB)

7:14e**Let them graze in Bashan and Gilead, as in the days of old.**

- Allow your^(sing) flock to graze in Bashan and Gilead as in days long ago.
- Let them enjoy your abundant blessings as they did in Bashan and Gilead in the past.

Let them graze in Bashan and Gilead, as in the days of old: In this line, Micah asks the LORD to restore to the people of Israel the prosperity and blessing that they enjoyed in the past. EBC (page 549) states that Bashan and Gilead were places of great fertility that became symbols of plenty. Here they are used in a request that the LORD restore Israel's former years of blessing. This line continues the metaphor in which the LORD's people are compared to a flock of animals. In this part of the metaphor, the people's experience of blessing is compared to the feeding of a flock of animals in good pasture.

Here are some ways to translate this part of the metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Allow them to graze in Bashan and Gilead as they did in the old days. (NET)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

like a flock of sheep, let them feed again in Bashan and Gilead as in the past

- Translate the meaning directly. For example:

let the people you have chosen enjoy the abundance of your blessings as they did long ago

Bashan and Gilead: These two places were occupied by the people of Israel early in their history. CBC (page 344) states that Bashan was located east and north-east of the Sea of Galilee. Gilead was located in the Transjordan between the Yarmuk and Arnon Rivers. They were known for their excellent pastures. Carson, CBC, NICOT, JFB, UBS, KD, ZIBBC, and ABC. Here they represent abundant prosperity and blessing. However, some commentators suggest that the intent of Micah's request may be more literal. Micah may be asking the LORD to expand Israel's territory to include Bashan and Gilead once again. UBS, Pusey, and NAC.

the days of old: This phrase refers to the early time period in the history of Israel when they first began to occupy the land. This reference was probably to the time of Moses and Joshua. See NAC, KD, and TOTC.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

As in days long ago (NIV)

as in days gone by (REB)

as they did long ago (GNT)

Micah 7:15

Section 7:14–20: A prayer to the LORD for restoration, and praise for his mercy

This section has two main parts. The first part, 7:14–17, contains prayers to the LORD for the restoration of his people and the defeat of their enemies. The second part, 18–20, is a hymn of praise to the LORD for his compassion and his faithful relationship with Israel. These Notes and the Display will assume that the main speaker is Micah, who speaks as a representative of the people. This suggestion is favored by EBC, JFB, TOTC, Mangum, and Waltke 2007. Commentators who suggest that the speaker is the people, collectively, include Achtemeier, NICOT, WBC, and UBS. However, in 7:15 and in 18–20 there are brief changes of speaker and/or addressee. See the notes under paragraph 7:14–17 and under paragraph 7:18–20 for more detailed discussion.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Prayer and Praise (NIV)

The Lord's compassion on Israel (NLT)

Paragraph 7:14–17

The Notes and the Display will follow the paragraph description below:

- In 7:14 Micah prayed to the LORD on behalf of the people.
- In 7:15 the LORD told how he would answer the prayer.
- In 7:16–17 Micah prayed again based on the answer that the LORD gave in 7:15.
- Some versions place paragraph headings here. These are some examples:

A prayer for the Confusion of Zion's Enemies (NJB)

Micah's Prayer and the Lord's Answer (CEV)

7:15a

As in the days when you came out of Egypt,

- As in the past when you^(sing) came out of Egypt,

- And Yahweh replied, “As I did when you^(plur) came out of Egypt,

As in the days when you came out of Egypt: There are two main interpretations of the referent of the word you in this clause part:

1. The word you refers to Israel. Or Micah as a representative of the people of Israel. See Waltke 2007 (pages 441–442). The LORD is the speaker. In this clause part he referred to the time that the people of Israel came out of Egypt. For example:

As in the days when you departed from the land of Egypt, I will show you miraculous deeds. (NET) (CEV, ESV, KJV, BSB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, RSV)

1. The word you refers to the LORD. Micah is the speaker. In this clause part he referred to the time that the LORD came out of Egypt. For example:

Show us miracles as in the days when you came out of Egypt. (REB) (GNT, GW, NAB, NJB, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a slight majority of versions. Consider if a cross-reference such as Exodus 13:3 might be helpful here. In the Display, one line will use you^(sing) to refer to Israel as a collective whole. The other line will use you^(plur) to refer to the people of Israel.

In Hebrew, this clause part indicates only that the people came out of Egypt. It leaves implicit that it was the LORD who led the people out. In some languages, it may be helpful to make this information explicit. For example:

As in the days when I brought you out of Egypt (NCV)

the days: In Hebrew, this phrase is an expression that means “the time.”

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

- Keep the expression. For example:

in the days when you came out of Egypt (NIV)

- Translate the meaning directly. For example:

when you came out of Egypt

7:15a–b (combined/reordered)

- I, the Lord, will work miracles just as I did when I led you out of Egypt. (CEV)

7:15b

I will show My wonders.

- I will show you^(sing) miracles.
- I will show you^(plur) wonders.”

I will show My wonders: There is a textual issue here:

1. The Masoretic Text has “I will show him.” For example:

I will show him wondrous deeds (NJPS) (BSB, CEV, ESV, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, RSV)

1. Some scholars think that the original Hebrew text was “Show us.” For example:

Show us miracles (REB) (GNT, GW, NAB, NJB, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It makes good sense and requires no change to the Hebrew text. Here the LORD promised that he would again do marvelous things for the people of Israel as he did when he rescued them from slavery in Egypt.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause part:

I will show you miraculous deeds (NET)

I will show them my wonders (NIV)

I will do mighty miracles for you (NLT)

show: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “show him.” The phrase refers to the LORD showing or demonstrating his power to Israel by doing marvelous things. The phrase “show him” sounds unnatural in some languages. Many versions translate this phrase in a more natural way in their language. For example:

show them (NIV)

do...for you (NLT)

wonders: This phrase refers to the acts of the LORD during the time of the exodus. In this context, some of these acts were the plagues in Egypt and the miracles

in the wilderness of Sinai. See the previous note for other ways to translate this phrase.

General Comment on 7:15a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these lines. For example:

^{15b}I, the Lord, will work miracles ^{15a}just as I did when I led you out of Egypt. (CEV)

Micah 7:16

Section 7:14–20: A prayer to the LORD for restoration, and praise for his mercy

This section has two main parts. The first part, 7:14–17, contains prayers to the LORD for the restoration of his people and the defeat of their enemies. The second part, 18–20, is a hymn of praise to the LORD for his compassion and his faithful relationship with Israel. These Notes and the Display will assume that the main speaker is Micah, who speaks as a representative of the people. This suggestion is favored by EBC, JFB, TOTC, Mangum, and Waltke 2007. Commentators who suggest that the speaker is the people, collectively, include Achtemeier, NICOT, WBC, and UBS. However, in 7:15 and in 18–20 there are brief changes of speaker and/or addressee. See the notes under paragraph 7:14–17 and under paragraph 7:18–20 for more detailed discussion.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Prayer and Praise (NIV)

The Lord's compassion on Israel (NLT)

Paragraph 7:14–17

The Notes and the Display will follow the paragraph description below:

- In 7:14 Micah prayed to the LORD on behalf of the people.
- In 7:15 the LORD told how he would answer the prayer.
- In 7:16–17 Micah prayed again based on the answer that the LORD gave in 7:15.
- Some versions place paragraph headings here. These are some examples:

A prayer for the Confusion of Zion's Enemies (NJB)

Micah's Prayer and the Lord's Answer (CEV)

7:16–17

In these verses, Micah was again the speaker. He prayed that the LORD would show these marvelous things both to the people of Israel and to the people of other nations. He also prayed that the people in those nations would respond by acknowledging the greatness of the LORD.

7:16a–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{16a}The nations will see and be ashamed, deprived of all their might.

^{16b}They will put their hands over their mouths,

^{16c}and their ears will become deaf.

In these lines, Micah prayed that the marvelous things, which the LORD would show the nations, would have strong impact on them.

Some versions translate these lines in a way that more clearly indicates a prayer. For example:

Let nations behold and be ashamed despite all their might; let them put hand to mouth; let their ears be deafened! (NJPS)

7:16a

Nations will see and be ashamed, deprived of all their might.

- Nations will see this and will be ashamed of all their might.
- When the nations see your wonders, they will be shamed because all their strength will be useless to them.
- Let the nations feel shame when they see your miracles. May they understand how weak they are when they compare all their power to yours.

Nations will see and be ashamed, deprived of all their might:

In this line, Micah prayed that the people of the nations would feel shame as a result of seeing the power of the LORD. The phrase be ashamed, deprived of all their might implies a comparison to the might of the LORD. The nations would feel shame because the power of the LORD showed how weak they really were.

Here are some other ways to translate this line:

When the nations see those miracles, they will no longer brag about their power. (NCV)

Nations will see this and be ashamed because of their helpless armies. (CEV)

The nations will see this and be frustrated in spite of all their strength. (GNT)

Nations: This phrase refers to nations other than Israel. They were nations of people who did not follow the LORD. They included Israel's enemies. Waltke 2007 (page 442) suggests that these were pagan people, in contrast to the LORD's people. Also, UBS and Pusey.

see: In Hebrew, this word means "see" or "realize." Mounce (page 1037). In this context the word probably had both meanings. The word see had a literal meaning because they would see miracles of the LORD with their own eyes. The word also had a figurative meaning because they would realize how weak they were by comparison.

7:16b

They will put their hands over their mouths, and their ears will become deaf.

- In shock they will cover their mouths and be deaf to the sounds around them.
- In dismay they will be unable to speak or hear.
- May they be struck with shock and awe.

They will put their hands over their mouths, and their ears will become deaf: In Hebrew, it is common to refer to attitudes and emotions by mentioning parts of the body (mouths, ears) that are associated with those attitudes and emotions.

The gesture of laying a hand over a mouth and the description of deaf ears are probably two ways of indicating the emotional effect that the power of the LORD had on the nations. This would include humiliation, shock, awe, and other emotions that the nations felt. TOTC (page 224) proposes that these expressions signify their humiliation. Davis (page 159) suggests shock and wonder. NAC (page 132) suggests awe and amazement. See also EBC, ABC and UBS for similar proposals.

The gesture of a person covering their mouth probably describes a literal action with symbolic meaning. UBS (page 259). However, the description of their ears being deaf was probably not meant literally. The NET footnote on these lines suggests that the opposing nations will be left dumbfounded by the LORD's power. Their inability to respond will make them appear to be deaf mutes. KD (page 347) cite Job 26:14 "who can understand the thunder of his power." This verse in Job does not mention deaf ears. However, the expression "their ears will be deaf" may describe the same

kind of impact on a person that Job experienced. The expression may express their inability to comprehend the greatness of his awesome power.

In some languages these references to parts of the body may not have the same meaning as they do in Hebrew. If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate 7:16b-c:

- Make the meaning of the references to body parts more explicit. For example:

They will cover their mouths in silent awe, deaf to everything around them. (NLT)

In dismay they will close their mouths and cover their ears. (GNT)

- Substitute different body part expressions that have the same meaning in your language. Make the meaning explicit if helpful. Include a footnote that describes the Hebrew gesture. For example:

May their livers fail and their kidneys be in dismay because of their great shame

footnote: In Hebrew: "they will lay their hands on their mouths, their ears will be deaf."

- Translate the meaning directly. For example:

Let them be struck with shock and awe.

Micah 7:17

Section 7:14-20: A prayer to the LORD for restoration, and praise for his mercy

This section has two main parts. The first part, 7:14-17, contains prayers to the LORD for the restoration of his people and the defeat of their enemies. The second part, 18-20, is a hymn of praise to the LORD for his compassion and his faithful relationship with Israel. These Notes and the Display will assume that the main speaker is Micah, who speaks as a representative of the people. This suggestion is favored by EBC, JFB, TOTC, Mangum, and Waltke 2007. Commentators who suggest that the speaker is the people, collectively, include Achtemeier, NICOT, WBC, and UBS. However, in 7:15 and in 18-20 there are brief changes of speaker and/or addressee. See the notes under paragraph 7:14-17 and under paragraph 7:18-20 for more detailed discussion.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Prayer and Praise (NIV)

The Lord's compassion on Israel (NLT)

Paragraph 7:14–17

The Notes and the Display will follow the paragraph description below:

- In 7:14 Micah prayed to the LORD on behalf of the people.
- In 7:15 the LORD told how he would answer the prayer.
- In 7:16–17 Micah prayed again based on the answer that the LORD gave in 7:15.
- Some versions place paragraph headings here. These are some examples:

A prayer for the Confusion of Zion's Enemies (NJB)

Micah's Prayer and the Lord's Answer (CEV)

7:17a–b

They will lick the dust like a snake, like reptiles slithering on the ground.

- They will suffer humiliation like a snake eating dust, like creatures that crawl on the ground.
- They will kiss the feet of their captors, like a snake that licks dust, like creatures that crawl on the ground.
- Let them be completely humiliated by their defeat.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{17a} They will lick the dust **like a snake**,

^{17b} **like reptiles slithering on the ground.**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 7:17b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 7:17a. For example:

^{17b} They will lick the dust **like reptiles slithering on the ground.**

In these lines, Micah continued to pray about the effect of the LORD's marvelous deeds on the nations. These lines are parallel similes. In each simile Micah compared the nations to animals that slid or crawled on the ground. The similarity is that the nations and the animals would both "lick the dust." See Genesis 3:14.

Some versions translate these lines in a way that more clearly indicates a prayer. For example:

Let them lick dust like snakes, like crawling things on the ground! (NJPS)

They will lick the dust: In Hebrew, the phrase lick the dust was a figure of speech that meant humiliation in defeat. Waltke 2007, NAC, A&F, ABC, and JFB. The leader of a defeated enemy would lie prostrate and kiss the feet of the one who defeated him. In this way he showed his acceptance of the victor's power over him. UBS, Pusey, NICOT, and TOTC.

a snake...reptiles slithering on the ground: In Hebrew, the word snake is literally "the snake." This phrase refers to snakes/serpents of any kind. In Hebrew, the word translated as reptiles slithering means "to crawl or glide like a snake." The phrase reptiles slithering on the ground may refer to a snake, reptile, or worm. Mounce (page 926) says "crawl, glide (of a snake)." Also, Waltke 2007 (page 443). JFB (page 696) suggests "like worms, reptiles or crawlers." Also NAC (page 132). The prostrate position of the defeated leaders was similar to the position of these animals that drag their bellies on the ground.

Here are some other ways to translate 7:17a–b:

- Keep the simile if it is understood. For example:

May they lick the dust like snakes, like creatures that crawl on the ground. (REB)

- Substitute a different expression or action that has the same meaning in your language. Include a footnote that describes the Hebrew expression. For example:

May they cry out "I surrender," like an animal caught in a trap

footnote: In Hebrew: "They shall lick dust like a snake, like the crawling things of the earth."

- Translate the meaning directly. For example:

Let them be humiliated by their defeat

7:17c–e

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning (these lines are from the NRSV, which follows the

interpretation that the Notes recommend for understanding the structure of these lines):

^{17c} They shall come trembling out of their fortresses

^{17d} they shall turn in dread **to the Lord our God;**

^{17e} and they shall stand in fear **of you.**

In these lines, Micah prayed that the nations would fear and submit themselves to the LORD. The first line implies that the nations would present themselves before him. The second and third lines talk about their submission to him. Each line says in a different way that the nations would fear him.

Some versions translate these lines in a way that more clearly indicates a prayer. For example:

Let them come trembling out of their strongholds to the Lord our God; Let them fear and dread You! (NJPS)

There is an interpretation issue in 17c–d about the line to which the phrase “to the Lord our God” belongs. The parallel lines are more literally “they will quake from their strongholds to Yahweh our God. They will be in dread and they will be afraid from you.” These are the two interpretations:

1. The phrase “to the Lord our God” belongs to 17d. The LORD is the one they will dread. In Hebrew, the phrase “to Yahweh our God” is the first (fronted) part of the line, which gives it emphasis. Davis (page 159) and Waltke 2007 (page 444). For example:

To the Lord our God they will come in dread (NASB) (ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, NIV, NRSV)

1. The phrase “to the Lord our God” belongs to 17c. The LORD is the one they come to from their fortresses. This interpretation is indicated by the NET footnote on “to the Lord our God.” For example:

Let them come trembling from their strongholds to the Lord our God. (REB) (BSB, NAB, NCV, NET, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB)

The Display will follow interpretation (1). However, either interpretation is acceptable and makes good

sense in this context. There is almost no meaning difference and each one implies the other.

7:17c

They will crawl from their holes

- They will come out of their strongholds shaking,
- They will tremble as they come out of their fortified places like frightened animals from their dens.
- May they come out of their hiding places shaking with fear.

(NRSV) they shall come trembling out of their fortresses:

In this line, Micah continued the similes from 7:17a–b to describe the defeated nations that would present themselves to the LORD. ABC, KD, NICOT, and JFB. He compared the nations to the snakes and crawling things that would come out from their holes or other places where they lived. KD and JFB.

(NRSV) trembling: This word means “shake,” “tremble.” Mounce (page 1038). The reason the nations would tremble is because of their fear and dread of the LORD.

(NRSV) fortresses: In this context, this word refers to a strong fortification or hiding place. In this simile, the word referred both to the nations and to the crawling things. With reference to the nations, it meant the strong places where the people thought they were secure from their enemies. Pusey (page 101). With reference to the snakes and crawling things, it meant the holes and hiding places where they lived. KD and JFB.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- As part of a simile. For example:

Then they will come trembling out of their strongholds like snakes from their holes

- Use a word that can refer to either people or animals. For example:

They will come out of their hiding places trembling. (GW)

7:17d

in the presence of the LORD our God;

- and turn in terror to Yahweh our^(excl) God,
- They will be afraid of you^(sing), Yahweh our God.
- Yahweh our God, I pray that they will turn to you with appropriate fear.

7:17e

they will tremble in fear of You.

- in fear of you^(sing).

- They will approach you in fear and awe.
- May they be in reverent awe of you.

7:17d-e

(NRSV) they shall turn in dread...they shall stand in fear: In Hebrew, this is two phrases which are more literally “they will be in dread...and they will be afraid.” The Hebrew words for dread and fear both mean “be afraid.” Mounce (pages 1019 and 952).

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

- Leave implied the intensity of emotion and the attitude that accompanies the fear and dread. For example:

Let them fear and dread you (NJPS)

- Supply words that indicate the intensity of the fear and dread. Optionally, indicate an attitude of respect and/or submission. This connotation is favored by UBS and JFB. However, NAC (page 132) says it is difficult to determine the nature of the fear. It may be literal fear only, or a fear along with respect and trust. Also see Pusey (page 101). The first example below indicates intensity. The second and third examples indicate attitudes that accompany the fear. For example:

They will be terrified of you (NET)

Let them approach with awe and fear (REB)

They will turn in fear to the Lord our God. (GNT)

(NRSV) to the Lord our God...of you: These parallel phrases both refer to the LORD. Waltke 2007, UBS, NAC, KD, WBC, and JFB.

In some languages, it may sound unnatural for Micah to address the LORD using the third-person phrase the Lord our God. Waltke 2007 (page 444) suggests that Micah 7:8-20 is a liturgical hymn. In such hymns the leader alternates between addressing God and addressing the congregation. In the phrase “to the LORD our God” Micah addressed the congregation. In the phrase “of you” Micah addressed God directly. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

General Comment on 7:17a-e

- Translate the phrases literally even if it sounds unnatural. For example:

To the Lord our God; Let them fear and dread you! (NJPS)

- Use a vocative or other device that sounds more natural in a prayer to the LORD. For example:

O Lord our God. They will be afraid of you (GW)

trembling in fear of you (the Lord, our God) (NAB)

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these lines. For example:

^{17a-b}Like snakes crawling from their holes, ^{17c-e}they will come out to meet the Lord our God. They will fear him greatly, trembling in terror at his presence. (NLT)

Micah 7:18**Section 7:14-20: A prayer to the LORD for restoration, and praise for his mercy**

This section has two main parts. The first part, 7:14-17, contains prayers to the LORD for the restoration of his people and the defeat of their enemies. The second part, 18-20, is a hymn of praise to the LORD for his compassion and his faithful relationship with Israel. These Notes and the Display will assume that the main speaker is Micah, who speaks as a representative of the people. This suggestion is favored by EBC, JFB, TOTC, Mangum, and Waltke 2007. Commentators who suggest that the speaker is the people, collectively, include Achtemeier, NICOT, WBC, and UBS. However, in 7:15 and in 18-20 there are brief changes of speaker and/or addressee. See the notes under paragraph 7:14-17 and under paragraph 7:18-20 for more detailed discussion.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Prayer and Praise (NIV)

The Lord's compassion on Israel (NLT)

Paragraph 7:18-20

In this paragraph, the subject changes. In 7:14-17, the subject was the nations' response to the marvelous things that the LORD would do. In this paragraph, the subject is the character of the LORD and his relationship to Israel.

The literary form of this paragraph is probably a hymn. Waltke 2007 (page 444). Micah is the speaker. He

represents people of Israel who believe in the LORD. In this hymn, the addressee alternates between the LORD and the people. In 7:18a–c, Micah addresses the LORD. In 7:18d–19b, he addresses the people. In 7:19c–7:20, he again addresses the LORD. The main themes are God’s love and his forgiveness of sin.

Some versions place a heading here. For example:

God’s Compassion and Steadfast Love (NRSV)

No One is Like God (CEV)

7:18

In this verse, Micah asks a rhetorical question to highlight how Israel’s God is unique. He forgives the sins of his people because of his special love for them, based on their covenant relationship.

7:18a

Who is a God like You,

- ¶ Who is like you^(sing), God?
- ¶ Our^(excl) God, there is no one like you!

Who is a God like You: EBC (page 551) notes that the name “Micah” means “who is like the LORD?” It is unclear whether or not this rhetorical question is an intentional play on words. This is a rhetorical question with the implied answer “no one.” Waltke 2007 (page 444).

The question intends to imply that Israel’s God is unlike any of the false gods of other nations. UBS (pages 260–261). However, in some languages, this question may wrongly imply that there are other gods. If that is true in your language, here is another way to translate it:

Our God, no one is like you. (CEV)

This rhetorical question can also be expressed as a statement. An example is the CEV above.

7:18b–c

who pardons iniquity and passes over the transgression of the remnant of His inheritance—

- You^(sing) pardon sin and pass over the rebellion of those who remain of your people.
- You forgive sin and remove the guilt of your people who are still alive.

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{18b} who pardons iniquity

^{18c} and passes over the transgression of the remnant of His inheritance—

In these lines, Micah explains how Israel’s God is unique. He forgives the iniquity of the remnant of his people.

who pardons iniquity...passes over the transgression:

The phrase who pardons iniquity is more literally “lifts up/removes sin/guilt and its penalties.” Mounce (page 998 and 1007) and CBC (page 345). The phrase passes over the transgression means “pass over rebellion/sin.” Mounce (page 1005 and 1024). These phrases are two ways to say that God forgives sin.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

removes guilt and pardons sin (NAB)

forgive sin and pardon the rebellion (NET)

freely forgive our sin and guilt (CEV)

the remnant of His inheritance: This phrase indicates who the referents are in this hymn. They are the ones whose transgression is passed over. There are two main interpretations of this phrase:

1. This phrase refers to the people of Israel who remained after the nation was punished. Favored by UBS (page 261). This interpretation fits the previous context well. For example, this is the meaning in Micah 2:12, 4:7, and 5:7–8. For example:

your people who are left alive (NCV) (CEV, GNT, NCV, NET, NLT96)

1. The phrase refers to all of God’s people. The phrase the remnant is another way to say His inheritance. Favored by Waltke 2007 (page 444), who suggests that the word “remnant” is in apposition to “his inheritance.” The two words refer to the same people, the remnant, that is, his inheritance. This interpretation fits the following context well. For example, 7:20 refers to God’s promise to be faithful to Jacob and Abraham, the ancestors of all the people of Israel. For example:

who pardons the guilt of the remnant, overlooking the sins of his special people (NLT) The parallel lines suggest that Micah described the same group of people in two ways. (NLT) The GW may also follow this interpretation. It has “your faith-

ful people.” However, it is not included here because the meaning is unclear. It may imply that faithful people are a subset of all the people. Or it may imply that all of God’s chosen people are called his faithful people.

Many versions are ambiguous. They can be understood as following either interpretation. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Micah uses the word remnant elsewhere with this meaning. See the notes on 2:12b.

His inheritance: This phrase gives attention to the special relationship that the LORD has with the people of Israel. They are the people he chose to be his own.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

your people (NET)

His own people (NJPS)

See the footnote under 7:14b “the flock of Your inheritance” for additional advice on the translation of the word inheritance.

The Hebrew pronoun in this phrase is “his.” However, it may be more natural in some languages to use the second-person pronoun “your” to match the “you” in 7:18a, as some other versions have done.

7:18d

who does not retain His anger forever, because He delights in loving devotion?

- He does not hold on to his anger forever, because it pleases him to show mercy.
- You^(sing) do not stay angry forever, but you^(sing) show unfailing love.

who does not retain His anger forever: Micah continues to explain how the God of Israel is unique. In Hebrew, the word retain means “hold.” Mounce (page 932). God does not hold on to his anger against the people who sin.

The Hebrew pronouns in this clause are third-person forms: “he” and “his.” See the note on “His inheritance” above for suggestions on using the pronoun “you” or other forms. The same information also applies to 18d.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause part:

Who does not persist in anger forever (NAB)

You do not remain angry forever (NET)

You will not be angry forever (GW)

because: This word introduces the reason why God forgives people instead of remaining angry with them.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

but (NET)

for (REB)

since (NJB)

He delights in loving devotion: This clause part gives the reason why he does not hold on to his anger.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause part:

He delights in unchanging love (NASB)

He loves graciousness! (NJPS)

you take pleasure in showing us your constant love (GNT)

delights: In Hebrew, this word means “desire,” “delight in,” or “have pleasure.” Mounce (page 938). He wants to forgive.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

enjoy (NCV)

pleased to be (CEV)

loving devotion: This phrase is more literally “covenant loyalty.” In Hebrew, this word means “unfailing love,” “loyal love,” “devotion,” “kindness.” Mounce (pages 937–938). It describes the attitude and actions that stem from the covenant relationship between the LORD and his people. The same Hebrew word is used in 6:8c. See the note there on “love mercy.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

loyal love (NET)

be merciful (REB)

faithful love (NJB)

Micah 7:19

Section 7:14–20: A prayer to the LORD for restoration, and praise for his mercy

This section has two main parts. The first part, 7:14–17, contains prayers to the LORD for the restoration of his people and the defeat of their enemies. The second part, 18–20, is a hymn of praise to the LORD for his compassion and his faithful relationship with Israel. These Notes and the Display will assume that the main speaker is Micah, who speaks as a representative of the people. This suggestion is favored by EBC, JFB, TOTC, Mangum, and Waltke 2007. Commentators who suggest that the speaker is the people, collectively, include Achtemeier, NICOT, WBC, and UBS. However, in 7:15 and in 18–20 there are brief changes of speaker and/or addressee. See the notes under paragraph 7:14–17 and under paragraph 7:18–20 for more detailed discussion.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Prayer and Praise (NIV)

The Lord's compassion on Israel (NLT)

Paragraph 7:18–20

In this paragraph, the subject changes. In 7:14–17, the subject was the nations' response to the marvelous things that the LORD would do. In this paragraph, the subject is the character of the LORD and his relationship to Israel.

The literary form of this paragraph is probably a hymn. Waltke 2007 (page 444). Micah is the speaker. He represents people of Israel who believe in the LORD. In this hymn, the addressee alternates between the LORD and the people. In 7:18a–c, Micah addresses the LORD. In 7:18d–19b, he addresses the people. In 7:19c–7:20, he again addresses the LORD. The main themes are God's love and his forgiveness of sin.

Some versions place a heading here. For example:

God's Compassion and Steadfast Love (NRSV)

No One is Like God (CEV)

7:19a–c

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{19a} He will again have compassion upon us;

^{19b} He will vanquish our iniquities.

^{19c} You will cast all our sins into the depths of the sea.

In these lines, Micah continues to talk about God's love, which he shows by showing compassion and forgiving sin. The first line is a general statement. The second and third lines give more detail.

In Hebrew, the pronouns in these lines vary. Micah refers to God as "He" in 19a–b, and "You" in 19c. This variety of pronouns may be a characteristic of the poetry of this hymn. However, in some languages, it may be preferable to use a second-person pronoun to refer to God in all three lines, and a first-person pronoun to refer to the people in all three lines. For example:

You will again have compassion on us.

You will overcome our wrongdoing.

You will throw all our sins into the deep sea. (GW)

7:19a

He will again have compassion on us;

- He will have mercy/pity on us^(incl) again.
- You^(sing) will again be merciful/compassionate to us^(excl).

He will again have compassion on us: In this general statement Micah expresses his confidence that the LORD will again have compassion on the people of Israel.

again: In Hebrew, this word means "turn" or "return." Mounce (page 1052). In this context it means to return to a previous condition, when he formerly showed compassion to Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

once again (NET)

Once more (REB)

compassion: In Hebrew, this word means "have compassion," "show mercy," or "take pity." Mounce (page 1040). The word is used to describe the love and care that a mother gives to her children. NAC, CBC, and UBS all make note of this connotation.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

have mercy (NET)

have pity (NJB)

love (NJPS)

7:19b

He will vanquish our iniquities.

- He will trample our^(incl) sins under his feet.
- You^(sing) will conquer our^(excl) sins as if you trampled them under your^(sing) feet.
- You will overcome our wrongdoing. (GW)

He will vanquish our iniquities: This line is a metaphor that compares the LORD's forgiveness of the people's sin to a warrior who conquers an enemy. Waltke 2007 (page 447) suggests that this metaphor, along with the metaphor in 19c, may refer back to the defeat of Pharaoh at the Red Sea. If so, these metaphors compare the LORD's forgiveness of sin to that event.

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

you will conquer our evil deeds (NET)

- Translate with a simile. For example:

You will take away the guilt from our sins as if you were a warrior sending away a defeated foe. Suggested by UBS (page 262).

- Translate the meaning directly. For example:

You will forgive our sins.

our iniquities: See the note on "pardons iniquity and passes over the transgression" under 7:18b–c.

7:19c

You will cast out all our sins into the depths of the sea.

- You^(sing) will send our^(excl) sins into the ocean depths.
- You will take away our sins as if you threw them into the deepest part of the sea never to be remembered again.
- You will completely remove our sins from us.

You will cast out all our sins into the depths of the sea: This line is a metaphor that compares the LORD's forgiveness of the people's sin to the total removal of something by throwing it into a deep part of the sea. Waltke 2007, NAC, NICOT, TOTC, and ABC all mention the possibility that that this metaphor may refer back to the defeat of Pharaoh at the Red Sea. It means that the LORD will forgive completely. NAC, CBC, NICOT, and UBS.

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

and hurl all our iniquities into the depths of the sea (NIV)

- Translate with a simile. For example:

You will remove our sins completely as if you threw them into the deepest ocean

- Translate the meaning directly. For example:

You will totally remove our sins from us

Micah 7:20

Section 7:14–20: A prayer to the LORD for restoration, and praise for his mercy

This section has two main parts. The first part, 7:14–17, contains prayers to the LORD for the restoration of his people and the defeat of their enemies. The second part, 18–20, is a hymn of praise to the LORD for his compassion and his faithful relationship with Israel. These Notes and the Display will assume that the main speaker is Micah, who speaks as a representative of the people. This suggestion is favored by EBC, JFB, TOTC, Mangum, and Waltke 2007. Commentators who suggest that the speaker is the people, collectively, include Achtemeier, NICOT, WBC, and UBS. However, in 7:15 and in 18–20 there are brief changes of speaker and/or addressee. See the notes under paragraph 7:14–17 and under paragraph 7:18–20 for more detailed discussion.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Prayer and Praise (NIV)

The Lord's compassion on Israel (NLT)

Paragraph 7:18–20

In this paragraph, the subject changes. In 7:14–17, the subject was the nations' response to the marvelous things that the LORD would do. In this paragraph, the subject is the character of the LORD and his relationship to Israel.

The literary form of this paragraph is probably a hymn. Waltke 2007 (page 444). Micah is the speaker. He represents people of Israel who believe in the LORD. In this hymn, the addressee alternates between the LORD and the people. In 7:18a–c, Micah addresses the LORD. In 7:18d–19b, he addresses the people. In 7:19c–7:20, he again addresses the LORD. The main themes are God's love and his forgiveness of sin.

Some versions place a heading here. For example:

God's Compassion and Steadfast Love (NRSV)

No One is Like God (CEV)

7:20a–b

You will show faithfulness to Jacob and loving devotion to Abraham,

- You^(sing) will be true to Jacob and show love to Abraham,
- We^(excl) know that you will be faithful to keep the covenant with Abraham and Jacob

Notice the parallel parts that are similar in meaning:

^{20a} You will show faithfulness **to Jacob**

^{20b} and loving devotion **to Abraham,**

There is an ellipsis (a deliberately omitted phrase) in 7:20b. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply the missing words from 7:20a. For example:

^{17b} and you will show loving devotion **to Abraham,**

In these lines, Micah expresses his confidence that the LORD will show his faithfulness and loyalty to Jacob and Abraham. The lines refer to the promise he made to Abraham and Jacob to be faithful to his covenant with them. Waltke 2007, NAC, and EBC. The implication is that the LORD would be faithful and loyal to the descendants of these patriarchs as well. JFB and EBC.

Some versions make this implied information explicit. For example:

You will show your faithfulness and constant love to your people, the descendants of Abraham and of Jacob, as you promised our ancestors long ago. (GNT)

faithfulness...loving devotion: In Hebrew, these words have a similar meaning. This pair of words often occurs in other verses of the Old and New Testaments. For example, Exodus 34:6 “steadfast love and faithfulness” and John 1:7 “grace and truth.” A&F (page 599) considers the two words to be hendiadys for “reliable mercy.” In this verse, the word faithfulness means that the LORD is “reliable.” He keeps every promise. BDB #571 (page 54), CBC, and JFB. The word loving devotion means that the LORD shows love by keeping his covenant. BDB #2617 (page 339), NAC, and CBC. The same Hebrew word is used in 7:18d. See the note there.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

loyal...loyal love (NET)

faithfulness...unfailing love (NLT)

keep your word...be faithful (CEV)

Jacob...Abraham: These are two important ancestors in the history of Israel. The LORD made his covenant with Abraham and reaffirmed it to Jacob. EBC and CBC. The covenant included the LORD's promise to Abraham that he would make a great nation of his many descendants.

**7:20a–c
(combined/reordered)**

- You will show us your faithfulness and unfailing love as you promised to our ancestors Abraham and Jacob long ago. (NLT)

7:20c

as You swore to our fathers from the days of old.

- as you^(sing) promised with an oath to our^(excl) ancestors/forefathers long ago.
- that you made with them in ancient times.

as You swore to our fathers from the days of old: In this line, Micah reaffirms why they can have faith in the LORD. The LORD swore to their ancestors long ago that he would be faithful and loyal.

swore: In Hebrew, this word means “to make a promise by binding oneself by an oath.” TWOT #2319.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

promised on oath (NET)

pledged on oath (NIV)

promised (NLT)

our fathers: This phrase probably refers to Jacob and Abraham, the two ancestors of the people of Israel that are named in 7:20a–b. Waltke 2007 (page 448) suggests that the reference is to Abraham and Jacob only. However, UBS (page 264) suggests that the reference may be to all the ancestors alive at the time the covenant was made at Sinai.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

our forefathers (NASB)

from the days of old: This phrase probably refers to the specific time when the LORD swore an oath to the ancestors. Often the word from can indicate a duration of time. However, in this context, the meaning is probably not a duration of time, but a point in time. Waltke 2007 (pages 448–449). It was the time in the distant past when the special relationship between the LORD and the people of Israel began. It is recommended that you translate this phrase in a way that indicates a point in time rather than a duration. For example:

as you promised our ancestors many years ago
(CEV)

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase the days of old:

in ancient times (NET)

long ago (NLT)

in days gone by (REB)

General Comment on 7:20a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder these lines. For example:

You will show us your faithfulness and unfailing love as you promised to our ancestors Abraham and Jacob long ago. (NLT)